



وزارة الصحة
Ministry of Health
State of Kuwait | دولة الكويت

Neonatal & Pediatric Common & Emergency Care Guide

BY PEDIATRICIANS | FOR PEDIATRICIANS



EVIDENCE
BASED



PRACTICAL



CLINICALLY
RELEVANT



FOR EVERY
CHILD



First Edition



SCAN FOR THE
ELECTRONIC VERSIONS

KUWAIT PEDIATRIC COUNCIL • BEDSIDE REFERENCE

Neonatal & Pediatric Common & Emergency Care Guide

VERSION **1.82** • Updated 7 October 2026

A searchable, algorithmic bedside companion for pediatricians and primary care physicians — every medication listed separately with weight-based dosing, first- to third-line therapy, and the can't-miss diagnoses. Tap any topic to open it.

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Disclaimer and scope of use. This guide is a clinical decision-support resource for pediatricians and primary care physicians practising within their scope in the governmental and private sectors of the State of Kuwait; it is not intended for patients or the public. Its recommendations do not establish a standard of care, are not legally binding, and do not indicate an exclusive course of action; variation according to the circumstances of the individual patient may be appropriate. It does not replace the clinical judgment of the treating physician, consultation with the relevant specialist, or Ministry of Health regulations, protocols and institutional policies, which take precedence where they differ.

The content reflects the evidence and guidelines available at the date of issue. Where higher-quality evidence or an updated guideline becomes available before the scheduled review, the newer evidence should take precedence. Weight-based doses should be confirmed against the approved product labelling and a current pediatric drug reference before administration. Drug-availability notes (◆) identify agents that may not be stocked in Kuwait and suggest alternatives. External links are provided for convenience; their content is outside the control of the authors and the Council.

Professional responsibility (State of Kuwait). Medical practice, the standard of care and professional accountability in Kuwait are governed by Law No. 70 of 2020 on the practice of the medical and allied health professions, patients' rights and health facilities,¹ and by the decisions of the Authority for Medical Responsibility established under it. This guide does not alter the treating physician's obligations under that law, including licensure and practice within scope, adherence to accepted medical practice, informed consent, and accurate and confidential medical records. Clinical decisions remain the responsibility of the treating physician and the treating institution.

Age & scope. This guide covers the newborn through the adolescent. A **neonate** is a baby aged ≤ 28 days; a **pediatric patient** is any child from birth **up to 18 years** of age. This mirrors Kuwait's **Child Rights Law No. 21 of 2015**, which defines a child as every person who has not completed 18 years.² In Kuwait the age of full legal (civil) majority is **21 years**; for any patient under 18, **consent to assessment and treatment is given by a parent or legal guardian**, while the older child/adolescent is involved according to their capacity. Individual services may apply their own operational age cut-offs, so confirm local policy.

Preparation. This guide was drafted, edited, and formatted with the assistance of an AI-based large language model used under direct human supervision. The tool was not an author and made no clinical judgments. All clinical recommendations, medication names and doses, diagnostic thresholds, and references were written by the author, checked against the primary sources and current guidelines, and reviewed by the review panel named below; the content is their work, not the AI tool's. Prepared in line with ICMJE guidance on the use of AI-assisted technologies and with the Ministry of Health **Practical Guide for the Use of Language-based Artificial Intelligence Tools in Healthcare Practice**, adopted and published as a guiding framework for staff of all MOH health facilities by Administrative Decision No. 6189 of 2026 of the Undersecretary of the Ministry of Health (issued under Law No. 70/2020 and Ministerial Decision No. 373/2025 on the code of ethics for health-sector workers).

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Reviewers: the review panel named above — reviewed the final version.

The author and reviewers have read this version and support its use as a reference alongside clinical judgment. Every effort has been made to ensure that the information in this guide is accurate and current at the time of issue. Errors or omissions may nevertheless occur; readers are asked to report them to the address below so that they can be corrected.

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What the colors mean

- 01 · Resuscitation** — cardiopulmonary arrest & the universal approach
- 02 · Behavioral & Psychiatric** — agitation, self-harm, drug-induced syndromes
- 03 · Cardiac & Shock** — arrhythmias, all types of shock, hypercyanotic spell
- 04 · Common Acute Conditions** — everyday clinic & ED infections and presentations
- 05 · Complex & Technology-Dependent Care** — tracheostomy, feeding tubes, ECMO, post-ICU, transport
- 06 · Endocrine & Metabolic** — diabetes, adrenal, inborn errors, electrolytes
- 07 · Focused Specialty Emergencies** — eye, dental, dermatologic, ENT & neurosurgical
- 08 · Gastroenterology & Hepatology** — liver failure, GI bleeding, pancreatitis, hepatitis, cholestasis
- 09 · Hematologic & Oncologic** — neutropenia, tumor lysis, sickle cell, bleeding
- 10 · Neonatal** — newborn-specific emergencies
- 11 · Neurologic** — seizures & status epilepticus
- 12 · Orthopedic & Musculoskeletal** — the limping child, SCFE, compartment syndrome, fractures
- 13 · Pediatric Trauma & TBI** — primary/secondary survey, traumatic brain injury
- 14 · Renal & Urology** — AKI, HUS, hypertensive emergency, acute scrotum & testicular torsion
- 15 · Respiratory, Allergy & Immunology** — airway, breathing, anaphylaxis, allergy & immunology
- 16 · Rheumatologic** — cytokine storm (HLH/MAS) & Kawasaki
- 17 · Surgical Emergencies** — recognize, resuscitate, refer
- 18 · Toxicology & Environmental** — poisoning, burns, heat, drowning, smoke inhalation

Each topic also carries an **urgency tag** showing how fast to act:

MINUTES

immediately life-threatening — act now

HOURS

urgent — stabilize and treat early

ASSESS

evaluate and manage on its own pathway

Call vs refer — in a **hospital**, **call** the in-house specialist team (on site); in a **polyclinic** — or any facility **where the specialty is not available** — **refer** the patient to a facility that has it.

Abbreviations

CPS — Canadian Pediatric Society
GINA — Global Initiative for Asthma
KDIGO — Kidney Disease: Improving Global Outcomes
KNCPP — Kuwait National Child Protection Program
NASPGHAN — North American Society for Pediatric Gastroenterology, Hepatology and Nutrition
PES — Pediatric Endocrine Society
PIDS — Pediatric Infectious Diseases Society
NTSP — National Tracheostomy Safety Project
AAP — American Academy of Pediatrics
NRP — Neonatal Resuscitation Program
AARC — American Association for Respiratory Care
AUA — American Urological Association
BTF — Brain Trauma Foundation
CDC — Centers for Disease Control and Prevention
ELSO — Extracorporeal Life Support Organization
EMA — European Medicines Agency
ESPGHAN — European Society for Pediatric Gastroenterology, Hepatology and Nutrition
EULAR — European Alliance of Associations for Rheumatology
FDA — US Food and Drug Administration
AHA — American Heart Association
IDSA — Infectious Diseases Society of America
ASHP — American Society of Health-System Pharmacists
ANMF — Australasian Neonatal Medicines Formulary
ESC — European Society of Cardiology
ISMP — Institute for Safe Medication Practices
SIDP — Society of Infectious Diseases Pharmacists
AES — American Epilepsy Society
EAN — European Academy of Neurology
PNS — Peripheral Nerve Society
RCPCH — Royal College of Paediatrics and Child Health (UK)
ILAE — International League Against Epilepsy
ISPAD — International Society for Pediatric and Adolescent Diabetes
MOH — Ministry of Health
BTS — British Thoracic Society (UK)
NAEMSP — National Association of EMS Physicians (US)

NICE — National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (UK)
WHO — World Health Organization
DRACMA — Diagnosis and Rationale for Action against Cow's Milk Allergy (WAO)
WAO — World Allergy Organization
ACR — American College of Rheumatology
APSA — American Pediatric Surgical Association
BSH — British Society for Haematology
CSTE — Council of State and Territorial Epidemiologists (US)
EAACI — European Academy of Allergy and Clinical Immunology
EAU — European Association of Urology
ECCO — European Crohn's and Colitis Organisation
ESPID — European Society for Paediatric Infectious Diseases
ILCOR — International Liaison Committee on Resuscitation
NAEPP — National Asthma Education and Prevention Program (US)
NCS — Neurocritical Care Society
NHLBI — National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (US)
RCS — Royal College of Surgeons (UK)
SSC — Surviving Sepsis Campaign
UHMS — Undersea and Hyperbaric Medical Society
AAO-HNS — American Academy of Otolaryngology–Head and Neck Surgery
BNF — British National Formulary (UK)
LITFL — Life in the Fast Lane (clinical education site)
ATLS — Advanced Trauma Life Support (course)
APLS — Advanced Paediatric Life Support (course)
AAF — amino acid formula
ABC — airway, breathing, circulation
ABCDE — airway, breathing, circulation, disability, exposure
ABG — arterial blood gas
ABO — ABO blood-group system
ACE — angiotensin-converting enzyme (inhibitor)
ACS — acute chest syndrome; also American College of Surgeons (trauma)
ADAMTS13 — von Willebrand factor-cleaving protease (ADAMTS13)
ADHD — attention-deficit / hyperactivity disorder

AED — automated external defibrillator; also antiepileptic drug

aEEG — amplitude-integrated electroencephalography

AEIOU — alcohol, epilepsy, insulin, opioids/overdose, uremia (coma mnemonic)

AGEP — acute generalized exanthematous pustulosis

AHI — apnea-hypopnea index

AHO — acute hematogenous osteomyelitis

AHT — abusive head trauma

aHUS — atypical hemolytic uremic syndrome

AKI — acute kidney injury

ALT — alanine aminotransferase

ALTE — apparent life-threatening event

AMPLE — allergies, medications, past history, last meal, events (history mnemonic)

AMR — antimicrobial resistance

AMS — altered mental status

ANC — absolute neutrophil count

AOM — acute otitis media

APGAR — Appearance, Pulse, Grimace, Activity, Respiration (score)

APML — acute promyelocytic leukemia

aPTT — activated partial thromboplastin time

ARDS — acute respiratory distress syndrome

ARF — acute rheumatic fever

ASD — atrial septal defect

AST — aspartate aminotransferase

ATOMAC — Arizona-Texas-Oklahoma-Memphis-Arkansas Consortium (pediatric trauma guidelines)

ASH — American Society of Hematology

ASO — antistreptolysin O

ATA — American Thyroid Association

ATP — adenosine triphosphate

AUC — area under the (concentration-time) curve

AV — atrioventricular

AVM — arteriovenous malformation

AVPU — alert / voice / pain / unresponsive (conscious-level scale)

AVSD — atrioventricular septal defect

B19 — parvovirus B19

BSA — body surface area

B symptoms — lymphoma constitutional symptoms (Ann Arbor staging): unexplained fever > 38 °C, drenching night sweats, weight loss > 10%

BCG — bacille Calmette–Guérin (vaccine)

BID — twice daily

BMI — body mass index

BNP — B-type natriuretic peptide

BP — blood pressure

BRUE — brief resolved unexplained event

BSPED — British Society for Paediatric Endocrinology and Diabetes

BUN — blood urea nitrogen

BWPS — Burch–Wartofsky Point Scale (for thyrotoxicosis)

BXO — balanitis xerotica obliterans

C1-INH — C1-esterase inhibitor

C3, C4 — complement components 3 and 4

CAH — congenital adrenal hyperplasia

CAP — community-acquired pneumonia

CBC — complete blood count

CCHD — critical congenital heart disease

CD46 — membrane cofactor protein (complement regulator)

CDH — congenital diaphragmatic hernia

CFU — colony-forming units

CH50 — total hemolytic complement

CHD — congenital heart disease

CICO — can't intubate, can't oxygenate

CK — creatine kinase

CKD — chronic kidney disease

CMC — children with medical complexity

CMPA — cow's milk protein allergy

CMV — cytomegalovirus

CNO — chronic nonbacterial osteomyelitis

CNS — central nervous system

CO — carbon monoxide

COG — Children's Oncology Group

COHb — carboxyhemoglobin

CPAP — continuous positive airway pressure

CPEG — Canadian Pediatric Endocrine Group

CPR — cardiopulmonary resuscitation

CRMO — chronic recurrent multifocal osteomyelitis

CRP — C-reactive protein

CRASH-2 / CRASH-3 — Clinical Randomisation of an Antifibrinolytic in Significant Haemorrhage trials (tranexamic acid in trauma / head injury)

CRRT — continuous renal replacement therapy

CSF — cerebrospinal fluid

CT — computed tomography

CVC — central venous catheter

CVID — common variable immunodeficiency

CVS — cardiovascular system

CXR — chest radiograph (chest X-ray)	FBC — full blood count
CYP2D6 — cytochrome P450 2D6 (codeine/tramadol metabolism)	FEIBA — factor eight inhibitor bypassing activity
D10 — 10% dextrose	FFP — fresh frozen plasma
DAT — direct antiglobulin (Coombs) test	FHH — familial hypocalciuric hypercalcemia
DDAVP — desmopressin	FiO₂ — fraction of inspired oxygen
DEFG — don't ever forget glucose (coma mnemonic)	FIS — flexible intubation scope
DIC — disseminated intravascular coagulation	FN — febrile neutropenia
DIVA — difficult intravenous access	FPE — food protein-induced enteropathy
DKA — diabetic ketoacidosis	FPIAP — food protein-induced allergic proctocolitis
DL — direct laryngoscopy	FPIES — food protein-induced enterocolitis syndrome
DMD — Duchenne muscular dystrophy	FTT — failure to thrive
DNase — deoxyribonuclease (dornase alfa)	FVC — forced vital capacity
DOPES — displacement, obstruction, pneumothorax, equipment, stomach (sudden deterioration of a ventilated child)	G6PD — glucose-6-phosphate dehydrogenase
DRESS — drug reaction with eosinophilia and systemic symptoms	GA²LEN — Global Allergy and Asthma European Network (anaphylaxis criteria)
DSD — difference / disorder of sex development	GAS — group A <i>Streptococcus</i>
DTaP — diphtheria, tetanus, acellular pertussis (pediatric)	GBS — group B <i>Streptococcus</i> ; also Guillain–Barré syndrome
EBV — Epstein–Barr virus	GCS — Glasgow Coma Scale
ECG — electrocardiogram	GER — gastroesophageal reflux
ECMO — extracorporeal membrane oxygenation	GERD — gastroesophageal reflux disease
ECPR — extracorporeal cardiopulmonary resuscitation	GFR — glomerular filtration rate
ED — emergency department	GGT — gamma-glutamyl transferase
EEG — electroencephalogram	GH — growth hormone
eGFR — estimated glomerular filtration rate	GI — gastrointestinal
EHF — extensively hydrolyzed formula	GIR — glucose infusion rate
EMLA — eutectic mixture of local anesthetics	GJ — gastrojejunal (tube)
ENT — ear, nose and throat (otolaryngology)	GU — genitourinary
ERCP — endoscopic retrograde cholangiopancreatography	H2-antagonist — histamine H2-receptor antagonist
ESBL — extended-spectrum β-lactamase	HA — hypoallergenic (partially hydrolyzed formula label)
ESETT — Established Status Epilepticus Treatment Trial	HAE — hereditary angioedema
ESC-NOW — Eat, Sleep, Console approach for Neonatal Opioid Withdrawal (trial)	HAST — hypoxia-altitude simulation test
ESR — erythrocyte sedimentation rate	HbA1c — glycated hemoglobin
ET — endotracheal (route)	HBO — hyperbaric oxygen
ETT — endotracheal tube	HBV — hepatitis B virus
EVD — external ventricular drain	HCN — hydrogen cyanide
eFAST — extended Focused Assessment with Sonography for Trauma (adds lung views for pneumothorax)	HCO₃⁻ — bicarbonate
FAST — Focused Assessment with Sonography for Trauma (bedside ultrasound for free fluid)	HCT — hematocrit
	HDU — high-dependency unit
	HEEADSSS — Home, Education, Eating, Activities, Drugs, Sexuality, Suicide, Safety (adolescent interview)
	HFNC — high-flow nasal cannula
	HHS — hyperosmolar hyperglycemic state
	HHV-6 — human herpesvirus 6

HIV — human immunodeficiency virus	LGA — large for gestational age
HLA — human leukocyte antigen	LMA — laryngeal mask airway
HLH — hemophagocytic lymphohistiocytosis	LMWH — low-molecular-weight heparin
HME — heat and moisture exchanger	LP — lumbar puncture
HR — heart rate	LOC — loss of consciousness
HSP — Henoch–Schönlein purpura (IgA vasculitis)	LR — likelihood ratio
HSV — herpes simplex virus	LRINEC — Laboratory Risk Indicator for Necrotizing Fasciitis (score)
HUS — hemolytic uremic syndrome	LTV — long-term ventilation
IABP — intra-aortic balloon pump	LV — left ventricle / ventricular
IBD — inflammatory bowel disease	MAP — mean arterial pressure
IBI — invasive bacterial infection (bacteremia or bacterial meningitis)	MAS — macrophage activation syndrome
ICP — intracranial pressure	MCAD — medium-chain acyl-CoA dehydrogenase deficiency
ICU — intensive care unit	MCP — membrane cofactor protein (CD46)
ID — infectious diseases	MDRO — multidrug-resistant organism
IDM — infant of a diabetic mother	MEDIF — airline Medical Information Form
IE — infective endocarditis	MEN — multiple endocrine neoplasia
IEI — inborn errors of immunity	MenACWY — quadrivalent meningococcal conjugate vaccine (serogroups A, C, W, Y)
IEM — inborn error of metabolism	MenB — serogroup B meningococcal vaccine
IgA — immunoglobulin A	MEP — maximal expiratory pressure
IgE — immunoglobulin E	MIC — minimum inhibitory concentration
IgG — immunoglobulin G	MIP — maximal inspiratory pressure
IgM — immunoglobulin M	min — minutes
IGRA — interferon- γ release assay	MIRM — <i>Mycoplasma pneumoniae</i> -induced rash and mucositis
IM — intramuscular	MIS-C — multisystem inflammatory syndrome in children
iNO — inhaled nitric oxide	MMA — methylmalonic acidemia
INR — international normalized ratio	MMR — measles, mumps and rubella (vaccine)
IO — intraosseous	MMRV — measles–mumps–rubella–varicella vaccine
IPNA — International Pediatric Nephrology Association	MRCP — magnetic resonance cholangiopancreatography
ITP — immune thrombocytopenia	MRI — magnetic resonance imaging
IU — international units	MRP — most responsible physician
IUGR — intrauterine growth restriction	MRSA — methicillin-resistant <i>Staphylococcus aureus</i>
IV — intravenous	MSSA — methicillin-susceptible <i>Staphylococcus aureus</i>
IVA — isovaleric acidemia	MTP — massive transfusion protocol
IVIG — intravenous immunoglobulin	MSUD — maple syrup urine disease
JAK — Janus kinase (inhibitor)	NAAT — nucleic acid amplification test
JIA — juvenile idiopathic arthritis	NAC — N-acetylcysteine
JVP — jugular venous pressure	NaCl — sodium chloride
KCl — potassium chloride	NAGS — N-acetylglutamate synthase
KCNQ2, SCN2A — neonatal-onset epilepsy genes	NAI — non-accidental injury
KPCC — Kuwait Poison Control Center	NEC — necrotizing enterocolitis
LAD — leukocyte adhesion deficiency	NEJM — The New England Journal of Medicine
LCHADD — long-chain 3-hydroxyacyl-CoA dehydrogenase deficiency	
LDH — lactate dehydrogenase	
LFTs — liver function tests	
LGMD — limb-girdle muscular dystrophy	

NEWS2 — National Early Warning Score 2

NG — nasogastric

NGT — nasogastric tube

NICU — neonatal intensive care unit

NIF — negative inspiratory force

NIV — non-invasive ventilation

NJT — nasojejunal tube

NK — natural killer (cell)

NMS — neuroleptic malignant syndrome

NPA — nasopharyngeal airway

NPO — nil per os (nothing by mouth)

NSAID — non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug

NT-proBNP — N-terminal pro-B-type natriuretic peptide

NTM — nontuberculous mycobacteria

ODT — orally disintegrating tablet

OGT — orogastric tube

OHP — 17-hydroxyprogesterone (17-OHP)

OI — oxygenation index

OME — otitis media with effusion

OPA — oropharyngeal airway

OPV — oral poliovirus vaccine

OR — odds ratio

ORS — oral rehydration solution

ORT — oral rehydration therapy

OSA — obstructive sleep apnea

OSI — oxygenation saturation index

PA — propionic acidemia; also posteroanterior (radiograph view)

PALF — pediatric acute liver failure

PALS — Pediatric Advanced Life Support

PaO₂ — arterial partial pressure of oxygen

PARDS — pediatric acute respiratory distress syndrome

PAS — Pediatric Appendicitis Score

PAT — Pediatric Assessment Triangle

PCR — polymerase chain reaction

PCT — procalcitonin

PDA — patent ductus arteriosus

PE — phenytoin equivalents

PEA — pulseless electrical activity

PECARN — Pediatric Emergency Care Applied Research Network

PED-TRAX — Pediatric Trauma and Tranexamic Acid study (observational)

PEEP — positive end-expiratory pressure

PEG — percutaneous endoscopic gastrostomy

PEN-FAST — penicillin-allergy risk-assessment score

PEP — post-exposure prophylaxis

PEWS — Pediatric Early Warning Score

PH — portal hypertension

PICC — peripherally inserted central catheter

PICS-p — post-intensive care syndrome — pediatric

PICU — pediatric intensive care unit

PIGN — post-infectious glomerulonephritis

PJP — *Pneumocystis jirovecii* pneumonia

PLP — pyridoxal-5-phosphate

PMA — postmenstrual age

PNPO — pyridox(am)ine 5'-phosphate oxidase (deficiency)

PO — by mouth (oral)

POC — portable oxygen concentrator

POCUS — point-of-care ultrasound

PPHN — persistent pulmonary hypertension of the newborn

PPI — proton pump inhibitor

PPV — positive-pressure ventilation

PR — per rectum (rectal route); also PR interval on ECG

PRAM — Pediatric Respiratory Assessment Measure

PRBC — packed red blood cells

PRN — as required (pro re nata)

PROPPR — Pragmatic, Randomized Optimal Platelet and Plasma Ratios trial

PSG — polysomnography

PSGN — post-streptococcal glomerulonephritis

PT — prothrombin time

PTH — parathyroid hormone

PTHrP — parathyroid hormone-related peptide

PTSD — post-traumatic stress disorder

PTU — propylthiouracil

PUCAI — Pediatric Ulcerative Colitis Activity Index

PVC — premature ventricular contraction

PVR — pulmonary vascular resistance

pVT — pulseless ventricular tachycardia

QID — four times daily

QRS — QRS complex (ECG)

QT — QT interval (ECG)

QTc — corrected QT interval

RADT — rapid antigen detection test

RAPD — relative afferent pupillary defect

RBC — red blood cell

RBS — random blood sugar

RBUS — renal and bladder ultrasound

RCA — right coronary artery

RCT — randomized controlled trial	T3 / T4 — triiodothyronine / thyroxine
RDS — respiratory distress syndrome	TB — tuberculosis
rFVIIa — recombinant activated factor VII	TBI — traumatic brain injury
RIG — rabies immunoglobulin	TBSA — total body surface area
RIME — reactive infectious mucocutaneous eruption	TBW — total body water
RLQ — right lower quadrant	TCA — tricyclic antidepressant
ROSC — return of spontaneous circulation	TcB — transcutaneous bilirubin
ROTEM — rotational thromboelastometry	Tdap — tetanus, diphtheria, acellular pertussis (adolescent/adult)
RR — respiratory rate	TEN — toxic epidermal necrolysis
RSI — rapid sequence intubation	TEN-4-FACESp — bruising clinical decision rule (Torso, Ears, Neck in a child ≤ 4 y or any bruise < 4 months; Frenulum, Angle of jaw, Cheek, Eyelid, Sclera; patterned)
RSV — respiratory syncytial virus	TEG — thromboelastography
RT — respiratory therapist	TFI — total fluid intake
RV — right ventricle	TID — three times daily
s — seconds	TIF — tracheo-innominate fistula
SA — septic arthritis	TIPS — transjugular intrahepatic portosystemic shunt
SBP — systolic blood pressure	TLS — tumor lysis syndrome
SC — subcutaneous	TM — tympanic membrane
SCAR — severe cutaneous adverse reaction (RegiSCAR / J-SCAR criteria)	TMA — thrombotic microangiopathy
SCFE — slipped capital femoral epiphysis	TMP-SMX — trimethoprim-sulfamethoxazole
sCD25 — soluble CD25 (soluble interleukin-2 receptor- α)	TOF — tetralogy of Fallot
SCID — severe combined immunodeficiency	tPA — tissue plasminogen activator
SCIWORA — spinal cord injury without radiographic abnormality	TRAb — TSH-receptor antibody
SGA — small for gestational age	TREC — T-cell receptor excision circle
SIADH — syndrome of inappropriate antidiuretic hormone secretion	TREKK — Translating Emergency Knowledge for Kids
SIDS — sudden infant death syndrome	TSB — total serum bilirubin
SIP — spontaneous intestinal perforation	TSH — thyroid-stimulating hormone
SIPA — shock index, pediatric age-adjusted	TSI — thyroid-stimulating immunoglobulin
sJIA — systemic juvenile idiopathic arthritis	TTE — transthoracic echocardiography
SJS — Stevens–Johnson syndrome	TTP — thrombotic thrombocytopenic purpura
SOPA — suction, open mouth, pressure increase, airway alternative (NRP corrective steps)	TTS — tight-to-shaft (tracheostomy cuff)
SpO₂ — peripheral oxygen saturation	TWIST — Testicular Workup for Ischemia and Suspected Torsion (score)
SPUR — severe, persistent, unusual, recurrent (immunodeficiency pattern)	TXA — tranexamic acid
SSSS — staphylococcal scalded skin syndrome	UCD — urea cycle disorder
SSTI — skin and soft-tissue infection	ULN — upper limit of normal
STAT — immediately (statim)	UTI — urinary tract infection
STEC — Shiga toxin-producing E. coli	V_d — volume of distribution
STI — sexually transmitted infection	VA — venoarterial (ECMO)
SVC — superior vena cava	VAD — ventricular assist device
SVR — systemic vascular resistance	VATS — video-assisted thoracoscopic surgery
SVT — supraventricular tachycardia	VCUG — voiding cystourethrogram
T1DM — type 1 diabetes mellitus	VF — ventricular fibrillation
T2DM — type 2 diabetes mellitus	VKDB — vitamin K deficiency bleeding

VL — videolaryngoscopy

VLCADD — very-long-chain acyl-CoA dehydrogenase deficiency

VP — ventriculoperitoneal (shunt)

VRE — vancomycin-resistant enterococci

VSD — ventricular septal defect

VT — ventricular tachycardia

VTE — venous thromboembolism

VUR — vesicoureteral reflux

VV — venovenous (ECMO)

VZV — varicella-zoster virus

WBC — white blood cell (count)

WOB — work of breathing

WPW — Wolff–Parkinson–White (syndrome)

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Find It by Symptom

The front door — start here: a presentation routes you to the card

Presentation → card index

NAVIGATOR

Presentation → card

You see a presentation, not a diagnosis. Start here and jump to the card.

Presentation	Go to
Bilious vomiting (green)	Malrotation / Midgut Volvulus
The limping / non-weight-bearing child	The Limping Child · Transient Synovitis vs Septic Arthritis · Slipped Capital Femoral Epiphysis (SCFE)
Cyanosis / the blue baby	Hypercyanotic (Tet) Spell · Neonatal & Infant CHD · Critical CHD – Pulse Oximetry Screening
Floppy infant / acute weakness	Guillain-Barré Syndrome / Acute Flaccid Paralysis · The Child with Neuromuscular Disease · Neonatal Sepsis (rapid approach)
Petechiae / purpura	Immune Thrombocytopenia (ITP) · IgA Vasculitis (Henoch-Schönlein Purpura) · Septic Shock
Stridor	Croup · Choking (Foreign-Body Obstruction) · Anaphylaxis · Retropharyngeal Abscess
Wheeze	Acute Asthma · Bronchiolitis · Anaphylaxis
Seizure	Convulsive Status Epilepticus · Febrile Seizure · Neonatal Seizures
Fever + non-blanching rash	Septic Shock · Bacterial Meningitis & Encephalitis
Acute scrotal pain	Acute Scrotum · Testicular Torsion
Jaundiced neonate	Neonatal Hyperbilirubinemia · Neonatal Cholestasis
Bloody diarrhea	Hemolytic Uremic Syndrome · Acute IBD Flare & Toxic Megacolon · Gastroenteritis & Dehydration
Apnea / brief resolved event	BRUE (Brief Resolved Unexplained Event) · Pertussis (Whooping Cough)
Severe abdominal pain	Acute Appendicitis · Intussusception · Malrotation / Midgut Volvulus · Diabetic Ketoacidosis
Bruising / abnormal bleeding	Immune Thrombocytopenia (ITP) · Acute Bleeding in Hemophilia · Vitamin K Deficiency Bleeding (VKDB) · Child Protection & Safeguarding
Fever in the young infant	Fever in the Young Infant
Shock / poor perfusion	Shock – Recognition & Type · Septic Shock

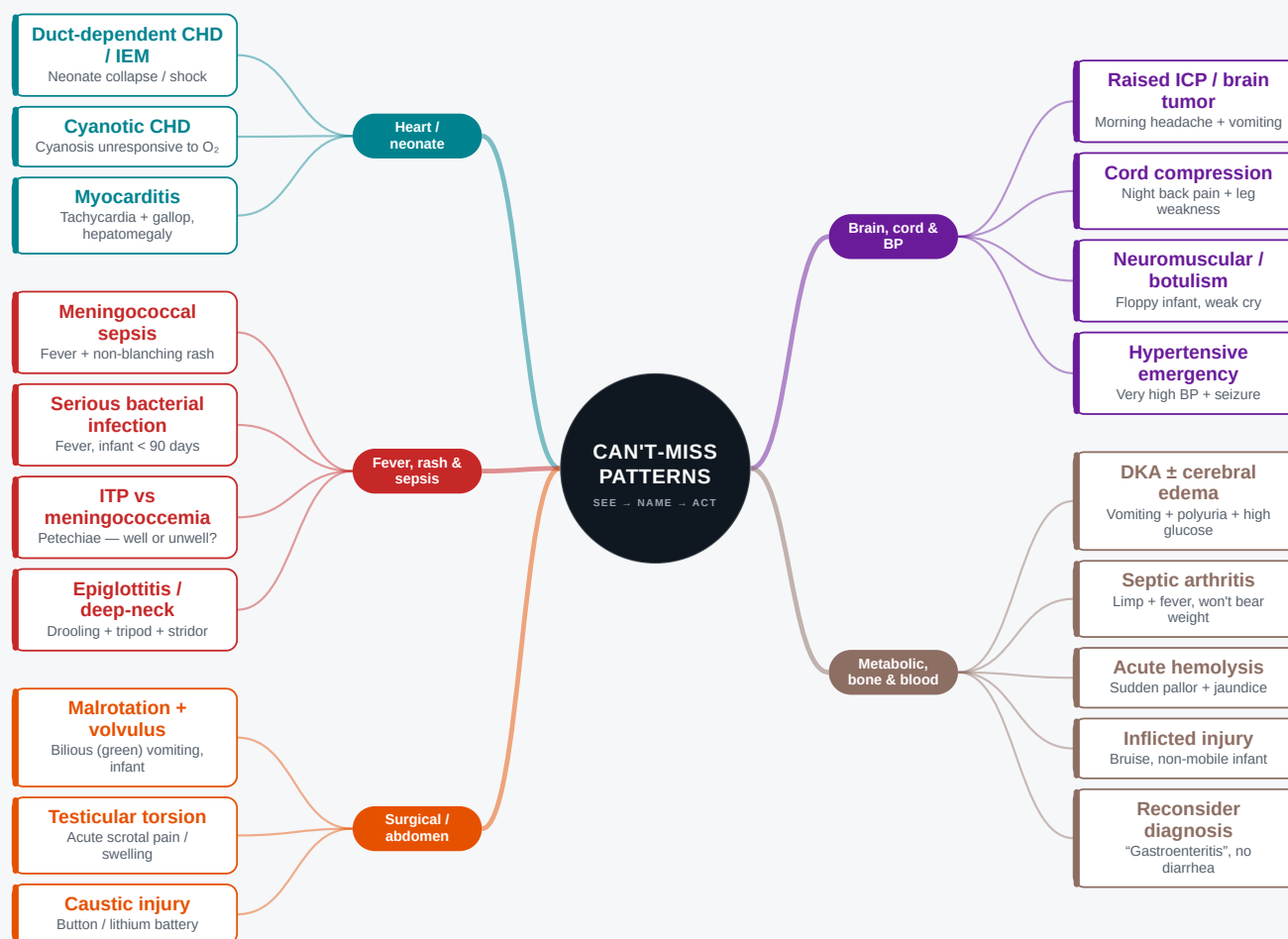
Presentation	Go to
Poisoning / ingestion	Poisoning & Toxic Ingestion • Button (Lithium) Battery Ingestion • Caustic (Corrosive) Ingestion
High glucose / ketones	Diabetic Ketoacidosis • Hyperglycemic Hyperosmolar State (HHS)
Hypoglycemia	Hypoglycemia (Beyond the Newborn) • Metabolic Crisis (Inborn Error) • Neonatal Hypoglycemia
Painful swollen joint + fever	Transient Synovitis vs Septic Arthritis • Osteoarticular Infections
Dark / tea-colored urine	Rhabdomyolysis • Acute Kidney Injury • Gross Hematuria
Agitation / behavioral crisis	Acute Severe Agitation • Self-Harm / Intentional Ingestion
Major hemorrhage / trauma	Massive Transfusion & Blood Products • Major Trauma – Primary Survey & Resuscitation
Anaphylaxis / urticaria + collapse	Anaphylaxis
The unwell child with a device	Tracheostomy Emergencies • Gastrostomy (Feeding) Tube Problems • The Child with Medical Complexity

◆ HOW TO USE

- This routes the commonest bedside **PRESENTATIONS** to the relevant cards — it is a starting point, not a differential.
- Tap a card name to jump straight to it.
- The full alphabetical index and the section colors remain the other two ways in.

Can't-miss patterns – recognition map

See it → name the danger → act. Each node is a sentinel pattern – tap it to jump to the full card (workup + doses). Not exhaustive; the section cards remain the source of truth.



Time-critical emergencies at a glance

Solid bar = clock starts at a knowable moment (a real deadline). Dashed bar = onset usually unknown — prognosis, act on suspicion.

The Golden Window

What must be done — and by when — for the guide's time-critical emergencies. The intervention above each bar is what the window governs.

► Red "now" = a step that starts immediately, before any window applies (e.g. 100% O₂ in CO poisoning).

■ Solid = clock starts at a knowable moment (recognition / arrival) — a real deadline to beat.

■ Dashed = onset usually unknown — the window is prognosis; act on suspicion, do not treat it as a countdown.



Solid-bar windows are consensus targets for starting the named intervention; dashed-bar figures are prognostic. Always act as early as possible. Immediate ABC resuscitation is assumed for every row. Built from the guide's own time-critical cards.

Cardiopulmonary Arrest MINUTES

Unresponsive, apneic, pulseless within 10 seconds → CPR now.

► HIGH-QUALITY CPR IS THE PRIORITY

- Rate **100–120 per minute**; depth $\frac{1}{3}$ of chest depth (~4 cm infant, ~5 cm child); full recoil; minimal interruptions³.
- Ratio **30:2** (single rescuer) · **15:2** (two rescuers). **Adolescent (post-pubertal): 30:2 for both single and two rescuers** (adult BLS)^{3,4}.
- **With an advanced airway (all ages):** continuous chest compressions with **1 breath every 2–3 seconds (20–30 breaths/min)**³, without pausing compressions.

DURING CPR

- Attach a monitor/defibrillator; establish access — **immediate IO in cardiac arrest if an IV is not already in place** (for other emergencies, limit peripheral IV attempts — ERC 2021: at most 2 attempts / 5 min — then go IO⁵); consider an **advanced airway** (then continuous compressions with one breath every 2–3 s); give oxygen.³
- Do not delay epinephrine or defibrillation for access or intubation³.



DECISION

Rhythm on the monitor?

SHOCKABLE • VF / pVT

Defibrillate as early as possible — 2 J/kg → 4 J/kg → ≥4 J/kg (subsequent shocks; up to 10 J/kg or the adult dose³, ≈ 200 J biphasic / 360 J monophasic).

- **Resume high-quality CPR** immediately after every shock³.
- **Reassess** rhythm and a central pulse (brachial in infants; femoral/carotid in children)³ **every 2 min**, pausing compressions ≤ 10 s. If VF/pVT persists, shock again and resume CPR.
- **Epinephrine** during CPR **after the 2nd shock**³ (don't pause compressions), then every 3–5 min.
- **Amiodarone** (or lidocaine) **after the 3rd shock**³ for refractory VF/pVT.

Sequence (a continuous cycle): shock → shock → epinephrine → shock → amiodarone → **back to shock** — keep repeating the 2-min CPR–shock cycle, epinephrine every 3–5 min and a further amiodarone dose as needed³.

NON-SHOCKABLE • asystole / PEA

Give epinephrine during CPR as soon as possible, then every 3–5 minutes. Continue high-quality CPR without unnecessary interruptions; check rhythm every 2 minutes. If a shockable rhythm appears, **cross over to the shockable³ (VF/pVT) pathway** and defibrillate.



EVERY CYCLE – REVERSIBLE CAUSES

- **6 H's:** hypoxia, hypovolemia, hydrogen ion (acidosis), hypo-/hyperkalemia, hypoglycemia, hypothermia³.
- **5 T's:** tension pneumothorax, tamponade (cardiac), toxins, thrombosis (pulmonary), thrombosis (coronary)³.

ROSC



Post-arrest: start post-arrest care · secure the airway · wean oxygen to target SpO₂ 94–99% (avoid hyperoxic reperfusion injury³) and normal carbon dioxide · systolic and/or mean arterial BP > 10th centile for age · targeted normothermia (36–37.5 °C) · correct metabolic derangements · treat seizures (EEG if persistent encephalopathy).

MEDICATIONS & ENERGY

Drug / action	Dose	Route & notes
Epinephrine (adrenaline)	0.01 mg/kg (max 1 mg)	IV/IO, 0.1 mg/mL (1:10,000) ³ concentration; give during CPR without pausing compressions, every 3–5 min
Amiodarone	5 mg/kg (max 300 mg)	IV/IO bolus for refractory VF/pVT; may repeat up to twice (3 doses total; max 15 mg/kg). Avoid in prolonged QT (further prolongs QT) ³
Lidocaine	1 mg/kg	IV/IO alternative to amiodarone ³
Defibrillation	2 → 4 → ≥4 J/kg	Unsynchronized; ³ up to 10 J/kg or adult dose (≈ 200 J biphasic / 360 J monophasic)

⚠ REMEMBER

- Respiratory failure is the leading cause of cardiac arrest in pediatrics — oxygenate and ventilate early³.
- Intraosseous access is fast — in **cardiac arrest go straight to IO if an IV is not already in place** (in other emergencies, IO if IV fails after 2 attempts / 5 min — ERC 2021⁵); do not delay epinephrine waiting for a vein³.

◆ ALGORITHMS

- Full AHA PALS flowcharts (cardiac arrest
- bradycardia
- tachycardia
- post-arrest) — cpr.heart.org



▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- Admit** — every child with return of circulation → **start post-arrest care** (oxygenation/ventilation targets, hemodynamic support, treat the cause, neuroprotection, avoid fever and hypo/hyperglycemia).³
- Home from the emergency department** — not applicable — care after unsuccessful resuscitation follows the death-confirmation and bereavement pathway.
- Refer — now** — the specialty for the reversible cause (6 Hs / 5 Ts): cardiology, surgery, toxicology, or metabolic; involve the resuscitation team early.

◆ SEE ALSO Situation-specific resuscitation: [Neonatal Resuscitation](#) · [Shock — Recognition & Type](#) · [Anaphylaxis](#) · [Difficult Airway](#) · [Major Trauma — Primary Survey](#).

Code Blue — team roles & positions

Assign each role out loud and close the loop: Team Leader (hands-off), Airway Manager, Compressor, Defib Operator / CPR Coach, Medications & Vascular Access (×2), and Recorder / Documenter.



Human-prompted, AI-generated image, reviewed and approved by the panel.

02

Behavioral & Psychiatric

Agitation · self-harm · drug-induced syndromes

Acute Severe Agitation MINUTES

Keep child and staff safe; look for a treatable cause.

① EXCLUDE AN ORGANIC CAUSE FIRST

Check glucose, oxygenation, head injury, intoxication/withdrawal, pain. Agitation is a symptom — treat the cause where present⁶.



② NON-DRUG MEASURES FIRST

Calm low-stimulation environment, verbal de-escalation, familiar caregiver; offer oral medication, including the child's own regular medication, when available.⁶

severe / unsafe



③ PHARMACOLOGIC (PER LOCAL PATHWAY)

Second-generation antipsychotics first-line; benzodiazepines where intoxication/anxiety predominates. Physical restraint = brief last resort, continuous monitoring⁶.

Drug	Dose (approximate)	Route & notes
Olanzapine	2.5–5 mg (< 40 kg); 5–10 mg (≥ 40 kg)	PO/IM/ODT; the ODT (orally disintegrating — Zyprexa Zydis) is easiest in an agitated child. Do not give within 1 h of a benzodiazepine (respiratory depression) ⁶
Risperidone	0.25–1 mg	PO; well tolerated ⁶
Lorazepam	0.05–0.1 mg/kg (max 2 mg)	PO/IM/IV; for substance- or anxiety-driven agitation ⁶
Haloperidol	0.025–0.05 mg/kg (max 5 mg)	IM; watch for dystonia/QT — second-generation agents preferred ⁶
Diphenhydramine	1–2 mg/kg/dose (max 50 mg)	IV/IM/PO; antidote for an acute dystonic reaction from an antipsychotic (haloperidol/risperidone) — not a treatment for agitation itself ⁶

⚠ CAUTION WITH BENZODIAZEPINES

- Avoid benzodiazepines and diphenhydramine in **delirium** — can worsen confusion (paradoxical disinhibition)⁶.
- Also avoid or use with caution in **developmental delay and autism**, where benzodiazepines commonly cause **paradoxical reactions (more agitation)**⁶.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — ongoing risk, a medical cause, or need for continued sedation/monitoring.
- **Home** — settled, medically cleared, with a safety plan and follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — psychiatry; medical/toxicology for organic causes.

Self-Harm / Intentional Ingestion HOURS

Stabilize the patient medically first, then address psychological safety.

① MEDICAL STABILIZATION

ABCDE, glucose, ECG, and a pregnancy test (β-hCG) in all post-menarchal females⁷. For any ingestion: identify agent and timing, check acetaminophen and salicylate levels, and contact poisons information (Kuwait Poison Control Center) for agent-specific advice⁸. Treat per the specific antidote pathway.



② SAFETY

Continuous one-to-one observation, safe environment, involve a trusted adult/caregiver. Do not discharge before a mental-health assessment⁷.



Refer for psychiatric/psychosocial assessment; arrange follow-up and support before discharge⁷.

◆ **CROSS-REFERENCE** General approach, antidotes, and Kuwait Poison Control hotline: see [Poisoning & Toxic Ingestion](#) (Toxicology, Trauma & Environmental).

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — medical risk from the ingestion/injury, or ongoing suicidality → admit and monitor.
- **Home** — medically cleared AND psychiatrically assessed as safe, with follow-up and means restriction.⁷
- **Refer — now** — psychiatry (risk assessment), social work/safeguarding, and toxicology.

Drug-Induced Hyperthermia Syndromes MINUTES

Three look-alikes with different triggers — and different antidotes.

Syndrome	Clue	Key treatment
Neuroleptic malignant syndrome	Antipsychotic; "lead-pipe" rigidity , slow onset, high creatine kinase ⁹	Stop drug; cool; fluids; benzodiazepine; dantrolene; bromocriptine ⁹
Serotonin syndrome	Serotonergic drug; clonus & hyperreflexia , rapid onset, agitation ¹⁰	Stop drug; cool; benzodiazepine; cyproheptadine ¹⁰
Malignant hyperthermia	Volatile anesthetic / succinylcholine ¹¹ ; rigidity, rising CO ₂	Stop trigger; dantrolene ; aggressive cooling; treat hyperkalemia/rhabdomyolysis; urgent PICU/toxicology/anesthesia — antidotes per local protocol ¹¹

⚠ ALL THREE

- Active cooling, IV fluids; treat hyperkalemia and rhabdomyolysis¹¹.
- Secure airway; transfer to PICU.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → PICU (cooling, sedation, dantrolene as indicated).
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; after resolution and review of the causative agent.

- **Refer — now** — toxicology/PICU; psychiatry/pharmacy for a medication review.

03

Cardiac & Shock

Shock recognition & types · septic shock · arrhythmias · myocarditis / heart failure · congenital heart disease · hypercyanotic spell

Shock — Recognition & Type MINUTES

Circulatory failure: tissues not getting enough oxygen. Hypotension is a late sign.

▶ RECOGNIZE EARLY (BEFORE HYPOTENSION)

- Tachycardia, prolonged or flash capillary refill, cool or mottled skin, weak pulses, altered mental status, reduced urine output, rising lactate.^{12,13}

UNIVERSAL FIRST STEPS

Start with ABCDEs · Oxygen · IV/IO access · monitor · check glucose & lactate · identify the type below¹².



DECISION

Which type of shock?

Type	Cause	Key treatment
Hypovolemic	Vomiting/diarrhea, hemorrhage, burns	Crystalloid or balanced solution 10–20 mL/kg boluses ¹⁴ ; blood products (packed red cells) early if hemorrhage ^{15,16} ; stop ongoing losses
Distributive	Sepsis, anaphylaxis, neurogenic	Fluids + early vasoactive; treat the cause (see Septic shock , Anaphylaxis)
Cardiogenic	Myocarditis, arrhythmia, heart disease	Cautious fluid 5 mL/kg slowly; inotrope/inodilator; treat arrhythmia; early cardiology consult and PICU escalation ¹⁷
Obstructive	Tension pneumothorax, tamponade, duct-dependent lesion, pulmonary embolism	Relieve the obstruction (decompress a tension pneumothorax, drain a tamponade, and — for example — prostaglandin for a duct-dependent lesion; massive/high-risk PE → thrombolysis + heparin, specialist-directed) ³

⚠ MIMICS SHOCK – NOT CIRCULATORY FAILURE

- **Carbon monoxide, cyanide, hydrogen sulfide, and methemoglobinemia** impair oxygen **delivery or use at the hemoglobin / cellular level**, not the circulation — so this is **not true shock**, and the usual endpoints (blood pressure, capillary refill) can look normal. **Suspect it** when perfusion and BP appear adequate but there is **unexplained lactic acidosis / tissue hypoxia** with a suggestive history (fire / smoke, enclosed space, oxidizing drugs). **SpO₂ is unreliable** — confirm with **co-oximetry / blood gas** ^{18,19}.
- It will **not respond to fluids or vasopressors**: give **100% oxygen** and the specific antidote ^{18,19,20,21} (see [Smoke Inhalation & CO](#) and [Poisoning](#)).

RESUSCITATION DRUGS

Drug	Dose	Notes
Balanced crystalloid	10–20 mL/kg (5 mL/kg if cardiogenic)	Ringer's lactate preferred; normal saline if a balanced fluid is unavailable. Bolus; reassess for fluid overload after each
Epinephrine (adrenaline) infusion	0.05–0.3 mcg/kg/min	Titrate to response; first-line vasoactive — epinephrine or norepinephrine (neither is preferred) ¹² . May start peripherally with close observation for extravasation until central access is obtained
Norepinephrine (noradrenaline) infusion	Start 0.05–0.1 mcg/kg/min titrate with the PICU second drug usually considered at ~0.3–1 mcg/kg/min ²²	Titrate to response; first-line alternative — warm/cold classification no longer directs the choice ¹² . May start peripherally with close extravasation monitoring until central access is obtained

⚠ FLUID CAUTION

- Reassess after every bolus.
- Vasoactives may start alongside fluids if evidence of life-threatening end-organ hypoperfusion.
- Slow or stop fluids at first **signs of fluid overload** — new crackles, enlarging liver, gallop, worsening work of breathing, or overload on POCUS ^{12,13} — especially suspected cardiogenic shock.

◆ THERAPEUTIC ENDPOINTS (AIM FOR)

- Heart rate and blood pressure normal for age, capillary refill ≤ 2 s, warm extremities with normal pulses ^{12,13}, normal mental status, urine output ≥ 1 mL/kg/h, falling / normalizing lactate (central venous O₂ saturation ≥ 70% where available).
- Reassess after every fluid bolus and every change in vasoactive support.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any child in shock → **call the PICU team to evaluate** (high-dependency/PICU); begin resuscitation before the type is confirmed.
- **Home from the ward** — only once the cause is treated and perfusion is normal off vasoactive support.
- **Refer — now** — by type — septic → PICU/infectious diseases; cardiogenic → cardiology; obstructive → treat the cause (tension pneumothorax, tamponade); hypovolemic/hemorrhagic → surgery/trauma. **Involve PICU in parallel** for any child in shock.

Septic Shock

MINUTES

SSC

Infection + circulatory dysfunction. Defined by the [Phoenix Sepsis Score](#)  (≥ 2 points = sepsis; ≥ 1 cardiovascular point = septic shock).

⚠ THE PHOENIX SCORE IS NOT A SCREENING TOOL

- The Phoenix Sepsis Score identifies **organ dysfunction** — by the time it is positive, sepsis is already established²³.
- It is **not** an early-screening tool.
- Keep using your standard pediatric **early-warning / sepsis-screening** triggers to catch the child **before** organ dysfunction develops²³.

FIRST HOUR — every minute counts



RESUSCITATE

- **Impaired perfusion** = altered mental status; tachycardia with weak or bounding pulses and wide pulse pressure ($\pm$ hypotension); capillary refill > 2 s, mottled cool skin or pallor; oliguria < 1 mL/kg/h (adolescents < 0.5 mL/kg/h)^{13,24}.
- 100% oxygen via non-rebreather mask; after resuscitation, titrate to SpO₂ 88–92% rather than $> 94\%$ ¹²
- If intubating, avoid etomidate¹²
- two IV/IO
- **antibiotics within 1 hour**¹²
- Probable sepsis **without** shock: rapid assessment; if sepsis is still likely, antibiotics ideally within 3 hours¹²
- IV fluid boluses.
- **Labs:** glucose, CBC + differential, PCT or CRP, electrolytes, ionized calcium, renal and liver function, coagulation, blood gas, lactate, cultures (blood $\pm$ urine).
- **Hypotension** (late sign) = systolic BP below, by age:
 - < 60 mmHg — neonate
 - < 70 mmHg — 1–12 mo
 - $< 70 + 2 \times \text{age}(\text{yr})$ — 1–10 yr
 - < 90 mmHg — ≥ 10 yr (PALS age-based thresholds; manual text).²⁴



FLUIDS

- **Balanced crystalloid** (Ringer's lactate preferred over 0.9% saline, except with hyponatremia or raised-ICP concern) 10–20 mL/kg boluses; reassess after each, up to 40–60 mL/kg in the first hour¹².
- Use crystalloids rather than albumin for initial resuscitation¹².
- **Watch for fluid overload** — new hepatomegaly, crackles, gallop, or B-lines on lung POCUS. Give further boluses only while shock persists without overload — titrate each bolus to markers of cardiac output and stop if shock resolves or overload develops¹²; FEAST showed harm from liberal boluses in children without ICU access.²⁵
- Use cardiac and lung point-of-care ultrasound (POCUS) to guide resuscitation where trained staff are available¹².
- Start vasoactives if shock persists after fluid boluses — no evidence-based volume threshold (before or after 40 mL/kg) — or earlier if overload develops¹².

fluid-refractory



VASOACTIVE

- **Call PICU immediately.**
- Start **epinephrine or norepinephrine** (either is acceptable first-line¹²) — the **warm/cold picture** (norepinephrine if warm/vasodilated with bounding pulses, epinephrine if cold/low-output) can **guide but no longer strictly directs**^{12,13} the choice; a well-sited peripheral IV is acceptable, with close extravasation monitoring while central access is arranged.
- **High-dose catecholamines** → add vasopressin or keep titrating the catecholamine¹².
- **Catecholamine-resistant shock** → consider hydrocortisone, especially with adrenal-insufficiency risk (purpura fulminans, recent/chronic steroids, hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal disease)^{12,13}; ACCM 2017 dosing ranges from 1–2 mg/kg/day (stress cover) up to 50 mg/kg/day titrated to shock reversal¹³
- Common formulary regimen (local practice): 1–2 mg/kg bolus (max 100 mg) then ≈ 2–4 mg/kg/day, or ≈ 50 mg/m² then 50–100 mg/m²/day.
- Give stress-dose hydrocortisone for suspected/documentated adrenal insufficiency. In catecholamine-resistant shock, hydrocortisone may reduce catecholamine requirements, but pediatric evidence remains limited^{12,13}. Call PICU.
- Do not give IV hydrocortisone once fluids and vasoactives have restored hemodynamic stability¹².
- **Refractory shock** — persisting despite fluids, ≥ 2 vasoactives, and hydrocortisone, or **low cardiac output on high inotropic support** → **consider VA-ECMO as rescue therapy** and contact an ECMO center early¹².

MEDICATIONS

Drug	Dose	Notes
Ceftriaxone (empiric)	100 mg/kg (max 4 g)	IV; empiric regimen by focus (immunocompetent, community-acquired): no obvious focus → ceftriaxone ± vancomycin ± amikacin; meningitis/encephalitis → ceftriaxone + vancomycin ± acyclovir; pneumonia → ceftriaxone ± vancomycin; skin/soft-tissue → cefotaxime + vancomycin ± clindamycin; toxic shock or necrotizing fasciitis → piperacillin-tazobactam + vancomycin + clindamycin; intra-abdominal → piperacillin-tazobactam; neonate → cefotaxime + ampicillin (± acyclovir if HSV suspected, ± vancomycin if MRSA suspected). Immunocompromised or hospital-acquired: add antipseudomonal cover and consider antifungal. Send MRSA screening swabs. Agent choice by focus follows local practice (Kuwait Pediatric Council antibiotic policy) ²⁶ . Meningitic ceftriaxone dose 50 mg/kg/dose every 12 h (100 mg/kg/day, max 4 g/day). ²⁷
Balanced crystalloid	10–20 mL/kg	Ringer's lactate preferred; normal saline if unavailable. Bolus, reassess after each

Drug	Dose	Notes
Epinephrine (adrenaline)	Start 0.05–0.1 mcg/kg/min	IV/IO infusion; escalate every 5–10 min to target — escalation and titration must be done by the PICU team . Central line preferred; peripheral is a bridge only with close extravasation monitoring until central access
Norepinephrine (noradrenaline)	Start 0.05–0.1 mcg/kg/min titrate with the PICU second drug usually considered at ~0.3–1 mcg/kg/min ²²	IV/IO infusion; escalate every 5–10 min to target — escalation and titration must be done by the PICU team . Central line preferred; peripheral is a bridge only with close extravasation monitoring until central access
Hydrocortisone	1–2 mg/kg (max 100 mg)	IV; give for suspected/documented adrenal insufficiency. No clear evidence for or against in catecholamine-resistant shock

◆ Vasoactive infusions — how to give them safely

- **EPINEPHRINE AND NOREPINEPHRINE INFUSIONS SHOULD BE GIVEN VIA A CENTRAL VENOUS CATHETER WHEREVER POSSIBLE.**¹³ **DO NOT DELAY** initiation of vasoactive support to obtain central access (SSC Pediatric 2026)¹².
- Peripheral use is a **BRIDGE ONLY** — via a large vein, a dedicated dilute infusion, with site review **EVERY 15 MINUTES FOR THE FIRST HOUR THEN HOURLY**, and conversion to central access as soon as feasible.
- **DOSES EXCEEDING THE STATED CENTRAL OR PERIPHERAL MAXIMUM REQUIRE CONSULTANT APPROVAL**, documented in the notes. Escalation beyond **1 MCG/KG/MIN** should prompt reassessment of the shock phenotype and consideration of **VASOPRESSIN AND HYDROCORTISONE**²⁸, rather than relying solely on dose escalation.

◆ Preparing the infusion — where you have no local formulary

- **AMPOULES (GULF/ME):** epinephrine (adrenaline) **1 MG/ML (1:1,000)** is the stock ampoule (0.1 mg/mL / 1:10,000 is the pre-filled code syringe)^{3,29,30}; norepinephrine (noradrenaline) **1 MG/ML** ampoules (2 mg/2 mL, 4 mg/4 mL). The strength printed on the ampoule is norepinephrine **BASE**: a 4 mg/4 mL ampoule contains **4 MG** — dose from the label strength.^{31,32}
- **RULE OF 6 (WEIGHT-BASED):** put **0.3 MG/KG IN 50 ML** (or 0.6 mg/kg in 100 mL) of glucose 5% → **1 ML/H = 0.1 MCG/KG/MIN** (0.05 = 0.5 mL/h; 0.3 = 3 mL/h).³³
- **STANDARD CONCENTRATION (SAFETY-PREFERRED):** epinephrine **10 / 20 / 40 MCG/ML**; norepinephrine (base) **16 / 32 / 64 MCG/ML**.^{33,34} **RATE (ML/H) = DOSE (MCG/KG/MIN) × WEIGHT (KG) × 60 ÷ CONCENTRATION (MCG/ML)**.³⁴ Use the most dilute for a peripheral bridge.^{12,34}
- **DILUENT & SAFETY:** dilute in **GLUCOSE 5%** (0.9% saline alone: permitted by the UK norepinephrine label, not recommended by US epinephrine and norepinephrine labels) — **NOT** with bicarbonate/alkaline fluids; **PROTECT FROM LIGHT** and discard if discolored^{29,31,32}; dedicated line; **NEVER BOLUS OR FLUSH** a vasoactive line³⁵; independent double-check of drug, concentration, weight, and rate.^{33,36}

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → PICU/high-dependency; fluid-refractory or vasoactive-requiring shock is always PICU.
- **Home from the ward** — not from the acute episode — step down once off vasoactives with a controlled source.
- **Refer — now** — infectious diseases for source control and antimicrobials; surgery for a drainable focus; an ECMO center if refractory.

Septic shock – the first hour

The first hour, step by step: recognize → access + labs → fluids → reassess → vasoactive → hydrocortisone/PICU, with antibiotics inside the hour. Details in the card above.



ANTIBIOTICS within 60 minutes

Two agents IV/IO, after cultures — do not delay for the lab.



Myocarditis / Acute Heart Failure HOURS

The "gastroenteritis" or "asthma" that is really the heart — look for it.

RECOGNIZE

- Viral prodrome, then **tachycardia out of proportion** to the fever, poor feeding, lethargy, grunting or respiratory distress.
- **Hepatomegaly, gallop rhythm, weak pulses, cool peripheries.** Older child: chest pain, syncope, palpitations.
- Commonly mislabeled as gastroenteritis, sepsis, asthma, pneumonia, or bronchiolitis.¹⁷

CONFIRM

ECG (sinus tachycardia, low voltages, ST/T changes, arrhythmia, or heart block), chest X-ray (cardiomegaly, pulmonary edema), troponin and BNP raised, echocardiogram for reduced function.¹⁷

RESUSCITATE WITH CARE

- Oxygen and monitor with caution; may need positive-pressure ventilation — **call PICU.**
- Do **not** give large fluid boluses.¹⁷
- Use 5 mL/kg slowly and reassess for **signs of fluid overload** (worsening hepatomegaly, new crackles, a gallop, or respiratory distress).
- Start inotropes early (cardiology/PICU-directed) — milrinone (preferred if blood pressure allows — an inodilator that lowers afterload and can drop BP) or dobutamine.
- Tailor to hemodynamics: normotensive with cold peripheries and rising lactate → dobutamine or milrinone; hypotensive with poor perfusion → epinephrine.
- Check and correct electrolytes (calcium, potassium, magnesium, phosphate).
- Treat arrhythmia, give oxygen and ventilatory support.
- Early PICU and pediatric cardiology; refractory shock needs urgent PICU/cardiology transfer — advanced mechanical circulatory support is a specialist/PICU decision.¹⁷

INOTROPES / VASOACTIVES

Drug	Dose	Notes
Milrinone	0.25–0.75 mcg/kg/min IV infusion	Inodilator — preferred if the blood pressure allows. Consider omitting the 50 mcg/kg loading dose in acute shock ¹⁷ to avoid hypotension.
Dobutamine	2–20 mcg/kg/min IV infusion	Normotensive with cold peripheries and rising lactate.
Epinephrine	0.05–0.3 mcg/kg/min IV infusion	Hypotensive with poor perfusion.

ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all suspected cases → PICU/cardiology; arrhythmia, low output, or a troponin/BNP rise mandates continuous monitoring.
- **Home from the ward** — only after cardiology review, recovered function, and a heart-failure plan.
- **Refer — now** — cardiology urgently (echo, rhythm); a transplant/ECMO/mechanical-support center if low output or refractory arrhythmia.

Bradycardia + Poor Perfusion MINUTES

Slow heart rate with shock — usually hypoxic.

FIRST

100% oxygen, support airway & breathing, monitor, IV/IO. **Ventilation corrects most pediatric bradycardia.**³



DECISION

HR < 60 with poor perfusion despite oxygenation & ventilation? Poor perfusion = acutely altered mental status, signs of shock, or low BP.

YES

Start CPR. Give epinephrine. Atropine for a vagal cause or heart block; consider pacing.³ Treat the reversible cause; call PICU/cardiology early.

NO

Support, observe, treat the cause, seek cardiology input.

LOOK FOR THE CAUSE

- **Hypoxia is the commonest — oxygenate and ventilate first.**³ Also: hypothermia; drugs/toxins; raised intracranial pressure (Cushing's triad — hypertension, bradycardia, irregular breathing) (see **Raised ICP**); increased vagal tone (e.g., suctioning, intubation); AV / heart block.
- A well, athletic, or sleeping child may be **physiologically** bradycardic.³

Drug	Dose	Notes
Epinephrine (adrenaline)	0.01 mg/kg (max 1 mg)	IV/IO, 0.1 mg/mL (1:10,000) concentration, every 3–5 min
Atropine	0.02 mg/kg (min 0.1, max 0.5 mg)	IV/IO; for vagal cause, AV block, or cholinergic/organophosphate toxicity ³

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → PICU with continuous monitoring, including any child needing atropine, epinephrine, or pacing.
- **Discharge** — only after a reversible cause is corrected, the rhythm is stable, and cardiology has reviewed.
- **Refer** — cardiology for pacing or structural/conduction disease; treat reversible causes (hypoxia, vagal, raised ICP, toxins, electrolytes).

◆ READING THE TRACING

- New to pediatric rhythms?
- See a [stepwise approach to the pediatric ECG](#)  and [common pediatric arrhythmias](#)  (LITFL ECG Library).

Supraventricular Tachycardia MINUTES

Narrow QRS, no rate variability. HR > 220 infant / > 180 child.

▲ THROUGHOUT

- Run a continuous ECG rhythm strip during every intervention — documents the moment of conversion; can unmask underlying WPW.³

DECISION

Hemodynamically unstable (shock, poor perfusion, reduced consciousness)?

UNSTABLE

Synchronized cardioversion; sedate only if it will not delay — use an agent that gives **amnesia**, not fentanyl alone (see sedation note). If IV/IO access is already in place, one rapid adenosine dose may be given while the defibrillator charges³ — never delay the shock.

STABLE

Vagal maneuvers first — ice to the face in infants; modified Valsalva in older children³ — then adenosine.

◆ MODIFIED VALSALVA

- Sit child semi-recumbent; blow into a 10 mL syringe hard enough to just move the plunger (~15 s); then immediately lay flat and raise legs to ~45° for 15 s.³⁷
- More effective than standard strain in the adult REVERT trial and a 2025 pediatric randomized trial.^{37,38}

Drug / action	Dose	Notes
Adenosine (1st dose)	0.1 mg/kg (max 6 mg)	△ Technique is critical: use the most proximal IV; two-syringe or 3-way-stopcock method — rapid push, then an instant 5–10 mL saline flush while raising the arm ³ . Often needs two people.
Adenosine (2nd dose)	0.2 mg/kg (max 12 mg)	If no response to the first dose.
If the 2nd dose fails	Consult cardiology	Next steps: synchronized cardioversion , or an antiarrhythmic infusion — amiodarone 5 mg/kg over 20–60 min OR procainamide 15 mg/kg over 30–60 min . Never mix antiarrhythmics. ³
Synchronized cardioversion	0.5–1 → 2 J/kg	For the unstable child. If it will not delay the shock, sedate with an agent that provides amnesia — do not rely on fentanyl alone (see the sedation note below).

△ SEDATION FOR CARDIOVERSION – AMNESIA, NOT JUST ANALGESIA

Fentanyl alone is a pitfall: it gives analgesia but **no amnesia** (pharmacology; PALS says only “consider sedation”), so the child may be awake and remember the shock; pushed rapidly it can cause **chest-wall rigidity**. **Ketamine’s** myocardial depression matters mainly in **prolonged, catecholamine-depleted** shock; in most children it is a net **sympathomimetic (positive inotrope)**, and ketamine or **etomidate** is standard for brief pediatric procedural sedation — there are no RCTs for this ~60-second window. **Involve a pediatric anesthesiologist** / follow your procedural-sedation protocol.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — first presentation, hemodynamic instability, or need for adenosine/cardioversion → monitored bed/PICU.
- **Home from the emergency department** — a stable child who reverts and stays in sinus rhythm, feeding and well, with cardiology follow-up and a clear return plan.
- **Refer — clinic** — cardiology for all confirmed SVT (WPW screen, ablation planning) and for recurrent episodes.

◆ READING THE TRACING

- Align terminology with PALS/cardiology: SVT = **narrow-complex tachycardia**, VT = **wide-complex tachycardia** (each with or without a pulse); cross-check the label with cardiology.
- New to pediatric rhythms?
- See a [stepwise approach to the pediatric ECG](#) and [common pediatric arrhythmias](#)



(LITFL ECG Library).



Ventricular Tachycardia (with a pulse) MINUTES

Wide-QRS tachycardia. Pulseless VT → use the arrest algorithm.

DECISION

Stable or unstable?

UNSTABLE

Synchronized cardioversion 0.5–1 → 2 J/kg.
Sedate if no delay (short-acting agent, e.g., IV fentanyl). Expert input.

STABLE

If **regular and monomorphic**, consider adenosine (diagnostic/therapeutic — may unmask SVT with aberrancy; not for irregular or polymorphic rhythms).
Polymorphic VT / torsades → magnesium sulfate 25–50 mg/kg IV (max 2 g) and avoid QT-prolonging antiarrhythmics³.
Contact cardiology before starting antiarrhythmics — a single infusion of amiodarone **or** procainamide (not both: additive QT prolongation)³.

Drug	Dose	Notes
Amiodarone	5 mg/kg (max 300 mg)	IV over 20–60 min if perfusing; monitor BP ³ & QT
Procainamide	15 mg/kg	IV over 30–60 min; do not combine with amiodarone ³

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- Admit** — all → PICU with continuous monitoring and a defibrillator at the bedside.
- Home from the ward** — not from the acute episode — only after cardiology work-up and a management plan.
- Refer — now** — cardiology urgently (structural disease, channelopathy, QT/electrolytes).
- Refer — clinic** — consider genetics and family screening.

◆ READING THE TRACING

- New to pediatric rhythms?
- See a [stepwise approach to the pediatric ECG](#) and [common pediatric arrhythmias](#)



(LITFL ECG Library).



Neonatal & Infant CHD

MINUTES

RECOGNIZE BY PRESENTATION

Three ways congenital heart disease declares itself in the newborn — cyanosis, shock, or heart failure.

① CYANOSIS – DUCT-DEPENDENT PULMONARY FLOW / MIXING ("5 T'S + 1")

- Transposition of the great arteries (duct-dependent for mixing)
- Truncus arteriosus
- Total anomalous pulmonary venous drainage (obstructed type = emergency)
- Tricuspid atresia
- Tetralogy of Fallot — **only the critical / pulmonary-atresia type is duct-dependent** (ordinary TOF presents with tet spells; see below).
- + 1: critical pulmonary stenosis / atresia.
- **Assess the response to oxygen — a formal hyperoxia test is no longer routinely recommended.**³⁹ High FiO₂ can accelerate ductal closure, dangerous in a duct-dependent lesion. Use pre-/post-ductal SpO₂, chest X-ray + blood gas, and echocardiography instead. In suspected duct-dependent CHD, **do not delay alprostadil** while waiting for a hyperoxia test³⁹.

② CARDIOGENIC SHOCK / COLLAPSE – DUCT-DEPENDENT SYSTEMIC FLOW (LEFT-HEART OBSTRUCTION)

- Hypoplastic left heart
- critical coarctation
- interrupted aortic arch
- critical aortic stenosis.
- Gray, mottled shock with **weak/absent femoral pulses**, a pre-/post-ductal saturation³⁹ & blood-pressure gap, and metabolic acidosis. **Avoid high inspired oxygen** — it lowers pulmonary vascular resistance and steals from systemic flow³⁹. Start alprostadil.

③ HEART FAILURE – LEFT-TO-RIGHT SHUNTS

- VSD
- AVSD
- PDA
- (large ASD — rarely).

- **Present after the first weeks as pulmonary vascular resistance falls — not as immediate newborn emergencies;** ASD rarely causes neonatal heart failure.⁴⁰
- Tachypnea, poor feeding, sweating with feeds, hepatomegaly, faltering growth.

Suspect a duct-dependent lesion → start Prostaglandin E1 (alprostadil) before the echocardiogram³⁹



ANTICIPATE

Apnea (be ready to intubate), hypotension, fever. Urgent cardiology + transfer; carry the infusion on transfer.

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Alprostadil (prostaglandin E1)	start 0.05–0.1 → maintenance 0.01–0.02 mcg/kg/min	IV infusion; two IV lines; never interrupt; once responding, titrate to the lowest effective dose (low dose maintains patency in ~80% with less apnea and fever ³⁹). Watch for apnea (~12%), hypotension, and fever ³⁹ — be ready to support ventilation

⚠ DON'T BE CAUGHT OUT

- The collapsed neonate labeled "sepsis," "bronchiolitis," or a "cyanotic spell" may be a closing duct.
- If shock or cyanosis does not respond to oxygen and fluids, **start alprostadil empirically** while arranging an urgent echocardiogram³⁹ — do not wait for imaging.
- In duct-dependent **systemic** lesions keep SpO₂ targets modest.

◆ AVAILABILITY

- Prescribe and label as **ALPROSTADIL** (the single unambiguous name³⁹ — avoid the ambiguous "prostaglandin E1" and any trade name).
- Stocked in neonatal and cardiac units.

◆ ARRHYTHMIA

- Tachycardia — **SVT** (narrow QRS) and **VENTRICULAR TACHYCARDIA** (wide QRS): see the Supraventricular Tachycardia and Ventricular Tachycardia cards; adenosine dosing is given on the SVT card.
- Screen every well newborn before discharge — see **Critical CHD — Pulse Oximetry Screening** (Neonatal).

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any duct-dependent lesion or cyanosis/shock → NICU/PICU; keep the duct open with alprostadil.

- **Home** — only under cardiology, with a feeding/oxygen/weight plan and clear red-flag advice.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric cardiology urgently (echo) and a cardiac-surgical center; arrange safe transfer.

◆ **SEE ALSO** Newborn screening & pulmonary hypertension: [Critical CHD — Pulse Oximetry Screening](#) · [Persistent Pulmonary Hypertension \(PPHN\)](#) (Neonatal).

Hypercyanotic (Tet) Spell

MINUTES

TETRALOGY OF FALLOT

Sudden deep cyanosis, distress, and a quieter murmur in Tetralogy of Fallot.

① POSITION & CALM

Knee-to-chest position (or let the child squat). Keep calm — minimal handling. Give 100% oxygen.⁴¹



② INCREASE RV PRELOAD

Morphine to settle the cycle; fluid bolus to increase filling.⁴¹



③ INCREASE SYSTEMIC RESISTANCE / SLOW THE HEART

- Phenylephrine; beta-blocker (propranolol or esmolol). **Avoid agents that increase contractility** — they worsen the outflow obstruction.⁴¹
- Phenylephrine, IV beta-blocker, and bicarbonate (for persistent acidosis) are specialist-supported — **call PICU/cardiology early**.

Drug	Dose	Notes
Morphine	0.1–0.2 mg/kg	IV/IM/subcut; settles the spell ⁴¹
Crystalloid bolus	10–20 mL/kg	IV, increases preload
Phenylephrine	5–20 mcg/kg	IV; raises systemic vascular resistance (formulary dosing) ⁴²
Propranolol	0.05–0.1 mg/kg	slow IV; alternative to esmolol (formulary dosing) ⁴²
Esmolol	500 mcg/kg IV load over 1 min, then 50–300 mcg/kg/min infusion	IV beta-blocker alternative to propranolol (formulary dosing) ⁴²
Sodium bicarbonate	1 mmol/kg	IV, if significant metabolic acidosis

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any spell → monitored bed/PICU; recurrent or severe spells need urgent intervention.

- **Home from the ward** — only after cardiology review, a spell-management plan (knee-chest, hydration, propranolol as advised), and caregiver education.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric cardiology urgently — a spell often brings surgical repair forward.

◆ **SEE ALSO** [Neonatal & Infant CHD](#) for duct-dependent lesions and alprostadil.

Blocked Systemic-to-Pulmonary Shunt (BT / Sano)

MINUTES

Shunt-dependent CHD

Sudden cyanosis with a **lost shunt murmur** — the shunt is occluding; a peripheral-hospital emergency.

▶ RECOGNIZE IT – THE SHUNT IS BLOCKING

- Known **shunt-dependent** cyanotic CHD (modified **Blalock–Taussig** or **Sano** shunt) with **acute, severe cyanosis**.^{43,44} *Modified Blalock–Taussig shunt*: a tube graft from the subclavian or innominate artery to the pulmonary artery. *Sano shunt*: a tube graft from the right ventricle to the pulmonary artery, used in the first-stage (Norwood) operation for hypoplastic left heart syndrome.
- **Loss of the continuous shunt murmur** (a patent shunt has continuous turbulent flow; an occluded shunt has no flow).⁴⁵
- **Sudden desaturation**, then **hypotension and metabolic acidosis**; falling PaO₂, rising lactate, falling cerebral NIRS from baseline.^{43,44}
- **Echo: reduced or absent flow** across the shunt confirms it — but do **not** delay treatment for imaging.^{44,45}

⚠ CALL FOR HELP NOW

- **Call cardiac ICU/PICU + cardiothoracic surgery + cardiology immediately**, and activate your retrieval service.^{43,44}
- The physiology to fix it: **drive more blood across the shunt — raise systemic vascular resistance (SVR) and lower pulmonary vascular resistance (PVR) — while you anticoagulate**.⁴⁴

① **RESUSCITATE (airway & oxygen)** — Secure the airway and ventilate; give **100% oxygen** and optimize oxygenation.⁴⁴ Urgent echo — but do not delay treatment.^{44,45}



② **RAISE SVR (push flow across the shunt)** — Fluid bolus **5 mL/kg** aliquots (4% albumin), reassessing; add a vasoconstrictor — **phenylephrine 3–10 mcg/kg slow IV**, or **norepinephrine 0.1 mcg/kg/min**, or **epinephrine up to 0.05 mcg/kg/min**.⁴⁴



③ **LOWER PVR (unload the lungs)** — Deepen **sedation + paralysis**; **hyperventilate** to lower PaCO₂ (mild respiratory alkalosis); keep well oxygenated.⁴⁴ **Magnesium sulfate 0.4 mmol/kg** (50%) may be added.

↓

④ **ANTICOAGULATE (stop the clot)** — Heparin 100 units/kg IV bolus, then 20 units/kg/h infusion (infants: 25–30 units/kg/h)^{44,46}; an optional **second 50 units/kg bolus** at 15 min. Restart **prostaglandin (alprostadil)** if the arterial duct has not been surgically ligated³⁹.

↓

⑤ **DEFINITIVE RESCUE** — cardiac catheterization (balloon angioplasty, stent, or thrombolysis) or emergency surgical shunt revision; ECMO to bridge a deteriorating child.^{44,47,48} Confirm with echo and transfer to the cardiac center.^{44,45}

MEDICATIONS – VASOPRESSOR, ALBUMIN AND MAGNESIUM DOSES ARE EXPERT PRACTICE; CONFIRM AGAINST YOUR CARDIAC CENTER'S PROTOCOL

Drug / product	Dose	Notes
■ SVR Phenylephrine	3–10 mcg/kg slow IV	Raises SVR ⁴⁴ ; dilute before use (e.g., 10 mg in 100 mL, then 1 mL made up to 10 mL)
■ SVR Norepinephrine (noradrenaline)	0.1 mcg/kg/min infusion	Raises SVR ⁴⁴ ; central line preferred, peripheral as a bridge ^{12,13}
■ SVR Epinephrine (adrenaline)	up to 0.05 mcg/kg/min infusion	Inotrope/vasopressor support ⁴⁴
■ SVR Albumin 4%	5 mL/kg aliquots	Volume to support preload/SVR; reassess after each
■ PVR Magnesium sulfate 50%	0.4 mmol/kg IV	Pulmonary vasodilator — helps lower PVR ⁴⁹
■ CLOT Heparin	100 units/kg IV bolus ^{44,46} → 20 units/kg/h (infants: 25–30 units/kg/h) ⁴⁶ ± 50 units/kg at 15 min	Prevents clot propagation; monitor APTT / anti-Xa ^{44,46,50}
■ DUCT Prostaglandin E1 (alprostadil)	per unit protocol	If the duct is not ligated — may reopen ductal pulmonary flow ³⁹

♦ **THE TRAP**

The instinct to give a vasodilator, or deep vasodilating sedation without vasopressor support, **drops SVR and worsens shunt flow**.⁴⁴ Do the opposite — **raise SVR, lower PVR, heparinize**, and get the child to the cath lab or operating room.⁴⁴ **A lost shunt murmur in a cyanotic child is the shunt occluding until proven otherwise.**^{44,45}

Prevent the second attack — every recurrence adds valve damage.

▲ DIAGNOSE — JONES 2015 (REVISED)

- Need **evidence of preceding group A strep** (rising/elevated ASO **or** anti-DNase B, or positive throat swab/RADT, or recent scarlet fever) **plus** either **2 major** or **1 major + 2 minor**⁵¹.
- Recurrence also allows **3 minor**⁵¹. **Chorea** and **indolent carditis** can be diagnostic on their own.⁵²
- Get an **echo in every suspected case** (repeat even if first is normal) — subclinical valve regurgitation counts as carditis⁵¹.

▲ USE THE MODERATE/HIGH-RISK COLUMN

- Gulf / Middle-East children are a **moderate-to-high-risk** population — applying low-risk thresholds under-diagnoses ARF⁵¹.
- In this group a **single joint (mono-arthritis or even mono-arthralgia)** and a **lower fever/ESR threshold** already count⁵¹.

Jones 2015	Low-risk population	Moderate / high-risk (Gulf)
Major	Carditis (clinical or subclinical on echo) · migratory polyarthritis (flitting, large joints) · chorea · erythema marginatum · subcutaneous nodules ⁵¹	Same, except joints = mono-arthritis, polyarthritis, or polyarthralgia ⁵¹
Minor	Polyarthralgia · fever ≥ 38.5 °C · ESR ≥ 60 mm/h and/or CRP ≥ 3.0 mg/dL · prolonged PR (if carditis not a major) ⁵¹	Mono-arthralgia · fever ≥ 38 °C · ESR ≥ 30 mm/h and/or CRP ≥ 3.0 mg/dL · prolonged PR (if carditis not a major) ⁵¹

A manifestation counts once — polyarthritis as a major cannot also be counted as a minor⁵¹.

TREAT

Target	What to give
Eradicate GAS (everyone, even if swab negative)	Benzathine penicillin G IM once: ≤ 27 kg → 600,000 units; > 27 kg → 1,200,000 units. Alt: penicillin V PO $\times 10$ d; if allergic, azithromycin 12 mg/kg/day (max 500 mg) $\times 5$ d. ⁵³
Arthritis / mild carditis	Aspirin 50–60 mg/kg/day PO in 4–5 divided doses (may be escalated to 80–100 mg/kg/day), continued until symptoms and inflammatory markers settle, then tapered; watch for tinnitus/hyperpnea (salicylate toxicity). Naproxen/ibuprofen are now preferred first-line for the arthritis. ⁵⁴
Moderate–severe carditis / heart failure	Consider prednisone/prednisolone 1–2 mg/kg/day (max 80 mg) in selected severe carditis, then taper, overlapping aspirin — overall benefit in meta-analyses is not evident. Diuretic + ACE inhibitor for heart failure; bed rest. ⁵⁴

Target	What to give
Sydenham chorea	Usually self-limited — quiet environment, protect from injury. If disabling: carbamazepine (first-line) or valproate (off-label); a corticosteroid may be added for very severe chorea. Salicylates do not treat the chorea itself. ⁵⁴

SECONDARY PROPHYLAXIS – BENZATHINE PENICILLIN G IM EVERY 3–4 WEEKS (≤ 27 KG 600,000 U; > 27 KG 1,200,000 U)⁵³

Category (from last attack)	Duration
ARF without carditis	5 years or until age 21 (whichever longer) ⁵³
Carditis, no residual valve disease	10 years or until age 21 (whichever longer) ⁵³
Carditis with residual valve disease	10 years or until age 40 — often lifelong ⁵³

◆ **IF THE IM INJECTION IS DECLINED** Oral **PENICILLIN V 250 MG TWICE DAILY** is an accepted alternative for secondary prophylaxis (sulfadiazine if penicillin-allergic) — but adherence is worse and it is **LESS EFFECTIVE THAN IM BENZATHINE**, which remains preferred⁵³.

✦ THE POINT OF THE CARD

- Treatment settles the attack; **prophylaxis prevents rheumatic heart disease**.⁵²
- Recurrences are cumulative valve damage — document the injection schedule and hand it over so it is never missed.⁵²

Pericarditis & Cardiac Tamponade MINUTES ESC 2015 • ESC 2025

Tamponade is a clinical diagnosis — drain, don't wait for the scan.

▴ PERICARDITIS – 2 OF 4

- Pleuritic chest pain **relieved by sitting forward**^{55,56}
- pericardial **friction rub**^{55,56}
- **widespread ST elevation / PR depression** on ECG (not one coronary territory)⁵⁵
- new/worsening **pericardial effusion** on echo.^{55,56}
- Supportive: raised CRP/ESR.⁵⁶
- Causes — viral/idiopathic (commonest), purulent, post-pericardiotomy, autoimmune (SLE, JIA), uremic, TB, malignancy^{55,56}.

⚠️ TAMPONADE – RECOGNIZE AND ACT

- **Beck's triad** (hypotension, muffled heart sounds, and raised JVP) + **tachycardia** and a **narrow pulse pressure**; **pulsus paradoxus > 10 mmHg** (inspiratory drop in systolic BP)⁵⁵.
- Children compensate then crash — tachycardia is the early sign. **A small effusion can tamponade if it accumulates fast** — volume on echo does not equal severity; the clinical picture does⁵⁵.
- Beck's triad and pulsus are often incomplete — their absence does not exclude it⁵⁵.

DECISION

Hemodynamic compromise (tamponade)?

YES

Emergency echo-guided pericardiocentesis — removing even a small volume rescues output⁵⁵. **IV fluid 10–20 mL/kg is a bridge only**, never a substitute (expert consensus — not guideline-stated). **Maintain systemic vascular resistance** with a vasopressor — **norepinephrine** (± **vasopressin**) — as a temporizing bridge to support coronary and systemic perfusion; keep the circulation **full, fast, and tight** (preload, avoid bradycardia, support afterload; expert consensus — not guideline-stated). **Avoid intubation / positive-pressure ventilation** — it drops preload and can cause arrest⁵⁵; if unavoidable, drain first, low tidal volume/PEEP, keep volume-loaded (expert consensus — not guideline-stated). Avoid diuretics/vasodilators.⁵⁷ Call **cardiology + cardiac surgery + PICU** in parallel (local practice).

NO

Uncomplicated pericarditis: **NSAID (ibuprofen) + colchicine** — colchicine halves recurrence⁵⁵. Treat the cause; restrict strenuous exercise until symptom-free with normal CRP/ECG/echo.⁵⁵ Steroids are second-line (increase recurrence)⁵⁵.

Drug	Pediatric dose	Notes
Ibuprofen	30–40 mg/kg/day divided every 6–8 h (max ~2.4 g/day) ⁵⁵	First-line anti-inflammatory; give with gastroprotection, taper on CRP ⁵⁵ .
Colchicine	< 5 yr: 0.5 mg/day · > 5 yr: 1–1.5 mg/day divided ⁵⁵	First-line adjunct — halves recurrence; reduce in renal impairment. ^{55,58}

Drug	Pediatric dose	Notes
Purulent pericarditis	Urgent drainage + IV vancomycin + 3rd-gen cephalosporin, ~3–4 weeks (antibiotic choice and duration: expert consensus — not guideline-stated) ⁵⁷	Surgical emergency — NSAIDs alone are inadequate; narrow to culture ⁵⁵ .

✦ THE TRAP

Don't reach for the ventilator in a crashing tamponade — positive-pressure ventilation can be the last straw. **Drain first.** And treat **purulent pericarditis** as the surgical emergency it is.^{55,57}

Infective Endocarditis (incl. Subacute) HOURS Modified Duke / AHA

Fever + a new murmur + positive cultures — think endocarditis; diagnose by the modified Duke criteria.

▶ SUSPECT IT – SUBACUTE CLUES

- Persistent/unexplained fever with a **new or changed regurgitant murmur** — the classic pairing.^{59,60}
- Subacute course over weeks: malaise, weight loss, night sweats, anorexia.⁵⁹
Viridans-group streptococci are the commonest cause in children with underlying heart disease (typically subacute native-valve disease); **S. aureus** dominates in children without heart disease and in acute disease⁶¹.
- Peripheral stigmata (late; immune-mediated or embolic): **splinter hemorrhages**, tender **Osler nodes**, painless **Janeway lesions**, **Roth spots**⁶², splenomegaly, embolic phenomena.^{60,63}
- At-risk: **congenital heart disease**, prosthetic valve/material, previous IE, indwelling central lines, IV drug use.^{59,64}

▶ MODIFIED DUKE CRITERIA – HOW TO CLASSIFY

- **DEFINITE** (clinical) = **2 major**, or **1 major + 3 minor**, or **5 minor**.^{62,64}
- **POSSIBLE** = **1 major + 1 minor**, or **3 minor**.^{62,64}
- **REJECTED** = firm alternative diagnosis, or resolution with ≤ 4 days of antibiotics⁶².

DECISION

The two **MAJOR** criteria

MICROBIOLOGY

Typical organism from ≥ 2 separate blood cultures (viridans streptococci, *S. gallolyticus/bovis*, HACEK group, *S. aureus*, or community-acquired enterococci with no primary focus), **or persistently positive** cultures of a compatible organism⁶².

ENDOCARDIAL

Echo evidence of **endocardial involvement: vegetation, abscess**, new partial dehiscence of a prosthetic valve, **or new valvular regurgitation** (worsening of an existing murmur is not enough)⁶².

THE FIVE MINOR CRITERIA

- **Predisposition** — predisposing heart condition or IV drug use.^{62,64}
- **Fever** > 38°C.^{62,64}
- **Vascular phenomena** — arterial emboli, septic pulmonary infarcts, mycotic aneurysm, intracranial or conjunctival hemorrhage, **Janeway lesions**.^{62,64}
- **Immunologic phenomena** — glomerulonephritis, **Osler nodes**, **Roth spots**, rheumatoid factor.^{62,64}
- **Microbiologic** evidence not meeting a major criterion⁶². (The 2023 Duke-ISCVID update adds imaging and surgical criteria and new predispositions.⁶⁴)

WORKUP – GET IT RIGHT THE FIRST TIME

- **Draw ≥ 3 sets of blood cultures** from separate venipunctures **before** starting antibiotics — the single most important step for diagnosis and tailoring therapy.^{59,65}
- Echo: **TTE first**; proceed to **TEE** if TTE is non-diagnostic, a prosthetic valve is present, or suspicion stays high.^{59,65}
- Add ESR/CRP, CBC, and urinalysis (microscopic hematuria supports it).⁶³ Do **not** delay antibiotics in a septic/unstable child once cultures are drawn.¹²

◆ Endocarditis prophylaxis (AHA / ESC 2023) — who

Prophylaxis needs **BOTH** a highest-risk cardiac condition **AND** a high-risk procedure.^{65,66} The **HIGHEST-RISK CARDIAC CONDITIONS**:

1. **PROSTHETIC HEART VALVE** (surgical or transcatheter) or prosthetic material used for valve repair.^{65,66}
2. **PREVIOUS INFECTIVE ENDOCARDITIS**.^{65,66}
3. **UNREPAIRED CYANOTIC CHD** (including palliative shunts/conduits).^{65,66}
4. Completely **REPAIRED CHD WITH PROSTHETIC MATERIAL/DEVICE** — during the **FIRST 6 MONTHS** after the procedure.⁶⁶
5. **REPAIRED CHD WITH A RESIDUAL DEFECT** at or adjacent to the prosthetic patch/device.⁶⁶
6. **CARDIAC TRANSPLANT** recipients who develop **VALVULOPATHY**.⁶⁶
7. **VENTRICULAR ASSIST DEVICE (VAD)** — added by **ESC 2023**.⁶⁵

◆ **ESC 2023 EMPHASIS**: for all **INTERMEDIATE- AND HIGH-RISK** patients, **GOOD ORAL HYGIENE AND REGULAR DENTAL REVIEW** prevent more endocarditis than any single antibiotic dose.^{65,67}

◆ Endocarditis prophylaxis (AHA) — which procedures

- **DENTAL** — any procedure that manipulates **GINGIVAL TISSUE** or the **PERIAPICAL REGION** of teeth, or **PERFORATES THE ORAL MUCOSA** (extractions, scaling, periodontal work, implants). Anesthetic injections through non-infected tissue, radiographs, orthodontic appliance placement or adjustment, and shedding of deciduous teeth do **NOT** count.^{65,66}
- **RESPIRATORY TRACT** — procedures with **INCISION OR BIOPSY OF THE RESPIRATORY MUCOSA** (e.g., **TONSILLECTOMY, ADENOIDECTOMY**, bronchoscopy **WITH BIOPSY**).⁶⁷ If the airway procedure treats an established infection, add an anti-staphylococcal agent when *S. aureus* is suspected.⁶⁷
- **INFECTED SKIN, SKIN STRUCTURES, OR MUSCULOSKELETAL TISSUE** — regimen should cover **STAPHYLOCOCCI AND B-HEMOLYTIC STREPTOCOCCI**.⁶⁷
- **NOT RECOMMENDED** for **GI OR GU PROCEDURES**, or for bronchoscopy/endoscopy **WITHOUT** incision/biopsy, solely to prevent endocarditis.⁶⁷
- ◆ **ESC 2023** is less restrictive for non-dental procedures — systemic prophylaxis **MAY BE CONSIDERED** (Class IIb) in high-risk patients undergoing an invasive diagnostic or therapeutic respiratory, GI, GU, skin, or musculoskeletal procedure.⁶⁵ Where the two guidelines differ, follow your local protocol.

PROPHYLAXIS REGIMEN — SINGLE DOSE 30-60 MIN BEFORE THE PROCEDURE⁶⁶

Situation	Pediatric dose (single)	Max
Able to take oral	Amoxicillin 50 mg/kg PO ⁶⁶	2 g ⁶⁶
Unable to take oral	Ampicillin 50 mg/kg IM/IV, or cefazolin / ceftriaxone 50 mg/kg IM/IV ⁶⁶	Ampicillin 2 g · cefazolin/ceftriaxone 1 g ⁶⁶
Penicillin allergy — oral	Cephalexin 50 mg/kg, or azithromycin / clarithromycin 15 mg/kg, or doxycycline (< 45 kg 2.2 mg/kg; ≥ 45 kg 100 mg) ⁶⁶	Cephalexin 2 g · azithromycin/clarithromycin 500 mg · doxycycline 100 mg ⁶⁶
Penicillin allergy — no oral	Cefazolin or ceftriaxone 50 mg/kg IM/IV ⁶⁶	1 g ⁶⁶

◆ **THE TRAP**

Clindamycin is no longer recommended (dropped in the 2021 AHA update⁶⁶ — *C. difficile* risk and adverse effects). Prophylaxis is **not** indicated for most CHD, nor for routine GI/GU procedures.^{66,67} Avoid cephalosporins if there is a history of anaphylaxis, angioedema, or urticaria to penicillin.⁶⁶ **Good oral hygiene and regular dental care prevent more endocarditis than any single antibiotic dose.**^{66,67}

Fever in a Well-Appearing Infant < 2 Months

HOURS

≤ 60 DAYS • CPS 2026 / AAP 2021

Most are viral — but ~8–13% have a serious bacterial infection⁶⁸. Define fever as rectal $\geq 38.0^{\circ}\text{C}$; stratify risk and spare the low-risk from over-testing.

SCOPE & FIRST MOVE

- This pathway is for the **well-appearing, full-term (≥ 37 wk), previously healthy** infant with a documented **rectal temperature $\geq 38.0^{\circ}\text{C}$** . Hypothermia $< 36.0^{\circ}\text{C}$ carries the same risk — manage identically⁶⁸.
- **This pathway does not apply to the ill-appearing at any age.**
- **Risk factors that are not applicable to this pathway:** prematurity < 37 wk, prior or prolonged hospitalization, a chronic / genetic / technology-dependent condition, immunodeficiency, recent antibiotics, or any focal bacterial infection (e.g., omphalitis, cellulitis).

KEEP A HIGH INDEX OF SUSPICION

- Even a well-appearing infant can deteriorate quickly.
- The youngest ($\leq 21\text{--}28$ days) have the highest risk of **invasive bacterial infection (IBI)** — bacteremia or bacterial meningitis) and the **lowest threshold** for full work-up, LP, empiric antibiotics, and admission⁶⁸.

EVERYONE GETS

- **All ages:** history + exam, **urinalysis + urine culture** (catheter or suprapubic; clean-catch acceptable), **blood culture, CBC + differential**, and an **inflammatory marker** — procalcitonin (PCT) or CRP.
- **Risk-stratify with a validated rule:** **PECARN** or **Step-by-Step** (both use PCT), or **Aronson** when PCT is unavailable — keep a **lower threshold for LP** with Aronson⁶⁹.
- **CSF pleocytosis** = > 15 cells/ mm^3 (≤ 28 d) or > 9 cells/ mm^3 (> 28 d) → treat as bacterial meningitis. Don't delay the LP if there are neurological signs.⁶⁹

RISK STRATIFICATION – VALIDATED LOW-RISK RULES

Rule	Low risk if ALL criteria are met
PECARN (uses PCT)	1) Urinalysis negative (leukocyte esterase, nitrite, ≤ 5 WBC/hpf); 2) ANC $\leq 4000/\mu\text{L}$; 3) PCT ≤ 0.5 ng/mL ^{69,70}
Step-by-Step (uses PCT)	1) Well-appearing; 2) 22–90 days; 3) urinalysis negative for leukocytes; 4) PCT < 0.5 ng/mL; 5) CRP ≤ 20 mg/L and ANC $\leq 10,000/\mu\text{L}$ ^{69,71}

Aronson (no PCT — keep a lower LP threshold)

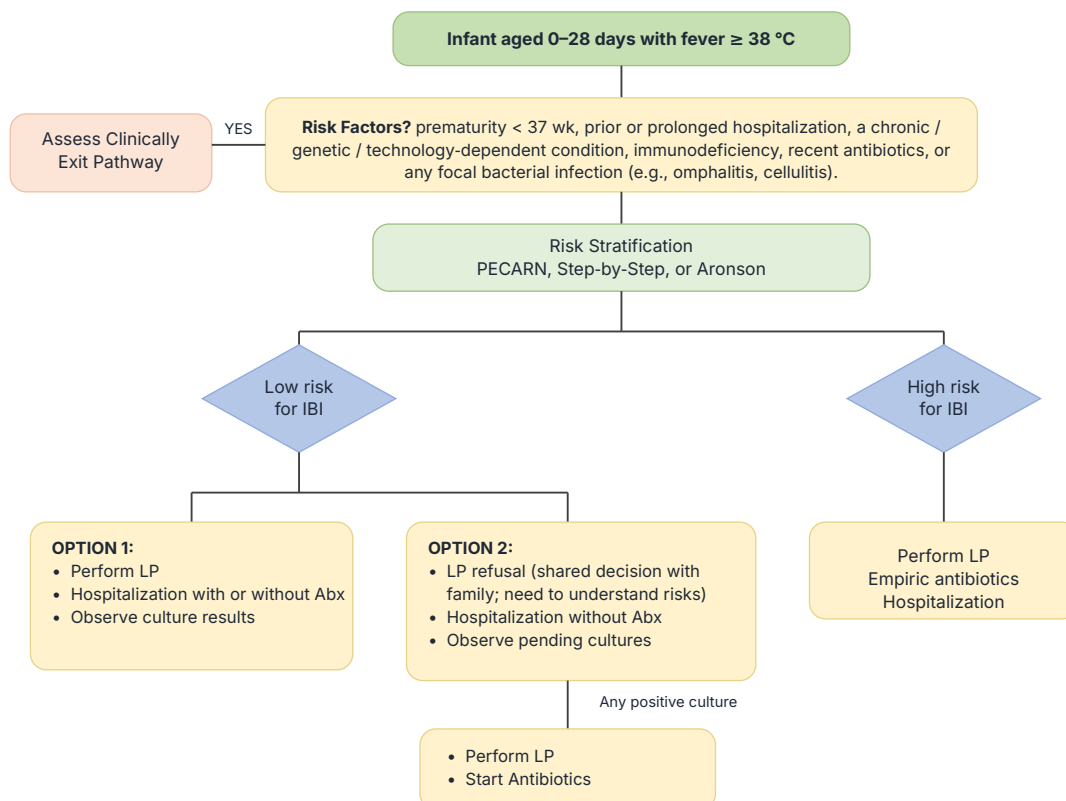
Low risk if ≤ 1 point: age < 21 d (1) · ED temp 38.0–38.4°C (2) or $\geq 38.5^\circ\text{C}$ (4) · ANC $\geq 5185/\mu\text{L}$ (2) · urinalysis positive (3)^{69,72}

◆ APPLYING THE RULES – PCT TIMING & ALTERNATIVES

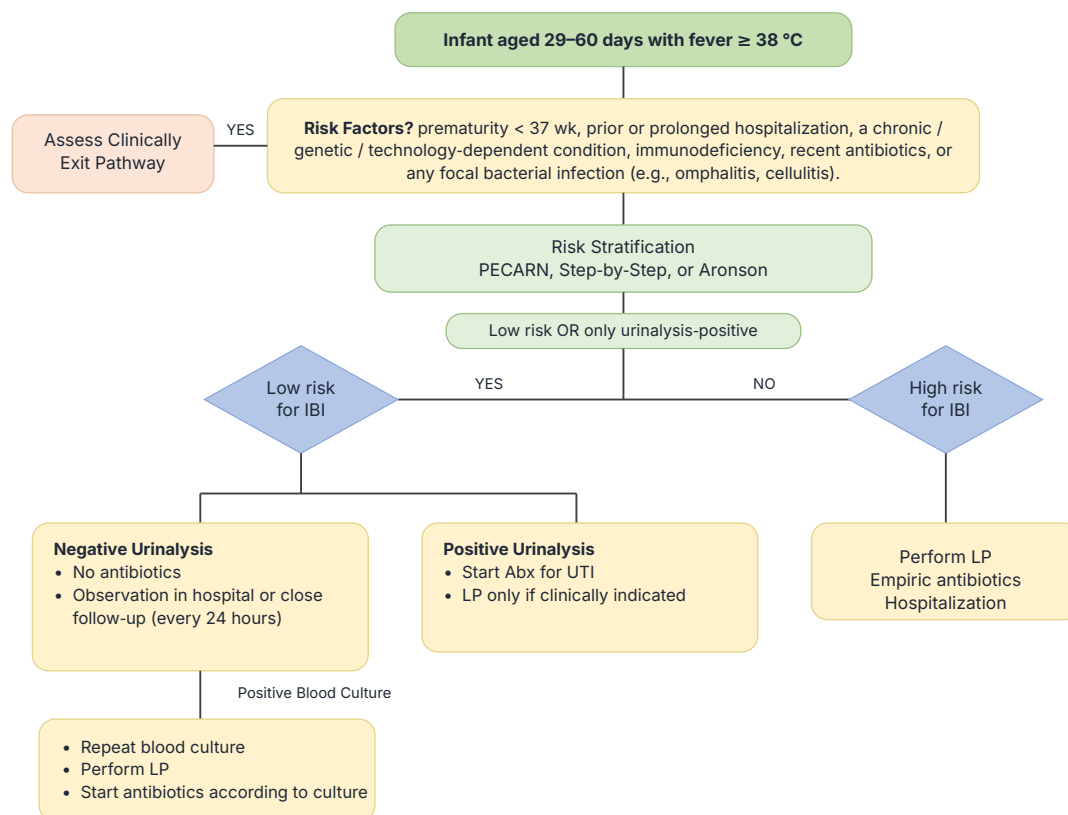
- Where **PROCALCITONIN IS NOT READILY AVAILABLE**, PECARN and Step-by-Step (both require PCT) **CANNOT BE FULLY APPLIED**. Use an alternative: the **ARONSON** rule (no PCT needed) and keep a **LOWER THRESHOLD FOR LP**; **CRP ≤ 20 MG/L** with a normal ANC and urinalysis still support lower risk.
- When PCT **IS** obtained, draw it **≥ 2 H AFTER FEVER ONSET** — it rises $\sim 3\text{--}4$ h after a bacterial trigger, so very early samples can read falsely low⁷³. It typically **STAYS LOW (< 0.5 NG/ML)** in isolated viral illness.
- Missed invasive infection with Step-by-Step clusters in the **22-28-DAY** group and in infants tested very early — keep a low threshold in these.⁷¹

FEVER PATHWAY ALGORITHMS (WELL-APPEARING, ≥ 37 WEEKS)

Algorithm 1 – infant 0-28 days with fever $\geq 38^\circ\text{C}$



Algorithm 2 – infant 29–60 days with fever $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$



EMPIRIC ANTIBIOTICS – WELL-APPEARING, ≥ 37 WEEKS

Age	First-line IV	Modifiers
0–7 days	Ampicillin 75 mg/kg/dose q6h + gentamicin 4 mg/kg/dose q24h ⁶⁹	Meningitis: add — or replace the aminoglycoside with — cefotaxime 50 mg/kg/dose q8h. HSV risk: add acyclovir 20 mg/kg/dose q8h.
8–28 days	Ampicillin 75 mg/kg/dose q6h + gentamicin 5 mg/kg/dose q24h ⁶⁹	Meningitis: add — or replace the aminoglycoside with — cefotaxime 50 mg/kg/dose q6h (200 mg/kg/day for meningitis at this age). HSV risk: add acyclovir 20 mg/kg/dose q8h.
29–60 days	Ceftriaxone 100 mg/kg/dose q24h ⁶⁹	Meningitis: add vancomycin 15 mg/kg/dose q6h. HSV risk: add acyclovir 20 mg/kg/dose q8h. Low-risk UTI: cefixime 8 mg/kg/dose q24h PO. ^{68,69}

◆ **BEYOND 60 DAYS** The well-appearing infant **61–90 DAYS** falls outside this pathway: risk of invasive infection is lower and routine blood culture / full septic work-up is **NOT REQUIRED**⁶⁹. Test **SELECTIVELY** (urinalysis ± inflammatory markers) and use clinical judgment; escalate only the ill-appearing or those with a positive screen.

◆ **SEE ALSO** For the neonate (≤ 28 days), see [Neonatal Sepsis — rapid approach](#) for neonatal-specific empiric therapy (ampicillin + gentamicin/cefotaxime $\pm$ acyclovir).

Gastroenteritis & Dehydration HOURS

Assess hydration: alertness, eyes, mucosa, skin turgor, capillary refill, urine output.

CLINICAL SIGNS OF DEHYDRATION

- Altered mental status
- sunken eyes
- dry oral mucosa
- poor skin turgor
- delayed capillary refill
- decreased urine output
- tachycardia
- abnormal peripheral perfusion.
- The more signs present, the greater the fluid deficit; no single sign is reliable alone.¹⁴

DECISION

Degree of dehydration?

NONE–MODERATE

Oral rehydration with ORS; a single ondansetron dose can reduce vomiting and the need for IV.¹⁴

SEVERE / SHOCK

IV/IO crystalloid bolus, repeat to reverse shock; then deficit + maintenance. Check glucose & electrolytes.

Drug / fluid	Dose	Route & notes
Oral rehydration solution	~50–100 mL/kg over 4 h	Oral/NG + replace ongoing losses. First-line for minimal ¹⁴ –moderate dehydration.
0.9% sodium chloride (bolus)	20 mL/kg	IV/IO rapid bolus for hypovolemia/shock; reassess during & after each bolus and repeat until perfusion is restored. If shock seems out of proportion to the diarrhea/vomiting, consider sepsis, DKA, a surgical abdomen, or myocarditis. Balanced crystalloid (e.g., Ringer's lactate) is an acceptable alternative. ¹⁴
0.9% sodium chloride (moderate)	10 mL/kg over 30–60 min	Moderate dehydration not tolerating oral — then reassess for a further bolus or transition back to ORT if tolerated.

Drug / fluid	Dose	Route & notes
Ondansetron	0.15 mg/kg/dose – single dose, max 8 mg (either route). Weight-based: 2 mg (8–15 kg) • 4 mg (15–30 kg) • 8 mg (> 30 kg)	PO preferred; age ≥ 6 months only . Reduces vomiting and the need for IV. Restart ORT 15–30 min after the dose . Ondansetron prolongs the QT interval dose-dependently — do not exceed 8 mg in a single pediatric dose (the 16 mg cap is an adult chemotherapy figure, not for gastroenteritis) ⁷⁴ .
Zinc (adjunct to ORS)	10 mg/day (< 6 mo) 20 mg/day (≥ 6 mo)	Oral, 10–14 days . A WHO/UNICEF measure for low- and middle-income settings where zinc deficiency is common — shortens diarrhea by ~½ day (~1 day if malnourished) concentrates at ≥ 6 months in zinc-deficient or malnourished children. Not routine in high-income, well-nourished populations including Kuwait ; reserve for malnutrition, documented zinc deficiency, or persistent / chronic diarrhea. Little benefit under 6 months. (ESPGHAN/ESPID acute-gastroenteritis guideline: zinc not recommended for well-nourished European children.) ⁷⁵
Racecadotril — optional adjunct	1.5 mg/kg/dose PO TID with ORS sachets 10 mg (≤ ~12 kg) / 30 mg (> ~13 kg). Age > 3 months. Continue until diarrhea stops (2 normal stools), max 7 days.	Antisecretory enkephalinase inhibitor — reduces stool water loss without slowing gut motility (unlike loperamide, which is contraindicated). Adjunct to ORS, not a substitute . Licensed and used in Kuwait/Europe/Asia; not FDA/NICE/AAP/CPS/WHO-endorsed . ESPGHAN/ESPID 2014: “may be considered” (II-B, weak recommendation, moderate-quality evidence; responder NNT ≈ 4). Cochrane 2019 found it safe with limited benefit (low-certainty) ⁷⁶ .

PEARLS

- Resume normal feeding (including breastfeeding) early. Antibiotics only for specific pathogens.¹⁴
- Red flags: bilious or bloody vomit, severe pain/distension (think surgical), inability to tolerate ORS.
- Zinc dosing & evidence: [WHO eLENA](#) .

▲ ADMIT • DISCHARGE • REFER

- **Admit** — shock or severe dehydration, failed oral/NG rehydration, intractable vomiting, dangerous electrolyte derangement, or diagnostic uncertainty.
- **Home from the emergency department** — minimal or mild dehydration tolerating oral rehydration, with carers confident on fluids and red-flag advice.

- **Refer — now** — surgical review if a surgical abdomen is suspected; PICU for refractory shock or severe electrolyte disturbance.

Acute Otitis Media

ASSESS

INFANT-CHILD • CPS 2016 / AAP 2013

Diagnose by the drum, not the symptoms — then choose between watchful waiting and antibiotics.

CLINICAL DIAGNOSIS – EFFUSION + ACUTE INFLAMMATION

- Acute onset (otalgia, ear-tugging, or non-specific signs in the non-verbal child) **plus** a middle-ear effusion **plus** signs of acute inflammation.
- **A bulging tympanic membrane is the key sign** — highest predictive value for bacterial AOM, especially if yellow, cloudy, or hemorrhagic.⁷⁷ Acute perforation with purulent otorrhea also confirms a bacterial cause — distinguish from otitis externa, chronic drainage, or tube discharge.
- **Not AOM:** a non-bulging drum, or erythema / air-fluid level alone without bulging. Effusion without inflammation is OME⁷⁷ — do not give antibiotics.
- **Scope:** the **watchful-waiting** option applies only to healthy children **≥ 6 months** (CPS 2016 / AAP 2013)^{77,78}. **Infants < 6 months are excluded from observation⁷⁷** — treat all with antibiotics. Excludes tympanostomy tubes, craniofacial anomalies, immunocompromise, or recurrent AOM.

DECISION BY AGE & SEVERITY

DECISION

How old is the child, and how severe?

< 6 MONTHS

Antibiotics for all — no watchful waiting (below the CPS/AAP observation range; the exam is less reliable and complications are more likely). In a **febrile infant ≤ 90 days**, do **not** attribute the fever to AOM alone — evaluate for invasive bacterial infection (see [Fever in the Well-Appearing Infant](#)).

≥ 6 MO – TREAT NOW

Bulging, erythematous TM **and** any of: highly febrile ($\geq 39^{\circ}\text{C}$), moderately-to-severely ill, severe otalgia, symptoms ≥ 48 h, perforation with otorrhea, or complicated disease (mastoiditis, facial palsy).⁷⁷

≥ 6 MO – WATCHFUL WAITING (24–48 H)

Otherwise-healthy child, mildly ill, alert, responding to antipyretics, low-grade fever ($< 39^{\circ}\text{C}$), mild otalgia — or when the diagnosis is uncertain. Needs assured follow-up.

◆ HOW TO WATCHFUL-WAIT (CHOOSE ONE)

- Reassess within 24–48 h to document the course; **OR** have the caregiver return if no improvement or worsening by 48 h; **OR** give a “safety-net” prescription to fill only if not improved by 48 h.
- Always give analgesia advice; ensure ready access to care.

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Amoxicillin (first choice)	40–45 mg/kg/dose BID	PO. Drug of choice — covers <i>S. pneumoniae</i> ; excellent middle-ear penetration. ⁷⁷
Amoxicillin-clavulanate	40–45 mg/kg/dose BID (amoxicillin component)	PO. If AOM + purulent conjunctivitis, amoxicillin in the last 30 days, or failure at 48–72 h. Specify the 14:1 suspension. ⁷⁷
Cefuroxime-axetil	15 mg/kg/dose BID (30 mg/kg/day; max 1 g/day)	PO, twice daily. Non-anaphylactic penicillin allergy (cefprozil is an alternative).
Ceftriaxone	50 mg/kg IM/IV once daily × 3 days	If oral not tolerated or amoxicillin-clavulanate failed. Reserve.

◆ DURATION – BY AGE

- < 2 years: 10 days. ≥ 2 years, uncomplicated: 5 days (CPS 2016; AAP 2013 gives 7 days for 2–5 years and 5–7 days for ≥ 6 years).^{77,78}
- Also 10 days for a perforated TM or recurrent AOM.
- Symptoms should improve within 24 h and resolve in 2–3 days — reassess if they persist or worsen.

⚠ ANALGESIA IS PART OF EVERY PLAN

- Pain control (acetaminophen or ibuprofen) is essential whether or not antibiotics are given — it is often the child's main need.
- Persistent effusion after treatment does **not** warrant a change of antibiotic; a middle-ear effusion can linger for months.⁷⁷

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — a complication (mastoiditis, intracranial spread, facial palsy), a toxic child, or failure of second-line therapy.
- **Home from the emergency department** — uncomplicated disease — analgesia, with observation or antibiotics per age and severity, and safety-netting.
- **Refer — now** — ENT for suspected mastoiditis or complicated disease.
- **Refer — clinic** — ENT for recurrent disease or a non-resolving effusion.

GAS Pharyngitis

ASSESS

≥ 3 YR • IDSA 2025

Most sore throats are viral. Score first to decide who needs a test — then treat the confirmed case.

▀ WHEN TO TEST – SCORE FIRST

- Sore throat is usually viral, and clinician judgment alone is unreliable. GAS causes up to ~30% of childhood (and ~15% of adult) pharyngitis.⁷⁹
- IDSA 2025 suggests a **clinical scoring system to decide who to test**. A score is most useful for spotting **low-probability** patients in whom testing is unlikely to help — prefer a score that needs no lab (Centor / McIsaac).⁷⁹
- **Does not apply under 3 years** — GAS in this age may not show the typical features; test only for an outbreak, scarlet fever, or a household case.⁸⁰
- Score criteria point to GAS: fever, tonsillar swelling or exudate, tender anterior cervical nodes, and **absence of cough**. Cough, coryza, or hoarseness point to a virus.

Centor / McIsaac – one point each	Point
Tonsillar exudate or swelling	+1
Tender / swollen anterior cervical nodes	+1
History of fever	+1
No cough	+1
Age 3–14 years (McIsaac)	+1

◆ HOW TO TEST

- Read the score as a probability of GAS: **≤1 LOW** (~1–10%) → testing can be deferred; **2–3 INTERMEDIATE** (~11–35%) → test; **≥4 HIGH** (~50%) → test, and still confirm before treating.⁷⁹
- Test with a rapid antigen test (RADT), a molecular test (NAAT), or throat culture.
- In children, confirm a **NEGATIVE** rapid antigen test with culture, or use a molecular test.⁸⁰
- The score selects *who to test* — never a treatment threshold.
- Do **NOT** use ASO titers to diagnose acute pharyngitis.⁷⁹
- Start treatment within 9 days of onset.

⚠ TEST EVEN IF THE SCORE IS LOW

Test regardless of a low score when the patient is high-risk: a **household GAS case** (shared indoor living or sleeping space), prior **rheumatic fever**, or features of complicated or systemic GAS — peritonsillar or retropharyngeal abscess, scarlet fever, or toxic shock.⁷⁹

Lab-confirmed GAS	Drug & dose	Duration
First choice	Amoxicillin 50 mg/kg once daily (max 1 g), or penicillin V ⁸⁰	10 days
Poor adherence expected	Benzathine penicillin G IM – < 27 kg: 600,000 U; ≥ 27 kg: 1,200,000 U	1 dose
Non-immediate (delayed / non-IgE) penicillin allergy	Cephalexin 20 mg/kg/dose BID (max 500 mg/dose) ♦ if unavailable: cefuroxime-axetil 20 mg/kg/day ÷ BID (max 500 mg/day) PO	10 days
Documented penicillin anaphylaxis / IgE-mediated (immediate) reaction	Azithromycin 12 mg/kg on day 1 (max 500 mg) then 6 mg/kg (max 250 mg) once daily on days 2–5 (IDSA, as corrected 2014) ⁸⁰ – the FDA-labeled 12 mg/kg once daily × 5 days (max 500 mg/day) is an accepted alternative. ⁵³ or clarithromycin 7.5 mg/kg/dose BID (max 250 mg/dose) × 10 days or clindamycin 7 mg/kg/dose TID (max 300 mg/dose) × 10 days	5–10 days

⚠ WHY WE TREAT

- Antibiotics prevent suppurative complications and acute rheumatic fever (but not post-streptococcal glomerulonephritis). **All GAS is penicillin-susceptible**, but macrolide/clindamycin resistance reaches ~20% and varies locally — reserve those for true penicillin anaphylaxis and confirm local susceptibility.⁸⁰
- Acetaminophen or ibuprofen for pain and fever; corticosteroids are not recommended as analgesic adjuncts.⁷⁹

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — rarely — complications (peritonsillar abscess, dehydration, systemic illness).
- **Home from the emergency department** — most, with antibiotics and safety-net advice.
- **Refer — now** — ENT for abscess.
- **Refer — clinic** — ENT for recurrent tonsillitis.

Urinary Tract Infection

HOURS

> 2 MONTHS

A common occult source of fever in infants — get a reliable sample before antibiotics.

◀ WHEN TO SUSPECT & TEST

- **Preverbal child** with unexplained fever ($> 39^{\circ}\text{C}$, no source) — especially **fever > 48 h** without another focus. A clear viral source (coryza, cough, diarrhea, rash) makes UTI unlikely.⁸¹
- **Verbal child (≥ 3 yr)**: dysuria, frequency, hematuria, abdominal/back pain, or new daytime incontinence. Beware bubble-bath / hygiene vulvovaginitis — sterile cultures, often mis-treated as UTI.
- **Usual pathogens**: *E. coli* (most), then *Klebsiella*, *Enterobacter*, *Citrobacter*, *Serratia*; *S. saprophyticus* in adolescent girls.⁸¹
- Do not over-diagnose: low colony counts, mixed growth, or **no pyuria** usually mean contamination or asymptomatic bacteriuria.

SAMPLING – BEFORE ANTIBIOTICS

- **Toilet-trained**: clean-catch midstream. **Not toilet-trained**: catheter or suprapubic aspirate for culture.
- A bag specimen may screen the urinalysis but its culture is unreliable (contamination up to 63%) — never use it to diagnose.⁸¹
- A single antibiotic dose sterilizes urine; always collect first.⁸¹

◆ **INTERPRETING THE URINALYSIS** UTI is unlikely if the urinalysis is completely normal. **LEUKOCYTE ESTERASE OR NITRITE POSITIVE** $\approx 93\%$ sensitive; **NITRITE ALONE** is highly specific ($\sim 98\%$) but often falsely negative (frequent voiding, Gram-positive / non-nitrate organisms)⁸¹. **PYURIA** (> 5 WBC/HPF, or $\geq 10/\mu\text{L}$) supports infection.

DIAGNOSTIC COLONY-COUNT THRESHOLDS

Collection method	Minimum count (CFU/mL)	Note
Clean catch / midstream	$\geq 10^5$	Mixed growth usually = contamination.
In-and-out catheter	$\geq 5 \times 10^4$	Indwelling-catheter specimens less reliable.
Suprapubic aspirate	Any growth	Most reliable method. ⁸¹

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — young infants, ill/septic, unable to tolerate oral, or complicated/obstructive UTI.
- **Home** — well child on oral antibiotics with follow-up.
- **Refer — clinic** — nephrology/urology for recurrent, atypical, or obstructive UTI, or abnormal imaging.

UTI – Treatment & Follow-up

HOURS

LOCAL SUSCEPTIBILITY

Oral is fine for most non-toxic children — pick the empiric agent from your antibiogram; plan for ESBL.

DECISION

Cystitis or febrile UTI / pyelonephritis?

CYSTITIS • AFEBRILE LOWER TRACT

Dysuria/frequency, no fever (mainly post-pubertal girls). **2–4 days** of an oral agent chosen by local *E. coli* susceptibility. No imaging needed.⁸²

FEBRILE UTI / PYELONEPHRITIS

Treat **7–10 days**. **Oral is as effective as IV** in non-toxic children likely to tolerate every dose.⁸¹ Use IV initially if toxic, < 2–3 months, vomiting, or unable to tolerate oral — then step down.

◆ ESBL RISK – PLAN FOR IT

- ESBL-producing Enterobacterales are increasingly isolated even without prior antibiotics — often resistant to cephalosporins and many oral agents.
- Where local ESBL rates are high or the child is high-risk: **AMIKACIN (IV)** is the most reliable aminoglycoside — active against the large majority of pediatric ESBL isolates, whereas gentamicin is variable (roughly half)^{83,84,85}. **TMP-SMX (PO)** is a useful oral step-down once susceptibility is confirmed, though ESBL isolates are often co-resistant.
- Fluoroquinolones are not routine in prepubertal children but may be used if the isolate is resistant to other oral options and oral therapy is a reasonable alternative to parenteral treatment⁸⁶.

ANTIMICROBIAL OPTIONS – IF THE ISOLATE IS SUSCEPTIBLE

Drug	Dose	Notes
Amikacin (IV)	15 mg/kg once daily	ESBL-active empiric choice ^{83,84,85} ; once-daily 15 mg/kg per the UK SmPC; monitor levels & renal function if > 48 h. ⁸⁷
Gentamicin (IV/IM)	5–7.5 mg/kg once daily	ESBL activity variable (~half of isolates) — confirm susceptibility. Monitor levels / renal function > 48 h.
Ceftriaxone (IV/IM)	50–75 mg/kg once daily (max 2 g)	Less nephrotoxic but broader; not reliable if ESBL.
Ampicillin (IV)	50 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 2 g/dose)	± aminoglycoside; many <i>E. coli</i> now resistant. (Lexicomp)
TMP-SMX (PO)	4–5 mg/kg/dose (TMP) BID	Preferred oral step-down once susceptible — covers many ESBL isolates if tested S. ⁸¹
Cefixime (PO)	8 mg/kg/dose once daily	Common first oral choice pending susceptibilities (if low ESBL).

Drug	Dose	Notes
Cefdinir (PO)	7 mg/kg/dose BID or 14 mg/kg once daily (max 600 mg/day)	Palatable oral step-down; not always on the MOH formulary . Like cefixime, not reliable against ESBL .
Cephalexin (PO)	12.5 mg/kg/dose QID	Oral cephalosporin option.
Amoxicillin-clavulanate (PO)	13 mg/kg/dose (7:1) TID	If susceptible; amoxicillin alone often resisted.
Ciprofloxacin (PO) *	15 mg/kg/dose BID	* Not routine in prepubertal children — reserve for resistant isolates.

◀ COMPLICATED UTI – ESCALATE & IMAGE EARLY

- Hemodynamic instability, **rising creatinine**, abdominal/bladder mass, poor urine flow, or **no improvement by 24 h / fever not settling by 48 h** on appropriate antibiotics.
- Use **IV until clearly improving**; start with a **renal & bladder ultrasound (RBUS)** to look for obstruction or abscess.⁸¹

⚠ IMAGING & FOLLOW-UP

- **RBUS** after a first febrile UTI in a child **< 2 yr** (during, or within ~2 weeks of, the illness)⁸¹.
- **VCUG is not routine** — consider it after a first febrile UTI only if RBUS is abnormal (**hydronephrosis, scarring, or findings suggesting high-grade VUR or obstructive uropathy**), with an atypical pathogen or complex course, or after a **second febrile UTI**^{81,88}. A normal RBUS does not exclude VUR (**VCUG** grades reflux; **DMSA** for scarring).
- Routine antibiotic **prophylaxis is not recommended** while awaiting RBUS.⁸¹
- Repeat urinalysis / culture to confirm cure is **not recommended** unless symptoms persist.
- Counsel families to test urine early in any future unexplained fever.
- Recurrent afebrile UTI is often driven by **bladder-bowel dysfunction** — assess and treat constipation (a major, modifiable risk factor).⁸¹

Skin & Soft Tissue Infections ASSESS CPS 2026

Match the antibiotic to the layer and the pathogen — most are oral, short-course, and cephalexin-first.

▶ TYPES – BY DEPTH & MORPHOLOGY

- **Impetigo** (epidermis): non-bullous (honey-crusted) or bullous; highly contagious. Mostly group A streptococcus (GAS) / *S. aureus*.
- **Erysipelas / cellulitis** (dermis → subcutis): spreading erythema, warmth, tenderness. Non-purulent cellulitis is more often **GAS**; purulent points to *S. aureus*.⁸⁹
- **Folliculitis / furuncle / carbuncle / abscess**: discrete pus collections — *S. aureus* (methicillin-susceptible, MSSA, or methicillin-resistant, MRSA). Source control is the priority.

- **Necrotizing infection** (fascia/muscle): pain out of proportion, rapid spread, necrosis, crepitus⁸⁹ — surgical emergency. GAS ± polymicrobial.

DECISION

How severe, and is there pus?

MILD / NON-PURULENT

Impetigo or small localized lesion, systemically well — often resolves with skin/wound care alone. Limited: topical **mupirocin 2% TID × 5 days**. Widespread/multiple lesions or systemic features: oral **cephalexin**.

PURULENT — ABSCESS / FURUNCLE

Incision & drainage is the treatment. For a small, drained abscess in a healthy host without surrounding cellulitis, antibiotics are usually **not** needed; stop them once source control is achieved.⁸⁹

SEVERE / DEEP / NECROTIZING

Extensive or rapidly progressive, systemic toxicity, necrosis or crepitus → **admit, IV antibiotics, urgent surgery**. Add an anti-toxin agent (clindamycin) and consult infectious diseases.

Oral cephalexin is the antimicrobial of choice when antibiotics are warranted.

BY PATHOGEN / SETTING

Target	Drug & dose	Notes
MSSA / GAS — oral, first-line	Cephalexin 25 mg/kg/dose (max 1 g) PO QID high-dose TID for moderate cellulitis	Drug of choice (CPS 2026). Covers MSSA and GAS. High-dose enables outpatient moderate cellulitis. ^{89,90}
MSSA / GAS — IV (admitted)	Cefazolin 33 mg/kg/dose IV q8h (max 2 g/dose)	IV first-line for non-toxic inpatients. Step down to oral cephalexin on improvement.
GAS — streptococcal	Amoxicillin 25 mg/kg/dose PO BID; penicillin G IV if severe	For confirmed/likely pure GAS (erysipelas, non-purulent cellulitis).
MRSA — oral, first-line	Trimethoprim-sulfamethoxazole 4–6 mg/kg/dose (trimethoprim component) PO BID	Preferred oral MRSA agent ⁸⁹ — also covers GAS. Use when colonized or MRSA strongly suspected.
MRSA — alternative	Clindamycin 10 mg/kg/dose PO/IV q8h	Only where local clindamycin susceptibility is high. Anti-toxin role in severe disease.

Target	Drug & dose	Notes
MRSA — IV (severe)	Vancomycin 15 mg/kg/dose IV q6h	Add when MRSA suspected in toxic/deep infection; stop once MRSA excluded. <i>K. kingae</i> (the leading bone/joint pathogen at 6–48 months) is generally susceptible to β -lactams, so cefazolin/cephalosporins — rather than vancomycin or clindamycin alone — are preferred empirically for bone/joint infection in under-4s. ^{91,92}

◆ DURATION & STEP-DOWN

- **5–7 DAYS IS USUALLY ENOUGH**, even for many severe SSTIs (rarely > 7 days). ^{89,90}
- Failure to improve → re-evaluate diagnosis and source control, not simply broaden.
- Avoid routine combination therapy (e.g., cephalexin + TMP-SMX) and broad outpatient IV (ceftriaxone).
- If a child improves on a non-MRSA agent but is later found MRSA-colonized/positive, **DO NOT SWITCH** — clinical response governs.

⚠ PREVENTING RECURRENCE

- Protect the skin barrier: optimize **eczema** control, diligent wound care, cover open lesions, treat scabies/lice, and encourage varicella vaccination.
- Reserve **decolonization** (5-day nasal mupirocin + chlorhexidine washes, or dilute bleach baths) for recurrent moderate–severe SSTIs or household clusters — success is variable and re-colonization common. ⁸⁹

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — systemic illness, rapid spread, an abscess needing drainage, immunocompromise, or failed oral therapy; suspected necrotizing infection → emergency.
- **Home** — localized, well child on oral antibiotics with review.
- **Refer — now** — surgery for drainage or necrotizing infection.

Cervical Lymphadenopathy ASSESS COMMON

Very common and usually reactive — your job is to separate the benign node from the few that need antibiotics, imaging, or a malignancy work-up.

▴ WHAT COUNTS AS ABNORMAL

- A small, mobile, palpable node is **normal** in most healthy children. Treat a **cervical node > 1 cm** as enlarged (inguinal > 1.5 cm; epitrochlear > 0.5 cm). ^{93,94}
- A **supraclavicular** node is **never normal** — it is the single highest-risk site for malignancy. Image and investigate every one. ^{93,95,96}

- Sort by **tempo & laterality** — it points to the cause.^{93,95}

PATTERN → LIKELY CAUSE

Pattern	Think	Action
Acute, bilateral, tender	Reactive viral URTI (commonest) EBV / CMV if prolonged with splenomegaly	Supportive, no antibiotics, safety-net. EBV serology if a glandular-fever picture. ^{93,95}
Acute, unilateral, tender, warm ± fluctuant	Bacterial lymphadenitis – S. aureus (incl. MRSA) & group A strep	Empiric oral antibiotics 10 d; ultrasound if fluctuant → drain an abscess. Review at 48 h. ^{93,94,97}
Subacute (2–6 wks) / chronic (> 6 wks), often non-tender	Nontuberculous (atypical) mycobacteria (violaceous, "cold", young child), cat-scratch (Bartonella), TB, toxoplasma ^{93,98}	Don't just re-course antibiotics — investigate. NTM → complete surgical excision; cat-scratch → usually self-limited (azithromycin if bulky/symptomatic). ^{93,97,99,100}

△ CAN'T-MISS – RED FLAGS FOR MALIGNANCY (LYMPHOMA / LEUKEMIA / METASTASIS)

- Supraclavicular** node; **hard, matted, fixed**, or **painless / rubbery**; **> 2 cm and enlarging**; persisting or progressive **beyond 4–6 weeks**; **generalized** nodes (> 2 non-contiguous regions) or **hepatosplenomegaly**; **B symptoms** — unexplained fever > 38°C, drenching night sweats, weight loss > 10%; a **mediastinal mass** on chest X-ray.^{93,94,95,101,102}
- Any one → urgent bloods + imaging and refer.^{94,103} **Strongest predictors:** a **larger node** and **older age** — the risk rises with each — more nodal sites, a supraclavicular site, fixed nodes, and an **abnormal chest X-ray**; fever, weight loss, and organomegaly may also raise the odds.^{96,101,104}

▴ WORK-UP (WHEN IT ISN'T SIMPLE REACTIVE)

- Bloods:** CBC + differential + **blood film** (blasts, cytopenias), **ESR / CRP, LDH**; EBV / CMV serology; a **TB test (IGRA or tuberculin)**; Bartonella / toxoplasma serology if exposed.^{93,94,101,105}
- Imaging:** **ultrasound first-line** (size, abscess, architecture); chest X-ray if any red flag (mediastinal mass).^{94,95,96,105}
- Biopsy** (excisional preferred) for a red-flag or supraclavicular node, **failure to regress by 4–6 weeks**, or progression despite treatment.^{93,94,106,107}

EMPIRIC ANTIBIOTICS – ACUTE BACTERIAL LYMPHADENITIS (10 DAYS)

Setting	Oral	Notes
Cover S. aureus + GAS	Cephalexin 25–50 mg/kg/day ÷ 3–4 OR amoxicillin-clavulanate ^{89,97}	Review at 48 h; most settle within days. Add source control if an abscess forms. ⁹³
MRSA risk / penicillin allergy	Clindamycin 20–40 mg/kg/day ÷ 3 ^{89,97}	Also covers GAS; use per local MRSA rates. ^{80,89}

Setting	Oral	Notes
Fluctuant / abscess	Incision & drainage + culture	Ultrasound-guided if deep; send pus for routine and mycobacterial culture. ^{93,94,97}

✦ DON'T FORGET

- A cervical node **> 1.5 cm** is a clinical criterion of **Kawasaki disease** — reassess if fever has lasted ≥ 5 days. ¹⁰⁸
- Tender anterior nodes with exudative pharyngitis suggest **GAS pharyngitis**. ⁸⁰
- A firm supraclavicular or matted node in a child with pallor or bruising → treat as possible malignancy and refer **same day**. ^{94,103,107}

✦ YOUR ROLE – THE GENERAL PEDIATRICIAN

- **Most nodes are yours to manage.** Do the first-line assessment and reassurance; classify by duration (**acute ≤ 2 wks** · **subacute 2–6 wks** · **chronic > 6 wks**) and actively look for a red flag. ^{93,95,106}
- Treat acute bacterial lymphadenitis empirically and **review at 48 h. Safety-net every child and set a definite review point** — a node that has not begun to shrink by **~4 weeks**, or is growing, needs work-up. ^{93,94,105}
- You can start the first-line bloods and request the ultrasound yourself. **Refer early rather than re-course antibiotics** for a persistent or red-flag node: **same-day to hematology-oncology** for a hard/matted/supraclavicular node or systemic features; **surgery/ENT** for excision biopsy (persisting > 6 weeks or progressive); **infectious diseases** for suspected TB or atypical mycobacterial disease. ^{93,94,97,103,107}

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — systemically unwell, a large / fluctuant node needing drainage, airway or deep-space concern, or a strong malignancy suspicion. ^{93,94,103,109}
- **Home from the emergency department** — the well child with a small, mobile, reactive node → safety-net and review in 2–4 weeks. ^{94,95,97}
- **Refer — clinic** — surgery / ENT for excision (NTM, abscess, biopsy); hematology-oncology for a red-flag node; infectious diseases for TB or atypical infection. ^{93,99,103}

Fever – Assessment & Antipyretics ASSESS NICE NG143

Fever $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$. Treat the child's discomfort and risk — not the number.

▀ RISK-ASSESS BY TRAFFIC LIGHT (AND BY AGE)

- Any infant **under 3 months** with fever is high-risk → use the **Fever in the Young Infant** pathway.

- **Red (high-risk):** pale/mottled/ashen/blue, no response to social cues, unrousable, weak/high-pitched cry, grunting, respiratory rate > 60, reduced skin turgor, bulging fontanelle, neck stiffness, non-blanching rash, focal seizures/neurology.¹¹⁰
- **Amber (intermediate):** pallor, decreased activity, poor feeding, dry mucous membranes, reduced urine, nasal flaring, tachycardia, fever ≥ 5 days, rigors, non-weight-bearing/limb swelling.¹¹⁰
- **Green (low-risk):** normal color, responsive, content, moist membranes — manage at home with safety-netting.

ANTIPYRETIC DOSING

Drug · route	Dose	Max · notes
Acetaminophen — PO	10–15 mg/kg/dose every 4–6 h PRN	≤ 1 g/dose, ≤ 5 doses/24 h; max 75 mg/kg/day (not > 4 g/day). Onset 30 ¹¹¹ –60 min.
Acetaminophen — IV	15 mg/kg/dose every 6 h	< 50 kg: max 15 mg/kg (750 mg/dose); ≥ 50 kg: 1 g/dose. ≤ 75 mg/kg/day (not > 4 g/day). ¹¹²
Ibuprofen — PO	5–10 mg/kg/dose every 6–8 h	Age ≥ 6 months. Max 400 mg/dose, 40 mg/kg/day. Give with food + ensure hydration. ¹¹¹
Ibuprofen — IV	10 mg/kg/dose every 6–8 h	Age ≥ 6 months. Max 400 mg/dose, 40 mg/kg/day.

◆ AVOID

- Acetaminophen — severe liver failure.
- Ibuprofen — dehydration, renal impairment, active GI bleeding / ulcer disease, or any poorly hydrated child.

⚠ USE ANTIPYRETICS FOR COMFORT, NOT THE THERMOMETER

- Give only while the child is uncomfortable.¹¹¹
- Combining or alternating the two clears fever faster and gives more fever-free time (PITCH trial), but does **not** improve comfort — so for comfort one agent is usually enough.¹¹³
- Switch agents if discomfort is not relieved; alternate only if discomfort recurs before the next dose; counsel carefully to avoid dosing errors.
- Tepid sponging is not recommended; don't over- or under-wrap. **Antipyretics do not prevent febrile seizures.**¹¹¹ Encourage fluids; safety-net for red/amber signs.

The Rash – Approach & Red Flags MINUTES

Two questions first: does the child look unwell, and does the rash blanch?

STEP 1 – DOES THE CHILD LOOK UNWELL? (BEFORE FOCUSING ON THE RASH)

- Rapid ABCDE-style screen: work of breathing; color and perfusion (capillary refill > 2–3 s, mottled, cold peripheries); heart rate and respiratory rate for age; mental status (irritable, lethargic); fever; neck stiffness, photophobia, bulging fontanelle in infants.
- Any red flag → urgent assessment + empiric IV antibiotics (see [Septic Shock](#)), **in parallel** with the rash exam. Looks well → Step 2.
- **A blanching rash does not rule out sepsis** — meningococcal disease often begins as a blanching maculopapular rash before turning petechial or purpuric, and the classic non-blanching rash can be a late sign.¹¹⁴ Escalate an unwell child whatever the rash looks like.
- **Darkly pigmented skin:** erythema, petechiae and purpura may appear dark brown or violaceous and be masked — check all over the body (including the nappy area), look for petechiae in the conjunctivae, and lower the threshold to escalate.¹¹⁵

STEP 2 – DOES THE RASH BLANCH? (PRESS A CLEAR GLASS AGAINST IT)

DECISION

Does the rash blanch under glass?

NON-BLANCHING

Petechiae (< 2 mm) or purpura (> 2 mm) — **purpura carries higher risk.**¹¹⁴ Unwell or febrile → treat as invasive meningococcal disease / sepsis until excluded. A **well** child still needs a diagnosis and follow-up (see below) — do not dismiss just because they look well.

BLANCHING

Usually benign — viral exanthem, urticaria, or eczema. Treat symptomatically; safety-net with clear advice to "come back if the child becomes unwell, even if the rash looks the same or fades."¹¹⁰

NON-BLANCHING – SORT THE CAUSE

Cause	Key features
Meningococcal / invasive bacterial	Ill, febrile — emergency (identified at Step 1)
IgA vasculitis (Henoch-Schönlein)	Palpable purpura on buttocks and legs in a <i>well</i> child; abdominal pain, arthralgia/arthritis; check urine for blood and protein (renal involvement)
Immune thrombocytopenia (ITP)	Well child, isolated low platelets, bruising; often post-viral; watch for mucosal bleeding (epistaxis, gums)
Mechanical purpura	Forceful cough, vomiting or breath-holding; classically above the nipple line (head and neck, SVC territory) — benign

Leukemia

Pallor, hepatosplenomegaly, fatigue, bone pain, unexplained bruising

BLANCHING – SORT THE CAUSE

Cause	Key features
Viral exanthems	Roseola, measles, rubella, slapped-cheek (parvovirus B19); hand-foot-and-mouth and varicella are vesicular, not purely maculopapular
Scarlet fever	Sandpaper rash + strawberry tongue → penicillin
Urticaria	Transient wheals → antihistamine; airway or systemic features → see Anaphylaxis
Kawasaki disease	Fever $\geq$ 5 days + rash + non-purulent conjunctivitis + mucositis/strawberry tongue + extremity changes + cervical node — easily mistaken early for scarlet fever or a viral exanthem (see Kawasaki Disease)

⚠ ANY UNWELL CHILD IS THE EMERGENCY

- Escalate immediately — with or without a rash, and whatever the rash looks like.
- This alone is sufficient.

▶ ESCALATE URGENTLY – REGARDLESS OF BLANCHING – ALSO IF

- Non-blanching rash with fever, ill appearance, or rapid spread.
- **Retiform purpura** (branching, angulated, stellate) rather than round petechiae/purpura — suggests vascular occlusion (DIC, severe sepsis, vasculitis) and is higher-acuity than ordinary purpura.¹¹⁶
- **Mucosal involvement** (eyes, mouth, genitals) with blistering or skin peeling → Stevens–Johnson syndrome / TEN or toxic shock syndrome. Superficial peeling with **perioral crusting and radial fissures but mucous membranes spared**, especially in young children → **staphylococcal scalded skin syndrome (SSSS)** — mucosal sparing is the classic clue that separates SSSS from SJS/TEN. The **Nikolsky sign** (gentle shearing pressure separates the epidermis) is positive in SJS/TEN, SSSS, and pemphigus.
- **Vesicles in a neonate** → herpes simplex. Skin vesicles are **absent in roughly 40–50% of neonatal HSV with CNS or disseminated disease** — keep the threshold low for a full sepsis + HSV workup (and empiric acyclovir) in any unwell neonate, even with no rash.¹¹⁷
- Fever $\geq$ 5 days with rash plus any Kawasaki features.¹⁰⁸

◆ BEDSIDE TIPS

Faded or changed rash? Ask whether a parent photographed it — useful for evanescent eruptions like urticaria. **Stroke test:** a wheal along a tongue-blade stroke = dermatographism (common, benign); a wheal raised specifically over a pigmented lesion = **Darier's sign** (mastocytosis — worth recognizing in recurrent unexplained wheals). **Herpes zoster** in a dermatomal band is usually benign and immunocompetent in children, especially after early-life varicella or vaccination; consider underlying immunodeficiency only if it is multidermatomal, sacral, recurrent, prolonged or treatment-refractory, or has invasive features.

Preseptal & Orbital Cellulitis

HOURS

CPS 2026

The orbital septum is the firewall — eye signs separate sight-threatening orbital disease from benign preseptal swelling.

THE DISTINCTION THAT DRIVES EVERYTHING

- The **orbital septum** is the anatomic firewall. **Preseptal (periorbital)** = infection anterior to it — usually from skin trauma or sinusitis; mostly benign. **Orbital** = posterior to it — a complication of **ethmoid sinusitis** eroding the lamina papyracea; threatens vision and brain.¹¹⁸
- The distinction drives etiology, imaging, antibiotics, and disposition.¹¹⁸

DIFFERENTIATE AT THE BEDSIDE

Clinical feature	Preseptal	Orbital
Eyelid swelling & erythema	Present	Present
Pain with eye movement	Absent	Present
Extraocular movements	Normal	Impaired / restricted
Proptosis	Absent	Often present
Chemosis / diplopia / ↓ acuity / RAPD	Absent	May be present
Fever / toxic appearance	May be present	Usually present

ETIOLOGY & MICROBIOLOGY

- Preseptal — traumatic:** skin flora after a bite/scratch → *S. pyogenes*, *S. aureus*.
- Preseptal — atraumatic:** a complication of bacterial rhinosinusitis.
- Orbital:** mirrors acute sinusitis — *Streptococcus* (*anginosus*, *pyogenes*, *pneumoniae* groups); *S. aureus* and oral anaerobes in chronic sinusitis / older children; *H. influenzae* if under-immunized.¹¹⁸
- MRSA:** generally low but rising — risk factors do not reliably predict it¹¹⁸; a **negative nasal MRSA swab reliably excludes** it and guides the oral step-down.

◆ IMAGING – CONTRAST CT ORBITS + SINUSES

- Well children with uncomplicated **PRESEPTAL** disease need **NO IMAGING**.¹¹⁸
- Contrast CT is first-line; MRI preferred if intracranial extension or cavernous sinus thrombosis is suspected.
- Its job: find who needs surgery or has a complication.
- Image **IF** toxic appearance, optic-nerve signs (abnormal vision, RAPD), intracranial signs (focal deficit, seizure), prominent forehead swelling, or high-risk labs (CRP > 120 mg/L, WBC > 20,000/ μ L).¹¹⁸
- Otherwise reasonable to **DELAY CT 24–36 H** to judge response when ENT / ophthalmology are available.¹¹⁸

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — orbital signs, systemic illness, age < 1, and all true orbital cellulitis → IV antibiotics.
- **Home from the emergency department** — mild preseptal in a well child on oral antibiotics with 24 h review.
- **Refer — now** — ophthalmology and ENT for orbital involvement; surgery for an abscess.

Preseptal & Orbital – Management

HOURS

RISK-BASED

Preseptal is mostly oral outpatient; orbital is admitted, IV, and shared with ENT + ophthalmology.

DECISION

Preseptal or orbital?

PRESEPTAL – MOSTLY OUTPATIENT

Well, immunized child, eyelid erythema/edema with **normal painless eye movements, normal vision, no proptosis** → oral antibiotics + review. Admit the very young, severe, or not-improving.

ORBITAL – ADMIT, EMERGENCY

Pain/restriction on eye movement, **proptosis, chemosis, diplopia, reduced acuity, or RAPD** → admit: CBC/CRP, blood cultures, IV antibiotics, **same-day ENT + ophthalmology**, CT per criteria. Do not swab the conjunctiva (contamination).

WHAT TO SEND

- Uncomplicated preseptal, well child: no work-up.
- Severe / uncertain / young child: **CBC + CRP**. Severe disease: **blood cultures before antibiotics**. Drained pus / abscess → culture ± PCR. **MRSA nasal swab** where available — a negative result reliably excludes MRSA and guides the oral step-down.

EMPIRIC ANTIMICROBIAL THERAPY

Scenario	First-line	Dose (max) · MRSA / notes
Traumatic preseptal (bite / broken skin)	PO cephalexin IV cefazolin	Cephalexin 25 mg/kg/dose q6h (100 mg/kg/day, max 4 g/day); cefazolin 33 mg/kg/dose q8h (100 mg/kg/day). MRSA suspected → TMP-SMX 4–6 mg/kg/dose (TMP) q12h or clindamycin. ¹¹⁸
Atraumatic preseptal (from sinusitis)	PO cephalexin IV cefazolin	Doses as above. Escalate to / add amoxicillin-clavulanate (co-amoxiclav 30 mg/kg [amoxicillin] q8h) if no response by 24–48 h or the child is under-immunized. ¹¹⁸
Orbital cellulitis (admitted)	IV ceftriaxone + vancomycin	Ceftriaxone 50 mg/kg q12h (max 4 g/day) + vancomycin 15 mg/kg q6h (target levels). Alternative: ceftriaxone + clindamycin (adds anaerobe/MSSA cover) or amoxicillin-clavulanate. PO step-down by culture + MRSA swab. ¹¹⁸
Severe · toxic / intracranial / optic-nerve	IV ceftriaxone (or cefotaxime) + vancomycin + metronidazole	Ceftriaxone 50 mg/kg q12h + vancomycin 15 mg/kg q6h + metronidazole 10 mg/kg q8h. CNS-penetrating triple cover; consult ID; assess for surgery.

◆ WHY THESE CHOICES – ADAPTED TO LOCAL EPIDEMIOLOGY

- In Kuwait, near-universal Hib and pneumococcal conjugate vaccination reduces the *H. influenzae* / *S. pneumoniae* contribution, so a first-generation cephalosporin (cephalexin/cefazolin — strong streptococcal + MSSA cover) is a reasonable narrow empiric choice for skin- and sinus-origin preseptal disease; escalate to amoxicillin-clavulanate on non-response or under-immunization.
- For orbital disease, **VANCOMYCIN IS INCLUDED EMPIRICALLY** as a **LOCAL ADAPTATION** to regional community-associated MRSA epidemiology (expert consensus — CPS 2026 adds vancomycin only when MRSA is suspected and notes a negative MRSA swab reliably excludes it); ceftriaxone covers sinusitis streptococci with good tissue/CNS penetration; metronidazole is added for intracranial extension.¹¹⁸
- Always tailor to immunization status, prior antibiotics, and the **LOCAL ANTIBIOGRAM**.

Condition	Duration
Preseptal cellulitis	5–7 days
Orbital cellulitis (uncomplicated) ¹¹⁸	10–14 days
Orbital + subperiosteal / orbital abscess (no intracranial)	2–3 weeks

✦ SURGERY, ADJUNCTS & STEP-DOWN

- Surgery:** subperiosteal or orbital abscess → prompt ENT + ophthalmology for possible drainage (most small subperiosteal collections settle medically)¹¹⁸; intracranial complications → neurosurgery.
- IV → oral** once clearly improving, narrowed by cultures / MRSA swab.

- **Adjuncts:** intranasal saline/steroids only with subspecialty input; systemic corticosteroids are **not** routinely recommended.¹¹⁹ Escalate to ID for systemic illness, non-response, large abscess, or intracranial extension.

⚠ SIGHT & BRAIN AT RISK – RED FLAGS

- Falling visual acuity, a relative afferent pupillary defect, severe or bilateral proptosis, ophthalmoplegia, cranial-nerve palsies, or altered consciousness → cavernous sinus thrombosis or intracranial spread.
- Image urgently and escalate immediately.
- Bilateral involvement or rapid progression despite IV therapy is an emergency.

◆ **DIFFICULT IV ACCESS?** Reassess for an early IV→oral switch at every line failure rather than re-sticking — see [IV → Oral Switch & the DIVA Patient](#) (Quick Reference).

BRUE (Brief Resolved Unexplained Event) ASSESS < 1 YR • AAP 2016

A frightening but now-resolved episode in a well-appearing infant — a diagnosis of exclusion.

▴ DEFINE

- An infant < 1 year, when an observer reports a **sudden, brief, now-resolved** episode of one or more of: cyanosis or pallor; absent, decreased, or irregular breathing; a marked change in tone (hyper- or hypotonia); or altered responsiveness.¹²⁰
- Diagnose a BRUE **only when no explanation is found** after appropriate history and examination.¹²⁰

▴ LOWER-RISK – ALL OF

- Age > 60 days; gestation ≥ 32 wk and corrected (postmenstrual) age¹²⁰ ≥ 45 wk.
- First event (no prior BRUE, not in clusters); duration < 1 min; no CPR by a trained provider; no concerning history or examination findings.¹²⁰

▴ LOWER-RISK – DO

- **Should** — educate caregivers about BRUEs and use shared decision-making to guide evaluation, disposition, and follow-up; offer resources for caregiver CPR training.
- **May** — obtain pertussis testing and a 12-lead ECG; briefly monitor with continuous pulse oximetry and serial observations.¹²⁰

× LOWER-RISK – DO NOT / NEED NOT

Should not: blood counts or cultures, CSF, electrolytes/renal panel/calcium, ammonia, blood gases, or metabolic screen (urine organic acids, plasma amino acids, acylcarnitine); chest X-ray, echocardiogram, EEG, or studies for reflux; home cardiorespiratory monitoring; acid-suppression or antiepileptic drugs. **Need not:** viral respiratory testing, urinalysis, glucose, bicarbonate, lactate, anemia work-up, or neuroimaging; admission **solely** for cardiorespiratory monitoring.¹²⁰

⚠ CONCERNING FEATURES → NOT LOWER-RISK, EVALUATE

- Toxic appearance, lethargy, vomiting, or respiratory distress at assessment; significant compromise / CPR during the event; recurrent or prior events; family history of sudden cardiac death, long-QT syndrome, unexplained drowning or motor-vehicle death, SIDS, or sibling BRUE; history suggesting seizure; paroxysmal cough or pertussis exposure; any trauma or concern for maltreatment; unexplained sibling death or dysmorphic features.
- These mandate **targeted** evaluation — the testing restrictions above apply to lower-risk infants only.

✦ PEARL – “LOWER-RISK” IS NOT “NO-RISK”

- In the multicenter BRUE network, about **4%** of infants had a serious underlying condition (most often a seizure disorder or an airway abnormality) and events recurred in roughly **7%** discharged from the ED and **11%** discharged from hospital.¹²¹
- The AAP criteria reliably identify low-risk infants but over-classify many as higher-risk.¹²¹
- Safety-net every family, offer CPR training, and consider asking carers to video any recurrence for diagnostic clarity.

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — higher-risk BRUE (age < 2 months, prematurity, repeated events, or concerning features) for monitoring.
- **Home from the emergency department** — lower-risk BRUE with education, CPR resources, and follow-up.
- **Refer — clinic** — by cause (cardiology, neurology, safeguarding).

Adolescent Emergencies – Kuwait Context

HOURS

ADOLESCENT

Mental-health crises and menstrual emergencies — within the Kuwait consent and confidentiality framework.

▶ MENTAL HEALTH & SELF-HARM

- Screen the psychosocial context in a calm, private setting — Home, Education, Eating, Activities, Drugs, Sexuality, Suicide/safety (HEEADSSS).⁷

- **Acute self-harm, suicidal ideation, or intentional ingestion** → manage per the [Self-Harm / Intentional Ingestion](#) card (continuous one-to-one observation, remove the means, treat the ingestion, mental-health assessment before discharge). This card adds the **adolescent consent, confidentiality, and safeguarding** framework below.

▶ MENSTRUAL EMERGENCIES

- **Heavy menstrual bleeding:** assess for hemodynamic compromise and anemia. Check CBC, ferritin, coagulation screen and **von Willebrand studies** (especially at menarche)¹²², thyroid function, and a pregnancy test — performed within the local legal/ethical and safeguarding framework, and discussed with a senior clinician where culturally sensitive.
- **Severe dysmenorrhea:** first-line is a scheduled NSAID; escalate to hormonal therapy for a menstrual indication if refractory, and reassess for secondary causes (endometriosis) if no improvement after 3–6 months.¹²³
- **Amenorrhea:** investigate primary amenorrhea if no menarche by age 15 (or within 3 years of thelarche), or by 13 with no secondary sexual characteristics; in secondary amenorrhea, exclude pregnancy first.^{124,125}

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Tranexamic acid	PO 1.3 g three times daily for up to 5 days (label dose, post-menarchal; not studied < 18 y) • IV 10 mg/kg/dose (max 600 mg) every 8 h	Acute heavy menstrual bleeding ^{122,126,127} . Weight-based 15–25 mg/kg regimens are local formulary practice, not label-stated.
Combined oral contraceptive / oral progestogen	per gynecology protocol	Hormonal control of acute bleeding or refractory dysmenorrhea
NSAID (ibuprofen / mefenamic acid)	ibuprofen 10 mg/kg/dose; mefenamic acid per protocol	Dysmenorrhea; also reduces menstrual blood loss
Iron	3–6 mg/kg/day elemental iron	Iron-deficiency anemia from chronic loss

⚠ SAFEGUARDING OVERRIDES CONFIDENTIALITY

- Confidentiality with an adolescent is real but **not absolute**.
- When there is imminent risk of serious harm — self-harm, suicide, abuse, or exploitation — override it: involve the guardian and escalate through the hospital safeguarding pathway.
- Treat life- or limb-threatening conditions immediately, with or without consent.

◆ KUWAIT LEGAL FRAMEWORK

- Under **LAW NO. 70/2020** (Medical Profession & Patients' Rights), informed consent is required before any intervention and, for a minor, is given by the **LEGAL GUARDIAN (WALI)**.¹
- **CONFIDENTIALITY (ARTICLE 13)**: the practitioner must not disclose a patient's secret — whether it came to their knowledge, was discovered through practice, or was entrusted to them — except in defined circumstances: a written order from a court, the public prosecution, or a competent investigating authority; disclosure to prevent or report a crime; notification of a communicable disease to the authority designated by the Ministry; the patient's written consent; information exchange required between the care team for the patient's management; or reporting of child abuse (Law 21/2015) or elder abuse/neglect (Law 18/2016).
- Under the **MENTAL HEALTH LAW NO. 14/2019**, a physician may hold a patient for **UP TO 72 HOURS** for psychiatric assessment when there is danger to self or others or an inability to self-care/consent (Art. 11);¹²⁸ involuntary referral is also permitted by judicial order or at the request of a relative (to second kinship), the treating physician, or an investigator. Disclosing a patient's psychological information is a **CRIMINAL OFFENSE**.
- Confirm exact article wording against the official gazette text and current Kuwait MOH circulars.

The Child with Obesity

ASSESS

AAP 2023

Obesity reshapes acute care — weight-based dosing, a harder airway, and comorbidities that present as emergencies.

▴ DEFINE

- **Obesity** = BMI $\geq$ 95th percentile for age and sex; **severe obesity** $\geq$ 120% of the 95th percentile (or BMI $\geq$ 35). A chronic disease with genetic, physiologic, and environmental contributors — not a failure of willpower.¹²⁹
- Focuses on how obesity **modifies acute care** — drug dosing, the airway, resuscitation, and the comorbidities that present as emergencies.

▴ APPROACH & WORK-UP

- Confirm the **BMI percentile**; targeted history (diet, activity, sleep/snoring, family history, medications) and exam for comorbidity signs — acanthosis nigricans, hypertension (correct-size cuff), hepatomegaly, hip/knee findings, papilledema.
- **Screen $\geq$ 10 years**: fasting glucose/HbA1c (T2DM), ALT (fatty liver), and a lipid panel; blood pressure with an appropriately sized cuff.¹²⁹

MANAGEMENT – DRUG DOSING IS THE KEY BEDSIDE TRAP

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Resuscitation drugs · defibrillation	Actual (total) body weight – but cap at the adult dose	Length-based tapes (Broselow) mis-estimate weight in obesity ¹³⁰ — verify actual weight.
General rule	No universal scalar – dosing is drug-specific	There is no valid one-size default ; the correct weight basis depends on each drug's pharmacokinetics. Confirm with clinical pharmacy / the formulary. Never exceed the adult dose; scaling a hydrophilic drug to total body weight can cause overdose. ¹³⁰
Lipophilic drugs, large V_d	Loading dose nearer total body weight	Then maintain on lean/adjusted weight (e.g., some sedatives, induction agents).
Cefazolin · succinylcholine · antineoplastics	Total body weight (TBW)	TBW is the correct scalar for these. ¹³⁰
Aminoglycosides · hydrophilic drugs	Adjusted or lean body weight	Volume of distribution altered; use adjusted body weight. ¹³⁰

◆ **RULE OF THUMB** When total body weight exceeds ~120% of ideal body weight, choose the weight basis deliberately — **PER DRUG, NOT BY A BLANKET RULE. NEVER EXCEED THE RECOMMENDED ADULT DOSE** for the indication, regardless of weight. For any drug not listed above, or with a narrow therapeutic index, **INVOLVE CLINICAL PHARMACY**.

⚠ AIRWAY & VENTILATION

- Anticipate **difficult bag-mask ventilation and intubation** and **rapid desaturation** (reduced functional residual capacity).
- Pre-oxygenate well, position **ramped/HELP** (ear-to-sternal-notch), and have adjuncts ready.
- Higher risk of OSA and obesity-hypoventilation.

🚩 RED FLAGS – DON'T-MISS ACUTE COMORBIDITIES

- **T2DM → DKA or HHS** — hyperglycemic hyperosmolar state is increasingly reported in youth with T2DM (up to ~2% present with HHS at T2DM onset) and obesity makes dehydration hard to assess.¹³¹
- **SCFE** — hip, thigh, or knee pain with a limp in an adolescent¹³² (see the **SCFE** card).
- **Idiopathic intracranial hypertension** — headache, papilledema, visual change.
- **Cholelithiasis / pancreatitis**, VTE in adolescents, worsening asthma control.

✦ PEARL – WEIGH THE CHOICE, NOT JUST THE CHILD

Document both actual weight and ideal body weight, pick the scalar per drug class, and avoid codeine (and tramadol) — the FDA recommends against their use in adolescents 12–18 with obesity, OSA or severe lung disease because of CYP2D6 ultra-rapid metabolism and respiratory depression.¹³³

Pertussis (Whooping Cough)

MINUTES

AAP Red Book 2024 • CDC

In the young infant, the danger is apnea and cyanosis — the “whoop” is often absent.

RECOGNIZE

- Paroxysmal coughing fits ± inspiratory whoop or post-tussive vomiting, worse at night, with well periods in between; often marked lymphocytosis.
- **Infants < 6 months / unimmunized:** may present with **apnea, cyanosis or bradycardia** and little cough — a low threshold to admit and monitor.⁹⁸

SEVERE / MALIGNANT PERTUSSIS

Extreme leukocytosis (WBC > 50 ×10⁹/L), pneumonia, pulmonary hypertension and refractory hypoxemia carry high mortality in young infants — escalate early to critical care; exchange transfusion/leukoreduction is considered in specialist units.⁹⁸

WORKUP

- **Nasopharyngeal PCR** — test of choice in the first 3–4 weeks of cough; culture (< 2 weeks) for confirmation/typing; serology in later/adolescent disease.⁹⁸
- CBC — marked **lymphocytosis; extreme leukocytosis** predicts pulmonary hypertension and death in young infants.
- Chest X-ray if respiratory distress.

Age	Azithromycin	Notes
< 6 months	10 mg/kg once daily for 5 days	Macrolide of choice — lowest risk of infantile pyloric stenosis ⁹⁸
≥ 6 months	10 mg/kg (max 500 mg) day 1, then 5 mg/kg (max 250 mg) days 2–5	PO

◆ PUBLIC-HEALTH & CONTACTS

- Pertussis is **NOTIFIABLE** — inform public health.
- Droplet precautions until 5 days of macrolide.⁹⁸
- Offer **POST-EXPOSURE PROPHYLAXIS** (same macrolide dosing) to close contacts, prioritizing households with infants < 12 months or pregnant women^{98,134}, and check the family's immunization status.
- Reinforce **MATERNAL TDAP** each pregnancy (27–36 weeks) as the main protection for young infants.⁹⁸

▲ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — any infant < 6 months, apnea/cyanosis, feeding difficulty, pneumonia or extreme leukocytosis.
- **Refer — now** — call critical care for severe pertussis.

05

Complex & Technology-Dependent Care

Technology-dependent & medically complex children — tracheostomy, feeding tubes, ECMO, post-ICU, transport

The Child with Medical Complexity ASSESS

When a Child with Medical Complexity presents unwell — start from their baseline, and treat the carer as the expert.

▲ WHO – AND WHY THEY DECOMPENSATE FAST

- **Children with Medical Complexity (CMC)** have chronic conditions with **medical fragility**, multiple coexisting problems needing **multidisciplinary care**, and often **medical technology dependence** — a tracheostomy, long-term ventilation, enteral feeding tubes and pumps, a central venous catheter, a ventriculoperitoneal shunt, or an intrathecal baclofen pump. They usually have **polypharmacy, coordinated care needs, and frequent healthcare use**.¹³⁵
- They have little reserve, present **atypically**, and the **carer knows the baseline** — when they say “this is not normal for him,” believe it and look hard.¹³⁶

▲ THE UNWELL CHILD – A STRUCTURED APPROACH

- **Start from baseline:** their usual saturations, tone, secretions, feeds, alertness, and seizure pattern. **Deviation from baseline is the alarm**, not the absolute number.
- **Read the emergency care plan first** — diagnosis, baseline, devices and sizes, drugs, allergies, and the agreed goals of care.
- **Think the common six:**
- infection

- **device malfunction**
- constipation
- pain / dystonia
- seizures
- medication problem (including **withdrawal**).
- These cause most acute presentations.¹³⁶

TECHNOLOGY PROBLEM – WHERE TO LOOK

Device	Red flag → action
Tracheostomy / home ventilator	Desaturation, distress, or alarm → blocked or displaced tube, tracheitis → see Tracheostomy Emergencies . Ventilator alarm → think DOPEs (displacement, obstruction, pneumothorax, equipment, stomach) ^{5,137}
Gastrostomy / jejunostomy	Dislodged or blocked tube, leak, or peritonism → see Gastrostomy (Feeding) Tube Problems a fresh stoma can close within hours
Central venous catheter	Fever = line infection until proven otherwise – paired cultures (line + peripheral) before antibiotics do not pull a tunneled line lightly. Occlusion or breakage → specialist
VP shunt	Vomiting, headache, drowsiness, irritability, or a bulging fontanelle = shunt malfunction / raised ICP until proven otherwise → urgent imaging + neurosurgery
Baclofen pump	Itch, rigidity, fever, agitation, autonomic instability = acute withdrawal (can be life-threatening) → urgent specialist bridge with benzodiazepines ± oral baclofen

⚠ **POLYPHARMACY & DO-NOT-STOP DRUGS**

- Do **not** abruptly stop chronic medications — **most should be continued** — including anticonvulsants, baclofen, and long-term steroids, or long-term oxygen / ventilation.¹³⁶
- If on long-term steroids and acutely unwell, give **stress-dose steroids** (see [Adrenal Crisis](#)).
- Reconcile every drug, check interactions, and bring the child's own equipment and ventilator settings with them.

◆ **PLAN BEFORE THE CRISIS** Agree and document the **BASELINE, THE EMERGENCY CARE PLAN, AND THE GOALS OF CARE** with the family and the medical home in advance — and make sure it travels with the child.¹³⁶

Tracheostomy Emergencies MINUTES

The deteriorating child with a tracheostomy — oxygenate both ways, then work the algorithm: patent, obstructed, or displaced?

PRINTABLE TRACHEOSTOMY TOOLS

- **WARD CARDS** — elective tube change (2 sides), bedside emergency box, the 5 R's of routine care · **PRINT ON A5**

Open / print ward cards (A5 PDF) kpc-guide.com/print/KPC-Tracheostomy-Ward-Cards-A5.pdf

- **BEDHEAD SIGNS** — tracheostomy (upper airway patent) and neck breather (laryngectomy) · **PRINT ON A4**

Open / print bedhead signs (A4 PDF) kpc-guide.com/print/KPC-Tracheostomy-Bedhead-Signs-A4.pdf

FIRST MOVES — CALL FOR HELP, OXYGENATE BOTH WAYS

- **Call for help.** Apply **high-flow oxygen to both the stoma and the face** as soon as it is available — use **two sources if you have them**; with a **single oxygen source, apply it to the airway the child is breathing through** (face or stoma)¹³⁸. Attach **pulse oximetry ± waveform capnography** (exhaled CO₂ = a patent or partly patent airway).^{138,139} Bring the **tracheostomy emergency kit**: same-size and one-size-smaller tubes, a suction machine + catheters, water-based lubricant, a cuff syringe, and a bag-valve-mask.^{138,140,141,142} Use the **bedside emergency card** (tube type and size, cuff status, **suction depth**); suction with a **premarked catheter to the pre-determined depth** on the card¹³⁸ — just past the tube tip, no deeper.¹⁴⁰ Routine **humidification** (HME / “Swedish nose”) helps prevent the thickened secretions and mucus plugs that obstruct the tube.^{140,142}
- **Rapid airway assessment:** look, listen, and feel at **BOTH the mouth and the stoma** — assess **chest rise, breath sounds (air entry), airflow, and exhaled CO₂** (if available).¹³⁸

DECISION

① Is the tracheostomy tube in place?

NO

Accidental decannulation. If **trained, reinsert the tracheostomy tube**. If not trained or reinsertion fails, **ventilate via whichever route achieves chest rise** (upper airway or stoma). Continue ventilation and await expert airway support.¹³⁸

YES

Tube is in place — proceed to the steps below.

② REMOVE WHAT MAY BE CAUSING THE PROBLEM

- Remove any **speaking valve or cap**, remove the **inner cannula** (if present), and **check the ventilator / circuit** (if ventilated) — this alone may relieve the obstruction.¹³⁸
- (Some inner cannulas must be reinserted to connect a breathing circuit.)¹³⁸

DECISION

③ Can you pass a suction catheter?

PASSES

Tube is **patent** — suction to clear secretions (a partially obstructed tube may still need replacing — if suction does not clear it, **change the tube**; do not persist)¹³⁸.
Ventilate via the tracheostomy if not breathing. Continue ABCDE.¹³⁸

WON'T PASS

Tube is **obstructed or displaced**. **Deflate the cuff** (if present — adult NTSP algorithm step; most pediatric tubes are uncuffed) — if this improves things, air is moving around the tube¹⁴³ → **remove the tracheostomy tube**.¹³⁸

after tube removal / still not ventilating

④ VENTILATE – VIA WHICHEVER ROUTE ACHIEVES CHEST RISE

- **Upper airway** (if patent): cover the stoma (gauze / finger) and bag-mask via the mouth/nose (± oral or nasal airway), or an LMA.¹³⁸
- **Stoma** (if the upper airway is not patent or oral/nasal ventilation is ineffective — e.g., laryngectomy, subglottic stenosis): ventilate over the stoma with an appropriately sized pediatric face-mask, or an LMA.¹³⁸

at once if trained – otherwise when trained help arrives

⑤ RE-ESTABLISH THE AIRWAY

- Re-cannulate with the **same-size tube**; if it will not pass, use **one size smaller**. If it still will not pass, **do not force** — **stop and keep ventilating** until expert airway support arrives, or **orally intubate** (an uncut / longer ETT, cuff sited **beyond the stoma**)^{138,140,141}
- Confirm with **capnography**. A **shoulder roll** (pillow or rolled towel under the shoulders) may improve airway patency and access to the stoma.¹³⁸

▶ DOPES – CAUSES OF DETERIORATION

- **D — Displacement** (accidental decannulation)^{5,137,139}
- **O — Obstruction** (mucus plug, blood, granulation tissue)^{5,137,139}
- **P — Pneumothorax**^{5,137}
- **E — Equipment failure** (ventilator / circuit, speaking valve, cap, inner cannula, oxygen failure)^{5,137,138,139}
- **S — Stomach** (distended stomach / abdominal compartment)^{5,137}

✦ KEEP THE OBTURATOR AT THE BEDSIDE

- Keep the tracheostomy **obturator at the bedside at all times.** ^{138,141}
- In an emergency it may be needed to **reinsert the child's existing tube** when a new tube is unavailable or there is no time to open one — a dedicated obturator **eases insertion, reduces trauma and protects the stoma.** ¹³⁸

⚠ NO UPPER AIRWAY? (LARYNGECTOMY / FIXED OBSTRUCTION)

- If the child **cannot be ventilated from above** (laryngectomy, severe subglottic stenosis), the **stoma is the only airway** — do not waste time on face-mask ventilation; oxygenate and re-cannulate or intubate the stoma. ¹³⁸
- Know this from the care plan **before** the emergency. ^{138,140}

⚠ BLEEDING – EXCLUDE TRACHEO-INNOMINATE FISTULA (TIF)

- **Massive bleeding — or a brief “sentinel” bleed — 3 days to 6 weeks after tracheostomy is TIF until proven otherwise** (adult-derived window) ^{138,144}; in children TIF also occurs late in long-term tracheostomies, and most reported pediatric cases had neurological comorbidity. ¹⁴⁵
- This is an airway/ENT/surgical emergency — call expert help (ENT, surgery, anesthesia/ICU) immediately. ¹³⁸
- As an expert-performed bridge while help arrives: **overinflate the cuff** to tamponade (controls bleeding in > 80% in adult series); if it fails, **orally intubate past the stoma** (ETT cuff distal to the bleed) and apply the **Utley maneuver** — a finger through the stoma compressing the artery against the back of the sternum — then **activate massive transfusion, call ENT + surgery, and go to OR.** ^{138,144}
- Any tracheostomy bleeding needs ENT review before discharge. ^{139,140}

▲ TRACHEITIS

- Increasingly **purulent / copious secretions, fever, plugging, rising work of breathing** — can obstruct. ^{139,140} Send a **tracheal aspirate** to guide antibiotics ¹³⁹; empiric cover usually includes *S. aureus* (including MRSA) and *Pseudomonas*, the organisms most often reported, guided by prior cultures and the local antibiogram ¹⁴⁶; step up humidification and suction. ¹⁴⁰

⚠ WHEN NOT TO CHANGE THE TUBE YOURSELF – CALL ENT / THE TRACHEOSTOMY TEAM

As a general pediatrician, **do not attempt an elective tube change** when: it is the **first change** (the surgical / ENT team performs or directly supervises the first change, usually at **day 3–7** post-formation, to confirm a patent tract)¹⁴⁷; the stoma is **fresh / immature (< 7 days**, especially percutaneous) — high risk of a **false passage** or an unrecoverable airway^{138,147}; you are **not trained in that specific tube**, or the correct-size tubes and suction are not at hand^{138,141}; the child is **unstable, on high ventilator / oxygen support, or has a known difficult airway** — change only where **ENT / anesthesia and airway rescue are immediately available**^{138,139}; or there is **active bleeding or suspected tracheo-innominate fistula** (an emergency, not a routine change)¹³⁸; the tracheostomy was placed for **critical upper airway obstruction** — the upper airway is **not a reliable rescue route**, so a lost or displaced tube can mean a **lost airway** (treat the stoma as the only airway and change only with ENT / anesthesia and airway rescue at the bedside)^{138,139,140}; or the child has had **major airway / tracheal reconstruction** (laryngotracheal reconstruction, slide tracheoplasty, tracheal resection & anastomosis) — the tube may cross or protect a **fresh repair**, so changes are done by the **surgical team only** (risk of disrupting the anastomosis or a false passage; expert consensus). Otherwise **keep the current tube, oxygenate, and get expert help**.¹³⁸

ELECTIVE TUBE CHANGE (ROUTINE)

- Two people.¹⁴⁰
- Supine with a **shoulder roll, neck extended**; pre-oxygenate (local practice) and suction.¹⁴⁰
- Load the obturator, lubricate, deflate the cuff.^{140,142}
- Remove the old tube along its curve; insert the new one on the **obturator** in a downward, inward arc — **never force. Remove the obturator immediately**, insert the inner cannula, inflate the cuff, and confirm (chest rise, breath sounds, capnography, suction catheter passes)^{138,140,142}
- Secure ties to a one-finger gap.¹⁴⁰

⚠ CALL ENT / ANESTHESIA EARLY

- Any bleeding · suspected TIF (emergency) · failed or difficult reinsertion · obstructing granulation · **accidental decannulation with a fresh stoma (< 7 days)** — lift the stay sutures ‘up and out’ to aid reinsertion; if it fails, intubate orally.^{138,139,140}
- An established stoma can still narrow within hours of decannulation¹⁴⁰, so if the tube has been out for several hours and the child is stable, call ENT before repeated attempts (dilation may be needed) — expert consensus, not guideline-stated.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any airway compromise → ED/PICU.¹³⁸
- **Home** — after the tube is secure and patent and the caregiver is confident.^{139,141}
- **Refer** — **now** — ENT and the home-ventilation/tracheostomy team.¹³⁹

© LEARN MORE – OPEN-ACCESS PEDIATRIC RESOURCES (no login required)

- **CINCINNATI CHILDREN'S – TRACHEOTOMY CARE** — caregiver handbook (Arabic available) plus short videos including an **EMERGENCY TUBE CHANGE**: cincinnatichildrens.org



- **ABOUTKIDSHEALTH (SICKKIDS) – TRACHEOSTOMY & VENTILATION** — home care, suctioning and **EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT**: aboutkidshealth.ca/trachvent



Tracheostomy Tubes & Cuff Types

REFERENCE

Know the exact tube before you change or ventilate — same stated size from different manufacturers is not interchangeable.

TUBE – WHAT IT IS AND WHEN

Tube	Material & features	Notes
PVC tube	PVC, firm, thermosensitive, radiopaque line neonatal / pediatric / pediatric-long cuffed (soft air cuff) or uncuffed. Pediatric sizes are single-lumen (no inner cannula). ¹³⁸	Single-patient, disposable. Sized by inner diameter (ID, mm) . ¹³⁸
Silicone tube	Silicone, soft and flexible, reusable cuff options tight-to-shaft (TTS) , air , or foam extended-proximal and adjustable-length (wire-reinforced) variants exist.	Bivona silicone tubes, including wire-reinforced variants, are labeled MR-conditional (≤ 3 T) — check the specific tube's labeling before MRI. Sized by ID. ¹⁴²

CUFF TYPES – INFLATE WITH WHAT, WATCH WHAT

Cuff	Inflate with	Use / caution
Uncuffed	–	Most children; airflow around the tube (speech), least mucosal injury.
Air cuff	Air	Positive-pressure ventilation or aspiration protection; keep cuff pressure < 20–25 cmH₂O (minimal-leak) — over-inflation causes mucosal ischemia. ¹⁴⁷
Tight-to-shaft (TTS)	Sterile water (never air)	Deflated, it sits flush like an uncuffed tube (speech / airflow); inflate only when needed. Air diffuses out of silicone ¹⁴⁷ — use water .

Cuff	Inflate with	Use / caution
Foam cuff	Self-inflating (pilot open to air)	For a difficult seal or tracheomalacia; actively deflate and cap the pilot to insert / remove, then release to self-inflate.

⚠ CUFF SAFETY

- Never use a **speaking valve or cap with the cuff inflated** — no route to exhale (can be fatal)¹⁴⁷; deflate cuff first.
- Deflate cuff whenever a seal is not needed, to protect mucosa and allow speech.

▴ BEFORE ANY TUBE CHANGE

- Same-size tubes from **different manufacturers differ in outer diameter and length — not interchangeable**; if you must substitute in an emergency, be ready to **downsize**.¹³⁸
- Keep a **same-size and one-size-smaller** spare at the bedside; know the exact tube from the **bedside emergency card**.
- After insertion, confirm airway — chest rise, **capnography**, suction catheter passes.

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- **ABOUTKIDSHEALTH (SICKKIDS) – TRACHEOSTOMY & VENTILATION** — home care, suctioning and **EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT**: aboutkidshealth.ca/trachvent 

Gastrostomy (Feeding) Tube Problems HOURS

A dislodged tube is time-critical — the stoma can close within hours. Tract age decides who replaces it.

▴ DISLODGED TUBE – THE CLOCK IS THE STOMA

- Empty tract narrows within hours — per **ESPGHAN / NASPGHAN** it can close within ~6 h, usually lost by **24 h**.¹⁴⁸ Keep it open **now**, then replace.
- **Tract age decides the route** — ask when the tube was first placed.

DECISION

How old is the stoma tract?

IMMATURE < 6 WEEKS

High risk of a **false tract / intraperitoneal placement** → **do NOT insert a tube into the stoma**. Cover stoma with gauze, keep nil-by-stoma, get to **hospital** for guided replacement by **pediatric surgery / gastroenterology / interventional radiology**.¹⁴⁸

MATURE ≥ 6 WEEKS

Epithelialized tract → bedside replacement usually safe. Replace **promptly** with a **same-size balloon tube**; lubricate, advance gently, inflate the balloon with water. **Caveat:** a **first PEG**, or **poor wound healing** (malnutrition, chemotherapy), may mature more slowly — up to **~3 months**; if unsure, **treat as immature**.¹⁴⁸

IF THE SAME SIZE WILL NOT PASS

- Place the largest **Foley catheter** that passes atraumatically to hold the stoma open, then **serially dilate in 2-Fr steps** to the target size.¹⁴⁹
- **Do not inflate a Foley balloon inside the tract to dilate** (expert consensus — not guideline-stated).
- If > 24 h out, or any resistance / false-passage concern → stop and refer.

◆ CONFIRM BEFORE FEEDING

- Verify intragastric position before use: **ASPIRATE GASTRIC CONTENTS**¹⁴⁹ (**PH ≤ 5.5** — the nasogastric-tube threshold, applied by extension¹⁵⁰) — **BEWARE A FALSE PH ON PROTON-PUMP INHIBITORS** (expert consensus).
- After any **DIFFICULT OR UNCERTAIN** replacement, confirm with a **WATER-SOLUBLE CONTRAST STUDY** — the ESPGHAN standard before first use of a replaced balloon tube.¹⁴⁸ **NEVER USE AIR INSUFFLATION** to confirm.
- Document tube type, French size, and balloon volume.

▲ BLOCKED TUBE & STOMA ISSUES

- **Blocked:** flush gently with **warm water**; do not force. Hold feeds until patency is confirmed.
- **Buried bumper:** suspect if the tube **will not rotate or advance freely**, or pain, leakage, or resistance on feeding — prevented by avoiding traction and rotating + advancing the tube regularly. Buried bumper or **suspected peritonitis** (pain, feed intolerance, fever, rigidity) → stop feeds, urgent **surgical review**.¹⁴⁸
- **Granulation, leak, redness, excoriation:** see [Enteral Feeding Tubes — Types & Complications](#).

▲ ADMIT / ESCALATE

- **Admit** — peritonitis or systemic infection; **buried bumper syndrome**; uncertain or **difficult placement**; concern of a **false passage**; any immature-tract dislodgement; **tube out > 24 h**.
- **Refer — now** — surgery / gastroenterology.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — peritonitis, a dislodged tube with a lost tract, or inability to replace it.

- **Home** — a replaced, patent tube with feeds tolerated.
- **Refer — now** — surgery/gastroenterology for tract problems or early dislodgement (< 4 weeks).

© **LEARN MORE – OPEN-ACCESS PEDIATRIC RESOURCES** (no login required)

- **CINCINNATI CHILDREN'S – G-TUBE HOME CARE** — caregiver handbook + procedure videos (Arabic available): cincinnatichildrens.org 
- **TOGETHER BY ST. JUDE – TYPES OF TUBES & DEVICES** — illustrated visual guide to NG / ND / NJ and G / GJ / J tubes and low-profile buttons: together.stjude.org 

Enteral Feeding Tubes – Types, Delivery & Complications

REFERENCE

Know the route before you feed or give a drug — the stomach tolerates boluses, the jejunum does not.

TUBE TYPES – ROUTE, HOW TO FEED, AND WHAT NOT TO GIVE

Tube	Route & how to feed	Do NOT
NGT / OGT	Stomach short-term bolus or continuous. Nasogastric vs orogastric route is a unit / clinical choice – evidence favors neither (in preterm infants).¹⁵¹ Choose by expected duration, gag strength, and respiratory status: prefer OGT when nasal airflow matters (preterm, CPAP, respiratory distress) or the gag is weak NGT is more secure for a stronger gag or longer use (preterm rationale: nasal tubes may compromise respiration, oral tubes displace more easily¹⁵¹; otherwise expert consensus). Confirm gastric aspirate pH ≤ 5.5 before each use (x-ray if in doubt; local policy: confirm by x-ray).¹⁵⁰	Never feed with position unconfirmed. Use OGT (not NGT) in suspected base-of-skull injury.
NJT	Nose → jejunum (post-pyloric) for gastroparesis or high aspiration risk. Continuous feeds only.	No bolus (dumping). pH is unreliable — confirm position by imaging (expert consensus — not guideline-stated).
Gastrostomy (PEG / high-profile / button)	Abdominal wall → stomach; long-term. Bolus or continuous.	Force or over-rotate a PEG bumper (buried bumper). A low-profile button needs an extension set to feed.
Gastrojejunostomy (GJ)	Through the gastric stoma, tip in jejunum gastric + jejunal ports. Jejunal port = continuous only gastric port = venting / medicines.	Blind replacement — needs fluoroscopy. No bolus down the jejunal port.
Jejunostomy (J)	Abdominal wall → jejunum. Continuous feeds only, small volumes.	Bolus feed. Attempt a bedside change — refer (surgical tract).

⚠ MEDICINES THROUGH A FEEDING TUBE

- Use **liquid formulations** where possible; **never crush enteric-coated or modified / sustained-release** tablets (blocks the tube, alters the drug).¹⁵²
- Give each drug **separately** and **flush with water** before, between, and after. **The route matters:** down a **jejunal (post-pyloric)** tube avoid hypertonic or large-volume drugs (dumping, perforation), and **some medications cannot be given jejunally at all** — check with pharmacy.
- Some **parenteral (injectable) preparations** can be given enterally when no oral liquid exists (e.g., **clonidine, glycopyrrolate**) — confirm suitability and dose with pharmacy first.

▴ DIFFERENTIATE THE TUBE AT THE BEDSIDE

- **Where it enters** — nose / mouth (NGT/OGT) vs the abdomen (gastrostomy / GJ / J).
- **Profile** — an external bumper with a **balloon port** (water valve) = balloon gastrostomy; **flush to the skin** needing an extension = low-profile **button**; a firm internal flange that resists gentle traction = **PEG**.
- **Ports** — **two labeled ports (GASTRIC + JEJUNAL)** = GJ; a single feed port plus a balloon port = gastrostomy.
- Read the **French size, length, and brand** off the tube and the care plan. Unsure of the route? Confirm with **contrast** — do not feed to find out.

MANAGE THE COMMON STOMA COMPLICATIONS

Problem	What & why	Management
Granulation (granuloma)	Red, moist, friable overgrowth from friction and moisture.	Stop the movement (secure the tube, correct balloon volume); saline soaks ; topical silver nitrate (protect surrounding skin with a barrier) or a short topical steroid ; silver / foam / hydrocolloid dressing. ¹⁴⁸
Leak	Gastric contents track around the tube.	Do not just upsize the tube (enlarges the stoma). Correct balloon volume; treat constipation, retching, delayed emptying (vent, prokinetic, slow the feed); treat granulation / infection; barrier cream. Consider buried bumper. ¹⁴⁸
Redness	Irritation vs infection.	< 5 mm erythema is usually irritation — barrier protection. Spreading redness, pain, swelling, or pus = infection → swab, then topical or systemic antibiotics (cover skin flora).
Excoriation	Enzymatic burn from leaked feed and acid.	Stop the leak at source; barrier products (zinc or dimethicone cream, pectin barrier ring / powder); keep dry; involve the stoma nurse.

◆ GOLDEN RULES

- Confirm route before feeding or giving a drug; **GASTRIC TOLERATES BOLUSES, JEJUNAL IS CONTINUOUS ONLY**; flush to keep patent.
- A fresh gastrostomy stoma can close within hours if the tube falls out — see [Gastrostomy \(Feeding\) Tube Problems](#).

📖 LEARN MORE – OPEN-ACCESS PEDIATRIC RESOURCES (no login required)

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ECMO – What the General Pediatrician Needs to Know

ASSESS

KNOW WHEN TO CALL • ELSO

Temporary heart–lung support for severe but **reversible** failure — your job is to recognize the candidate and call **early**.

▴ WHAT IT IS

- Temporary machine support that **oxygenates the blood and removes CO₂** (± supports the circulation) to buy time for **potentially reversible** heart or lung failure. It is a **bridge** — to recovery, a decision, or transplant — **not a cure**, and is run only in a specialized PICU / ECMO center. ^{153,154}
- **VV (veno-venous) = lung support** (the heart still works); **VA (veno-arterial) = heart ± lung support**, and covers **ECPR** (ECMO during a refractory but reversible cardiac arrest). ^{153,155}

⚠ WHEN TO THINK ECMO – CALL EARLY

Severe **cardiac or respiratory failure not responding to maximal conventional therapy**, in a child with a **reversible cause** (e.g., fulminant myocarditis, ARDS / severe pneumonia, PPHN; neonatal MAS or CDH). **Call the PICU / ECMO center early** — before catastrophic deterioration or irreversible brain injury; timely referral improves outcomes, so do not wait for arrest. **The center decides candidacy, thresholds, and timing.** ^{153,154,155,156}

⚠️ USUALLY NOT A CANDIDATE

- An **irreversible** condition with no exit strategy · **severe irreversible brain injury** · a **lethal chromosomal / congenital anomaly** (e.g., trisomy 13 or 18 — not 21) · **uncontrolled bleeding**.^{153,154,156}
- Extreme prematurity, very low birth weight, and many days of prior ventilation lower the chance of benefit.^{153,154,156}
- The final decision rests with the ECMO team.¹⁵⁵

✦ YOUR ROLE – BEFORE AND AFTER

- You are **not** expected to run ECMO — you **recognize the failing-yet-reversible child and escalate**.^{153,154}
- Resuscitate and support maximally, **protect the brain and other organs**, avoid irreversible injury, and **call the PICU / ECMO center early**.^{153,154}
- Afterwards, **survivors need long-term multidisciplinary follow-up**: about **1 in 4** neonatal survivors has neuropsychological deficits (more after cardiac ECMO) and new problems can appear later — track development and arrange **hearing tests** (sensorineural loss can be progressive / late).¹⁵⁷
- Support the family through a **high-risk, uncertain course** (major complications include bleeding, clots, and stroke).^{153,154,157}

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — refractory cardiac or respiratory failure with a reversible cause → **PICU / ECMO center now**.^{153,154}
- **Refer — now** — discuss early — call **before** the child is in extremis; deterioration is often rapid.¹⁵⁴

Post-PICU Syndrome (PICS-p) ASSESS AFTER CRITICAL ILLNESS

Surviving the PICU is only the start — new physical, cognitive, emotional, and social problems can follow the child and family for years.

▴ WHAT IT IS

- **Post-Intensive Care Syndrome — pediatric (PICS-p)**: new or worsening impairment across **four domains** after critical illness — **physical, cognitive, emotional, and social** — affecting the **child and the family**. It emerges over the months after discharge and can persist for years.^{158,159,160}
- You, the general pediatrician, are the one who **sees these children back** — so you screen for it, coordinate care, and reassure.^{159,160,161}

THE FOUR DOMAINS – WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Domain	Watch for
Physical	ICU-acquired weakness, fatigue, pain, poor feeding / growth, reduced exercise tolerance, poor sleep residual respiratory or organ problems. ^{159,161}
Cognitive	Attention, memory, and executive difficulties developmental regression in the young declining school performance. ^{159,161}
Emotional	PTSD, anxiety, depression, nightmares / delusional memories, fear, irritability or aggression, behavioral change. ^{159,161,162}
Social	Trouble reintegrating at school, absenteeism, withdrawal from peers and activities, identity and participation problems. ^{159,161}

► HIGHER RISK AFTER...

- **Longer PICU stay, mechanical ventilation, sedation and delirium**, renal replacement, ECMO, cardiac arrest, sepsis, ARDS, or major trauma; oncology / neurology diagnoses; an **unscheduled admission**; younger age and pre-existing conditions.^{159,163}

⚠ DON'T FORGET THE FAMILY (PICS-F)

- Parents and siblings are affected too: screened before PICU discharge, **~60% of parents were at risk of PTSD and ~75% of depression** (single-center study)¹⁶⁴, alongside anxiety, financial strain, and impaired family functioning.^{158,159,161}
- Ask how the **family** is coping, and support them.^{159,161}

✦ YOUR ROLE

- At the first post-discharge visits and beyond: **screen every domain** (development, school, mood / sleep, physical function) and the family's wellbeing; **coordinate multidisciplinary follow-up** — physiotherapy / occupational therapy / speech-language therapy, psychology, neurodevelopmental assessment, and **school liaison**; reconcile medications; and treat the family as part of the patient.^{159,161}
- Normalize and follow up rather than dismiss — recovery is a trajectory, not an event.^{158,161,165}

► ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Screen** — every child at follow-up after a significant PICU admission.^{159,161}
- **Refer — now** — escalate new severe mental-health symptoms (e.g., self-harm risk) or acute physical deterioration.^{159,161}

- **Refer — clinic** — neurodevelopment / rehabilitation, psychology / psychiatry, and the relevant specialty for persistent domain-specific problems; social work for family support.^{159,161}

Aeromedical Transport – Neonatal & Pediatric ASSESS

PRE-FLIGHT ASSESSMENT • MOH A-ADM-014

Match the transport tier to clinical risk — two predictable cabin stresses (hypoxia, gas expansion) drive the pre-flight assessment.

▲ TWO CABIN STRESSES – ASSESS BEFORE EVERY FLIGHT

- **Hypobaric hypoxia** — cabins are pressurized to a maximum **8,000 ft** equivalent ($\approx$ breathing **15% oxygen** at sea level); a healthy PaO_2 falls to **~60–75 mmHg** (8–10 kPa; SpO_2 ~89–94%). Limited cardiopulmonary reserve desaturates further. **Resting SpO_2 alone is insensitive.** If available, a **HAST (hypoxia-altitude simulation test)** best predicts in-flight oxygen need in a child with chronic lung or cardiac disease.¹⁶⁶ **If HAST is not available,** use the practical **alternative:** base the decision on **resting oximetry, the diagnosis and trajectory, and any prior flight tolerance,** and — when in doubt — **give empiric in-flight oxygen** (double an existing flow) or choose a **sea-level cabin / air ambulance** for higher-risk children.^{166,167,168,169}
- **Trapped-gas expansion** — gas in a closed space expands **~38%** from sea level to 8,000 ft. Pneumothorax, recent surgery with retained gas, and intracranial or intraocular gas need a **sea-level cabin (air ambulance)** when the gas cannot be excluded. A **current pneumothorax requires a chest drain before any urgent flight**¹⁶⁶ — even if it is minimal.

△ NEONATAL & INFANT AIR TRANSPORT – STABILITY, NOT AGE, GOVERNS

- **Term neonate:** defer non-urgent flying for roughly the **first 7 days** (ideally to ~40 weeks corrected) to confirm feeding, thermoregulation, and no undiagnosed cardiorespiratory problem or silent pneumothorax. ^{166,168}
- **Preterm without chronic lung disease:** the “~3 months corrected age” figure is a **soft guide, not a fixed cutoff** — fitness depends on **gestational maturity + demonstrated cardiorespiratory stability + being apnea-free**, judged individually. Avoid flying during a respiratory infection until ~6 months corrected age (apnea risk). Former preterms with **BPD / neonatal chronic lung disease:** discuss with a respiratory pediatrician and, where available, a **HAST** before flying (~70% desaturate on hypoxic challenge). ^{166,167,168}
- **An incubator is not mandatory for a stable infant** — a physiologically stable infant may travel in an aircraft **bassinet / in-arms**. A **transport incubator** is needed for thermal instability, continuous monitoring, controlled oxygen/humidity, or mechanical ventilation. ^{167,168,169}
- **Respiratory support changes the route, not by age:** a ventilated or monitoring-dependent infant goes by **dedicated air ambulance** (incubator/transport platform, continuous SpO₂ + ECG, capnography if ventilated, altitude-appropriate settings, sea-level-cabin option). A **stable, monitored, ventilated infant can still be flown** for urgent surgery with a specialist team. ^{166,167,169}
- **Tier by stability:** stable, self-ventilating, thermally stable → **bassinet/in-arms commercial** (after the term deferral / individualized preterm assessment); oxygen-dependent or apnea-risk → **commercial + medical clearance + in-flight O₂** (roughly double the flow at cruise); unstable/ventilated/monitoring-dependent → **dedicated air ambulance**. ^{167,168,169}

IN-FLIGHT OXYGEN – INFANTS & YOUNG CHILDREN

Current support / status	Action
Already on oxygen	Double the flow rate in flight as a starting point; confirm it is deliverable in the cabin. ^{166,167,168}
Needs > 4 L/min at baseline	Commercial flight not advised → escalate to air ambulance . ^{166,167}

◎ OXYGEN LOGISTICS

- Carriers supply oxygen at fixed flows (often 2–4 L/min, set rates or none). ^{168,170}
- A need for precise or higher flow, or a corrected requirement > ~4 L/min, cannot be reliably managed on a scheduled flight. ^{167,168}
- Carry an airline-approved **PORTABLE OXYGEN CONCENTRATOR (POC)** with battery for ≥ 150% of journey time; the US prohibits passenger oxygen cylinders (use a POC or carrier oxygen). ^{166,168,170}

TRANSPORT TIER – ASSIGN THE LOWEST TIER THAT SAFELY COVERS THE WHOLE JOURNEY

Tier	Mode & escort	Typical pediatric patient
0	Commercial seat, no escort	Stable, self-caring; PEWS low. ¹⁶⁹
1	Commercial seat + non-medical attendant	Minor / vulnerable; needs help with mobility, not clinical care. ¹⁶⁹
2	Commercial seat + a competent trained caregiver a nurse/RT is required only if oxygen- or ventilation-dependent, or other risk is expected	Stable tracheostomy on room air (with a trained caregiver competent in the device), stable oxygen, or pump feeding. ¹⁶⁹
3	Commercial seat or stretcher + physician + nurse (add RT for home-vent)	Stable established home ventilation, or a fragile child with deterioration potential. ¹⁶⁹
4	Dedicated air ambulance + critical-care team	Critically ill or unstable (meets air-ambulance criteria below). ¹⁶⁹

© SCORING & PERSONNEL (PER POLICY)

- The policy stratifies patients by **LEVEL OF CARE 0-4** and a **NEWS-BASED RISK LEVEL** (Low = 1-4 · Medium = 5-6 · High = ≥ 7).¹⁶⁹ In children, substitute an age-appropriate **PEWS** (NEWS2 is not for use under 16 yr).¹⁷¹
- If findings fall between tiers, choose the **HIGHER TIER**. A low score with **HIGH DETERIORATION POTENTIAL** (end-stage lung disease, potential airway/hemodynamic compromise) is classified up by the accompanying physician.¹⁶⁹
- AT LEAST TWO COMPETENT PERSONNEL** escort any patient; for a child, include a **PARENT/LEGAL GUARDIAN** where possible.¹⁶⁹

© **LOCAL AVAILABILITY (KUWAIT)** A **DEDICATED PEDIATRIC / NEONATAL AEROMEDICAL TRANSPORT TEAM IS NOT YET ESTABLISHED** — transfers are currently staffed by the **ACCOMPANYING PEDIATRIC / TREATING TEAM**. Confirm current MOH capability early and coordinate through the A-ADM-014 pathway (Directorate of Treatment Abroad).¹⁶⁹

⚠ DEDICATED AIR AMBULANCE (SEA-LEVEL CABIN) – WHEN COMMERCIAL CARRIAGE WILL NOT DO

Any one absolute criterion mandates it: **acute / unstable ventilation** or a credible need to intubate or escalate in transit; **hemodynamic instability** needing vasoactive / inotropic infusion; a **trapped-gas condition** needing sea-level cabin (unresolved pneumothorax, recent intracranial / intraocular gas, significant bowel obstruction); need for **invasive monitoring or mechanical support** (arterial-line titration, ICP monitoring, IABP, **ECMO**, VAD, external pacing); **refractory hypoxemia** or oxygen need beyond carrier capability; **status epilepticus** / uncontrolled seizures; or a communicable disease needing **isolation**. Under the policy, **Medevac (air ambulance)** also applies to **priority 1–2 cases**, expedited transfer of an unstable patient, brain-death repatriation, or when the commercial route/port is not cleared. **Absolute contraindications to flight until treated:** untreated pneumothorax, hemothorax or a compromising effusion, cardiac tamponade, recent abdominal surgery / immediate post-op, or a penetrated eye injury.¹⁶⁹

✦ AIRWAY & CUFFS AT ALTITUDE

- The cabin is a poor place to rescue a failing airway — **secure a difficult or unstable airway definitively before departure**, not aloft; do not defer a foreseeable intubation to the aircraft.^{169,172}
- Air in an endotracheal / tracheostomy **cuff** expands as cabin pressure falls — cuff pressure rises on ascent and falls (with a leak) on descent; **measure cuff pressure with a manometer and adjust the cuff volume as needed** during ascent and descent, or consider filling the cuff with saline/water.¹⁷²
- Confirm the ventilator and oxygen are airline-approved with battery for $\geq 150\%$ of journey time.^{167,168}

▀ TEAM, CLEARANCE & HANDOVER

- **Escort competence:** current **pediatric / neonatal resuscitation** (PALS / NRP) and competence with the child's devices; the accompanying physician is the **MRP** en route.¹⁶⁹
- **Clearance:** pre-flight medical report + **risk assessment** reviewed and approved by the **MRP** (senior registrar or above) **7–14 days and again 48–72 h** before departure; airline **MEDIF** for commercial carriage. A **return/repatriation reassessment is mandatory** before flying home.¹⁶⁹
- **Handover:** document status before, during and on arrival, and give a structured handover to the receiving team using the policy's **handover tools**.¹⁶⁹

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Escalate** — any air-ambulance criterion, or a deteriorating trajectory → critical-care transport team + treatment-abroad / transport committee.¹⁶⁹
- **Proceed commercial** — stable child at Tier 0–3 with a completed pre-flight clinical assessment (HAST where available) and confirmed oxygen/device support.^{167,168,169}
- **Refer — now** — the MOH Directorate of Treatment Abroad (DTA) decides transport type; involve the relevant clinical council for team and equipment.¹⁶⁹

Diabetic Ketoacidosis

HOURS

ISPAD 2022 • TREKK 2023

Glucose > 11 mmol/L (200 mg/dL) + pH < 7.3 or bicarbonate < 18 + ketonemia (β -hydroxybutyrate $\geq$ 3 mmol/L).

Diabetic Ketoacidosis – bedside algorithm

Adapted from TREKK¹⁷³; aligned with the Kuwait PICU Task Force • ISPAD 2022.

Recognition of DKA

Diagnostic criteria — ALL 3:

- Hyperglycemia: blood glucose > 11 mmol/L
- Metabolic acidosis: pH < 7.3 or HCO_3^- < 18 mmol/L
- Ketonuria/ketonemia: moderate-large urine ketones or β -hydroxybutyrate $\geq$ 3 mmol/L

DKA severity	Mild	Moderate	Severe
pH	7.20–7.29	7.10–7.19	< 7.1
HCO_3^- (mmol/L)	10–18	5–9	< 5

Initial Management

- Assess ABCs, vital signs (including blood pressure) + neuro-vitals (GCS, pupils), weight & signs of dehydration.
- Rapid bedside glucose & blood ketones. Establish **TWO IV accesses**. Start fluid resuscitation immediately.
- **Investigations:** serum glucose, electrolytes, venous gas, urea, creatinine, osmolality, ketones.
- **Newly diagnosed DM (before insulin if feasible):** insulin, C-peptide, HbA1c, anti-insulin antibody.
- **After stabilization:** anti-GAD, anti-ZnT8, anti-IA2, TFTs, anti-TPO, coeliac screen.
- **If infection suspected:** CBC, CRP, cultures.

Fluid Resuscitation

(dehydration drives DKA complications, including acute kidney injury)

- NS or RL **10–20 mL/kg (max 1 L) IV bolus over 20–30 min** — if in shock, 20 mL/kg NS or RL as quickly as possible.
- Repeat NS or RL 20 mL/kg (max 1 L) bolus if ongoing hypoperfusion (cap refill $\geq$ 3 s centrally, cool extremities).
- Reassess vitals & perfusion after each bolus.

⚠ CEREBRAL EDEMA — the leading cause of death; watch at EVERY stage

MONITOR THROUGHOUT

Can develop before, during or after treatment — highest risk 4–12 h into management. Re-screen at every step of this algorithm.

Suspect if:

- GCS $\leq$ 13, severe/progressive headache, focal neurological signs, incontinence and/or inconsolability, **AND/OR**
- Cushing's triad: rising BP, bradycardia, abnormal breathing.

If suspected — act in this order:

- **Recheck blood glucose first** — a critical drop / hypoglycemia mimics these signs and is rapidly reversible; treat at once if low.
- **Call the PICU team immediately** — mortality is high once confirmed; do not wait for the CT head. Treat on clinical suspicion.
- Elevate head of bed to 30° & keep midline; reduce IV fluids to **60%** of the rehydration-table rate; watch BP & perfusion.
- **3% NaCl 5 mL/kg (max 250 mL) IV over 10–15 min** or mannitol 0.5–1 g/kg (max 100 g) IV over 10–15 min; may repeat $\times 1$ after 30 min or use the alternate agent.

Ongoing IV Fluids & Insulin

Weight (kg)	5–<10	10–<20	20–<40	≥ 40
Rate (mL/kg/h)	6.5	6	5	4 (max 500 mL/h)

Rehydrate with 0.45–0.9% NS or RL per the table above.

Insulin — regular insulin infusion **0.1 unit/kg/h IV**, at least **1 h after IV fluids** (delay if $\text{K}^+ < 3.5$), 0.05 unit/kg/h in children < 5 y or milder DKA (pH > 7.15). **Never bolus insulin.**

Preparation: 50 units regular insulin in 50 mL 0.9% NS (1 unit = 1 mL); flush the tubing with insulin solution before use.

Potassium — for K^+ 3.5–5.5 mmol/L, add **40 mmol/L KCl** to fluids alongside insulin (see table for $\text{K}^+ > 5.5$ or < 3.5).

Dextrose — add dextrose 5% if BG falls to **14–17 mmol/L**, or sooner if the rate of fall is > 5 mmol/L/h after initial fluid expansion.

Severe hypophosphatemia (< 0.32 mmol/L) — treat even if asymptomatic: give part of the potassium as **potassium phosphate** (about half as KCl + half as potassium phosphate, e.g. 20 mmol/L KCl + 20 mmol/L potassium phosphate — see the potassium table for the local protocol). Monitor serum calcium & magnesium during the infusion — phosphate can cause hypocalcemia.

CAUTION

- **Intubation is HIGH-RISK** in DKA — it removes the child's respiratory (CO_2) compensation for the acidosis.
- **DO NOT** give sodium bicarbonate unless there is life-threatening hyperkalemia, or severe acidosis (pH < 6.9) with compromised cardiac contractility.
- **NEVER** give potassium as an IV bolus or push, and **NEVER** flush a potassium-containing line — the concentrated residual delivered suddenly can cause fatal arrhythmia/arrest. Give KCl only **diluted, by controlled infusion pump, added to the fluid bag**; correct severe hypokalemia in **PICU/HDU**.

Ongoing Monitoring

- **Every 1 h:** blood glucose, vital signs, neuro-vitals (headache, irritability, incontinence, pupils, GCS), fluid in & out — **screen for cerebral edema at each check** (see red box).
- **Every 2 h:** blood gas, electrolytes, blood β -hydroxybutyrate.
- **Every 4 h:** urea, creatinine, electrolytes, Mg, phosphate, calcium, anion gap.

Potassium — by the serum K^+

K^+ (mmol/L)	Action
> 5.5 (or anuric)	Defer potassium — add it only once the child has passed urine (confirming not anuric) or K^+ has fallen to ≤ 5.5 .
3.5–5.5	Add 40 mmol/L KCl to fluids together with insulin — or 20 mmol/L KCl + 20 mmol/L potassium phosphate.
< 3.5	Give potassium first & defer insulin until $\text{K}^+ \geq 3.5$. Severe hypokalemia needs a dedicated, pump-controlled KCl correction infusion (≤ 0.5 mmol/kg/h; continuous ECG) in PICU/HDU — the pump sets the rate; never a bolus, never flush the line .
Severe / persistent	If hypokalemia persists despite maximal replacement, reduce the insulin rate by 25%.

Delivered K^+ rate = fluid rate (mL/kg/h) $\times$ KCl concentration (mmol/mL). Peripheral max = 40 mmol/L (local Kuwait PICU: 60 mmol/L KCl, or 30 KCl + 30 potassium phosphate); higher concentrations need central access.

Acidosis Not Improving (Despite treatment)

Re-evaluate

- IV fluid calculations.
- **Insulin delivery system and dose** — check for disconnection, wrong insulin/NS mixing in the bag, a pump or rate error, an occluded line, or an infiltrated cannula.
- Need for additional fluid resuscitation.
- Consider sepsis.
- Anion gap or blood β -hydroxybutyrate — for a normal-anion-gap (hyperchloremic) metabolic acidosis or normal blood β -hydroxybutyrate, consider changing NS to RL or 0.45% NS to reduce the chloride load.

Escalation — who to call

- Pediatric endocrinology / diabetes team — call in **ALL** cases of DKA to guide insulin, biochemical targets and transition to subcutaneous insulin.
- Call the PICU team immediately for: suspected cerebral edema; severe DKA; age < 5 y; reduced consciousness; hemodynamic instability; or high-risk features (pH < 7.1, $\text{pCO}_2 < 21$ mmHg, urea > 7 mmol/L).

◆ FLUIDS – THE ISPAD 2022 METHOD

- After the bolus, replace the estimated deficit (**5% mild · 7% moderate · 10% severe**, minus the bolus) **plus maintenance** evenly over **24–48 h**; the weight-band rates in the algorithm equal a 7% deficit (minus a 10 mL/kg bolus) plus maintenance over 24 h. Rapid versus slow rehydration and 0.45% versus 0.9% saline did not change neurological outcomes in the 1,389-episode PECARN FLUID trial.^{131,174}

◆ SEVERITY & PICU

- **For DKA managed in the PICU, follow the latest Kuwait PICU Task Force DKA guideline** — the local task-force protocol governs fluid, insulin and electrolyte targets in the unit.¹⁷⁵
- Consider PICU for severe DKA, young children (age < 5 y), reduced consciousness, long symptom duration, compromised circulation, or high-risk features (pH < 7.1, pCO₂ < 21 mmHg, urea > 7 mmol/L).¹³¹

▲ CEREBRAL INJURY – FURTHER DETAIL

- If focal neurological deficits develop, obtain an urgent CT to exclude cerebral venous thrombosis or intracranial hemorrhage. **Do not postpone treatment to obtain a CT.** Perform hourly GCS so cerebral injury is caught early — it is the leading cause of death in pediatric DKA.¹³¹

◆ AVOID WHERE POSSIBLE

Intubation (ventilation removes the child's respiratory compensation for the acidosis), central venous catheters (thrombosis risk; a large dead space can make insulin delivery erratic if insulin runs through the CVC), and routine urinary catheterization.¹³¹

✦ PEARL – THE MASQUERADES OF NEW-ONSET DKA

- First-presentation diabetes is missed when DKA wears a disguise: **abdominal pain and vomiting** taken for gastroenteritis or appendicitis, **Kussmaul breathing** taken for pneumonia or an asthma attack, and **polyuria** taken for a urinary tract infection or, in a younger child, secondary enuresis.
- A bedside glucose and ketones settle it in seconds.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all children with DKA; **level of care follows severity**: **mild DKA** → general pediatric ward with hourly monitoring; **moderate/severe**, young age (< 5 y), reduced consciousness, or high-risk features → high-dependency/PICU.¹³¹
- **Home from the ward** — not from DKA; after transition to subcutaneous insulin with diabetes-team education.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric endocrinology/diabetes team for all; PICU for cerebral-injury risk.

Hyperglycemic Hyperosmolar State (HHS)

MINUTES

ISPAD 2022

Not “severe DKA” — very high glucose, very high osmolality, little ketosis, and higher mortality.

▴ DEFINE (DIFFERS FROM DKA)

- Glucose > **33 mmol/L (600 mg/dL)**, serum osmolality > **320 mOsm/kg**, pH > **7.3** and **bicarbonate > 15**, only mild ketosis, with altered consciousness/profound dehydration. Increasingly seen in adolescents with obesity/type-2 diabetes.¹³¹

⚠ MANAGE IT DIFFERENTLY FROM DKA

- Fluid deficits are larger (~12–15%) and **fluid — not insulin — is the priority first.**¹³¹
- Start insulin **later and lower** (only once glucose stops falling with fluids alone¹³¹, ~0.025–0.05 unit/kg/h).
- Watch for **rhabdomyolysis, malignant-hyperthermia-like fever, thrombosis and arrhythmia from potassium/phosphate shifts.**¹³¹
- Mortality is higher than DKA.¹³¹

✦ MIXED PICTURES EXIST

- Some children have features of both HHS and DKA.
- When ketoacidosis coexists, follow DKA fluid/insulin caution but expect a **bigger fluid requirement** and monitor osmolality and creatine kinase closely.

▴ WORKUP

- Glucose, **venous blood gas**, beta-hydroxybutyrate/ketones.
- Electrolytes with **corrected sodium**, potassium, **phosphate, magnesium, calcium**; BUN/creatinine.
- **Calculated effective osmolality**; ECG + continuous cardiac monitoring.
- **Creatine kinase** — screen for rhabdomyolysis.

Step	Approach	Notes
Fluids first	0.9% saline; restore circulation, then replace deficit steadily	Aim to lower glucose gradually with fluid alone initially
Insulin (delayed)	0.025–0.05 unit/kg/h once glucose plateaus on fluids	No bolus; avoid rapid osmolar shifts
Monitor	Osmolality, K⁺, PO₄, Ca²⁺, creatine kinase, neuro obs	Anticipate rhabdomyolysis and hyperthermia

▴ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** to high-dependency/PICU.

- **Call** pediatric endocrinology and critical care.

Adrenal Crisis / Salt-Wasting CAH

MINUTES

BSPED 2023

Shock + low sodium + high potassium + low glucose; collapse with illness.

RECOGNIZE

- Known adrenal insufficiency/CAH under stress, or a neonate (1–4 weeks) with vomiting, poor feeding, weight loss, hyperpigmentation, ambiguous genitalia (in females).¹⁷⁶
- Labs: low sodium, high potassium, metabolic acidosis, low glucose.

① STEROID – DON'T WAIT

Hydrocortisone immediately (draw 17-OHP/cortisol first only if no delay).¹⁷⁷



② FLUIDS + GLUCOSE

Saline bolus, repeat; treat low glucose; maintenance with dextrose-saline.



③ ELECTROLYTES & CAUSE

High potassium usually corrects with fluids + steroid (ECG for peaked T waves). Treat the trigger (often infection); cover empirically for sepsis if suspected. Endocrine + PICU.

Drug / fluid	Dose	Route & notes
Hydrocortisone	< 1 yr 25 mg 1–5 yr 50 mg > 5 yr 100 mg	IV/IM ¹⁷⁸ , then 50–100 mg/m ² /day divided every 6 h ¹⁷⁷
Sodium chloride 0.9%	20 mL/kg	IV bolus, repeat
Dextrose 10%	5 mL/kg	IV, for low glucose
Fludrocortisone	0.1 mg once daily	Oral — maintenance only, not for the acute crisis

⚠ DO NOT USE DEXAMETHASONE FOR SALT-WASTING CRISIS

- It has **no mineralocorticoid effect**.¹⁷⁶
- Give hydrocortisone immediately — do not delay it for lab results.
- High-dose hydrocortisone (> 50 mg) covers the mineralocorticoid need acutely; fludrocortisone is added later for maintenance.¹⁷⁶

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → monitored bed; hydrocortisone before labs, treat hypoglycemia/hyponatremia.
- **Home from the ward** — only after stabilization, endocrine review, and stress-dosing/emergency-injection education.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric endocrinology (the "endocrine review" required before discharge).

Hypoglycemia (Beyond the Newborn)

MINUTES

PES 2015

Plasma glucose < 3.9 mmol/L (70 mg/dL) — treat now; draw the critical sample first only when it will not delay treatment.¹⁷⁹

▲ RECOGNIZE

- **Autonomic:** sweating, tremor, tachycardia, hunger, pallor, anxiety. **Neuroglycopenic:** lethargy, irritability, poor feeding, behavior change, confusion, seizures, coma.
- **Whipple triad** confirms it: low plasma glucose + consistent symptoms + resolution with glucose. Confirm any bedside reading with a **laboratory plasma glucose** (glucometers are unreliable when low).¹⁷⁹
- Red-flag context: hepatomegaly (glycogen storage / fatty-acid oxidation defect), midline defects or micropenis (hypopituitarism), hyperpigmentation (adrenal insufficiency), fasting- or illness-triggered episodes, or a high glucose-infusion requirement.

▲ DRAW THE CRITICAL SAMPLE – BUT NEVER DELAY TREATING SEVERE OR SYMPTOMATIC HYPOGLYCEMIA

Obtain the sample before glucose **whenever it can be drawn immediately**. If the child is **symptomatic or severely hypoglycemic, treat first** and take the sample as soon as access allows — do not delay treatment for the sample. At the moment of hypoglycemia (ideally glucose < 2.8 mmol/L): **lab glucose, venous gas/bicarbonate, insulin + C-peptide, β-hydroxybutyrate + free fatty acids** (the pivotal branch point), **lactate, ammonia, cortisol + growth hormone, acylcarnitine profile + carnitine, plasma amino acids**; and the **first-void urine** for ketones, organic acids ± toxin/sulfonylurea screen. One missed sample can cost the diagnosis.¹⁷⁹

① CORRECT NOW

IV **D10 2 mL/kg** (200 mg/kg) slow push — avoid large hyperosmolar boluses. If alert with a safe airway: oral rapid carbohydrate ~0.3 g/kg.¹⁷⁹



② MAINTAIN

- Continue **D10 at maintenance** and titrate the **glucose-infusion rate** to keep glucose > 3.9 mmol/L (central line for > D12.5)
- A requirement > **8–10 mg/kg/min strongly suggests hyperinsulinism** (a hallmark¹⁷⁹ — confirm on the critical sample); maintain euglycemia with escalating dextrose as an initial measure until the endocrinology team advises.



Glucagon 0.5–1 mg IM/IV/SC (or 0.03 mg/kg, max 1 mg) when there is no IV access or hyperinsulinism is suspected — a rise > 1.7 mmol/L (30 mg/dL) suggests hyperinsulinism. It fails in glycogen-depleted states (ketotic hypoglycemia, fatty-acid oxidation defects).¹⁷⁹

▀ READ THE KETONES/FREE-FATTY-ACIDS BRANCH

- **Low ketones + low free fatty acids** (non-ketotic) with detectable insulin → **hyperinsulinism** (congenital K_{ATP} , Beckwith-Wiedemann, exogenous insulin/sulfonylurea, dumping).¹⁷⁹
- **Low ketones + high free fatty acids** (hypoketotic) → **fatty-acid oxidation defect** (e.g. VLCADD or LCHADD) — abnormal acylcarnitines ± hyperammonemia/cardiomyopathy.
- **High ketones + high free fatty acids** (appropriate) → **ketotic hypoglycemia of childhood** (commonest, 1–5 yr, illness-triggered, diagnosis of exclusion), **GH/cortisol deficiency**, or **glycogen storage disease** (hepatomegaly, high lactate).¹⁷⁹

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — unexplained symptomatic or persistent hypoglycemia → until fasting safety is documented and a cause established.
- **Home** — only after a documented safe fast and a sick-day/emergency plan (home glucagon where indicated).
- **Refer — now** — pediatric endocrinology/metabolic; hyperinsulinism or a glucose infusion rate > 8–10 mg/kg/min → **consult endocrinology with congenital hyperinsulinism (CHI) expertise.**

Acute Electrolyte Emergencies MINUTES

Stabilize the heart, stop the seizures, then correct at a safe rate.

▀ HYPERKALEMIA — GET AN ECG FIRST

- **Hyperkalemia** = serum K^+ > **5.5 mmol/L** (mild 5.5–6.0 · moderate 6.0–6.5 · severe > **6.5** or ECG changes); **hypokalemia** = K^+ < **3.5 mmol/L** (severe < 2.5).¹⁸⁰
- ECG progression: peaked T waves → flattened P / prolonged PR → widened QRS → sine wave → arrest. Treat urgently if there are **ECG changes or potassium > 6.5 mmol/L**.¹⁸⁰
- If the child is well with a normal ECG, repeat a **free-flowing venous sample** first — hemolysis causes pseudohyperkalemia.¹⁸⁰ **Stop all potassium intake** and potassium-raising drugs.

HYPERKALEMIA – STABILIZE, SHIFT, REMOVE

Step / drug	Dose	Route & notes
STABILIZE · Calcium gluconate 10%	0.5 mL/kg (max 20 mL) IV over 5–10 min	Cardiac monitor; protects the heart, does not lower potassium. Repeat after 15 min if ECG still abnormal. Not in the same line as bicarbonate (precipitates); caution in digoxin toxicity ¹⁸⁰
SHIFT · Insulin (soluble) + glucose	0.1 unit/kg (max 10 units) + glucose 0.5 g/kg IV (= 5 mL/kg of dextrose 10%)	Onset 10–20 min; monitor glucose closely — early and late hypoglycemia ¹⁸⁰
SHIFT · Salbutamol (nebulized)	2.5–5 mg (high dose 10–20 mg)	Additive to insulin; may cause tachycardia ¹⁸⁰
SHIFT · Sodium bicarbonate	1 mmol/kg IV	Only if acidotic; modest, adjunctive effect
REMOVE · Potassium binder	0.5–1 g/kg (max 30 g) oral / rectal	Sodium/calcium polystyrene sulfonate; slow onset — not for immediately life-threatening hyperkalemia; avoid with ileus, bowel obstruction, or NEC risk ¹⁸⁰
REMOVE · Furosemide	1 mg/kg IV	If making urine
REMOVE · Dialysis	–	Refractory or severe; involve renal / PICU early

◆ THE LOGIC

- Calcium and the shifters (insulin, salbutamol, bicarbonate) only **BUY TIME**; only binders, loop diuretics, and dialysis actually remove potassium from the body.¹⁸⁰
- Recheck potassium and glucose after treating.

SODIUM – CORRECT AT A SAFE RATE

© **DEFINITIONS** Hyponatremia = $\text{Na}^+ < 135 \text{ MMOL/L}$ (severe < 125); hypernatremia = $\text{Na}^+ > 145 \text{ MMOL/L}$ ¹⁸¹ (> 150 is often used for hypernatremic dehydration — expert consensus, not guideline-stated).

Problem	Treatment	Notes
Hyponatremia with seizures / encephalopathy	3% saline 2 mL/kg (max 100 mL) IV over 10 min repeat once or twice until symptoms improve	Each bolus raises sodium by about 2 mmol/L ¹⁸¹ ; stop boluses once symptoms improve and keep the rise ≤ 12 mmol/L in 24 h ¹⁸² ; many experts aim for a 5–6 mmol/L rise in the first 1–2 h and no more than 10 mmol/L in the first 5 h and 15–20 mmol/L in 48 h (expert consensus — not guideline-stated).
Hyponatremia (no severe symptoms)	Treat the cause; correct slowly	Do not exceed 8 mmol/L per 24 h (a conservative expert limit ¹⁸¹ ; NICE pediatric ceiling 12 mmol/L per 24 h) — osmotic demyelination. Volume depletion → 0.9% saline; SIADH → fluid restriction ¹⁸²
Hypernatremic dehydration	Resuscitate shock with isotonic fluid first, then rehydrate over ~48 h	Lower sodium ≤ 0.5 mmol/L per hour (≤ 10–12 per 24 h) — faster risks cerebral edema ^{182, 183}

CALCIUM & MAGNESIUM

◎ **DEFINITIONS** Hypocalcemia = total calcium < **2.1 MMOL/L** or ionized < **1.1 MMOL/L** (neonate < 2.0 mmol/L; correct total calcium for albumin). Hypomagnesemia = Mg²⁺ < **0.7 MMOL/L** (blocks correction of low K⁺ and Ca²⁺).

Problem	Treatment	Notes
Symptomatic hypocalcemia	Calcium gluconate 10% 0.5–1 mL/kg slow IV (local practice – the UK label gives age-banded doses of 0.1–0.9 mL/kg, up to 2 mL/kg in severe neonatal hypocalcemia ¹⁸⁴), cardiac monitor then infusion	Tetany, seizures, prolonged QT, Chvostek / Trousseau signs. Monitor heart rate / ECG during injection; avoid extravasation (tissue necrosis) ¹⁸⁴
Refractory hypocalcemia or hypokalemia	Check and replace magnesium	Low magnesium blocks correction of both — replace it first (it makes hypokalemia refractory to potassium and impairs parathyroid hormone secretion) ^{185,186}

⚠ THE SAFE-RATE RULE

Move fast to **stabilize the heart** (calcium) and **stop seizures** (3% saline), but correct chronic sodium **slowly**: overcorrecting low sodium causes osmotic demyelination, and dropping high sodium too fast causes cerebral edema.¹⁸⁷

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — symptomatic or severe derangements, or those needing infusions/monitoring → high-dependency/PICU.
- **Home from the emergency department** — mild, asymptomatic, correctable causes, with a follow-up recheck.

- **Refer — now** — nephrology/endocrinology by cause; PICU for arrhythmia risk or rapid shifts.

Hypercalcemia HOURS

Corrected calcium > 2.6 mmol/L (10.5 mg/dL); > 3.5 mmol/L (14 mg/dL) is a crisis. ¹⁸⁸

RECOGNIZE

- **Stones, bones, groans & psychiatric moans:** nephrocalcinosis/stones; bone pain; constipation, nausea, anorexia, pancreatitis; lethargy, confusion, weakness, hypotonia, coma. Infants: poor feeding, failure to thrive, irritability. ¹⁸⁸
- **Polyuria → dehydration** (nephrogenic diabetes insipidus) — vicious cycle worsening the calcium. Cardiac: **short QT**, bradyarrhythmia; monitor ECG when severe/symptomatic. ¹⁸⁸
- **Correct for albumin:** add 0.8 mg/dL per 1 g/dL albumin below 4.0; confirm with **ionized calcium**. ¹⁸⁸
- Mild 2.6–3.0
- moderate 3.0–3.5
- severe > 3.5 mmol/L.

FIND THE CAUSE — PTH IS THE BRANCH POINT

- **High or inappropriately normal PTH** → primary hyperparathyroidism (think MEN) or **familial hypocalciuric hypercalcemia** (low urine Ca/Cr — benign, do **not** operate). ¹⁸⁸
- **Suppressed PTH** → malignancy (PTHrP/osteolysis), vitamin D intoxication, granulomatous disease, immobilization, thiazides, milk-alkali. Send PTHrP, 25-OH & 1,25-(OH)₂ vitamin D, phosphate, magnesium, urine Ca/Cr. ¹⁸⁸
- **Infants:** subcutaneous fat necrosis, Williams syndrome, idiopathic infantile hypercalcemia, neonatal severe hyperparathyroidism.

LOWER THE CALCIUM — HYDRATE, THEN REMOVE

Step / drug	Dose	Route & notes
Stop intake	—	Stop all calcium & vitamin D (diet, fluids, supplements); stop thiazides, lithium, vitamin A/D
0.9% saline (cornerstone)	10–20 mL/kg bolus, then ~2–3× maintenance (~3000 mL/m ² /day)	IV; restores volume then drives calciuresis; target brisk urine output ¹⁸⁸
Furosemide	1 mg/kg IV	Only after volume repletion; for fluid overload; monitor K ⁺ /Mg ²⁺
Calcitonin (salmon)	4 IU/kg SC/IM every 6–12 h (up to 8 IU/kg q6h)	Rapid onset (2–6 h), modest; tachyphylaxis by 48 h ¹⁸⁸ — a bridge. <i>Salmon</i> is the potent form used clinically (≈40× human calcitonin).

Step / drug	Dose	Route & notes
Zoledronic acid (preferred)	0.025–0.05 mg/kg/day IV (max 4 mg; pediatric dose: local practice) 4 mg/5 mL vial, dilute 1:20 in 0.9% saline, infuse over 15 min	Preferred bisphosphonate for high bone turnover (malignancy, immobilization) — higher response rate (complete response ~88% vs ~70%) and a much shorter infusion (5 min vs 2 h in the trial) than pamidronate in adult hypercalcemia of malignancy (Major, <i>J Clin Oncol</i> 2001). ¹⁸⁹ Onset 24–48 h; ensure volume replete; watch for hypocalcemia; reduce/withhold in renal impairment
Pamidronate (alternative)	0.5–1 mg/kg IV over 2–4 h (pediatric dose: local practice)	Alternative where zoledronic acid is unavailable; same indications (adult comparative trial) ¹⁸⁹ ; onset 24–48 h; ensure volume replete; watch for hypocalcemia
Glucocorticoid	Prednisone 1–2 mg/kg/day	For vitamin D–mediated, granulomatous disease, or lymphoma/leukemia ¹⁸⁸
Dialysis	–	Severe/refractory, renal failure, or cannot tolerate a saline load

▀ ADMIT • DISCHARGE • REFER

- **Admit** — moderate–severe, symptomatic, or > 3.5 mmol/L → monitored bed/PICU with ECG.
- **Home from the emergency department** — mild & asymptomatic with an outpatient workup and offending agents stopped.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric endocrinology ± oncology/nephrology.
- **Refer — clinic** — parathyroidectomy for primary hyperparathyroidism (not for FHH).

Thyroid Storm (Thyrotoxic Crisis) MINUTES ATA 2016 • BWPS

Decompensated hyperthyroidism: fever, tachyarrhythmia and agitation, often with a trigger.

▀ RECOGNIZE

- Known/undiagnosed Graves' disease with **hyperthermia**, marked **tachycardia or tachyarrhythmia** (atrial fibrillation/heart failure), agitation or reduced consciousness, and GI upset — usually with a trigger (infection, surgery, DKA, medication non-adherence).

⚠ TREAT ON CLINICAL SUSPICION

- Do not wait for thyroid function results.
- Provide supportive care (cooling, fluids, treat the trigger) and block the thyroid axis in the right **order** — β -blockade and a thionamide first, and give **iodine only after** the thionamide to avoid fueling hormone synthesis.¹⁹⁰

WORKUP

- **TSH (suppressed), free T4, free T3, TRAb/TSI.**
- CBC, LFTs, glucose, electrolytes, calcium; **ECG.**
- Diagnosis is **clinical** (Burch-Wartofsky¹⁹⁰ ≥ 45 highly suggestive) — do not delay treatment for labs.

Step / drug	Dose	Route & notes
1 • Propranolol (β -block)	0.25–0.5 mg/kg/dose PO/NG q6h or 0.01–0.05 mg/kg IV (max 1 mg/dose) (local practice)	Controls heart rate, tremor and agitation; slows peripheral T4→T3. Caution in heart failure — treat failure alongside ^{190,191}
2 • Methimazole (thionamide)	0.5–1 mg/kg/day PO/NG/PR divided q8h (max 30 mg/day — local practice)	Blocks new hormone synthesis; give the thionamide before iodine. Carbimazole is the equivalent prodrug ^{190,191}
2 • PTU (thionamide — alternative)	5–10 mg/kg/day PO/NG divided q8h (local practice)	Also blocks peripheral T4→T3. Either thionamide is acceptable — no difference in mortality (Lee, <i>JAMA Netw Open</i> 2023; adult ICU data); ATA 2016 has historically listed PTU first in storm ¹⁹² . Pediatric guidance avoids PTU because of the risk of hepatic failure. ¹⁹¹
3 • Potassium iodide (strong iodine solution)	1–5 drops PO/NG q8h (local practice; pediatric pre-operative SSKI regimen 1–4 drops three times daily)	Blocks hormone release ^{190,191} ; give ≥ 1 h after the thionamide
4 • Hydrocortisone	1–2 mg/kg/dose IV q6h (or 50–100 mg/m ² /day) (local practice)	Reduces peripheral T4→T3 conversion and covers relative adrenal insufficiency ^{190,191}

ADMIT • REFER

- **Admit** to PICU/HDU.
- **Call** pediatric endocrinology and critical care.

Metabolic Crisis (Inborn Error) MINUTES ANY AGE

Suspected inborn error of metabolism — "sepsis that doesn't fit."

RECOGNIZE (THINK INBORN ERROR)

- Encephalopathy, vomiting, seizures, or apnea after a symptom-free interval or a catabolic trigger (fasting, intercurrent illness, surgery); poor feeding; tachypnea. Family history or parental consanguinity.¹⁹³

- Mimics sepsis — “sepsis that doesn’t fit.” Presents at **any age**, not only the newborn. Not every metabolic crisis is hyperammonemic — the pattern points to the group:¹⁹³

Pattern	Acid-base · ammonia	Pointers
Urea-cycle (hyperammonemia)	Respiratory alkalosis; very high ammonia; low urea ¹⁹³	Little or no acidosis; encephalopathy ± seizures
Organic acidemia (MMA / PA / IVA)	High-anion-gap metabolic acidosis + ketosis; ammonia high (secondary)	Hypoglycemia; offending acid on urine organic acids ¹⁹⁴
MSUD	Ketosis with normal / near-normal ammonia; acidosis variable (expert consensus)	Maple-syrup odor (urine/cerumen); high plasma leucine (alloisoleucine diagnostic) ¹⁹⁵

① STOP CATABOLISM

Stop all protein — a **temporary** emergency measure (first ~24–48 h) **until the metabolic team advises**; prolonged protein restriction itself worsens catabolism, so protein is reintroduced on their guidance. Run high-dextrose fluids; avoid hypotonic fluids and lactated Ringer's.¹⁹³ Treat low glucose. **This card is initial stabilization pending specialist consultation.**



② IMMEDIATE LABS + CALL METABOLIC TEAM

- Ammonia (free-flowing sample, **on ice, run STAT and process immediately**)¹⁹³, blood gas, glucose, lactate, ketones, electrolytes/anion gap.
- Send as **confirmatory** (not routine/STAT): plasma amino acids, urine organic acids, acylcarnitines.

high ammonia



③ NITROGEN SCAVENGERS + COFACTORS

See drug table — coordinate with the metabolic service.

ammonia > ~500 / rising / coma



Urgent hemodialysis or CRRT. Transfer to a metabolic center.¹⁹³

Drug / measure	Dose	Route & notes
Dextrose 10%	1.5× maintenance; glucose infusion rate 8–10 (up to 15–20) mg/kg/min	IV — reverses catabolism
Sodium benzoate + sodium phenylacetate	250 mg/kg load over 90–120 min, then 250 mg/kg/day	IV; central line preferred, peripheral acceptable when life-saving — ask pharmacy for an appropriately diluted preparation. ¹⁹³ In MMA / PA , phenylacetate/phenylbutyrate is not the primary scavenger (depletes glutamine) — benzoate ± carglumic acid per the metabolic team. ¹⁹⁴
L-arginine hydrochloride	200–600 mg/kg	IV load then per day; omit in arginase deficiency ¹⁹³
Carglumic acid	Acute 100–250 mg/kg/day (2–4 divided doses) then maintenance ~50 mg/kg/day (range 10–100) in 2 divided doses – titrate to plasma ammonia	Oral/NG; for NAGS deficiency & some organic acidemias ^{193,194}
L-carnitine	100 mg/kg	IV / oral; for suspected organic acidemia

◆ AVAILABILITY

- Nitrogen scavengers, carglumic acid and L-carnitine are **SPECIALIST STOCK** held in tertiary metabolic / PICU units, not general wards.
- Phone the metabolic on-call **EARLY** — high-dextrose fluids, protein cessation and dialysis access can start anywhere while drugs are sourced. **AVOID VALPROATE.**¹⁹³

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all suspected → PICU; stop protein, high-dose dextrose, treat hyperammonemia.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; under the metabolic team with an emergency regimen.
- **Refer — now** — metabolic/genetics urgently and a center capable of ammonia scavengers/hemofiltration.

Pediatric Eye Emergencies

MINUTES

SIGHT-THREAT

Chemical burn — irrigate before anything else. Leukocoria, orbital cellulitis, and a ruptured globe are the sight- and life-threats not to miss.

⚠️ CHEMICAL INJURY – IRRIGATE FIRST

- Immediate, copious irrigation with **saline (or clean water)** for **≥ 15–30 min BEFORE** examination or imaging; evert the lids, sweep out particulate matter, recheck pH until neutral (≈ 7.0 – 7.5). **Alkali** (drain/oven cleaner, cement, wet button batteries) penetrates deeper than acid.¹⁹⁶
- Then urgent ophthalmology.

▶ THE CAN'T-MISS DIAGNOSES

- **Orbital (post-septal) cellulitis** — **proptosis, pain on or limited eye movement, reduced acuity or color vision, a relative afferent pupillary defect**, chemosis → emergency. **CT orbits + sinuses, IV antibiotics, ophthalmology + ENT**. Distinguish from **preseptal** (lid swelling only, with **normal** movement, vision, and pupil)¹⁹⁶ (see [Preseptal & Orbital Cellulitis](#)).
- **Ruptured / penetrating globe** — after trauma with a **distorted (teardrop) pupil**, prolapsed dark uveal tissue, or marked subconjunctival hemorrhage → cover with a **rigid shield (never a pad or any pressure)**, keep **NPO**, give analgesia + antiemetic, update tetanus, and refer urgently. **No drops, no ointment.**¹⁹⁶
- **Leukocoria (white pupil reflex)**, a new squint, or an **absent red reflex** → **retinoblastoma** until proven otherwise → urgent ophthalmology (a life-threatening tumor).¹⁹⁷
- **Ophthalmia neonatorum** — hyperacute purulent conjunctivitis in the **first days of life** → gonococcal risk (corneal perforation) → emergency: **systemic ceftriaxone or cefotaxime is the main treatment** (adequate systemic therapy makes topical antibiotics unnecessary; prefer cefotaxime in the jaundiced neonate or with calcium-containing IV fluids), frequent saline irrigation of discharge, admit and swab; **test for both *N. gonorrhoeae* and *C. trachomatis*.**⁹⁸
- **Acute red painful eye** with photophobia/reduced vision, or **hyphema** (blood layering in the anterior chamber after trauma) → same-day ophthalmology.
- **Corneal ulcer (microbial keratitis)** — red, painful, photophobic eye with a **white/opaque corneal infiltrate or haze** ± discharge; high risk in **contact-lens** wearers and after trauma → sight-threatening, same-day ophthalmology. **Do not patch**; stop contact-lens wear.¹⁹⁶
- **Congenital / infantile glaucoma** — the infant triad of **watering (epiphora), photophobia, and blepharospasm** with an **enlarged or cloudy cornea (buphthalmos)** → urgent ophthalmology (needs surgery); do not dismiss as a blocked tear duct.¹⁹⁸

- **New anisocoria (unequal pupils)** — may signal a **third-nerve palsy, Horner syndrome, or raised ICP / herniation** (see [Raised ICP](#)); with reduced consciousness, ptosis, or trauma it is a red flag → urgent assessment. Check pupils in **both light and dark** to localize.¹⁹⁶

⚠ SAFEGUARDING – RETINAL HEMORRHAGES

Multilayered retinal hemorrhages extending to the periphery in an infant with encephalopathy suggest **abusive head trauma** — involve safeguarding and ophthalmology¹⁹⁹ (see [Fractures — Non-Accidental Red Flags](#)).

✦ PEARL – CHECK THE RED REFLEX IN EVERY CHILD

A symmetrical red reflex helps exclude retinoblastoma, cataract, and vitreous pathology; any **white, asymmetric, or absent** reflex needs urgent ophthalmology.¹⁹⁷

✦ YOUR ROLE – THE GENERAL PEDIATRICIAN

- You are the first responder, not the eye surgeon.
- Three time-critical moves are yours: **(1) irrigate immediately** for any chemical splash — don't wait for ophthalmology; **(2) shield** (never pad or press) a suspected ruptured globe, keep **NPO**, give analgesia + antiemetic; **(3) check the red reflex in every child** and treat leukocoria / an absent reflex as retinoblastoma.
- Document **visual acuity, pupils, and eye movements** before referral. **Avoid drops, ointment, or any pressure** on a possibly open globe, and never patch a suspected corneal ulcer.
- Then refer to ophthalmology (add ENT for orbital cellulitis) within the timeframe the diagnosis demands.

📌 REFER

- **Refer — now** — ophthalmology urgently — chemical injury, suspected globe rupture, leukocoria/absent red reflex, orbital cellulitis (add ENT), acute vision loss, or hyphema.

Dental & Oral Emergencies MINUTES TIME-CRITICAL

An avulsed permanent tooth is a true emergency — reimplant within minutes. Never reimplant a primary tooth. Watch the swelling that threatens the airway.

📌 DENTAL TRAUMA

- **Luxation** (displaced or mobile tooth) — **do not attempt to reposition it**; analgesia and same-day dental referral.²⁰⁰
- **Crown fracture** — preserve any fragment and keep it moist (milk or saline); analgesia; prompt dental review — pulp exposure needs same-day care.
- **Primary tooth avulsion** — **do NOT reimplant** (risks of damaging the permanent successor); reassure and arrange dental review.²⁰⁰

- **Post-extraction bleeding** — firm gauze pressure 15–20 min ± tranexamic acid; if it persists, consider an undiagnosed **bleeding disorder**.

⚠ **AVULSED PERMANENT TOOTH – MINUTES MATTER**

- **Reimplant as soon as possible.** Hold the tooth by the **crown** — **never touch or scrub the root** (protect the periodontal ligament).
- If dirty, rinse ~10 s in **cold milk or saline**, reinsert, have the child bite on gauze.
- If reimplantation isn't possible, transport the tooth in **Hank's solution or cold milk** — **never water**.²⁰⁰
- Then urgent dental care for splinting; **assess tetanus prophylaxis** — indicated for a contaminated avulsion and guided by both the child's immunization status and the nature of the wound; consider antibiotics.
- Prognosis falls sharply once **extra-oral dry time exceeds ~60 min**, and periodontal-ligament cells are then considered non-viable — **reimplant anyway**.²⁰⁰

✦ **PEARL – MILK BEATS WATER**

If Hank's solution isn't to hand, **cold milk** is the best readily-available storage medium; tap water is hypotonic and kills periodontal-ligament cells, worsening the outcome.²⁰⁰ **Time is tooth.**

▀ **PRIMARY HERPETIC GINGIVOSTOMATITIS (HSV-1)**

- The commonest cause of a painful mouth with fever in the **1–5-year-old: fever** (usually **3–5 days**, occasionally up to a week), **swollen, friable, bleeding gingiva**, and crops of **painful vesicles → ulcers** on the gingiva, tongue, lips, and buccal mucosa (often with perioral spread), drooling, and **refusal to eat or drink**. Tender **cervical lymphadenopathy** is usual and, being reactive, resolves as the illness settles. Self-limited — the illness runs **~10–14 days**.²⁰¹
- **Management is supportive** — the priority is **hydration and analgesia** (acetaminophen ± ibuprofen); offer cold, bland fluids. **Dehydration from poor intake is the main reason to admit**. Avoid topical lidocaine/anesthetic gels in young children (toxicity).²⁰²
- **Oral acyclovir** — **15–20 mg/kg/dose 4×/day for 5–7 days** (max single dose 800 mg); immunocompromised children **20 mg/kg/dose 4×/day for 7–10 days**; immunocompromised adolescents 400 mg 3×/day for 10 days or until resolution.²⁰²
Significant or disseminated disease in an immunocompromised child needs IV acyclovir (5–10 mg/kg/dose q8h) rather than a prolonged oral course. Shortens fever, oral lesions, and viral shedding **only if started within 72 h of symptom onset**; not routine for the well child presenting late.
- Distinguish from **herpangina** (coxsackievirus — ulcers on the soft palate/tonsillar pillars, **gingiva spared**) and hand-foot-and-mouth disease.²⁰¹ **Admit/refer** the dehydrated, the immunocompromised, or suspected **eczema herpeticum** / disseminated HSV.

▀ **ORAL SOFT-TISSUE INJURIES**

- **Tongue lacerations** — most heal without sutures (rich blood supply). **Repair** if the wound gapes at rest, is large (> ~1–2 cm), bleeds persistently, is through-and-through, or splits the free edge/tip (a bisecting flap) — these risk a notched tongue.

- **Lip lacerations** — a wound that **crosses the vermilion border** needs precise realignment of the border first (a 1 mm step is visible); through-and-through wounds need layered closure. Palpate and image for an **embedded tooth fragment** or foreign body after a fall onto the teeth.
- **Buccal & gingival mucosa** — most intraoral tears heal spontaneously; suture only large, gaping, or food-trapping wounds. A deep cheek wound can injure the **parotid duct or facial nerve** — refer.
- **Embedded foreign bodies** — account for **every tooth fragment**: a missing piece may be buried in the lip/tongue (soft-tissue radiograph or ultrasound) or aspirated (**chest X-ray if unaccounted for**). Remove grit/glass, irrigate, and assess tetanus status.
- **Intruded tooth** (driven into the socket) — **refer to a pediatric dentist**. A **primary** intruded tooth is usually left to **re-erupt spontaneously** (do not reposition — protect the permanent tooth bud); a **permanent** intruded tooth needs dental assessment for repositioning.²⁰⁰
- Repair intraoral and lip wounds within ~24 h with analgesia; give antibiotics for through-and-through lip wounds, bites, or grossly contaminated wounds.

▀ DENTOALVEOLAR ABSCESS / FACIAL SWELLING

- Analgesia and **dental source control** — **incision and drainage, root canal (pulp) treatment, or extraction of the causative tooth** — with a **mandatory dental referral**. For a **localized** abscess without systemic involvement or spreading, definitive dental treatment is the primary management and **systemic antibiotics are generally not required; reserve antibiotics for facial cellulitis, systemic signs, significant spreading, or suspected deep-space infection** (per clinical judgment and MOH protocols). These commonly present **directly to dental clinics**, where the dentist identifies the source and delivers timely definitive treatment.²⁰² **Watch for spread to the deep neck, floor of mouth, or orbit** — a spreading facial-space infection can progress to Ludwig's angina (next).

⚠ AIRWAY – LUDWIG'S ANGINA

Firm submandibular swelling — in children often **unilateral at onset** before becoming bilateral — with a **raised (elevated) tongue**, drooling, or trismus is a deep-space infection that can obstruct the airway. **Call for airway help early — anesthesia, oral & maxillofacial surgery, ENT, or pediatric surgery** (all are equipped to manage these cases), give IV antibiotics, and do **not** lay the child flat.²⁰³ **Time-critical — urgently call or refer.**

✦ YOUR ROLE – THE GENERAL PEDIATRICIAN

- Most of what reaches you is yours to start.
- For an **avulsed permanent tooth**, reimplant or store it in **cold milk** and send urgently — minutes decide the tooth; **never reimplant a primary tooth**.
- Give analgesia, control post-extraction bleeding with pressure ± tranexamic acid, **assess tetanus** for contaminated wounds, and suture only the soft-tissue lacerations that need it — account for **every tooth fragment**.
- Treat herpetic gingivostomatitis supportively, watching hydration.
- Escalate the two true emergencies fast: a spreading facial-space infection or **Ludwig's angina** (airway — call/refer anesthesia, oral & maxillofacial surgery, ENT, or pediatric surgery), and refer to dental / maxillofacial for avulsion, pulp exposure, or abscess.

▀ REFER

- **Refer — now** — dental / maxillofacial urgently — avulsion, fractures with pulp exposure, facial fractures, or a facial-space infection; for any airway threat call **anesthesia, oral & maxillofacial surgery, ENT, or pediatric surgery** — all are equipped to manage these cases.
- **Refer — clinic** — an intruded tooth → pediatric dentist.

Dermatologic Emergencies HOURS CAN'T-MISS

Fever + rash — find the killers: meningococemia / purpura fulminans, SJS/TEN, staph scalded skin, and eczema herpeticum.

⚠ NON-BLANCHING RASH + FEVER

- Petechiae or purpura that **do not blanch** in an unwell/febrile child = **invasive meningococcal disease / sepsis / purpura fulminans** until proven otherwise — take blood cultures, give **empiric IV antibiotics immediately**, follow the **Septic Shock** pathway.¹¹⁴
- Do not wait for investigations.

▀ THE CAN'T-MISS RASHES

- **SJS / TEN** — dusky/targetoid macules with skin detachment and **erosions of ≥ 2 mucosal sites** (eyes, mouth, genitals), 1–3 weeks after a **drug** (antibiotics, anticonvulsants).²⁰⁴ **Stop the culprit**; fluids, skin + eye care, urgent dermatology + ophthalmology, transfer to a **burns/PICU** unit. **Avoid the culprit drug and relevant cross-reacting agents** — broad beta-lactam avoidance applies mainly when a beta-lactam is the suspected culprit (see [Antibiotic Allergy](#)).
- **Staphylococcal scalded skin syndrome (SSSS)** — young child, fever, **tender diffuse erythema with superficial peeling (Nikolsky +)** and perioral crusting; **mucosae spared**. Toxin-mediated: IV anti-staphylococcal antibiotic (**cefazolin** first-line in Kuwait, as flucloxacillin is not available locally) + analgesia + fluids.²⁰⁵

- **Eczema herpeticum** — clusters of **monomorphic punched-out vesicles/erosions on eczematous skin** in an unwell child → start **acyclovir** urgently; ophthalmology if periocular. (HSV superinfection.)²⁰⁶
- **DRESS** — fever, widespread morbilliform rash, **facial edema**, lymphadenopathy, **eosinophilia**, and organ (liver) involvement 2–8 weeks after a drug → stop the drug, supportive care ± steroids.²⁰⁷
- **Necrotizing fasciitis** — **pain out of proportion**, rapidly spreading dusky/edematous skin, systemic toxicity → surgical emergency + broad-spectrum antibiotics.⁸⁹

- **Confirm the signs** — dusky/targetoid macules with **skin detachment** and **erosions of ≥ 2 mucosal sites**; **Nikolsky +** (lateral shearing pressure detaches epidermis on non-blistered skin), **Asboe-Hansen +** (a blister extends sideways with slight tangential pressure), and **widespread skin tenderness** — typically 1–3 weeks after a culprit drug.²⁰⁴
- **Prognosis** — calculate **SCORTEN** (best at day 1 and day 3). **In children it over-estimates mortality** (pediatric death rates are far lower), so use it for guidance, not as a ceiling.²⁰⁴
- **Investigations** — CBC with differential, urea & electrolytes, LFTs, glucose, bicarbonate, coagulation profile, CRP/ESR, magnesium, phosphate, lactate, urinalysis. **Sepsis is the leading cause of death** — infective screen (blood cultures; skin swabs for **HSV/VZV and bacteria**) and treat superadded infection. **Chest X-ray**; **Mycoplasma testing guided by the clinical picture** (in children, **reactive infectious mucocutaneous eruption [RIME]** — the current term, which subsumes the former *Mycoplasma*-induced rash and mucositis [MIRM] — is a distinct, milder mimic with **prominent mucositis and little skin loss**; RIME can also follow other respiratory pathogens, so test by presentation rather than routinely).²⁰⁸ **Skin biopsy** if the diagnosis is unclear.
- **Act now** — **stop the culprit drug immediately** (earlier withdrawal improves survival); **transfer to a burns unit or PICU**.²⁰⁹
- **Supportive care is the mainstay** — IV fluids & electrolytes, **thermoregulation**, nutrition, **analgesia**; **gentle handling, minimize friction/shear**; **non-adherent dressings** (petrolatum-impregnated gauze or silicone/advanced dressings); avoid **prophylactic** systemic antibiotics — treat proven infection. Early multidisciplinary team: **dermatology, ophthalmology** (prevent ocular scarring; amniotic-membrane grafting in severe eye disease), **urology/gynecology** (prevent genital adhesions), wound care, pain, psychology.²⁰⁹
- **Systemic immunomodulation** — **specialist decision, low-certainty evidence**. Drug withdrawal + supportive care remain the priority. If an agent is used, **ciclosporin** and **etanercept (anti-TNF)** carry the most promising (still low-certainty) mortality signals; **corticosteroids** are controversial; **IVIG monotherapy is not supported** (used, if at all, combined with corticosteroids). Individualized by the specialist team.²¹⁰
- **After recovery** — screen for **ocular, cutaneous, urogenital and psychological** sequelae; document the culprit, give a clear **allergy alert** (avoid re-exposure and cross-reacting agents), and consider **HLA-guided avoidance** where relevant (e.g. HLA-B*15:02 & carbamazepine, HLA-B*58:01 & allopurinol).²⁰⁴

Evidence: BAD children & young people SJS/TEN guideline 2018; European S3 guideline 2024; RIME/MIRM terminology per Damari et al., *J Hosp Med* 2025. Culprit-drug withdrawal + supportive care have the clearest benefit; all systemic immunomodulators remain low-certainty.

- **Recognize** — young child, fever, tender diffuse erythema with **superficial peeling (Nikolsky +)**; **desquamation of the flexures** and **radial fissuring/crusting around the eyes, mouth and nose**; **mucosae are spared**. Toxin-mediated (exfoliative toxin from a distant staphylococcal focus).²⁰⁵
- **Cultures** — **swab the focus, not the blisters**. Nasopharynx/nares, conjunctivae, throat, umbilicus, urine, blood, and any suspected primary site; in a **neonate** include the **umbilical stump and circumcision site**. **Bulla fluid is sterile** (unlike bullous impetigo) — do not culture it. **Skin biopsy is usually unnecessary** — reserve it (or a frozen section) for when SJS/TEN cannot be excluded (SSSS splits high in the granular layer; TEN is full-thickness).²⁰⁵
- **Antibiotics** — start an **IV anti-staphylococcal** agent: **cefazolin** is first-line in Kuwait (the penicillinase-resistant penicillins — flucloxacillin, nafcillin, oxacillin — are the international first-line but are not available locally), switching **IV → oral** once improving; **clindamycin** only as an **anti-toxin** adjunct where susceptible (added benefit uncertain in children, resistance rising); **vancomycin** if MRSA is suspected/prevalent or first-line fails. Doses below — de-escalate once afebrile and per sensitivities.²⁰⁵
- **Supportive care** — treat like a **superficial burn**: fluid & electrolyte balance, thermoregulation, nutrition, **analgesia**, and **minimal handling**. **Wound care** with **petrolatum/Vaseline-impregnated gauze** (apply to the dressing — do not smear emollient directly onto raw skin); **warm compresses** to facial crusting. Watch for fluid loss and secondary sepsis.
- **Prognosis** — good in children with prompt treatment (low mortality); higher risk in neonates and with extensive involvement.²⁰⁵

Antibiotic	Dose (pediatric)	Route & notes
Cefazolin (first-line IV)	25–33 mg/kg/dose q8h (max 1 g/dose)	IV; first-generation cephalosporin — anti-staphylococcal first-line in Kuwait (flucloxacillin not available locally)
Flucloxacillin / nafcillin / oxacillin (where available)	25–50 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 2 g/dose)	IV; penicillinase-resistant anti-staphylococcal — the international first-line, not currently available in Kuwait
Clindamycin (anti-toxin adjunct)	10 mg/kg/dose q8h (max 900 mg/dose)	IV/PO; optional — suppresses toxin, only where susceptible; benefit uncertain in children
Vancomycin (if MRSA)	15 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 1 g/dose)	IV; if MRSA suspected/prevalent or first-line fails
Oral step-down	Cephalexin 25 mg/kg/dose q6–8h (max 1 g/dose)	PO once afebrile & improving; complete ~7-day course (dicloxacillin/flucloxacillin where available)

Evidence: pediatric SSSS systematic review (Pediatr Dermatol 2025); Merck Manual (professional). Bullae are sterile — culture the primary focus; anti-staphylococcal therapy + supportive care is the mainstay.

- **Recognize** — clusters of **monomorphic punched-out vesicles/erosions** on eczematous skin in an unwell child; **honey-colored crusting** means the lesions are **impetiginized** (secondary *S. aureus*).²⁰⁶
- **Isolate** — contact precautions: **gloves and gown** until lesions are dry and crusted.
- **Confirm (don't delay treatment)** — **deroof an intact vesicle** with a sterile needle and swab the clear fluid for **HSV-1/2 & VZV PCR** (± Tzanck smear as a rapid bedside adjunct); take a **bacterial swab (C&S)** for secondary infection. Diagnosis is clinical — start antivirals empirically.²⁰⁶
- **Baseline labs** — CBC and a metabolic/renal panel, and check hydration, **before IV acyclovir** (renal safety).
- **Antivirals early — they save lives** — **IV acyclovir 5–10 mg/kg/dose q8h** (dose by ideal body weight; ensure hydration) if **systemically unwell, severe/disseminated, periocular, or poor oral intake**; **oral acyclovir per local protocol** for milder disease. Continue ~10–14 days / until lesions crust; step IV → oral on improvement.²⁰⁶
- **Cover secondary infection** — if impetiginized, add an **oral anti-staphylococcal antibiotic** for *S. aureus*.
- **Eyes** — facial/periocular involvement warrants **urgent ophthalmology** to exclude **corneal disease (herpetic keratitis)**; start topical ophthalmic antiviral if corneal lesions are suspected.
- **Skin / eczema care** — once antivirals are started (many **pause topical steroids for ~48 h, then restart the appropriate-potency topical corticosteroid** as the child improves — steroids must never delay antivirals).²⁰⁶ **Bland ointment emollients** (avoid creams — they sting); **non-soap cleansers**; lukewarm **5-min baths, pat (never rub) dry, no soap**; warm compresses to crusted areas; loose cotton clothing; avoid friction.
- **Supportive & referral** — fluids/electrolytes, analgesia, nutrition; admit if extensive/systemic/dehydrated. **Neurology** if CNS involvement is suspected; **dermatology at discharge** for ongoing eczema management.

Evidence: StatPearls (Eczema Herpeticum); pediatric emergency guidance. Early antivirals are the priority; topical steroids treat the underlying eczema but must not delay antivirals.

- **Recognize** — morbilliform rash with facial edema starting on the **face** → **upper trunk** → **extremities** (can **worsen even after the drug is stopped**), plus fever, lymphadenopathy, **eosinophilia** and atypical lymphocytes. Onset is **late: 2–8 weeks** after starting the culprit — but within **~24 h on re-challenge**. Commonest culprits: **anticonvulsants** (carbamazepine, phenytoin, lamotrigine, phenobarbital), **allopurinol**, and **antibiotics** (sulfonamides, vancomycin, minocycline). First-degree relatives carry up to **~25% risk** with the same drug (HLA-linked).²⁰⁷
- **Organ involvement** — **liver first** (hepatitis), then lung, kidney, **heart (myocarditis)**, spleen, GI and neurologic; **HHV-6/7, EBV, CMV reactivation** is characteristic. **Late endocrine autoimmunity** (hypothyroidism, type 1 diabetes) can appear months afterwards.²⁰⁷
- **Diagnose** — clinical, scored with the **RegiSCAR** or **J-SCAR** criteria. **Labs:** CBC + differential (eosinophilia, atypical lymphocytes), **LFTs** (may stay abnormal for months), renal panel + urinalysis (proteinuria/hematuria), CK, lipase, CRP/ESR/**ferritin**, baseline **TFTs + glucose**, viral PCR (HHV-6/7, EBV, CMV), **ECG + troponin + baseline echo**, and CXR if respiratory symptoms; extend the work-up by clinical suspicion. **Skin biopsy** to exclude mimics.²⁰⁷
- **Manage** — **stop the culprit immediately** and **label the patient hypersensitive**; supportive care; **high-potency topical corticosteroids**. For organ involvement, **systemic corticosteroids** — prednisolone **0.5–1 mg/kg/day (max 60 mg/day)** with a **slow taper over weeks–months** to avoid relapse; adjuncts/alternatives (specialist): **ciclosporin**, IVIG (limited evidence), JAK inhibitors (anecdotal).²⁰⁷
- **Monitor & avoid** — screen for **autoimmune sequelae** (thyroiditis, type 1 diabetes): **TSH, free T4 and glucose for up to 2 years**.²⁰⁷ **Strict lifelong avoidance** of the culprit and cross-reacting drugs; document the allergy clearly.

Evidence: EAACI position paper on DRESS in children 2025; RegiSCAR / J-SCAR criteria. Prompt drug withdrawal + staged (skin-only vs organ) therapy; steroids taper slowly to prevent relapse.

- **Recognize** — **pain out of proportion** and **edema extending beyond the visible erythema**; rapidly spreading dusky skin, fever, **crepitus**, bullae, necrosis or ecchymosis, and a **hard "wooden" feel** of the subcutaneous tissue; **cutaneous anesthesia is a late sign**. Lower > upper extremities. Special forms: **perineum (Fournier gangrene)**, head & neck, and neonatal infection (e.g. from omphalitis).⁸⁹
- **It is a surgical emergency — call the surgeon now**. Early aggressive debridement is the single biggest determinant of survival; **do not let the LRINEC score or imaging delay surgery**.⁸⁹
- **Scoring / labs** — the **LRINEC** score can help distinguish necrotizing fasciitis from other soft-tissue infection, **but a low score does not exclude it** (poor sensitivity in children).⁸⁹ Send CBC + differential, basic metabolic panel, glucose, CRP, **serum lactate**, coagulation profile, and **blood cultures (2 sets)** — then start antibiotics without waiting.
- **Imaging** — CT (or MRI) may support the diagnosis but **must never delay surgical exploration**.
- **Empiric antibiotics** (after cultures) — broad-spectrum covering **gram-positive incl. MRSA + gram-negative + anaerobes**, plus **clindamycin for its antitoxin effect**: e.g. **vancomycin 15 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 1 g/dose) + piperacillin-tazobactam 100 mg/kg/dose (piperacillin) q6–8h** (or meropenem 20 mg/kg/dose q8h, max 1 g/dose) + **clindamycin 10–13 mg/kg/dose q8h (max 900 mg/dose)**; de-escalate on sensitivities.⁸⁹
- **Surgery = the gold standard** — surgical exploration is both the **definitive diagnosis and the treatment** (expect repeat looks/debridement); send intra-operative specimens for **Gram stain, culture, and histology** — **alert microbiology in advance**: processing is **time-critical once tissue reaches the lab** (expedite the Gram stain and keep direct communication).
- **Who leads** — **shared surgical responsibility**. The operative lead follows the **anatomical site**: **orthopedics** (limbs), **ENT or maxillofacial** (head & neck), **plastics** (soft-tissue coverage), **urology** (perineum / Fournier), **general/pediatric surgery** (trunk / abdomen). In complex or multi-region cases, **several surgical subspecialties may need to collaborate together in the ED**.
- **Support & referral** — aggressive hemodynamic resuscitation / PICU; **IVIG** as an adjuvant in selected cases (streptococcal toxic shock).⁸⁹ Refer to **infectious diseases and plastic/reconstructive surgery** (with pediatric/general surgery).

Evidence: IDSA skin & soft-tissue infection guidelines 2014. Surgery is time-critical — neither the LRINEC score nor imaging should delay operative exploration.

⚠ NEONATE

Vesicles, or an unwell neonate with a rash, may be **neonatal HSV** — start **high-dose IV acyclovir 20 mg/kg/dose every 8 h** and a full sepsis work-up without delay. Treat for **14 days** (skin-eye-mouth disease) or **21 days** (CNS or disseminated disease); for **CNS disease**, repeat CSF HSV PCR near the end of therapy and continue until it is negative, then give **oral acyclovir suppression — 300 mg/m²/dose 3×/day for 6 months**.⁹⁸

✦ PEARL – READ THE PATTERN

Non-blanching + unwell = sepsis; **monomorphic vesicles on eczema** = eczema herpeticum; widespread peeling with **mucosal erosions** = SJS/TEN, versus **mucosa spared / superficial** = SSSS.

▮ REFER

- **Refer — now** — dermatology + the relevant team urgently; **PICU/burns** for extensive TEN; **ophthalmology** for any mucosal/ocular involvement; **urology/gynecology** for genital involvement.

Pediatric ENT Emergencies MINUTES AIRWAY / ENT

The airway threatens, bleeds, and batteries that can't wait — stabilize first, then call ENT.

⚠ BUTTON BATTERY IN THE NOSE OR EAR – HOURS MATTER

- A disc battery lodged in the nose or ear causes **liquefactive necrosis and septal/ostial perforation within hours**; **unilateral foul or bloody discharge** is the clue.
- ENT emergency — **urgent removal**; do **not irrigate** a nasal battery.²¹¹ (Swallowed batteries → **Button Battery Ingestion**.)

▮ RECOGNIZE & ACT

- **Acute upper-airway obstruction** — stridor, drooling, tripod posture → epiglottitis / bacterial tracheitis / severe croup: keep the child **calm and upright, minimal handling**, call **anesthesia + ENT**, and **do not examine the throat**³ (see [Croup](#), [Difficult Airway](#), [Retropharyngeal Abscess](#)).
- **Post-tonsillectomy bleeding** — any bleed (classically **day 5–10**) is an emergency: sit up, suction, **IV access + fluids/blood**, tranexamic acid, call ENT + anesthesia, prepare for the operating room. Swallowed blood **hides the true loss**.
- **Deep-neck / peritonsillar / retropharyngeal abscess** — trismus, muffled “hot-potato” voice, neck stiffness or torticollis → IV antibiotics, imaging, ENT; watch the airway.²¹²
- **Acute mastoiditis** — post-auricular swelling/erythema with a **protruding pinna** after otitis media → IV antibiotics + ENT (risk of intracranial spread / venous sinus thrombosis).⁹⁸
- **Severe epistaxis** — sit forward, **pinch the soft part 10–15 min**, topical vasoconstrictor; if uncontrolled or recurrent, ENT — consider a **bleeding disorder**, or juvenile angiofibroma in an adolescent boy.
- **Ear/nose foreign body** — refer for removal; for a live insect, instill lidocaine or oil first.

⚠ AIRWAY

Do **not** try to visualize the airway or lay the child flat when epiglottitis or a deep-neck abscess is suspected — summon **anesthesia/ENT**, keep the child calm and upright.

✦ PEARL – UNILATERAL DISCHARGE = FOREIGN BODY / BATTERY

Unilateral foul or bloody nasal discharge in a toddler is a **foreign body** — and a **battery** until **excluded**; examine, image if needed, and remove urgently.²¹¹

✦ YOUR ROLE – THE GENERAL PEDIATRICIAN

- Secure the child first, not the diagnosis.
- In suspected epiglottitis or a deep-neck abscess, keep the child **calm and upright**, give oxygen, do **not** examine the throat or lay them flat, and summon **anesthesia + ENT**.
- For post-tonsillectomy bleeding, get **IV access, fluids/blood, and tranexamic acid** while ENT is called — assume swallowed blood hides the true loss.
- Recognize the emergencies that can't wait: a **nasal/aural button battery** and **unilateral bloody discharge** need same-hour ENT.
- Control epistaxis with **10–15 min of firm pressure** before escalating.
- Your job is early recognition, first stabilization, and a timely ENT / anesthesia call.

▴ REFER

- **Refer — now — ENT urgently** — nasal/aural battery, post-tonsillectomy bleed, deep-neck abscess, mastoiditis, or uncontrolled epistaxis; **anesthesia** for any airway threat.

Pediatric Neurosurgical Emergencies

MINUTES

TIME-CRITICAL

Shunt failure, rising ICP, and cord compression — recognize early, control the pressure, and call neurosurgery.

⚠ VP SHUNT MALFUNCTION – TREAT AS RAISED ICP

- In a child with a shunt, **headache, vomiting, drowsiness, irritability, a bulging fontanelle, or any change from baseline = a blocked shunt until proven otherwise.**²¹³
- Assess, image (**CT or rapid-sequence MRI + shunt series**), call **neurosurgery urgently**.
- Shunt **infection** (fever, redness/swelling along the tract, or a new malfunction) carries the same urgency — manage on a defined pathway: **sample CSF from the shunt/reservoir plus blood cultures**; start empiric antimicrobials covering **staphylococci (including MRSA) and Gram-negative organisms** — e.g. **vancomycin + an anti-pseudomonal beta-lactam (cefepime, ceftazidime, or meropenem)**; plan **removal or externalization of the infected hardware**; and involve **neurosurgery and infectious diseases early.**²¹⁴
- Controlling raised ICP is the priority while awaiting neurosurgery.

▴ RECOGNIZE & ACT

- **Raised ICP / impending herniation** — falling GCS, an unequal or fixed pupil, **Cushing's triad** (hypertension, bradycardia, irregular breathing), or abnormal posturing → **head up 30°, midline neck, normocapnia, treat seizures, hyperosmolar therapy** (hypertonic saline or mannitol), urgent neurosurgery (see²¹⁵ [Raised ICP](#)).

- **Non-traumatic intracranial hemorrhage** — sudden severe headache, focal deficit, or coma (AVM, aneurysm, tumor) → urgent CT + neurosurgery.
- **Depressed / open skull fracture or penetrating head injury** → neurosurgery + antibiotics + tetanus (see [Traumatic Brain Injury](#)).
- **Acute spinal cord compression** — neck or back pain with arm or leg weakness, a sensory level, or bladder/bowel dysfunction (tumor, abscess, trauma) → **urgent MRI**, dexamethasone if tumor, and **urgent spine-surgical referral — neurosurgery or pediatric orthopedic spine surgery** (either may be consulted for extradural pathology: epidural abscess, vertebral/extradural tumor, or bony trauma) ± oncology — time-critical for recovery. In **traumatic spinal cord injury**, also involve **PICU for hemodynamic (MAP) support** — maintain mean arterial pressure and avoid hypotension to preserve cord perfusion; watch for **neurogenic shock** (hypotension with bradycardia).
- **CSF leak** — clear rhinorrhea/otorrhea or a tense pseudomeningocele after surgery/trauma → neurosurgery (meningitis risk).

⚠ DON'T DELAY IMAGING

A shunted child who is drowsy or vomiting needs **urgent imaging and a neurosurgical call** — deterioration can be rapid; do not attribute it to a viral illness.

✦ PEARL – ASK THE PARENTS

Parents of a shunted or hydrocephalic child usually recognize their own child's **“shunt-failure pattern”** — take that history seriously and image.

✦ PEARL – PROTECT THE PUPIL EXAM

Have **ophthalmology look for papilledema**, but **avoid dilating the pupils in a drowsy or deteriorating child** — mydriatic drops abolish the pupillary response, a key sign of herniation.

✦ YOUR ROLE – THE GENERAL PEDIATRICIAN

- Recognize, control the pressure, and call — you are not expected to operate.
- In any shunted child, treat headache / vomiting / drowsiness / any change from baseline as a **blocked shunt until proven otherwise**: image (CT or rapid-sequence MRI + shunt series) and call neurosurgery.
- While waiting, deliver the **ICP first-aid that is yours** — head up 30°, midline neck, normocapnia, treat seizures and fever, and give hyperosmolar therapy for impending herniation.
- Take a parent's **“this is his shunt-failure pattern”** seriously.
- Don't anchor on a viral illness, and refer **time-critically** for cord compression (urgent MRI) and open / depressed skull fractures.

▴ REFER

- **Refer — now** — neurosurgery urgently — shunt malfunction/infection, raised ICP, intracranial hemorrhage, or a depressed/open skull fracture; acute spinal cord compression — neurosurgery or pediatric orthopedic spine surgery (either for extradural pathology); add

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Gastroenterology & Hepatology

GI bleeding · liver failure · pancreatitis · hepatitis · neonatal cholestasis · ingestion (foreign body / battery) · feeding-tube problems → **Common Acute Conditions**

Upper Gastrointestinal Bleeding MINUTES

Hematemesis or melena — resuscitate first, then find and treat the source.

RECOGNIZE & STRATIFY

- Bleeding proximal to the ligament of Treitz: **hematemesis** (fresh or coffee-ground) or **melena**. Confirm true blood — swallowed maternal or epistaxis blood and red foods mislead.²¹⁶
- Clinically significant** = hemodynamic instability, a hemoglobin fall ≥ 2 g/dL, or a transfusion requirement — most need PICU.²¹⁶
- Age-based causes**: neonate — swallowed maternal blood, vitamin K deficiency bleeding, stress gastritis; infant/child — reflux esophagitis, gastritis, peptic ulcer, Mallory-Weiss tear; any age with liver disease — **varices**. Consider an **ingested button battery** (urgent chest X-ray; see [Button Battery Ingestion](#)).²¹⁷

Investigate — order → look for → what it means

Order	Look for	What it tells you
CBC + serial hemoglobin	Hb fall ≥ 2 g/dL; thrombocytopenia	Severity & transfusion need ²¹⁶
Blood group + crossmatch	—	Prepare blood early in any significant bleed
Coagulation — PT/INR, aPTT, fibrinogen	Coagulopathy	Correct before/with endoscopy; a prolonged INR also flags underlying liver disease ²¹⁷
LFTs + albumin	High bilirubin, low albumin	Chronic liver disease → suspect a variceal source ²¹⁷
Urea & creatinine	Urea raised out of proportion to creatinine	Supports an upper (vs lower) GI source — absorbed blood-protein load ²¹⁷
Venous blood gas + lactate	Metabolic acidosis, rising lactate	Hypoperfusion → the bleed is severe; escalate ²¹⁷

① RESUSCITATE FIRST

ABC, two large-bore IVs, crystalloid; send crossmatch; correct coagulopathy/thrombocytopenia. Protect the airway in brisk hematemesis.



DECISION

Hemodynamically unstable?

UNSTABLE / MASSIVE

Resuscitate to **hemodynamics** and activate the **massive transfusion protocol** (empiric RBC:plasma:platelet ratios) — **not** a fixed Hb target.²¹⁸ PICU; urgent endoscopy once stabilized.^{217,219}

STABLE

Restrictive transfusion — transfuse at **Hb < 7 g/dL**, target 7–9 g/dL (extrapolated from adult data). Over-transfusion raises portal pressure and can worsen variceal bleeding.^{218,219,220}



DECISION

Variceal suspected? (known/suspected liver disease, splenomegaly, umbilical-catheter history)

VARICEAL

Octreotide infusion (start early, after senior/GI discussion). In **cirrhotic** portal hypertension, add **broad-spectrum IV antibiotic prophylaxis** (per local susceptibility) for 5–7 days (e.g., ceftriaxone); role in non-cirrhotic PH unclear.²¹⁹ Endoscopy within 24 h — band ligation preferred (sclerotherapy if ligation is not feasible).²¹⁹

NON-VARICEAL

High-dose IV **proton pump inhibitor**.²²¹ Endoscopy for hemostasis — injection + cautery/clips²¹⁷ (± hemostatic powder for refractory bleeding — adult guidance) — **early (≤ 24 h)** once resuscitated²¹⁷; emergent/urgent (≤ 6–12 h) endoscopy only if still unstable despite resuscitation (adult guidance).²²²



Uncontrolled bleeding → balloon tamponade (Sengstaken-Blakemore) as a bridge in massive variceal bleeding; interventional radiology (TIPS) or surgery — keep the massive transfusion protocol running.²¹⁷

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Octreotide	bolus 1–2 mcg/kg (max 50 mcg) then 1–2 mcg/kg/h infusion (titrate up to ~5 mcg/kg/h if bleeding continues)	IV; variceal bleeding. Once bleeding stops, wean gradually (rebound risk); monitor glucose ²²³
Pantoprazole / omeprazole	1–2 mg/kg (max 40 mg) IV bolus then 0.1–0.2 mg/kg/h infusion (max 8 mg/h) for severe bleeding, or intermittent high-dose IV	Non-variceal; also stress-ulcer prophylaxis ²²¹
Ceftriaxone	50 mg/kg/dose once daily (max 2 g)	Broad-spectrum IV prophylaxis per local susceptibility, 5–7 days , in cirrhotic portal hypertension with acute variceal bleeding; benefit in non-cirrhotic portal hypertension unclear ²¹⁹
PRBC transfusion	restrictive: transfuse at Hb < 7 g/dL, target 7–9 g/dL	Especially variceal/cirrhosis (threshold extrapolated from adult data); transfuse promptly for hemodynamic instability or ongoing massive bleeding regardless of Hb ^{218,219,220}

⚠ AT THE BEDSIDE

Do not routinely place a nasogastric tube — in adults it does not improve outcomes, is complicated in about a third of patients, and endoscopy is the diagnostic and therapeutic tool (adult data).^{224,225} **If varices are suspected** (known chronic liver disease or portal hypertension, splenomegaly, prior varices), **avoid blind nasogastric tube insertion** — it can traumatize varices and provoke bleeding, and gains nothing before endoscopy; leave gastric access to the endoscopy/anesthesia team (expert consensus — not guideline-stated). **Protect the airway** in brisk hematemesis; do not over-transfuse a stable variceal bleed.^{217,219}

▴ ADMIT • DISCHARGE • REFER

- **Admit** — all significant bleeds → resuscitation and endoscopy.
- **Home from the emergency department** — a minor self-limited bleed after observation, with follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — gastroenterology (endoscopy); surgery/interventional radiology for uncontrolled bleeding.

Lower Gastrointestinal Bleeding

HOURS

AGE-STRATIFIED

Hematochezia — most are benign, but resuscitate first and never miss the surgical causes.

RECOGNIZE & STRATIFY

- Bleeding distal to the ligament of Treitz: **hematochezia** (fresh or maroon blood/clots per rectum), or melena from a brisk right-colonic/small-bowel source. Confirm it is blood — red foods, drugs, and bismuth mislead.²¹⁷
- Separate the sick from the well first:** a pale, tachycardic child, or blood with bilious vomiting or severe pain, points to a **surgical emergency** (intussusception, malrotation with volvulus, or NEC in a neonate) — see the red lines below.²¹⁷
- Age-based commonest causes:**
 - Neonate** — swallowed maternal blood, anal fissure, cow's-milk protein allergy, **NEC**, vitamin K deficiency bleeding, malrotation/volvulus.
 - Infant / toddler** — anal fissure, cow's-milk protein colitis, **intussusception**, **Meckel diverticulum** (painless, brisk), infectious colitis.
 - Child / adolescent** — infectious colitis, **juvenile polyp** (painless), anal fissure, inflammatory bowel disease, Henoch-Schönlein purpura, hemorrhoids.

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Investigate — order → look for → what it means

Order	Look for	What it tells you
CBC + serial hemoglobin	Anemia, Hb fall, thrombocytopenia; microcytosis	Severity & chronicity (microcytic = chronic loss) ²¹⁷
Coagulation — PT/INR, aPTT	Coagulopathy	Bleeding diathesis; vitamin K deficiency bleeding in a neonate ²¹⁷
Blood group + crossmatch	—	Prepare blood for any significant bleed
Urea & creatinine	A raised urea:creatinine ratio	Suggests an upper source instead — reconsider ²¹⁷
Stool — culture, <i>C. difficile</i> , ova/parasites; fecal calprotectin	Pathogen; raised calprotectin	Infectious colitis vs inflammatory bowel disease ²¹⁷
Abdominal ± Doppler ultrasound	Target / pseudo-kidney sign; free air	Intussusception; NEC / perforation ²¹⁷
^{99m} Tc-pertechnetate (Meckel) scan	Ectopic gastric mucosa	Meckel diverticulum in painless brisk bleeding ²¹⁷

① RESUSCITATE FIRST

ABC, IV access, crystalloid, crossmatch; transfuse by the **restrictive** strategy (Hb < 7 g/dL) unless unstable or massively bleeding.²¹⁸



DECISION

Sick child, or surgical features?

SURGICAL / UNSTABLE

Bilious vomiting, peritonism, a palpable mass or **currant-jelly** stool, or a distended tender neonatal abdomen → **urgent surgical review + imaging** (ultrasound for intussusception; contrast study for malrotation). Do not delay.²¹⁷

WELL / STABLE

Treat by the likely cause — fissure care and address constipation; trial a cow's-milk-protein-free diet in a well infant with colitis; supportive care for infectious colitis.²¹⁷



Persistent, significant, or unexplained bleeding → **endoscopy (colonoscopy ± upper endoscopy)** by pediatric gastroenterology; a **Meckel scan** for painless brisk bleeding.²¹⁷

⚠ RED LINES – DO NOT MISS

- **Intussusception** — colicky pain, drawing up the legs, currant-jelly stool, a sausage-shaped mass — ultrasound first, then air/contrast enema reduction.
- **Malrotation with volvulus** — bilious vomiting with rectal bleeding is a surgical emergency until excluded.
- **Meckel diverticulum** — massive **painless** rectal bleeding in a young child.
- **NEC** in a preterm/neonate — distension, bloody stools, systemic upset (see **Necrotizing Enterocolitis**).

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▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any significant bleed, hemodynamic compromise, or a suspected surgical cause.
- **Home from the emergency department** — a well child with a minor self-limited cause (fissure, small polyp bleed) and follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery for intussusception/volvulus/Meckel/NEC; gastroenterology for endoscopy.
- **Refer — clinic** — gastroenterology for suspected IBD or recurrent/unexplained bleeding.

Acute Liver Failure HOURS

Coagulopathy not corrected by vitamin K — transfer to a transplant center early.

▴ **DEFINE (PALF)**

- Biochemical liver injury with a **coagulopathy not corrected by vitamin K**: INR ≥ 1.5 **with** hepatic encephalopathy, or INR ≥ 2.0 **without** it — and no known chronic liver disease.²²⁶
- Encephalopathy is hard to read in infants (irritability, poor feeding, reversed sleep). Look for hypoglycemia, jaundice, hyperammonemia.
- Seek a treatable cause: acetaminophen, herpes simplex virus, autoimmune hepatitis, Wilson disease, metabolic (galactosemia, tyrosinemia), gestational alloimmune liver disease.²²⁶

○ **Investigate — order → look for → what it means (NASPGHAN)**

Order	Look for	What it tells you
PT / INR	INR ≥ 1.5 with encephalopathy, or ≥ 2.0 without it — not corrected by vitamin K	Meets the PALF diagnostic criterion ; the trend is the key prognostic marker ²²⁶
Ammonia, glucose, venous gas/bicarbonate, lactate ($\pm$ pyruvate)	Hyperammonemia, hypoglycemia, metabolic acidosis, high lactate	Complications & severity — drive PICU/transplant escalation ²²⁷
Bilirubin, albumin/total protein, AST/ALT/GGT	Rising bilirubin, low albumin	Degree of hepatocellular injury & synthetic failure ²²⁷
CBC, electrolytes, Ca/Mg/phosphate	Cytopenias, electrolyte derangement	Supportive-care targets; bleeding risk ²²⁷
Etiology panel: acetaminophen level, HSV PCR + viral serology, autoimmune markers, ceruloplasmin/Wilson studies, metabolic screen (galactosemia, tyrosinemia), gestational alloimmune liver disease workup	A treatable cause	Directs specific therapy — NAC, acyclovir, immunosuppression, chelation, exchange/IVIG ²²⁷

Suspect it → contact a pediatric liver transplant center / PICU immediately



SUPPORT

- Treat hypoglycemia (continuous dextrose, glucose infusion rate 6–8 mg/kg/min)
- Give one dose of parenteral vitamin K. **Do not routinely correct the INR without bleeding or a pre-invasive procedure** — it is the prognostic marker the transplant team needs.²²⁶
- Manage hyperammonemia/encephalopathy with transplant-hepatology/PICU guidance (lactulose/ammonia-lowering, nurse head-up, avoid sedatives, transfer early); cover empirically for sepsis if unwell.
- Consider adding acyclovir in a neonate with suspected HSV infection, and N-acetylcysteine if acetaminophen toxicity is suspected.

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
10% dextrose infusion	glucose infusion rate 6–8 mg/kg/min, titrate	Keep glucose normal; check frequently
Vitamin K	single parenteral dose	To exclude vitamin K–responsive coagulopathy
N-acetylcysteine	per acetaminophen protocol	Acetaminophen toxicity; not routine in non-acetaminophen disease — the pediatric RCT showed no survival benefit, so any use is a transplant-center/hepatology decision ²²⁸
Acyclovir	consider in a neonate/infant with suspected HSV	HSV is a treatable cause ⁹⁸

⚠ AVOID HARM

- Avoid sedatives/benzodiazepines (not cleared by a failing liver; they mask encephalopathy) and hepatotoxic drugs. **Do not chase a normal INR with plasma** in a non-bleeding child — it erases the key trend.
- Watch for cerebral edema (rising intracranial pressure) as encephalopathy advances.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → PICU/transplant center.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely.
- **Refer — now** — hepatology/transplant urgently; PICU for encephalopathy/cerebral edema.

Acute Pancreatitis HOURS NASPGHAN 2018

Diagnose on two of three — then fluids, analgesia, and early feeding.

▴ DIAGNOSE (≥ 2 OF 3)

- Abdominal pain compatible with acute pancreatitis (epigastric, may radiate to the back).
- Amylase and/or **lipase ≥ 3× the upper limit of normal** (lipase is more specific).²²⁹

- Imaging consistent with acute pancreatitis (ultrasound first; CT/MRI if needed).
- Look for a cause in every case: structural/biliary, trauma (including inflicted injury), drugs, infection, metabolic, systemic illness, genetic.

○ Investigate — order → look for → what it means

Order	Look for	What it tells you
Lipase (± amylase)	≥ 3× the upper limit of normal	Diagnostic criterion (lipase more specific than amylase) ²²⁹
CBC, CRP, hematocrit	Leukocytosis, rising CRP, hemoconcentration	Inflammatory burden & early severity ²²⁹
BUN, creatinine	Rising BUN, acute kidney injury	Key severity predictor — escalate fluids/PICU ²²⁹
Glucose, calcium	Hyperglycemia, hypocalcemia	Severity markers ²²⁹
ALT, bilirubin, GGT ± triglycerides	Raised ALT/bilirubin; high triglycerides or calcium	Biliary (gallstone) vs metabolic cause — suspected obstruction: MRCP first , then ERCP only when a therapeutic procedure is needed ²²⁹
Abdominal ultrasound first-line; MRCP for suspected biliary or pancreatic-duct obstruction/anomaly; CT for suspected complications	Gallstones, necrosis, ductal anomaly, choledocholithiasis	Etiology & complications ²²⁹

① FLUIDS

Crystalloid **1.5–2× maintenance** first 24–48 h (10–20 mL/kg bolus for hypovolemia). Target urine output > 0.5–1 mL/kg/h; monitor cardiac, pulmonary, and renal status closely for 48 h.²²⁹



② ANALGESIA & FEEDING

- Adequate analgesia, including opioids when needed. **Start enteral nutrition early** (within 48–72 h, as tolerated — oral/gastric/jejunal); enteral is preferred over parenteral.
- Prolonged gut rest is no longer recommended.²²⁹



No routine prophylactic antibiotics — reserve them for proven infection (e.g., infected necrosis).²²⁹

Therapy	Dose / setting	Notes
Crystalloid (balanced, or saline + 5% dextrose)	1.5–2× maintenance, first 24–48 h avoid overly aggressive fluids – reassess for pulmonary edema, AKI, and shock, especially in severe disease	Most important early intervention
Morphine	0.05–0.1 mg/kg IV, titrate	Opioid analgesia when needed
Early enteral nutrition	within 48–72 h	Oral/gastric/jejunal; enteral preferred over parenteral

⚠ WATCH FOR SEVERE DISEASE

- Most complications declare within 48 h.
- Persistent organ dysfunction (respiratory, cardiovascular, renal) defines severe acute pancreatitis — escalate to PICU.
- Gallstone pancreatitis with suspected obstruction: **MRCP first** (first-line and prerequisite), then **ERCP** for stone clearance if obstruction is confirmed; involve surgery and GI.

▢ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — essentially all confirmed cases — for IV fluids, analgesia, and monitoring; ICU for organ dysfunction or predicted severe disease.
- **Home from the ward** — mild disease once pain is controlled, feeding is re-established, and the cause is being addressed.
- **Refer — now** — surgical or gastroenterology review for biliary/structural causes, necrosis, or complications.

Acute Hepatitis HOURS

Most recover — the job is to catch the few progressing to liver failure.

▢ ASSESS

- Raised transaminases ± jaundice, nausea, anorexia, right-upper-quadrant pain, dark urine, pale stools.
- Causes: viral (hepatitis A/B/C/E, EBV, CMV, adenovirus, enterovirus, herpes simplex virus, SARS-CoV-2), drug-induced (including acetaminophen), autoimmune hepatitis, Wilson disease, metabolic, ischemic.⁹⁸
- **Check synthetic function and a coagulation profile (INR) at presentation** — it separates uncomplicated hepatitis from evolving liver failure. In a sick or deteriorating child, also send **ammonia, lactate, glucose, and a toxicology (acetaminophen) screen.**²²⁶

○ Investigate — order → look for → what it means

Order	Look for	What it tells you
AST/ALT, bilirubin	Markedly raised transaminases ± jaundice	Confirms hepatocellular injury
PT/INR, albumin	Prolonged INR, low albumin	Synthetic failure → evolving acute liver failure — separates it from uncomplicated hepatitis ²²⁶
Ammonia, glucose, lactate, venous gas	Hyperammonemia, hypoglycemia, acidosis	Complications & severity in a sick/deteriorating child ²²⁶
Acetaminophen level; viral panel — hepatitis A/B/C/E, EBV, CMV, HSV PCR	A treatable/infectious cause	Directs specific therapy (NAC, acyclovir) and public-health notification ⁹⁸
Autoimmune markers, ceruloplasmin, ferritin	Autoimmune hepatitis, Wilson disease, HLH	Specific etiologies not to miss ²²⁶

MANAGE

- Mostly supportive: hydration, antiemetics, avoid hepatotoxins, review every drug.
- Test for **viral hepatitis** as indicated; send autoimmune markers, ceruloplasmin, and **ferritin**. Notify per public-health requirements for notifiable viral hepatitis.



Red flags → treat as acute liver failure: a rising INR not corrected by vitamin K, hypoglycemia, or any encephalopathy. Refer urgently.

⚠ DON'T MISS THE TURN

- A child with hepatitis who develops coagulopathy (INR ≥ 1.5 –2.0), hypoglycemia, or altered behavior is no longer “just hepatitis” — escalate to the Acute Liver Failure pathway (see [Acute Liver Failure](#)) and contact a transplant center.
- Consider acetaminophen toxicity and Wilson disease in any severe presentation.²²⁶

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any coagulopathy, hypoglycemia, encephalopathy, severe vomiting or dehydration, or diagnostic uncertainty.
- **Home** — well child with stable or improving enzymes, normal INR, tolerating oral intake, with follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — urgent transplant-center/hepatology referral if it evolves to acute liver failure (rising INR, encephalopathy).

Conjugated jaundice is never physiological — the biliary-atresia clock is ticking.

THE RULE

- **Any infant still jaundiced at 2 weeks** (3 weeks if breastfed and well) needs a **fractionated (total and direct) bilirubin** — do not assume breast-milk or physiological jaundice.²³⁰
- **Cholestasis** = conjugated/direct bilirubin **> 1.0 mg/dL (> 17 µmol/L)**, regardless of the total bilirubin — always pathological (NASPGHAN/ESPGHAN 2017; the older "> 20% of total" rule is no longer used).^{230,231}
- Pale (acholic) stools and dark urine point to biliary obstruction — use a stool-color reference card.
- **Prioritize the treatable causes** — exclude biliary atresia (time-critical), sepsis, urinary tract infection, hypothyroidism, hypopituitarism, galactosemia, and tyrosinemia.²³⁰

Investigate — order → look for → what it means

Order	Look for	What it tells you
Fractionated (total + direct) bilirubin	Direct > 1.0 mg/dL (> 17 µmol/L), regardless of the total	= cholestasis — always pathological ^{230,231}
GGT, ALT/AST, albumin	Pattern of injury (high- vs low-GGT)	Narrows the differential ²³⁰
Coagulation (PT/INR)	Coagulopathy	Fat-soluble vitamin deficiency → give vitamin K ²³⁰
Abdominal ultrasound (fasting), first-line	Absent/small gallbladder, triangular-cord sign	Clue to biliary atresia (time-critical) ²³⁰
Septic + metabolic screen — glucose, ammonia, lactate, blood gas, urine reducing substances, thyroid, cultures	A treatable cause	Exclude sepsis/UTI, hypothyroidism, galactosemia, tyrosinemia ²³⁰

Neonatal conjugated hyperbilirubinemia = a medical emergency → urgent pediatric gastroenterology consultation



ACT NOW

Start the workup above the **same day**; give **vitamin K** (cholestasis impairs fat-soluble vitamin absorption and risks bleeding); do not wait for an outpatient appointment.²³⁰

⚠ BILIARY ATRESIA IS TIME-CRITICAL

- Kasai portoenterostomy works best **within the first 60 days of life** — outcomes fall sharply after.²³⁰
- A delayed referral for “prolonged jaundice” can cost the native liver.
- When in doubt, fractionate the bilirubin and refer the same day.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — for workup and any decompensation — a medical emergency for evaluation.
- **Home from the emergency department** — a stable infant with an expedited outpatient workup.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric hepatology urgently for the admitted infant (exclude biliary atresia before 6 weeks).
- **Refer — clinic** — pediatric hepatology urgently (expedited) for the stable infant sent home (exclude biliary atresia before 6 weeks).

Foreign Body Ingestion

HOURS

ESPGHAN 2026

X-ray to locate it first; then the object and where it sits decide the timing.

▴ FIRST STEP

- Ask **what, when, and how many**.
- **Plain radiographs** — a **chest X-ray (PA or AP frontal + lateral**, including the neck / upper esophagus) and an **abdominal X-ray**; together these cover neck-to-pelvis. The **lateral CXR** locates and characterizes an esophageal object and shows the button-battery **double-ring / halo** sign (vs a coin); the **abdominal film** tracks an object that has passed into the stomach or bowel.
- **Radiolucent objects** (most plastic, wood, glass, thin aluminum, fish/food bones) may not show — **a normal film does not exclude them**; consider further imaging or endoscopy if suspicion is high.²³²
- Keep child fasting (nothing by mouth) until disposition decided.²³²

Timing	Which swallowed objects
Now endoscopy ≤ 2 h	Button battery in the esophagus; two or more magnets , or a magnet plus a metal object (any level) ²³² ; sharp or pointed object in the esophagus; esophageal blockage — drooling, unable to swallow saliva; airway distress or signs of perforation; any symptomatic child .
Within 24 h next day at the latest	Any other object lodged in the esophagus — never leave one there beyond 24 h. ²³³ Sharp object, or magnets, sitting in the stomach or duodenum. Object ≥ 2.5 cm (25 mm, ~1 inch) wide or ≥ 5–6 cm (~2 inches) long — too big to pass the pylorus or duodenum. ²³³

Observe
at home,
elective

A single blunt object (e.g., a coin) already past the esophagus into the stomach, < 2.5 cm wide and < 5 cm long, with no battery or magnet. 80–90% pass within 1–2 weeks. Re-image only if symptoms appear; remove if it is still in the stomach at ~ 2–4 weeks.²³²

Water beads
admit &
observe;
surgery, not
endoscopy

Superabsorbent (water) beads are radiolucent — plain films miss them; use **abdominal ultrasound**. Small ingestions (a few beads) usually pass: admit, serial abdominal examination, watch for bilious vomiting, distension or pain. **Endoscopy rarely retrieves them** and is not the pathway. **Involve pediatric surgery early** for large ingestions or any sign of obstruction — most symptomatic children need an operation.^{234,235}

⚠️ RED LINES

- Batteries and magnets are never simply observed — an esophageal battery or two or more magnets is an emergency at any level (see [Button Battery Ingestion](#)).
- An esophageal foreign body left beyond 24 h risks pressure necrosis, perforation, and aorto-/tracheo-esophageal fistula.²³²
- Return for pain, vomiting, fever, drooling, bleeding, or black stool.

◆ **WHO REMOVES IT** A foreign body lodged in the **UPPER (CERVICAL) ESOPHAGUS, AT THE LEVEL OF THE CLAVICLES (T2)**, typically removed by ENT with a **RIGID ESOPHAGOSCOPE**; objects lower (esophagus/stomach) usually managed by GI with flexible endoscopy.

◆ **SEE ALSO** [Button \(Lithium\) Battery Ingestion](#).

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — symptomatic, an esophageal object, or high-risk (magnets, sharp, long).
- **Home from the emergency department** — asymptomatic gastric blunt object with return advice.
- **Refer — now** — GI/surgery for endoscopy (esophageal, magnets, sharp objects).

Button (Lithium) Battery Ingestion MINUTES ESPGHAN 2026

An esophageal battery burns within 2 hours — move fast.

LOCALIZE

Urgent **chest X-ray (PA or AP frontal + lateral)** covering neck to upper esophagus (add an **abdominal X-ray** if the battery is not seen). A "double-ring / halo" sign distinguishes battery from coin. Esophageal location = emergency.²³⁶



DECISION

Battery in the esophagus?

YES – ESOPHAGEAL

Endoscopic removal within 2 hours. See mitigation doses below — do not let them delay removal.²³⁶

PAST ESOPHAGUS, asymptomatic

Often expectant with follow-up imaging; remove if symptomatic, co-ingested magnet, or fails to progress.²³³

Mitigation	Dose	Route & notes
Honey	10 mL every 10 min, up to 6 doses	Oral; within 12 h. Pre-hospital. Only if ≥ 12 months — never give honey under 12 months. ²³⁶
Sucralfate	1 g every 10 min, up to 3 doses	Oral; in-hospital, before removal ²³⁶

⚠ AFTER REMOVAL

Injury continues — watch for delayed strictures and tracheo-/aorto-esophageal fistula.²³⁶

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all esophageal batteries → emergency.
- **Home from the emergency department** — after confirmed passage past the esophagus in an asymptomatic child, per protocol.
- **Refer — now** — GI/ENT/surgery IMMEDIATELY for esophageal lodgement — do not delay.

Functional Constipation & Fecal Impaction**ASSESS**

ESPGHAN/NASPGHAN · NICE

Common, benign, and clinical — but disimpact before maintenance and screen for red flags.

▴ RECOGNIZE (ROME IV)

- **< 4 years** — ≥ 2 of the following for ≥ 1 month; **≥ 4 years** — ≥ 2 at least once a week for ≥ 1 month (with insufficient criteria for IBS):
- ≤ 2 defecations/week
- painful or hard stools
- large-diameter stools
- a large fecal mass in the rectum
- excessive stool retention
- (if toilet-trained) ≥ 1 episode of fecal incontinence/week or a history of large stools that may obstruct the toilet.²³⁷
- Retentive posturing / withholding — often presents as **overflow soiling** mistaken for diarrhea.
- Acute presentations: abdominal pain, a palpable fecal mass, urinary symptoms, or a distressed withholding child.

▀ DIAGNOSE – CLINICAL

- History + examination make the diagnosis. **Without a red flag, no routine investigations** — no bloods (celiac, thyroid, calcium, lead), imaging, allergy testing, or transit studies.²³⁷
- **A digital rectal exam is not needed when ≥ 2 Rome IV criteria are met** — reserve it for a single criterion, a red flag, or to confirm impaction when the abdominal exam is unclear. A plain abdominal film is not used to diagnose constipation.²³⁷

⚠ RED FLAGS – THINK ORGANIC DISEASE, DO NOT JUST TREAT

- Onset from birth or delayed meconium > 48 h (Hirschsprung)
- ribbon stools
- failure to thrive
- unintentional weight loss or slow growth
- bilious vomiting
- severe distension
- blood without a fissure
- abnormal anal position or tone, absent anal/cremasteric reflex, sacral dimple, hair tuft or lower-limb weakness (spinal)
- perianal scarring or extreme fear on exam (safeguarding)
- family history of autoimmune disease or cystic fibrosis.
- Examine the perineum and back.²³⁸

TREAT

- Disimpact first if a fecal mass is present — **maintenance alone will worsen overflow soiling**. Then start maintenance the same day, add behavioral measures, and review at 2 weeks.²³⁸
- **Goal — one soft, painless stool daily with no withholding or soiling**. Continue maintenance at goal for ≥ 2 months and until **symptom-free for ≥ 1 month** — in a toilet-training child, continue until trained — then **wean gradually rather than stopping abruptly**; do not stop while symptoms persist.²³⁷
- **Break the pain-withholding cycle** — an anal fissure or painful defecation drives retention; keeping stool soft (with topical fissure care) is what lets maintenance work.²³⁹

POLYETHYLENE GLYCOL (PEG 3350/4000) – FIRST-LINE FOR BOTH STEPS

Step	Dose	Notes
Disimpaction	PEG 1–1.5 g/kg once daily (oral) for 3–6 consecutive days	Oral is as effective as enemas and less invasive; expect a few messy days. A rectal enema is an alternative if oral is refused or fails. ²³⁸
Maintenance	PEG 0.4–1.5 g/kg once daily (start ~0.4 g/kg, titrate up to ~1.5 g/kg/day as needed)	First-line and superior to lactulose . Titrate to the goal above; reassess at 2 weeks if inadequate. ²³⁷

Step	Dose	Notes
Add-on / alternative	Stimulant (senna or bisacodyl, age-appropriate) lactulose if PEG unavailable	Second-line adjunct when PEG alone is insufficient — not a substitute for disimpaction.

◆ PEG – WITH OR WITHOUT ELECTROLYTES

- Same drug (macrogol); the only difference is added balancing salts. **With electrolytes** for high-volume **disimpaction**; **without** (more palatable) is an equal option for **maintenance**. The electrolyte-containing macrogol stocked locally covers both; improve palatability by chilling and mixing it into a flavored drink.^{240,241}

◆ SIDE-EFFECTS & PRECAUTIONS

- **PEG (osmotic)** — dose-related loose stools, bloating, flatulence and nausea; over-titration can cause diarrhea or overflow soiling — **reduce the dose, do not stop**. Maintain adequate fluid intake. Clinically significant electrolyte disturbance is rare (the electrolyte form guards against it further), and there is **no tolerance or dependence** with long-term use.²³⁷
- **Stimulants (senna, bisacodyl)** — abdominal cramps and diarrhea; in diaper-wearing or incontinent children, prolonged skin contact with senna can cause a blistering perianal ("senna") dermatitis, so keep the skin clean and barrier-protected. No good evidence for a "lazy bowel" at therapeutic doses.²³⁷
- **Lactulose** — flatulence, bloating and cramps, with more adverse events than PEG and inferior efficacy; reserve it for where PEG is unavailable or unlicensed.²⁴²
- **General** — titrate to one soft, painless stool daily; do not stop abruptly (relapse); recheck adherence and dose before escalating.

◆ INFANTS < 1 YEAR

- PEG is effective and first-line; **LACTULOSE IS THE ALTERNATIVE** where PEG is unavailable or unlicensed.
- In a **REFRACTORY** infant, consider a **2-4 WEEK TRIAL OF A COW'S-MILK-PROTEIN-FREE DIET**.
- **INFANT DYSCHIZIA** — straining then passing a *soft* stool, < 9 months — is **NOT** constipation and needs no laxative.²³⁷

✦ WHEN MAINTENANCE ISN'T WORKING

- **Check adherence and dose first** — under-dosing and stopping too early are the commonest reasons for relapse.
- Re-check for a **retained impaction**; re-disimpact if present.
- Add a **stimulant** (senna or bisacodyl); then reconsider the diagnosis / red flags.
- Prucalopride, lubiprostone and linaclotide are **not established in children** — specialist use only.²³⁸

✦ DIET, BEHAVIOR & COUNSELING

- Normal fiber and fluid; **fiber supplements, extra fluid, and probiotics are not proven** and do not replace a laxative.²³⁷
- Demystify and remove blame; scheduled toilet sits ~5 min after meals with foot support; a stool diary and reward system.
- **Long-term PEG is safe and not habit-forming** — reassure families to keep the dose adequate.²³⁷
- Relapse is common and treatment often runs months; about half are off laxatives by 6–12 months — set expectations and follow up.²³⁸

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — rarely — failed disimpaction or severe symptoms.
- **Home from the emergency department** — most, with disimpaction, maintenance laxatives, and education.
- **Refer — clinic** — pediatric **gastroenterology** for red flags / suspected organic disease, failure of optimized maintenance after ~3 months, diagnostic uncertainty, or a child needing ongoing second-line therapy; **surgery for suspected Hirschsprung** — rectal suction biopsy is the gold standard (contrast enema and anorectal manometry are adjuncts).²³⁷

Reflux & GERD

ASSESS

INFANT-FOCUSED · 2018

Distinguish the thriving "happy spitter" from true reflux disease.

▴ REFLUX VS DISEASE

- **GER (physiological)**: effortless regurgitation in a comfortable, thriving infant; peaks ~4 months, resolves by 12–18 months. Not a disease²⁴³ — reassurance.
- **GERD**: reflux causing troublesome symptoms or complications — feeding refusal, faltering growth, esophagitis, recurrent aspiration.²⁴³

① REASSURE + CONSERVATIVE

- Parental education; avoid overfeeding; smaller, more frequent feeds; thickened feeds; hold upright after feeds; continue breastfeeding.
- Do **not** use prone/side positioning for sleep (SIDS risk).²⁴³



② TRIAL IF NOT IMPROVING (INFANT)

2–4 weeks of extensively hydrolyzed (or amino acid) formula, or maternal dairy exclusion if breastfed — overlaps with cow's milk protein allergy.²⁴³



Refer to gastroenterology — do **not** start acid suppression in an infant yourself. The gastroenterologist assesses and decides the next step: a **PPI / H2 trial**, or **upper-GI endoscopy or a contrast study**.²⁴³

Time-limited **4–8 week** trial of acid suppression (proton-pump inhibitor or H2-antagonist), then **wean and reassess**.²⁴³

⚠ DO NOT ACID-SUPPRESS SIMPLE REFLUX

- Proton-pump inhibitors are **not** recommended for unexplained crying, distress, or visible regurgitation in an otherwise well infant — no benefit and real harms.²⁴³
- Avoid acid suppression for isolated cough/wheeze. **Red flags** (investigate / refer): bilious or projectile vomiting, blood in vomit or stool, onset after 6 months or persisting beyond 12–18 months, faltering growth, fever, lethargy, or a bulging fontanelle.

▢ ADMIT • DISCHARGE • REFER

- Admit** — rarely — only for complications (apnea, faltering growth, aspiration) or diagnostic uncertainty.
- Home from the emergency department** — uncomplicated reflux with reassurance and feeding advice.
- Refer — clinic** — gastroenterology for red flags, faltering growth, or treatment failure.

Ingestion Injuries — See Also

Corrosive ingestion is covered in the Toxicology section.

◆ **CROSS-REFERENCE CAUSTIC (CORROSIVE) INGESTION** (Toxicology & Environmental) — acid/alkali esophageal injury; no charcoal, no emesis, airway first, endoscopy at 12–24 h.

Acute IBD Flare & Toxic Megacolon

MINUTES

ESPGHAN-ECCO 2025

Bloody diarrhea with systemic upset — and the colon that dilates and can perforate.

▢ RECOGNIZE

- Known or new IBD with **frequent bloody stools**, abdominal pain, fever, tachycardia and raised inflammatory markers; grade severity (e.g. **PUCAI** in ulcerative colitis).
- Toxic megacolon** — colonic dilatation with systemic toxicity (fever, tachycardia, tenderness/distension); a surgical emergency.²⁴⁴

⚠ WHAT MAKES IT WORSE

- **Avoid antimotility agents, opioids and anticholinergics** — they can precipitate toxic megacolon.²⁴⁴
- Exclude infection (including **C. difficile** and enteric pathogens) before/while escalating immunosuppression.
- Rising distension, worsening toxicity, or free air means **surgery**.

📌 WORKUP

- **PUCAI at admission and daily** (score it below) — acute severe colitis = PUCAI $\geq$ 65. **Day 3 > 45** → plan second-line therapy (screen, discuss); **day 5 $\geq$ 65** → start second-line; **35–65 on day 5** → continue IV steroids 2–5 more days with daily scoring; **< 35** → responding, continue and transition to oral.²⁴⁴
- CBC, CRP/ESR, albumin, electrolytes, renal and liver function.
- **Stool infection panel including C. difficile** (consider CMV on biopsy if steroid-refractory).
- **Abdominal X-ray** for colonic dilatation / toxic megacolon; limited unprepped sigmoidoscopy where needed.

◆ PUCAI – SIX CLINICAL ITEMS, NO LABS (0–85)

Item	Score
Abdominal pain	none 0 · can be ignored 5 · cannot be ignored 10
Rectal bleeding	none 0 · small amount, in < 50% of stools 10 · small amount with most stools 20 · large amount (> 50% of stool content) 30
Stool consistency (most stools)	formed 0 · partially formed 5 · completely unformed 10
Stools per 24 h	0–2 0 · 3–5 5 · 6–8 10 · > 8 15
Nocturnal stools (waking the child)	no 0 · yes 10
Activity level	no limitation 0 · occasional limitation 5 · severely restricted 10

- **< 10** remission · **10–34** mild · **35–64** moderate · **$\geq$ 65** severe (acute severe colitis — admit for IV steroids).^{244,245}

Step	Approach	Notes
Resuscitate	IV fluids, correct electrolytes (esp. K ⁺), transfuse if needed	Monitor for toxic megacolon
Treat the flare	IV corticosteroids for severe colitis	Gastroenterology-directed; escalate to infliximab or cyclosporine by day 5 if inadequate response; pharmacologic VTE prophylaxis for all hospitalized ²⁴⁴

Step	Approach	Notes
Toxic megacolon	Bowel rest, decompression, urgent surgical review	Colectomy if deteriorating/perforation

▲ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — all acute severe colitis.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric gastroenterology and surgery (early joint care for toxic megacolon).

09

Hematologic & Oncologic

Neutropenia · tumor lysis · sickle cell · bleeding

Chemotherapy-induced Febrile Neutropenia MINUTES

Fever in a child on chemotherapy — a medical emergency until proven otherwise.

◆ NOT ON CHEMOTHERAPY?

- This card is for the **oncology / chemotherapy (or post-transplant) patient**. For a **well, previously healthy, immunocompetent child** with an incidental fever + neutropenia, use [Febrile Neutropenia — Otherwise Healthy Child](#) instead — empiric antibiotics are usually **not** required.^{246,247}

▲ DEFINE

- Fever — single oral temp ≥ 38.3 °C, or ≥ 38.0 °C sustained over 1 h between checks, **without antipyretic use** (even if first reported at home) — **plus** absolute neutrophil count < 500 cells/ μ L (or expected to fall below).²⁴⁸

Empiric broad-spectrum antibiotics within 1 hour — do not wait for the count²⁴⁸



WORKUP

- Blood cultures (peripheral + each central line lumen — at least one must be drawn, central preferred; do not delay antibiotics waiting for both), full blood count with differential, renal panel (electrolytes, creatinine, glucose), lactate, urinalysis $\pm$ culture, focused exam (skin, perianal, line site)
- Start antibiotics immediately if unstable — even without labs collected.²⁴⁸

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Piperacillin-tazobactam	75–80 mg/kg/dose (piperacillin component) every 6 h (max 4000 mg/dose)	IV; first-line anti-pseudomonal monotherapy ^{248,249}
Cefepime	50 mg/kg/dose every 8 h (max 2000 mg/dose)	IV; alternative monotherapy if piperacillin-tazobactam is unavailable ²⁴⁹
Meropenem	20 mg/kg/dose every 8 h (max 1 g/dose; 2 g/dose if CNS/severe)	IV; for penicillin / β -lactam allergy; also for resistant organisms, CNS infection, or instability ²⁴⁹
Ceftazidime (+ vancomycin)	50 mg/kg/dose every 8 h (max 2000 mg/dose)	IV; if piperacillin-tazobactam is unavailable — give with vancomycin for gram-positive cover ²⁴⁹
Vancomycin (add only if indicated)	15 mg/kg/dose every 6 h if < 12 yr every 8 h if $\geq$ 12 yr (max 1 g/dose; level-guided)	IV; for instability, line/skin infection, known resistant organism — not routine; requires drug-level monitoring

◆ LOCAL CHOICE

- Follow your local antibiogram — the empiric agent should match local resistance.
- Add an **AMINOGLYCOSIDE** (amikacin or gentamicin) **ONLY** for hemodynamic instability or known/suspected multidrug-resistant gram-negative rods, and until culture results are available.²⁴⁹
- SELECTED LOW-RISK** (including but not limited to: anticipated neutropenia $\leq$ 7 days, no comorbidity, stable, tolerating oral intake, reliable caregiver & transport) may be managed as an outpatient as per local protocol: day-1 IV **CEFTRIAXONE** (100 mg/kg, max 4 g) + gentamicin, stepping down to oral ciprofloxacin + amoxicillin-clavulanate; review daily.²⁴⁹
- Do not routinely add vancomycin (other than as the gram-positive companion to ceftazidime above).²⁴⁸ Granulocyte colony-stimulating factor only in consultation with hematology/oncology. **AGE < 2 MONTHS** (rare): ampicillin + ceftazidime, in consultation with infectious diseases / pediatric hematology-oncology (expert practice — not guideline-stated).

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- Admit** — high-risk febrile neutropenia (oncology/chemotherapy) → immediate empiric antibiotics.
- Home from the emergency department** — selected low-risk after risk assessment with close follow-up (the well-appearing non-oncologic child).
- Refer — now** — oncology/hematology.

Febrile Neutropenia – Otherwise Healthy Child

ASSESS

IMMUNOCOMPETENT CHILD

The well child with fever, commonly a viral illness, found to have an incidental low ANC — usually transient and benign, unlike chemotherapy-induced neutropenia from myelosuppression. Some malignancies (e.g., a localized brain tumor) do not suppress the marrow and so do not cause

neutropenia.

◆ THE KEY QUESTION – WHICH CAME FIRST?

- **INFECTION → NEUTROPENIA** (a virus transiently suppresses or consumes neutrophils in a healthy child) behaves very differently from **NEUTROPENIA → INFECTION** (marrow failure, malignancy, post-transplant).²⁴⁶
- Most well, febrile children with incidental neutropenia are the former and do **NOT** need empiric febrile-neutropenia antibiotics.²⁴⁶

▀ DEFINITIONS & MECHANISM

- **Neutropenia = absolute neutrophil count (ANC) < 1500/μL.**
- Mild 1000–1500
- moderate 500–1000
- **severe < 500**; very severe < 200.
- Normal ANC varies by age and ethnicity (benign ethnic neutropenia).²⁴⁶
- **Fever (neutropenic definition):** single oral temp ≥ 38.3 °C, or ≥ 38 °C sustained > 1 h, or twice > 38 °C in 12 h. Avoid rectal temperatures (mucosal trauma).²⁴⁶
- **Common viral triggers:** RSV, influenza A/B, parvovirus B19, Epstein-Barr virus (EBV), cytomegalovirus (CMV), human herpesvirus 6 (HHV-6), varicella-zoster. Other unidentified viruses may also cause neutropenia or other transient cytopenias. Mechanisms: transient marrow suppression, peripheral destruction/margination, or an autoimmune process.²⁴⁶

▀ WHAT MAKES IT LOW-RISK (USUALLY PRESUMED VIRAL)

- **Well-appearing**, immunocompetent, clear viral context, no features of sepsis or primary immunodeficiency.
- **Short anticipated duration** — viral neutropenia typically resolves within ~2–4 weeks, rarely beyond 6 weeks; risk rises mainly when neutropenia is prolonged²⁴⁶ (> 30 days).
- No prior neutropenia, recurrent/severe infections, failure to thrive, or family history of a congenital syndrome; not on a neutropenia-inducing drug; not immunosuppressed.

DECISION

Ill-appearing or any high-risk feature?

LOW-RISK • WELL CHILD

Well-appearing, presumed viral, short-duration, no clue to an underlying cause. **Low risk of serious infection** — manage supportively with close follow-up. A history of a previously normal ANC is reassuring here.

HIGH-RISK

Ill-appearing (hypothermia, hypotension, lethargy), or known/suspected **severe congenital neutropenia (no prior normal ANC on record; e.g., Kostmann), aplastic anemia, or other marrow-failure/immunodeficiency** → medical emergency.

Most transient neutropenia is viral — it does not require antimicrobial therapy.²⁴⁶

LOW-RISK – EVALUATION & DISPOSITION

Step	What to do	Notes
Cultures	Blood culture stratified by severity: not required in mild (ANC 1000–1500), consider in moderate (500–1000), obtain in severe (< 500) consider urine culture (esp. young / female)	CPS: ensure a peripheral blood culture in severe neutropenia (ANC < 0.5 ×10 ⁹ /L) and in any ill-appearing child; consider urinalysis/urine culture in incontinent children (generally < 24 months) or with UTI risk factors. ²⁴⁶ Don't rely on urinalysis — pyuria is often absent in neutropenia. ²⁴⁷
Blood film	Peripheral blood film in all newly discovered neutropenia (if not already done)	Look for blasts, dysplasia or a left shift — helps exclude malignancy / marrow failure.
Identify the virus	Consider a respiratory multiplex PCR (not just influenza/RSV)	Confirming a viral cause supports a benign, transient course; may not always identify a specific viral species.
Targeted tests	As indicated: chest radiograph, abdominal imaging, lumbar puncture, stool testing	A normal radiograph can mislead — infiltrates may appear only as the ANC recovers.
Disposition	Discharge home with close follow-up if well and follow-up assured	Recheck CBC to confirm recovery ²⁴⁶ ; most normalize within ~2–4 weeks.

HIGH-RISK – MANAGEMENT

Empiric therapy	Agent / approach	Notes
Act promptly	Full infectious work-up, hospitalize, start empiric antimicrobials without waiting for the ANC trend	Involve hematology ± infectious diseases early.
First-line	Piperacillin-tazobactam (broad-spectrum, anti-pseudomonal)	Backbone of high-risk empiric cover, as in chemotherapy-related FN. ²⁴⁸
Tailor by risk	Adjust for known colonization (MDRO, MRSA), prior prophylaxis, local antibiogram	Add MRSA cover (vancomycin) for hemodynamic instability, line, or skin/soft-tissue infection.

⚠ DON'T OVER-TREAT – OR UNDER-TREAT

- The well child with an incidental low ANC during a viral illness is **not** chemotherapy-induced myelosuppression — reflexive broad-spectrum antibiotics add resistance and harm with little benefit.
- Conversely, never anchor on “just a virus”: an **ill-appearing** child, **prolonged** neutropenia (> 30 days), recurrent/severe or unusual infections, oral ulcers, or failure to thrive warrant a congenital/marrow-failure work-up and prompt treatment.²⁴⁶

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — only if febrile with concerning features or a suspected/confirmed bacterial infection.
- **Home from the emergency department** — well child — expectant management with a scheduled recheck of counts.
- **Refer — clinic** — hematology for persistent (> 6 weeks), profound (< 500 consistently), or recurrent neutropenia.

Tumor Lysis Syndrome

MINUTES

BSH 2025 · COIFFIER 2008

Massive cell breakdown — after starting chemotherapy, or spontaneously in high-burden leukemia/lymphoma.

▶ THE BIOCHEMICAL QUARTET

- **High** potassium, **high** phosphate, **high** uric acid; **low** calcium → acute kidney injury (see [Acute Kidney Injury](#)), arrhythmia, seizures.²⁵⁰

① HYDRATION IS THE BACKBONE OF CARE

- **Established TLS:** IV hyperhydration starting at **3 L/m²/day, up to 4 L/m²/day** in children by renal function and fluid status (BSH 2025); adjust to keep urine output ≈ **100 mL/m²/h** (80–100 mL/m²/h; 4–6 mL/kg/h if ≤ 10 kg); 200 mL/kg/day if ≤ 10 kg.^{250,251}
- **No potassium in any IV fluid** — balanced crystalloids (Hartmann's, Plasma-Lyte) contain potassium; avoid potassium and phosphate supplements; loop diuretic only for fluid overload; caution in high-count leukemia with low hemoglobin (hemodilution).²⁵¹
- **Prophylaxis:** oral fluids 2–3 L/m²/day the day before, the day of and the day after starting therapy; IV hydration if high risk or unable to drink.²⁵¹
- Routine urinary alkalinization not recommended.^{250,251}



DECISION

Risk level?

INTERMEDIATE

Allopurinol + hydration.²⁵⁰

HIGH / ESTABLISHED

Rasburicase + hydration. Do not give allopurinol on a rasburicase day. High risk includes (not limited to) white cell count > 50,000, elevated or rapidly rising uric acid, or suspected lymphoma with bulky disease (mediastinal mass, multiple significantly enlarged nodes).²⁵⁰



② TREAT THE ELECTROLYTES

- Manage hyperkalemia (see [Electrolyte Emergencies](#)).
- Treat symptomatic hypocalcemia with appropriate replacement.
- For refractory derangement or oliguric kidney injury, escalate urgently to nephrology/PICU — dialysis is a specialist decision (AEIOU indications); the threshold is lower than in other AKI because lysis is ongoing.²⁵¹
- **Monitor** potassium, uric acid, phosphate, calcium and creatinine every 6–12 h in established TLS (more often for life-threatening hyperkalemia); at least twice daily, up to 3–4×/day, in high-risk prophylaxis; strict fluid balance and urine output.²⁵¹

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Allopurinol	10 mg/kg/day PO divided every 8 h (max 800 mg/day) = 100 mg/m ² 8-hourly (BSH)	PO; start ≥ 12 h before chemotherapy; prevents new urate; reduce in renal impairment; interaction with diuretics; skin reactions. ^{250,251}
Rasburicase — oncology-directed	0.2 mg/kg IV over 30 min once daily Repeat doses and duration are decided with the oncology team by uric acid and clinical response (established TLS up to 7 days; high-risk prophylaxis up to 5 days) Stop allopurinol while on rasburicase; restart 24 h after the last dose	Breaks down existing urate. Start, repeat doses and duration are the oncology team's decision — the licensed 0.2 mg/kg/day is the recommended pediatric dose. ^{251,252} Samples for uric acid on ice . Do NOT give in known G6PD deficiency ; in a very unwell child the consultant may give it without waiting for the result after weighing the risks. ²⁵¹

⚠ RASBURICASE + G6PD DEFICIENCY

- Rasburicase is **contraindicated** in glucose-6-phosphate dehydrogenase deficiency (causes hemolysis and methemoglobinemia) — screen at-risk patients before giving — **G6PD level** if status unknown (e.g., new diagnosis not yet screened); especially relevant here given high prevalence.²⁵³
- Send urate samples on ice.²⁵⁰

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all at-risk or established TLS → hyper-hydration and monitoring (allopurinol for intermediate risk; rasburicase for high risk or rapidly rising uric acid); severe/refractory → PICU with the dialysis team (nephrology).
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; after resolution of TLS and confirmed stability.
- **Refer — now** — oncology/nephrology (dialysis for refractory).

Sickle Cell Crises MINUTES

Pain crisis, acute chest syndrome, splenic sequestration, and stroke — plus every patient is functionally asplenic.

VASO-OCCLUSIVE (PAIN) CRISIS

Step	Action	Notes
Analgesia — fast	Opioid within 30–60 min; add NSAID/acetaminophen	Use a pain protocol; reassess every 15–30 min. Do not delay analgesia — splinting (shallow, guarded breathing from pain) can progress to acute chest syndrome. ^{254,255}
Hydration	Oral if able; if unable to drink, IV at no more than maintenance rate	Avoid over-hydration (acute chest risk); some protocols use 0.75× maintenance (local practice) ²⁵⁶
Oxygen + warmth	If SpO ₂ < 95% on room air ²⁵⁶ (or below baseline)	Keep warm; treat the trigger

▲ ACUTE CHEST SYNDROME

- **Definition:** new pulmonary infiltrate + respiratory symptoms / fever / chest pain — the leading cause of death in patients with sickle cell disease.
- **Treatment:** oxygen (keep SpO₂ > 95%), broad-spectrum antibiotics covering atypicals (cefotaxime + azithromycin/clarithromycin), bronchodilator if wheezing, incentive spirometry while awake.²⁵⁶
- **Escalation:** early hematology/PICU discussion for **simple vs exchange transfusion** if severe hypoxia or falling hemoglobin.²⁵⁶

▲ SPLENIC SEQUESTRATION

- Rapidly enlarging spleen + falling hemoglobin **and/or platelet count** → hypovolemic shock. Give fluids for shock and consult hematology immediately.
- Transfuse **cautiously** to raise the hemoglobin to a stable level, not to normal.²⁵⁶ Over-transfusion risks rebound hyperviscosity as the spleen releases trapped cells (expert consensus).

▲ ACUTE STROKE

- Sudden focal deficit, seizure, or new altered consciousness → **urgent neuroimaging** with immediate hematology and neurology involvement.
- **Ischemic stroke** — transfuse urgently, do not delay. **Exchange transfusion is the definitive treatment** (goal HbS < 30%; keep total Hb ≤ 10 g/dL to avoid hyperviscosity), under hematology and neurology. If the child is significantly anemic (**Hb < 9 g/dL**) or exchange is not immediately available, give a **simple (top-up) transfusion as an immediate bridge** — but do not raise Hb above ~10 g/dL. Aim to start exchange **within 6 h**.²⁵⁷
- **Hemorrhagic stroke** is managed case by case, in tandem with neurosurgery.

◆ **FEVER IN SICKLE CELL DISEASE IS AN EMERGENCY** All patients functionally asplenic, at risk of overwhelming infection by encapsulated organisms — give prompt empiric antibiotics — **CEFTRIAXONE** is the agent of choice (once-daily; enables outpatient management of low-risk cases). Use **CEFOTAXIME IN INFANTS < 1 MONTH**, in whom ceftriaxone is contraindicated (bilirubin displacement); another broad-spectrum agent covering encapsulated bacteria may be used if allergic.^{254,258} Assess for the crises above. **CONSIDER ORAL ANTIBIOTICS ONLY IF STRICTLY LOW-RISK (PER LOCAL PROTOCOL)**: age > 1 year and clinically well with normal vitals (SpO₂ ≥ 95%); no focal source, severe pain, acute chest, or sequestration; reassuring labs (WBC 5–30 ×10⁹/L, reticulocytes > 100 ×10⁹/L, platelets > 100 ×10⁹/L); a first parenteral antibiotic dose given in the ED with 2–4 h observation; and a reliable home situation with guaranteed 24-h follow-up.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — severe uncontrolled pain, acute chest syndrome, sequestration, stroke, priapism, or sepsis.
- **Home** — pain controlled on oral analgesia, well and hydrated, with follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — hematology; PICU for acute chest/stroke; exchange-transfusion decisions.

Acute Bleeding in Hemophilia MINUTES

"Factor First" — replacing clotting factor is always the priority; give factor before imaging or detailed assessment so there is no delay to life/limb-saving treatment.

▲ PRINCIPLE

- In any serious bleed — especially head injury — give factor **immediately**, before the CT scan or full work-up. Each unit/kg of factor VIII (factor 8) raises the level by ~2%; each unit/kg of factor IX (factor 9) by ~1%.²⁵⁹

Scenario / agent	Dose	Target & notes
Hemophilia A — severe / head injury	Factor VIII ~50 units/kg	IV; aim factor level 80 ²⁵⁹ –100%
Hemophilia A — minor bleed	Factor VIII ~25 units/kg	IV; aim ~50% ²⁵⁹

Scenario / agent	Dose	Target & notes
Hemophilia B — severe	Factor IX 100–140 units/kg	IV; aim 80 ²⁵⁹ –100%
Mild hemophilia A	Desmopressin (DDAVP)	Only if a documented prior response; not for major bleeds ²⁵⁹
Known inhibitor — life/limb threat	rFVIIa 90 mcg/kg, or FEIBA 75–100 units/kg	IV; bypassing agents — call hematology urgently for use and guidance ²⁵⁹
Tranexamic acid (mucosal / oral bleeds)	25 mg/kg/dose PO every 8 h, or 10 mg/kg/dose IV every 8 h	Excellent adjunct for oral/mucosal bleeds. Avoid with FEIBA (thrombosis risk) and in hematuria (ureteric clot obstruction). ²⁵⁹

⚠ HEAD INJURY

- Treat to 100% factor level immediately and **before** the CT.
- If weight unknown, give roughly three times the usual joint-bleed dose.
- Contact the on-call hematologist.
- Do not hesitate to give factor; use the Breslow tape to estimate weight if unknown.²⁶⁰

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — major or life-threatening bleeds (head, neck, gut, compartment).
- **Home from the emergency department** — minor bleeds controlled after factor, with a home plan.
- **Refer — now** — hematology for all; neurosurgery/surgery as needed — give factor before imaging.

Immune Thrombocytopenia (ITP) ASSESS ASH 2019

Isolated thrombocytopenia in a well child — treat the bleeding, not the number.

▀ RECOGNIZE

- Sudden bruising, petechiae or mucosal bleeding in an otherwise **well** child (often 1–4 weeks after a viral illness), **isolated** platelets $< 100 \times 10^9/L$ with normal hemoglobin, white count and film.²⁶¹
- Grade the bleeding, not just the count: **“dry” purpura** (skin only) vs **“wet” purpura** (mucosal — oral blood blisters, epistaxis, GI/urinary) — wet bleeding drives treatment.²⁶¹

⚠ RED FLAGS – THIS IS NOT SIMPLE ITP

- Hepatosplenomegaly, lymphadenopathy, bone/joint pain, pallor or fatigue, **any other cytopenia**, or an atypical film → suspect **leukemia, aplastic anemia, HUS or NAI** and involve hematology before steroids.
- Steroids can partially treat and mask leukemia — **never start empiric steroids without a film reviewed by hematology**²⁶¹.

✦ FIRST DECISION – OBSERVE OR TREAT

- For a child with **no or minor (dry) bleeding**, observation is preferred **regardless of platelet count** — most childhood ITP is self-limiting.²⁶¹
- Drug therapy is for **significant mucosal (wet) bleeding** or bleeding that affects daily life, not for a low number alone.²⁶¹ Actively bleeding toddlers with counts < 10 ×10⁹/L may need a short oral-steroid course — decided case by case.

📌 WORKUP

- **CBC + peripheral blood film** — confirm **isolated** thrombocytopenia and look for blasts, schistocytes or other cytopenias.
- **Blood group**, and a **direct antiglobulin test** (Coombs test) before anti-D.²⁶¹
- **No routine bone marrow** in typical ITP — reserve for atypical features (other cytopenias, organomegaly, constitutional symptoms) or before splenectomy.²⁶¹

Option	Dose	Route & notes
Prednisolone / prednisone	2–4 mg/kg/day (max 120 mg/day) for 5–7 days, then stop	PO; short courses need no taper (taper only if prolonged/recurrent); ideally the film is seen first; cost-effective with tolerable short-course side-effects ²⁶¹
IV immunoglobulin (IVIG)	0.8–1 g/kg as a single dose (may repeat once)	IV; fastest platelet rise — first-line when a rapid rise is needed; expensive and requires special access ²⁶¹
Anti-D immunoglobulin	50–75 µg/kg once (formulary dosing) ⁴²	IV; only if Rh(D)-positive, non-splenectomized, no autoimmune hemolysis ²⁶¹ — watch for hemolysis
Tranexamic acid	10–15 mg/kg/dose (max 1000 mg) every 8 h – formulary dosing ⁴²	PO/IV; adjunct for mucosal bleeding — avoid in hematuria (upper urinary tract bleeding risks ureteric obstruction) ²⁶²
Platelet transfusion	Only for life-threatening bleeding	Give with IVIG + steroid; consumed rapidly — not for the count alone ²⁶¹

◆ BRIDGE TO DEFINITIVE CARE

- For life-threatening bleeding (intracranial, massive GI): platelets + IVIG 1 g/kg + IV methylprednisolone + tranexamic acid together, and call hematology/critical care.²⁶¹
- Avoid IM injections, aspirin/NSAIDs and contact sport while counts are low.

▲ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — wet purpura, severe bleeding, or any diagnostic doubt.
- **Refer — now** — hematology (call) for all new severe thrombocytopenia; urgently if red flags for malignancy — do not hesitate to reach out for guidance.

New-Diagnosis Oncologic Emergencies

MINUTES

ELN 2019 · REVIEW-BASED

The child who arrives before anyone knows they have cancer — new malignancies can present with emergencies that are lethal in hours.

▲ PATTERNS TO RECOGNIZE

- **Hematologic malignancy** (5): febrile neutropenia / sepsis (functionally neutropenic despite a high WBC), hyperleukocytosis, mediastinal mass, tumor lysis syndrome, and severe coagulopathy (a subset of leukemia — APL).²⁶³
- **Solid tumors** (3): tumor lysis syndrome, mediastinal mass (by origin/location), and local effects (spinal cord compression, raised ICP).

▲ MEDIASTINAL MASS (SVC COMPRESSION SYNDROME)

- Orthopnea, stridor, facial/neck swelling and plethora, distended neck veins, cough worse when supine — often T-cell lymphoma/leukemia.²⁶³
- **Do NOT sedate or lie the child flat** and avoid general anesthesia — the airway and great vessels can collapse irreversibly. Keep **upright**, give oxygen, get an **erect** chest film / echo, and call oncology + anesthesia/critical care.²⁶³ **Always consult hematology-oncology once a mediastinal mass is identified.**
- **Getting tissue safely:** obtain the diagnosis by the least-invasive route that avoids general anesthesia — peripheral node, bone marrow, or pleural/pericardial fluid. If a procedure is unavoidable in a cooperative child, use light sedation with local/regional anesthesia and **preserve spontaneous ventilation** (avoid muscle relaxants and positive-pressure ventilation). When general anesthesia, rigid bronchoscopy, or ECMO might be needed, give **steroids** and — if the child is stable — postpone to let the mass shrink; if general anesthesia is unavoidable in moderate-to-high-risk disease, plan to escalate fast: rigid bronchoscopy, airway stent, and ECMO on standby.¹⁰⁹

▲ HYPERLEUKOCYTOSIS / LEUKOSTASIS

- WBC > 100 × 10⁹/L with headache, hypoxia, confusion, priapism or visual change.²⁶³

- Hydrate (2–3× maintenance), start **tumor-lysis** prophylaxis (see [Tumor Lysis Syndrome](#)), and **avoid red-cell transfusion** unless critically anemic — it raises viscosity. Keep platelets $\geq 20\text{--}30 \times 10^9/\text{L}$. Urgent oncology $\pm$ leukapheresis.²⁶³

COAGULOPATHY (SUSPECT APLM)

- Deranged coagulation studies in suspected leukemia are a medical emergency. Inform hematology/oncology and the hematopathologist promptly to identify **acute promyelocytic leukemia (APML)** on morphology.²⁶⁴
- If APML is identified, **All-Trans Retinoic Acid (ATRA)** is life-saving and given without delay — under hematology/oncology guidance after hematopathology confirmation.²⁶⁴

MALIGNANT SPINAL CORD COMPRESSION

- Back pain (esp. night/waking) — or **neck pain with arm weakness or numbness** when the compression is cervical — leg weakness, a sensory level, urinary retention or constipation — a neurosurgical-oncological emergency.²⁶³
- Give **dexamethasone** immediately, arrange **whole-spine MRI**, and call oncology plus the **pediatric spine service — orthopedics or neurosurgery, depending on local coverage** — outcome depends on how quickly power is preserved.²⁶³

WORKUP

- All:** CBC + differential, **peripheral blood smear**, electrolytes, renal & liver profile, **uric acid**, **LDH**, **phosphate**, **potassium**, **calcium**, and coagulation screen (tumor-lysis / DIC).²⁶³
- Mediastinal mass / SVC:** **erect + supine chest X-ray**, CT chest and echocardiogram; obtain the **least-invasive** diagnostic tissue (peripheral blood, effusion, marrow).
- Leukostasis:** WBC, coagulation, type & crossmatch; neuroimaging if neurological signs.
- Cord compression: whole-spine MRI with contrast** — do not wait for it to start dexamethasone if the deficit is progressing.²⁶³

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Dexamethasone (cord compression)	1–2 mg/kg IV once (max 10 mg), then per oncology	IV; do not delay for imaging if deficit is progressing — but confirm no undiagnosed leukemia first where possible ²⁶³
Methylprednisolone (anterior mediastinal mass)	16 mg/m ² /dose IV every 12 h if IV access is difficult, PO prednisone 20 mg/m ² /dose every 12 h	IV/PO; obtain a biopsy first if the patient's condition allows — steroids can rapidly shrink lymphoma and obscure the diagnosis. If a malignant effusion is present, it may be aspirated and sent for flow cytometry. Assess airway security before any sedation or positioning. ²⁶³
IV fluids (leukostasis / TLS)	2–3× maintenance, no potassium initially	IV; with rasburicase/allopurinol per Tumor Lysis Syndrome

⚠ TWO TRAPS

- Sedating a child with an anterior mediastinal mass for a “quick CT” or line has caused fatal airway collapse — imaging is **erect and unsedated**.
- And giving steroids before a film in possible hematological malignancy can obscure the diagnosis — coordinate with oncology.²⁶³

▶ REFER

- **Refer — now** — call pediatric oncology urgently for all of the above; involve critical care, anesthesia, neurosurgery and hematopathology as required.

10

Neonatal

NRP 2025 · AAP hyperbilirubinemia 2022

Neonatal Resuscitation

MINUTES

NRP 2025

Effective ventilation is the single most important step.

DECISION

Term? Good tone? Breathing or crying?

YES

Delayed cord clamping ≥ 60 s, dry, skin-to-skin, keep warm, monitor.²⁶⁵

NO

Warm, dry, stimulate, position airway, clear secretions if needed. SpO₂ (right hand) + ECG.

apnea / gasping / HR < 100

GOLDEN MINUTE

Start PPV within 60 s. Term 21% oxygen; preterm 21–30%. Assess for chest rise after 15 s; if none, perform MR SOPA corrective steps.²⁶⁵

HR < 60 after 30 s effective PPV

COMPRESSIONS

Coordinate 3:1 (90 compressions + 30 breaths/min), increase to 100% oxygen, ideally via a secured airway. Reassess after 60 s. **Compressions are effective only after establishing good chest rise.**²⁶⁵

HR still < 60

Give epinephrine; treat hypovolemia; reconsider airway, pneumothorax, dose, technique.²⁶⁵

Drug / fluid	Dose	Route & notes
Epinephrine (adrenaline)	IV/IO 0.02 mg/kg (0.2 mL/kg) ET 0.1 mg/kg (1 mL/kg)	0.1 mg/mL (1:10,000). IV/IO preferred; ET only while establishing access. ²⁶⁵ Repeat every 3–5 min.
Volume (saline or blood)	10 mL/kg	IV/IO, for hypovolemia ²⁶⁵

◆ **ALGORITHM** Full AHA/AAP neonatal resuscitation algorithm — cpr.heart.org



Critical CHD – Pulse Oximetry Screening

ASSESS

≥ 24 H • AAP 2025

Screen every well newborn before discharge — catches duct-dependent lesions before they collapse.

WHO & HOW TO SCREEN

- **Who:** asymptomatic infants at **≥ 24 hours** of age (or shortly before discharge if earlier), in the well-baby nursery, **not on supplemental oxygen**.²⁶⁶
- **How:** measure SpO₂ in the **right hand (pre-ductal)** and **either foot (post-ductal)**.²⁶⁶

DECISION

Result of the screen?

PASS

SpO₂ ≥ **95% in BOTH** limbs **and** ≤ 3% difference between them. Routine newborn care.²⁶⁶

IMMEDIATE FAIL

Any reading **< 90%** in either limb → straight to echocardiography.²⁶⁶

borderline

RETEST ONCE

90–94% in either/both limbs, **or** > 3% hand–foot difference → repeat **once after 1 hour** (one retest, not two).²⁶⁶ Still not passing → fail.

any fail

Urgent echocardiography — and rule out sepsis, PPHN, and respiratory causes (4–5× more common than CCHD)²⁶⁶

⚠ SCREENING DOES NOT REPLACE EXAMINATION

- It can **miss left-sided obstruction**, especially coarctation of the aorta.
- Check **femoral pulses** and four-limb saturations/blood pressure on every newborn.
- Some CCHD is not hypoxemic in the first hours — a normal screen does not exclude it.²⁶⁶
- For the lesions, presentation, and emergency management, see [Neonatal & Infant CHD](#) (Cardiac & Shock).

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — a failed screen → keep for echo; cyanosis/shock → NICU + alprostadil.
- **Home from the ward** — a passed screen with a normal exam (newborn nursery, before discharge).
- **Refer — now** — pediatric cardiology for any failed screen (echo before discharge).

◆ **SEE ALSO** Lesion recognition & management: [Neonatal & Infant CHD](#) and the [Hypercyanotic \(Tet\) Spell](#) (Cardiac & Shock).

Persistent Pulmonary Hypertension (PPHN)

MINUTES

TERM / LATE PRETERM

Labile, severe hypoxemia out of proportion to the lung disease — the circulation never made the switch.

▶ RECOGNIZE

- Severe cyanosis/desaturation **poorly responsive to oxygen**, often labile (large swings with handling).²⁶⁷
- **Differential cyanosis**: pre-ductal SpO₂ (right hand) higher than post-ductal (foot) by **> 5–10%** — right-to-left shunt across the duct.²⁶⁷
- Common settings: meconium aspiration, sepsis/pneumonia, birth asphyxia, congenital diaphragmatic hernia, or idiopathic.²⁶⁷
- Confirm by **echocardiography** — and exclude duct-dependent congenital heart disease before committing to therapy.²⁶⁷

① OPTIMIZE LUNGS, AVOID SWINGS

- **Intubate and ventilate** — recruit the lung (gentle ventilation; surfactant if parenchymal disease — meconium aspiration / RDS). **Minimal handling**, cluster cares, sedation/analgesia.
- Keep temperature, glucose, calcium, and pH normal.²⁶⁷



② TARGETS

Pre-ductal SpO₂ low-to-mid 90s, PaO₂ 55–80 mmHg (7.3–10.6 kPa). Support blood pressure and cardiac output with fluids/inotropes²⁶⁷ so systemic pressure ≥ pulmonary pressure.



③ PULMONARY VASODILATOR

- Suspected PPHN needs urgent neonatology/cardiology/PICU care; iNO, milrinone, norepinephrine, and ECMO referral are specialist-directed.²⁶⁷
- Start **inhaled nitric oxide** once the oxygenation index is ≥ 20 –25 (after lung recruitment)
- Response is a clear rise in oxygenation within ~30 min.²⁶⁸



No response with OI rising toward ~40, or refractory shock → ECMO — refer to an ECMO center early.²⁶⁷

⚠ ECHOCARDIOGRAM – ALWAYS

- A neonatal echocardiogram should **always** be performed when PPHN is suspected — to confirm the diagnosis and exclude underlying congenital heart disease; iNO can be detrimental in some CHDs.²⁶⁷

Therapy	Dose / setting	Notes
Inhaled nitric oxide	start 20 ppm	Above 20 ppm rarely adds benefit and raises methemoglobin/NO ₂ — monitor. Assess response after 20–30 min. Do not stop abruptly (rebound) ²⁶⁸
Milrinone / inotropes	specialist-directed	Support cardiac output; milrinone for left-ventricular dysfunction, in addition to its pulmonary vasodilator properties
Norepinephrine	specialist-directed	Add-on to milrinone when blood pressure drops — raises systemic vascular resistance and further lowers the pulmonary/systemic pressure ratio ²⁶⁹

◆ NOTE

- The approach above is suggested when the cause of pulmonary hypertension is **INCREASED PULMONARY VASCULAR RESISTANCE (PVR) AND** evidence of an ischemic hit is absent. Other scenarios of pulmonary hypertension are approached differently.
- A trial of **ORAL SILDENAFIL** can be attempted where iNO is not available, after specialist consultation.²⁷⁰

⚠ OXYGENATION INDEX & A KEY CONTRAINDICATION

- OI = (mean airway pressure × FiO₂ × 100) ÷ PaO₂ in mmHg. **Do not give inhaled nitric oxide in duct-dependent congenital heart disease** — confirm the heart on echo first.²⁶⁷
- Wean FiO₂ and settings slowly; sudden small drops can trigger prolonged desaturation.²⁶⁷

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → NICU/PICU.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; after weaning support, with follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — neonatology/cardiology; an ECMO center if refractory.

◆ **SEE ALSO Neonatal & Infant CHD** — exclude duct-dependent CHD before attributing cyanosis to PPHN.

Neonatal Hypoglycemia HOURS CPS 2019

Often asymptomatic — screen the at-risk, treat early, find the persistent few.

▲ RECOGNIZE & WHO TO SCREEN

- Signs are non-specific: jitteriness, poor feeding, lethargy, hypotonia, temperature instability, apnea — and, when severe, seizures. **Many affected newborns are asymptomatic, so at-risk infants must be screened.**¹⁷⁹
- Screen at-risk infants from ~2 h of age, pre-feed: infant of a diabetic mother (IDM), large- or small-for-gestational-age (LGA / SGA-IUGR), late-preterm / preterm, perinatal stress or asphyxia, hypothermia or sepsis, maternal beta-blocker, and congenital syndromes (e.g. Beckwith-Wiedemann) or midline / microphallus features (suggesting hypopituitarism).¹⁷⁹
- Confirm a low point-of-care (POC) reading with a **laboratory plasma glucose** — whole-blood / POC reads ~15% lower and falls further with processing delay — but **treat first; do not wait for the lab**¹⁷⁹.

Phase	Threshold	Meaning
Transitional — first 72 h	< 2.6 mmol/L (47 mg/dL)	The physiologic nadir is normal — catch the at-risk or persistently low infant, don't over-treat healthy transitional dips. ²⁷¹
Persistent — beyond 72 h	< 3.3 mmol/L (60 mg/dL)	Also applies to hypoglycemia first presenting after 72 h — below this warrants investigation for a hypoglycemia disorder. ^{179,271}
On IV dextrose	hold > 2.6 mmol/L (47 mg/dL)	Suspect a disorder if glucose cannot be held ¹⁷⁹ > 2.6 mmol/L on GIR 5–8 mg/kg/min.

DECISION

First 72 h — symptomatic (any level), or asymptomatic glucose < 2.6 mmol/L (47 mg/dL)?

SYMPTOMATIC, or < 1.8 mmol/L (32 mg/dL)

IV D10 mini-bolus 2 mL/kg, then infusion at 80 mL/kg/day (GIR ≈ 5.5 mg/kg/min).
Recheck in 30 min; increase the glucose supply stepwise, rechecking 30 min after each step.²⁷¹ No IV access → glucagon IM.

ASYMPTOMATIC 1.8–2.5 mmol/L (32–45 mg/dL)

Feed + buccal 40% dextrose gel 0.5 mL/kg; recheck in 30 min.^{271,272}

still 1.8–2.5 mmol/L

REPEAT ONCE

Feed ± a second buccal gel dose; recheck in 30 min.

second repeat, or symptoms appear

Start IV D10 — mini-bolus 2 mL/kg then GIR 5–8 mg/kg/min; escalate as needed.

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Dextrose 10%	2 mL/kg (200 mg/kg) bolus	IV/IO; then infusion at GIR 5–8 mg/kg/min, escalate by 2 mg/kg/min as needed. Concentrations > 12.5% need central access.
Dextrose gel 40%	0.5 mL/kg (200 mg/kg) buccal	First-line for asymptomatic; massage into buccal mucosa, then feed. May repeat once. ²⁷²
Glucagon	0.2 mg/kg (200 mcg/kg) – max 1 mg	IV bolus (CPS: 0.1–0.3 mg/kg, or infusion 10–30 mcg/kg/h), or IM/SC as a bridge when IV access is not yet available; in hyperinsulinism it typically raises glucose within 10–15 min (PES: 0.5–1 mg usually effective). ^{179,271} Watch for hyponatremia.
Diazoxide	1.7–5 mg/kg/dose PO q8h	Endocrinology-led, for confirmed hyperinsulinism; usually with chlorothiazide. Pre-treatment echo (fluid retention, pulmonary hypertension risk). ¹⁷⁹

⚠ PERSISTENT / REFRACTORY – THINK HYPERINSULINISM

Persisting beyond 48–72 h, recurring, or needing **GIR > 8–10 mg/kg/min** to stay euglycemic warrants a **critical (hypoglycemia) sample**, drawn at glucose < 2.6–2.8 mmol/L (best < 50 mg/dL) *before* correcting: plasma glucose, insulin, C-peptide, beta-hydroxybutyrate (ketones), free fatty acids, cortisol, growth hormone — plus ammonia, lactate, and an acylcarnitine profile / urine organic acids. Hyperinsulinism = inappropriately low ketones and free fatty acids with detectable insulin, a glycemic response to glucagon, and a high glucose requirement. Refer to endocrinology / metabolic.¹⁷⁹

✦ PEARLS

- Glucose is normally lowest in the first 24–72 h (transitional); the goal is to catch the at-risk or persistently low infant, not to over-treat healthy transitional dips.

- Do not discharge an at-risk infant until persistent hypoglycemia is excluded — i.e. pre-feed glucose stays above target¹⁷⁹ through a normal feed–fast cycle.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — symptomatic, persistent, or needing IV dextrose/high glucose-infusion rate.
- **Home from the ward** — transient, resolved, feeding well with stable pre-feed glucose.
- **Refer — now** — endocrinology/metabolic for persistent or recurrent hypoglycemia (hyperinsulinism workup).

Neonatal Hyperbilirubinemia

HOURS

≥ 35 WK · AAP 2022

Use total serum bilirubin against the hour- and gestation-specific nomogram.

▲ ASSESS & DECIDE

- Any jaundice under 24 h, or visible jaundice → measure bilirubin. **Transcutaneous bilirubin (TcB)** is a valid screen; **confirm with a total serum bilirubin (TSB)** when the TcB is within 3 mg/dL (50 μmol/L) of the phototherapy threshold, is ≥ 15 mg/dL (250 μmol/L), or once phototherapy has started.²⁷³ Use the **total** value against the threshold (do not subtract the direct fraction).²⁷⁴ **Severe hyperbilirubinemia** = peak TSB > 425 μmol/L (25 mg/dL) or need for exchange transfusion.²⁷³
- Thresholds for phototherapy and exchange depend on **gestational age (35–40 wk), age in hours, and neurotoxicity risk factors** — read the AAP nomogram or app each time, never a single fixed number.²⁷⁴
- **Neurotoxicity risk factors:** gestation < 38 weeks, albumin < 3.0 g/dL (30 g/L), isoimmune hemolysis (positive DAT), G6PD deficiency or other hemolysis, sepsis, clinical instability in the prior 24 h — these **lower** the threshold.²⁷⁴
- **Suspect hemolysis** when the TSB rises ≥ 5 μmol/L/h (0.3 mg/dL/h) in the first 24 h or ≥ 3.5 μmol/L/h (0.2 mg/dL/h) thereafter, or fails to respond to intensive phototherapy → CBC, reticulocytes, smear, DAT, G6PD/pyruvate-kinase assay; sepsis screen if clinically indicated.²⁷³
- **Find the cause** when the level is high or rising — hemolytic: ABO/Rh isoimmunization (DAT), G6PD deficiency, hereditary spherocytosis; non-hemolytic: cephalohematoma or bruising, polycythemia, sepsis, hypothyroidism, and breast-milk vs inadequate-breastfeeding jaundice.²⁷⁴
- **Conjugated (direct) hyperbilirubinemia is a different problem** — for neonatal cholestasis see [Neonatal Cholestasis](#) in the GI & Hepatology section.

TREAT

At/above the phototherapy line → phototherapy + feeding/hydration + find the cause.²⁷⁴

within 2 mg/dL (30 μmol/L) of the exchange line — pre-exchange zone



ESCALATION OF CARE

Intensive phototherapy + IV fluids without delay; withhold enteral feeds; urgent TSB, direct bilirubin, CBC, albumin, chemistries, type & crossmatch, hemolysis work-up; **repeat TSB every 2–3 h**; consult neonatology and prepare transfer to a unit that can perform exchange. IVIG is not routine: give 0.5–1 g/kg over 2 h (may repeat once at 12 h) for **isoimmune** hemolytic disease at the pre-exchange threshold when exchange cannot be performed promptly.^{273,274}

at/above exchange line, or encephalopathy

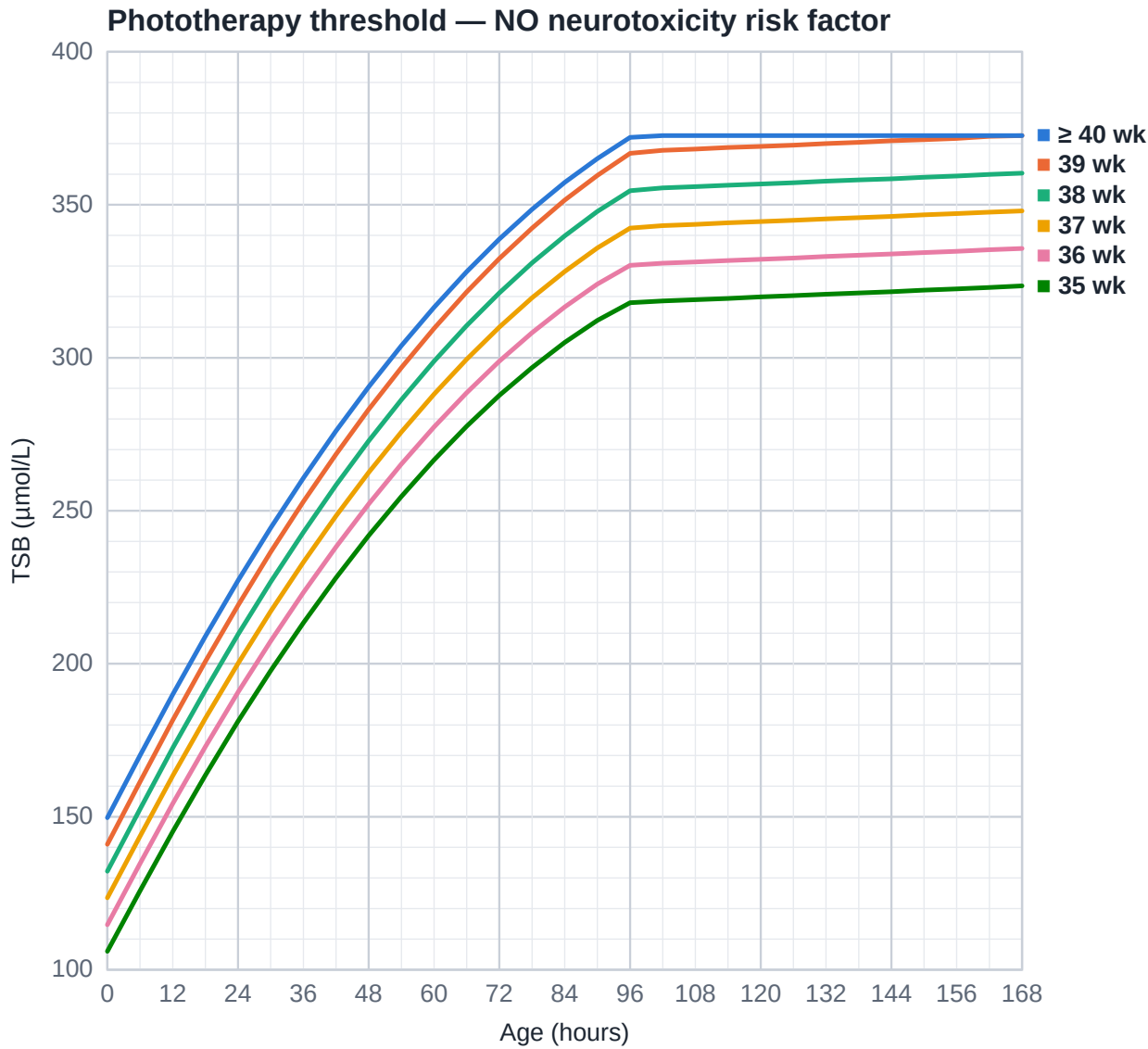
Immediate exchange transfusion for any sign of acute bilirubin encephalopathy (high tone, arching, high-pitched cry, lethargy). NICU.²⁷⁴

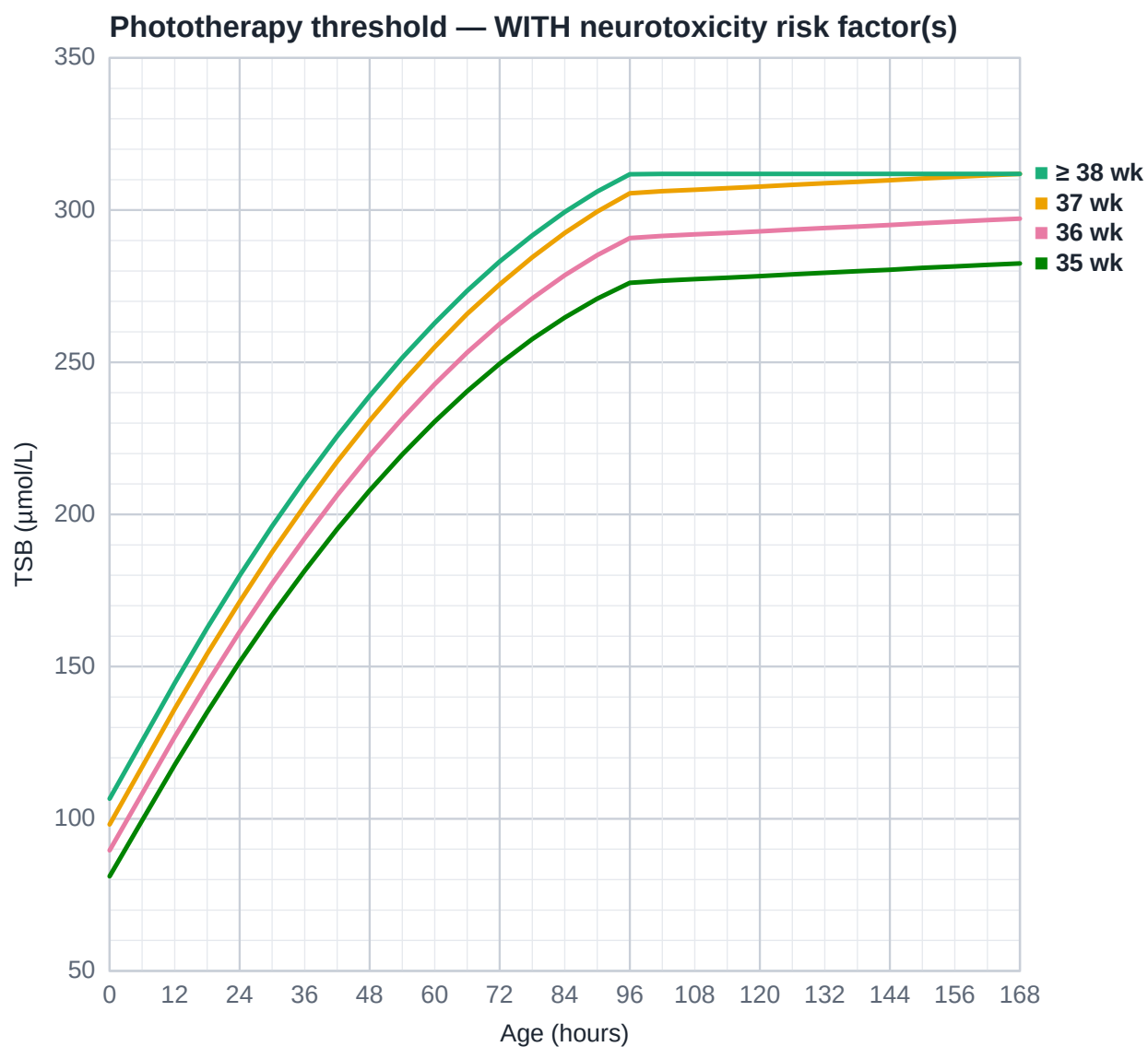
◆ NOMOGRAM & FOLLOW-UP

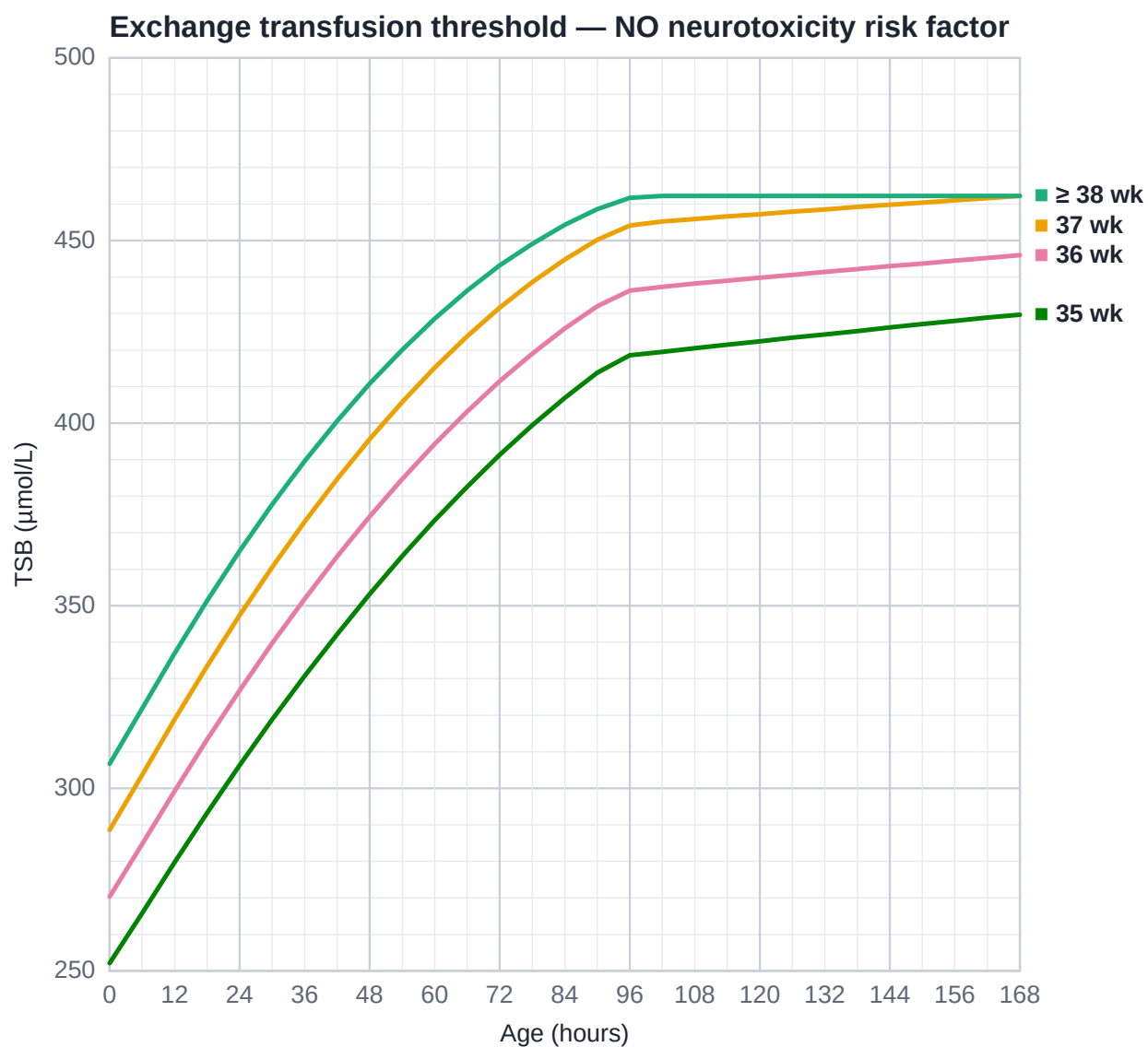
- Kuwait laboratories report bilirubin in **MMOL/L**. Plot the hour-specific total serum bilirubin on the **AAP 2022 THRESHOLD CURVES** — in $\mu\text{mol/L}$ using the **CPS 2026 FIGURES** (Figures 2–7, AAP data reproduced with permission; cps.ca)^{273,274} or the online calculators below, which accept either unit ($\div 17.1$ converts $\mu\text{mol/L}$ to mg/dL). Decision values on this card are given in both units.
- Calculators: peditools.org/bili2022  or bilitool.org .
- Before discharge, set the follow-up interval by the **GAP BETWEEN THE TSB AND THE PHOTOTHERAPY THRESHOLD**: the smaller the gap, the sooner the recheck (often within 24 hours).²⁷⁴

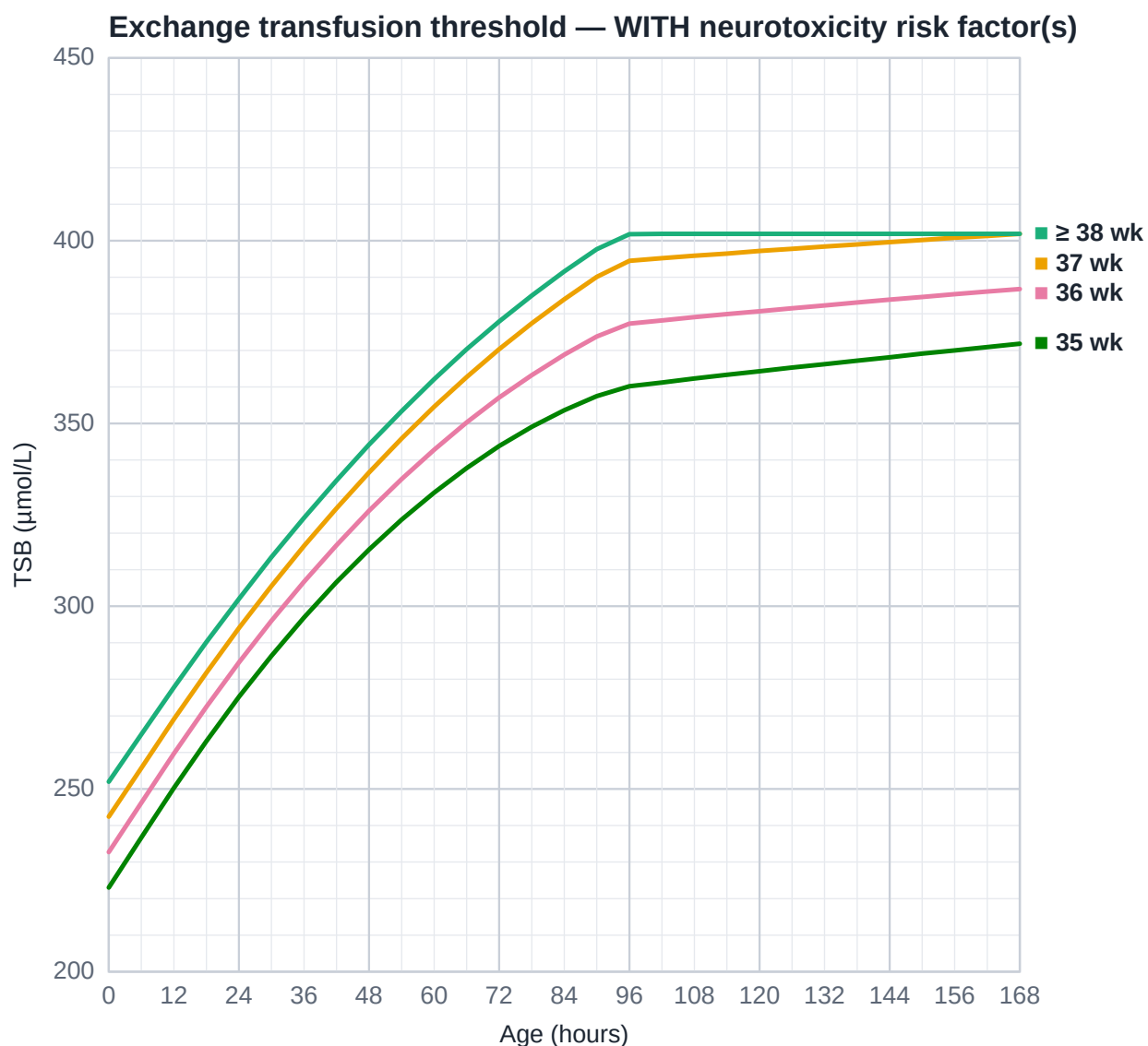
Treatment thresholds in $\mu\text{mol/L}$ – AAP 2022 curves, 35 to ≥ 40 weeks

Redrawn from the AAP 2022 hour-specific thresholds as published in $\mu\text{mol/L}$ by the Canadian Paediatric Society (2026), gridlines every 10 $\mu\text{mol/L}$ and 6 h, 0–168 h; beyond 168 h the 35–37-week lines rise by $\leq 20 \mu\text{mol/L}$ and the ≥ 38 -week lines are flat – use the calculator for days 8–14. Full text: [CPS 2026 guideline \(doi:10.1093/pch/pxaf034\)](#) · [AAP 2022 guideline \(doi:10.1542/peds.2022-058859\)](#). Neurotoxicity risk factors: albumin < 30 g/L, isoimmune or other hemolytic disease, sepsis, significant clinical instability in the preceding 24 h.^{273,274}









◆ **ΔTSB – THE “RULES OF 30” (CPS 2026)**

- **ΔTSB** = hour-specific phototherapy threshold – measured TSB or TcB (screen at ≥ 12 h of age, before discharge; TcB valid only if not on phototherapy).²⁷³
- **ΔTSB ≤ 30 μmol/L** → delay discharge: < 24 h old, consider starting phototherapy; ≥ 24 h old, repeat TSB in 4–12 h and start phototherapy if rising. **31–60** → repeat TSB in 12–24 h. **61–90** → repeat in 24–48 h. **> 90** → routine follow-up with the primary provider.²⁷³
- With neurotoxicity risk factors, phototherapy may be started when the TSB is within 30 μmol/L of the threshold.²⁷³
- **Stop phototherapy** once the TSB is > 30 μmol/L below the threshold (≥ 38 wk) or > 60 μmol/L below (35–37 wk). Re-check TSB 12–24 h after stopping for rebound (re-crossing the threshold within 72–96 h); with hemolytic disease re-check at 6–12 h, then every 24 h until the TSB is falling and ΔTSB > 60. TcB may be used ≥ 18 h after phototherapy stops.²⁷³

⚠ DON'T RELY ON A SINGLE VALUE

- Plot against time.
- A rapidly rising level, early jaundice, or hemolysis can cross thresholds fast — recheck on the interval the nomogram specifies.²⁷⁴
- TcB should **not** be used for follow-up when the baby is on phototherapy — use serum bilirubin.²⁷⁴

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — levels at/above phototherapy or exchange thresholds, or a rapid rise.
- **Home** — below threshold, feeding well, with a bilirubin-recheck plan.
- **Refer — now** — hematology for hemolysis; an exchange-capable unit near exchange thresholds.²⁷³
- **Refer — clinic — audiology** (formal hearing assessment) if peak TSB > 400 µmol/L, the pre-exchange threshold was reached, or exchange was performed; **neurodevelopmental follow-up** if the pre-exchange threshold was reached, exchange was performed, or neurological signs occurred; after immune hemolytic disease, check hemoglobin at 4–10 weeks for late anemia.²⁷³

Neonatal Sepsis – Early-Onset (rapid approach) MINUTES

Non-specific: temperature instability, poor feeding, lethargy, apnea, distress.

▶ ACT ON SUSPICION

- Septic screen (blood culture ± CSF/urine, blood count, CRP), check glucose. Start empiric antibiotics promptly — do not wait for results. Support airway/breathing/circulation; NICU.²⁷⁵

◆ EARLY- VS LATE-ONSET

Early-onset (≤ 72 h) is vertically acquired — group B *Streptococcus*, *E. coli*, *Listeria*; empiric **ampicillin + gentamicin** (below). **Late-onset (> 72 h)** is often hospital-acquired, especially in preterm infants with prolonged stays and invasive procedures (coagulase-negative staphylococci, *S. aureus*, Gram-negatives) and needs different empiric cover per your unit protocol.²⁷⁶

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Ampicillin	50 mg/kg/dose (meningitis 100 mg/kg/dose)	IV; interval by postnatal age. Use the meningitic dose if CSF not obtained or CNS involvement. ²⁷⁵
Gentamicin	4–5 mg/kg	IV (interval by gestation/age) ²⁷⁵
Cefotaxime	50 mg/kg	IV, add if meningitis suspected ⁹⁸
Acyclovir	20 mg/kg every 8 h	IV, add if herpes simplex suspected ⁹⁸

⚠ BILIOUS VOMITING IN A NEONATE

Green vomiting is **malrotation with volvulus until proven otherwise** — see Surgical.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all with risk factors or clinical signs → empiric antibiotics after cultures.
- **Home from the ward** — not until sepsis is excluded/treated; a reassuring 36–48 h course with negative cultures may stop antibiotics.
- **Refer — now** — neonatology/PICU for instability.

◆ **SEE ALSO** The neonate (≤ 28 days) is always high-risk in the febrile-infant pathway — use [Fever in the Young Infant](#) for the full age-stratified workup; this card is the neonatal-specific rapid approach.

Omphalitis & Delayed Umbilical Separation HOURS NEONATE

Red or discharging umbilical stump — treat as neonatal sepsis; watch for necrotizing fasciitis.

▴ RECOGNIZE

- Periumbilical **erythema, induration, tenderness**; purulent or malodorous discharge from the stump.²⁷⁷
- Spreading abdominal-wall cellulitis, or systemic signs (poor feeding, lethargy, temperature instability, tachycardia) = **invasive infection / sepsis**.²⁷⁸
- Uncommon with dry cord care (~1 in 1000) but can progress rapidly²⁷⁸ — treat as a neonatal emergency.
- **Risk factors:** low birth weight or prematurity, prolonged rupture of membranes or maternal infection, non-sterile or home delivery, umbilical catheterization, and unclean cord practices (e.g., cow-dung application — also a tetanus risk). Onset is typically around day 3.²⁷⁷

⚠ RED FLAGS → NECROTIZING FASCIITIS / MYONECROSIS (SURGICAL EMERGENCY)

- Pain or tenderness out of proportion, rapidly spreading or **dusky / bullous** skin, crepitus, peau-d'orange edema, systemic toxicity.
- It can deteriorate fast despite mild initial findings — reassess often and mark the margins.
- Any of these → **urgent pediatric surgery for debridement**; do not delay for imaging.²⁷⁸
- Debridement resects the umbilical vein, both arteries, and any urachal remnant (even if they look normal); reported mortality is high (~60–85%), so err toward early surgical exploration in the critically ill infant.²⁷⁸

INVESTIGATE & TREAT

- Blood culture (+ discharge swab), CBC, CRP; full neonatal sepsis workup.

- Start IV antibiotics **immediately** — cover staphylococci (incl. MRSA), group A Streptococcus, Gram-negatives (E. coli, Klebsiella, Proteus) and anaerobes (Bacteroides, Clostridium); the exact regimen follows the local antibiogram and neonatal formulary.²⁷⁷
- If systemic: keep nil by mouth (septic ileus), IV fluids / parenteral nutrition; manage as neonatal sepsis.

EMPIRIC IV ANTIBIOTICS – DOSES SHOWN ARE GENERAL PEDIATRIC (PER DOSE · INTERVAL); ADJUST FOR NEONATES BY GESTATIONAL/POSTNATAL AGE AND FOR HEPATIC/RENAL IMPAIRMENT; CONFIRM AGAINST THE LOCAL FORMULARY AND ANTIMIOGRAM

Drug	Dose (per dose · interval)	Role
Cefotaxime	50 mg/kg/dose q6h	Gram-negative cover
+ Cefazolin	33–50 mg/kg/dose q8h	Gram-positive (MSSA) — use vancomycin where MRSA is prevalent
± Metronidazole	7.5–10 mg/kg/dose q6–8h	Add for anaerobes — foul discharge or maternal chorioamnionitis
Meropenem	40 mg/kg/dose q8h	OR (severe cases) — alternative for necrotizing fasciitis (with vancomycin + clindamycin)
± Vancomycin	15 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 1 g/dose)	Where MRSA is prevalent; monitor levels
± Clindamycin	5–10 mg/kg/dose q6–8h	Necrotizing fasciitis (antitoxin effect)

◆ DURATION

- About 7 days for uncomplicated periumbilical cellulitis; 10–14 days IV with bacteremia or sepsis; 14–21 days if meningitis; prolonged and surgically-guided in necrotizing fasciitis (local practice — not guideline-stated).
- Tailor to cultures, susceptibilities, and clinical response — older infants may step down to oral once clearly improving.

◆ DELAYED UMBILICAL SEPARATION

- Normal separation is by ~2 weeks (range 3–45 days, mean ~10 days); antiseptic cord care delays it versus dry care, so a **well** infant is usually benign.
- Not off by **3–4 weeks** = delayed (up to ~10% of newborns). ⚠ **Suspect leukocyte adhesion deficiency (LAD)** if delayed separation + omphalitis or soft-tissue infection that forms **no pus** + persistent marked leukocytosis without infection (often 40–60 ×10⁹/L) + poor wound healing → **consult immunology whenever LAD is suspected**. There is a growing group of LAD syndromes with variable defects; normal expression of CD18 alone is not sufficient to exclude LAD-1 — functional assays must be performed if clinical suspicion is high.²⁷⁷
- Most isolated delay in a well infant with a normal white count is **not** LAD.²⁷⁷
- Other causes: a patent urachus or omphalomesenteric duct (see below), factor XIII deficiency (stump bleeding).

UMBILICAL GRANULOMA

- Moist pink granulation after separation → silver-nitrate cautery (protect surrounding skin) or topical salt.
- Refer if persistent discharge or a polyp suggests a duct remnant.²⁷⁷

⚠ DON'T MISS – PATENT DUCT REMNANTS

- **Patent omphalomesenteric (vitelline) duct** = persistent ileum-to-umbilicus connection; **patent urachus** = bladder-to-umbilicus. Both present after cord separation with intermittent umbilical drainage: **small-bowel contents** (omphalomesenteric duct) or **clear urine-like fluid, more with crying or voiding** (urachus).^{279,280}
- A sinus or small opening may be visible at the umbilical base; **ultrasound** may show a tubular structure extending deep to the umbilicus. If an opening is present it can be cannulated for a **sinogram/fistulogram** to demonstrate communication with the ileum or bladder.^{280,281}
- Other remnants that mimic granuloma: **umbilical polyp** (bright-red, mucosa-covered, does not respond to silver nitrate — ectopic ileal/gastric mucosa) and urachal or omphalomesenteric **cyst/sinus** (persistent wetness, infected periumbilical mass).²⁸²
- ► **Refer all to pediatric surgery** — prolapsed bowel through a patent omphalomesenteric duct is a surgical emergency; small urachal remnants often close spontaneously in infancy, so excision is decided by the surgeon.^{280,281}

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → IV antibiotics (neonatal-sepsis pathway).
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; complete the IV course — older infants may step down to oral.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery for necrotizing fasciitis.
- **Refer — clinic** — pediatric surgery for a suspected duct remnant; immunology for suspected leukocyte adhesion deficiency.

Necrotizing Enterocolitis HOURS Modified Bell

Preterm or stressed neonate: feeding intolerance, distension, bloody stools.

▴ RECOGNIZE

- Feeding intolerance, bilious or rising gastric residuals, **abdominal distension and tenderness**, bloody stools.²⁸³
- Systemic: lethargy, apnea, temperature instability, shock. Mostly preterm (onset often the 2nd–4th week, later at lower gestation); term infants with congenital heart disease or asphyxia are also at risk.²⁸³

- Risk rises with prematurity and formula feeding; human (breast) milk and standardized feeding protocols are protective.²⁸³

CONFIRM

- Abdominal X-ray (supine + left-lateral decubitus): **pneumatosis intestinalis** (intramural gas — the radiologic hallmark), portal venous gas, a persistent fixed dilated loop, or free air.²⁸⁴
- Bloods: CBC, CRP, blood gas, lactate, blood culture, coagulation, electrolytes.
- Bowel ultrasound (wall thickness/perfusion, free fluid) is a useful adjunct.²⁸⁵
- Repeat X-ray every 6 h while acute.²⁸⁴

Modified Bell stage	Findings	Bowel rest + antibiotics
I — Suspected	Nonspecific signs (apnea, temperature instability), distension, occult or gross blood X-ray normal or ileus	NPO + NG drainage ~3 days; stop antibiotics if NEC is excluded ²⁸⁴
II — Definite (proven)	Above + absent bowel sounds ± tenderness pneumatosis ± portal venous gas (IIB: metabolic acidosis, thrombocytopenia) ²⁸⁴	NPO + NG ~7–10 days; antibiotics 7–10 days
III — Advanced	Critically ill: shock, acidosis, DIC, peritonitis. IIIA bowel intact IIIB perforated (pneumoperitoneum) ²⁸⁴	NPO + NG ~14 days; antibiotics 14 days; surgery

TREAT

- Stop enteral feeds (NPO), nasogastric tube on free drainage, IV fluids and parenteral nutrition.
- Broad-spectrum IV antibiotics²⁸³ covering Gram-negatives and anaerobes — e.g. ampicillin + gentamicin + metronidazole (or piperacillin-tazobactam); add vancomycin if a central line or a resistant organism is suspected (regimen per local practice).
- Correct acidosis, thrombocytopenia, and coagulopathy; support blood pressure.
- Serial exams and X-rays.
- **Surgical consultation** if no improvement or signs of perforation are present.

⚠ SURGERY NOW

Pneumoperitoneum (perforation) is an absolute indication. Also: deterioration despite maximal medical therapy, a fixed dilated loop, abdominal-wall erythema, a palpable mass, or a positive paracentesis (stool / bile / pus). Options: laparotomy with resection, or a primary peritoneal drain in the unstable extremely-low-birth-weight infant²⁸³ — in the NEST trial laparotomy was favored when the preoperative diagnosis was NEC rather than isolated perforation.²⁸⁶

✦ PEARLS

- **Pneumatosis intestinalis is the radiologic hallmark**; portal venous gas signals more extensive disease and a worse prognosis.²⁸³

- **Spontaneous intestinal perforation (SIP) is a distinct entity** — earlier onset (first week), often after indomethacin or steroids, a focal perforation with *no* pneumatosis; treat with anaerobe-covering antibiotics (~7 days) plus drainage or laparotomy.²⁸³

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → NICU, nil by mouth, gut decompression, antibiotics.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; after recovery, with feeding advice.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery (perforation or deterioration).

Neonatal Seizures

MINUTES

ILAE 2023

Often subtle — and often a treatable cause behind them.

▲ RECOGNIZE & CONFIRM

- Subtle signs: lip-smacking, cycling or pedaling, eye deviation, apnea, focal clonic or tonic movements.²⁸⁷
- **Only focal clonic and focal tonic seizures can be diagnosed clinically** — all other types need EEG or amplitude-integrated EEG (aEEG) to confirm. Electrographic-only seizures are common, especially after the first drug (electroclinical dissociation), so monitor with EEG and **treat electrographic seizures**.²⁸⁷
- Common causes: hypoxic-ischemic encephalopathy (most common), stroke, intracranial hemorrhage, infection / meningitis, metabolic (low glucose, calcium, sodium, magnesium), inborn errors, and genetic or structural epilepsies.²⁸⁷

FIND THE CAUSE

- Glucose, calcium, magnesium, sodium; blood gas, lactate, ammonia.
- Sepsis screen including lumbar puncture, with **CSF HSV PCR** (start empiric IV acyclovir if neonatal HSV is possible)²⁸⁷
- Cranial ultrasound, then MRI. If unexplained: metabolic work-up (plasma amino acids, urine organic acids, CSF glucose / lactate / glycine) and genetic testing for early-onset epilepsy (e.g. KCNQ2, SCN2A). **Correct reversible causes first** — refractory hypocalcemia is often driven by low magnesium.²⁸⁷

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Phenobarbital	20 mg/kg IV load (further 10–20 mg/kg to ~40 mg/kg total)	First-line regardless of etiology (superior to levetiracetam, NEOLEV2). Use the shortest course; discontinue early once acute provoked seizures are controlled. ²⁸⁸
Levetiracetam	40–60 mg/kg (max 4.5 g)	IV; second-line — preferred when there is cardiac disease. ²⁸⁷
Phenytoin / fosphenytoin	20 mg/kg (PE)	IV; second-line; favored for suspected sodium-channelopathy (e.g. KCNQ2, SCN2A). ²⁸⁷

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Midazolam infusion	0.05–0.4 mg/kg/h (after 0.2 mg/kg load)	IV; refractory seizures. ²⁸⁷
Lidocaine (lignocaine)	specialist infusion (load, then taper)	IV; refractory. Avoid with phenytoin and in cardiac disease (proarrhythmic). ²⁸⁷
Pyridoxine	100 mg IV	Trial under EEG + cardiorespiratory monitoring (apnea / cerebral depression); for vitamin B6-dependent epilepsy or unexplained refractory seizures.
Pyridoxal-5-phosphate (PLP)	30 mg/kg/day ÷ doses	If pyridoxine fails and PNPO deficiency is suspected.
Folinic acid	3–5 mg/kg/day	Add-on for pyridoxine-dependent epilepsy with incomplete response.
Dextrose 10% / calcium gluconate 10% / magnesium sulfate	2 mL/kg / 0.5–1 mL/kg slow / 0.1–0.2 mmol/kg	IV; correct hypoglycemia, hypocalcemia, hypomagnesemia.

✦ PEARLS

- **Phenobarbital remains first-line** (superior to levetiracetam for electrographic control, NEOLEV2 RCT), but use the shortest course and **stop early** once acute provoked seizures are controlled — often before discharge.²⁸⁸
- Refractory with no cause found: trial **pyridoxine**, then **pyridoxal-5-phosphate** if PNPO is suspected, then add **folinic acid** — these treat vitamin-responsive epilepsies that anticonvulsants miss.²⁸⁷

⚠ JITTERY IS NOT SEIZING

- Jitteriness stops with gentle holding and has no eye or autonomic features; true seizures do not stop with restraint.²⁸⁷
- Don't miss glucose, calcium, magnesium, or infection.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → NICU with monitoring/aEEG.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; under neurology with a plan.
- **Refer** — now — neurology and metabolic/genetics for the cause.

Vitamin K Deficiency Bleeding (VKDB)

MINUTES

AAP 2022

Preventable with one injection at birth — the late form presents as catastrophic intracranial hemorrhage.

RECOGNIZE (THREE WINDOWS)

- **Early** (0–24 h) — usually maternal enzyme-inducing drugs (anticonvulsants, rifampicin, warfarin).²⁸⁹
- **Classic** (day 2–7) — bruising, GI or umbilical bleeding in a baby who missed prophylaxis.²⁸⁹
- **Late** (2–12 weeks) — exclusively breastfed, no/oral-only prophylaxis, or malabsorption/cholestasis; up to half present with **intracranial hemorrhage** (bulging fontanelle, seizures, pallor, poor feeding).²⁸⁹

ANY BLEEDING NEONATE

- Check a coagulation screen (prolonged PT/aPTT with normal platelets and fibrinogen suggests VKDB), give vitamin K without waiting for confirmation, and image the brain if any neurological sign.²⁸⁹
- Investigate for **cholestasis/malabsorption** in late VKDB.²⁸⁹

WORKUP

- **Coagulation screen** — **prolonged PT** (most sensitive) and aPTT with **normal platelets and fibrinogen** (distinguishes from DIC); rapid correction after vitamin K confirms.²⁸⁹
- CBC / film.
- **Neuroimaging** (cranial ultrasound / CT) if any neurological sign — late VKDB commonly presents as intracranial hemorrhage.²⁸⁹

Setting	Dose	Route & notes
Prophylaxis at birth	Phytonadione (vitamin K ₁) 1 mg (0.5 mg if < 1500 g)	IM — single dose; the reliable route ²⁸⁹
Active bleeding	Vitamin K ₁ 1–2 mg slow IV (formulary dosing) ⁴²	Plus FFP or prothrombin complex concentrate for serious/intracranial bleeding (expert practice — not addressed by the AAP prophylaxis statement)

COUNSELING

- IM prophylaxis at birth prevents both classic and late VKDB; purely oral regimens are less protective, especially in breastfed infants and cholestasis.²⁸⁹
- Reinforce with families who decline the injection.

ADMIT • REFER

- **Admit** — any bleeding neonate; PICU/neurosurgery for intracranial hemorrhage.

- **Refer — now** — gastroenterology if underlying cholestasis/malabsorption.

Neonatal Abstinence Syndrome

ASSESS

ESC-NOW • NEJM 2023

The jittery, inconsolable, poorly feeding newborn after in-utero drug exposure.

RECOGNIZE

- Tremors/jitteriness, irritability and a high-pitched cry, hypertonia, poor feeding/uncoordinated suck, vomiting/loose stools, sweating, sneezing, and disturbed sleep — typically within the first days after opioid exposure (later for long-acting agents).²⁹⁰

⚠️ EXCLUDE MIMICS; WATCH FOR SEIZURES

Hypoglycemia, sepsis, hypocalcemia, hyperthyroidism and hypoxic-ischemic encephalopathy can look similar — check them. **Seizures** occur in severe withdrawal and warrant pharmacological treatment and escalation.²⁹¹

✦ NON-PHARMACOLOGICAL CARE FIRST

- The **Eat-Sleep-Console** approach — rooming-in, breastfeeding where appropriate, swaddling, low stimulation, skin-to-skin — reduces the need for medication and shortens stay.²⁹⁰
- Reserve opioids (morphine or methadone) for infants who cannot feed, sleep or be consoled despite optimal supportive care.²⁹⁰

WORKUP

- Primarily **clinical** — the **Eat-Sleep-Console** assessment (feeds $\geq$ 1 oz / breastfeeds · sleeps $\geq$ 1 h · consoled $\leq$ 10 min).
- Confirm exposure with **maternal history + maternal/infant toxicology** (urine, meconium, or umbilical cord).²⁹¹
- Exclude mimics: glucose, calcium, sepsis screen and thyroid studies as indicated.

ADMIT • REFER

- **Admit** — admit/observe for scoring; escalate if seizures or failure of supportive care.
- **Refer — now** — neonatology, social work and safeguarding as indicated.

Neonatal Dosing by Corrected Age (PMA) DOSING

Lexicomp • confirm against unit formulary

The dose per kg barely changes — corrected age changes the **interval**.

THE ONE IDEA

- **Postmenstrual age (PMA) = gestational age at birth + weeks since birth.**²⁹² Immature kidneys clear renally-eliminated drugs slowly, so the more premature the baby and the younger the postnatal age, the **longer the interval** between doses.^{293,294}
- For aminoglycosides and vancomycin, the dose stays roughly the same per kg while the gap between doses stretches.⁴²

△ LEVELS GOVERN, NOT A FIXED SCHEDULE

- Any published regimen is a **starting point** only.^{295,296}
- After the first doses, the **drug level** sets the interval for gentamicin, amikacin and vancomycin — draw a trough just before the next dose and do not give it until the level is acceptable. **Extend the interval (do not cut the dose)** for renal impairment / oliguria, perinatal asphyxia or therapeutic cooling, and concurrent indomethacin / ibuprofen or vancomycin.⁴²
- Confirm every value against your unit's formulary and a live NeoFax / BNF for Children.^{297,298}

DOSES – USE A NEONATAL REFERENCE

- Neonatal and premature dosing is **PMA- and postnatal-age-dependent**, and aminoglycoside/vancomycin regimens are titrated to **drug levels** — so specific doses and intervals are **not reproduced here**.^{293,294,295}
- Use a maintained neonatal dosing reference — **NeoFax, Lexicomp**, or the **BNF for Children** — for gentamicin, amikacin, vancomycin and β -lactam dosing by PMA and postnatal age, and confirm every value against your **unit protocol / NICU formulary**.^{42,297,298}

◆ **EMPIRIC EARLY-ONSET SEPSIS — AMPICILLIN + GENTAMICIN** (ampicillin covers group B *Streptococcus* and *Listeria*; gentamicin adds Gram-negative cover and synergy). Avoid ceftriaxone in neonates (bilirubin displacement, calcium precipitation).^{27,275} **AAP 2018 • FDA label**

✦ CAFFEINE CITRATE – THE QUINTESSENTIAL NEONATAL DRUG

- Apnea of prematurity: **load 20 mg/kg**, then **5 mg/kg once daily** maintenance (up to 10 mg/kg/day for refractory apnea).²⁹⁹
- Always prescribe as **citrate** — caffeine base is half the number (20 mg citrate = 10 mg base).²⁹⁹ **Caffeine • CAP trial**

Convulsive Status Epilepticus (> 1 month of age) MINUTESSeizure $\geq$ 5 minutes or repeated without recovery — treat by the clock.**0–5 MIN · STABILIZE (CLOCK STARTS AT SEIZURE ONSET)**

- **Time is counted from the start of the seizure, not from arrival.** A child who reaches you already seizing $\geq$ 5 min gets the benzodiazepine **immediately** — airway, oxygen and IV/IO access proceed **in parallel**, never before the drug.^{300,301}
- Airway + oxygen 10–15 L/min via non-rebreather mask · IV/IO · monitor.
- **Check glucose** (treat if low); send sodium, calcium, magnesium, glucose.³⁰⁰

5 min from onset · 1st line

BENZODIAZEPINE – MAY REPEAT ONCE AFTER 5 MINLorazepam IV/IO, or diazepam IV/IO; **no IV access → do not wait for one:** intramuscular midazolam (preferred), buccal/intranasal midazolam, or **rectal diazepam**.^{300,301}

~15–20 min · 2nd line

ESETT: THE THREE ARE EQUALLY EFFECTIVE**Levetiracetam** (preferred — fewer side effects and easy administration), valproate, or fosphenytoin/phenytoin (phenobarbital is an alternative).³⁰²

~40 min · refractory

3RD LINE · PICU Refractory status epilepticus: urgent PICU/anesthesia/neurology (anesthetic infusion, continuous EEG, find the cause). Intubation is a team decision whenever needed — not reserved for this step.³⁰³

FIRST LINE – BENZODIAZEPINES

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Lorazepam	0.1 mg/kg (max 4 mg)	IV/IO
Diazepam	0.2–0.3 mg/kg (max 10 mg) IV/IO · rectal 0.5 mg/kg (max 20 mg)	IV/IO; rectal when there is no IV access — an accepted first-line route ³⁰⁰
Midazolam	0.1 mg/kg IV (max 4 mg) 0.2 mg/kg IM/buccal/intranasal (max 10 mg)	IM/buccal/intranasal preferred when no IV access ³⁰⁰

SECOND LINE – CHOOSE ONE

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Levetiracetam	40–60 mg/kg (max 4.5 g)	IV; often preferred for safety ³⁰²
Valproate	40 mg/kg (max 3 g)	IV; avoid if metabolic/mitochondrial disease or liver failure suspected. Avoid in suspected mitochondrial/POLG disease, significant liver disease, or thrombocytopenia/coagulopathy ³⁰²
Fosphenytoin	20 mg PE/kg (max 1.5 g)	IV (PE = phenytoin equivalents)
Phenytoin	20 mg/kg (max 1.5 g)	IV slow, cardiac monitoring — use if fosphenytoin unstocked
Phenobarbital	15–20 mg/kg IV	Alternative second-line; monitor for respiratory depression and hypotension

◆ DRAVET SYNDROME

- Known/suspected Dravet syndrome (prolonged febrile hemiclonic seizures in infancy): prefer **LEVETIRACETAM** or **VALPROATE**; sodium-channel blockers (phenytoin/fosphenytoin) are avoided as **MAINTENANCE** but are **NOT** contraindicated for acute status epilepticus.³⁰³
- Phenobarbital is an alternative.

THIRD LINE – REFRACTORY (PICU)

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Midazolam infusion	0.2 mg/kg load → 0.05–0.4 mg/kg/h	IV; titrate to EEG ³⁰³
Ketamine / thiopental / propofol	specialist dosing	IV infusion titrated to EEG; propofol short-term only (propofol infusion syndrome — monitor labs) ³⁰³
Pyridoxine	100 mg IV	Trial in refractory seizures in infants ³⁰³ < 2 yr
Dextrose 10% (if low glucose)	2 mL/kg	IV/IO

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- Admit** — all → monitored bed; refractory or needing infusions → PICU.
- Home from the ward** — not from the acute episode; a first seizure that stops may go home after workup, neurology follow-up.
- Refer — now** — neurology (EEG, cause); **PICU for refractory status, or airway/hemodynamic compromise.**

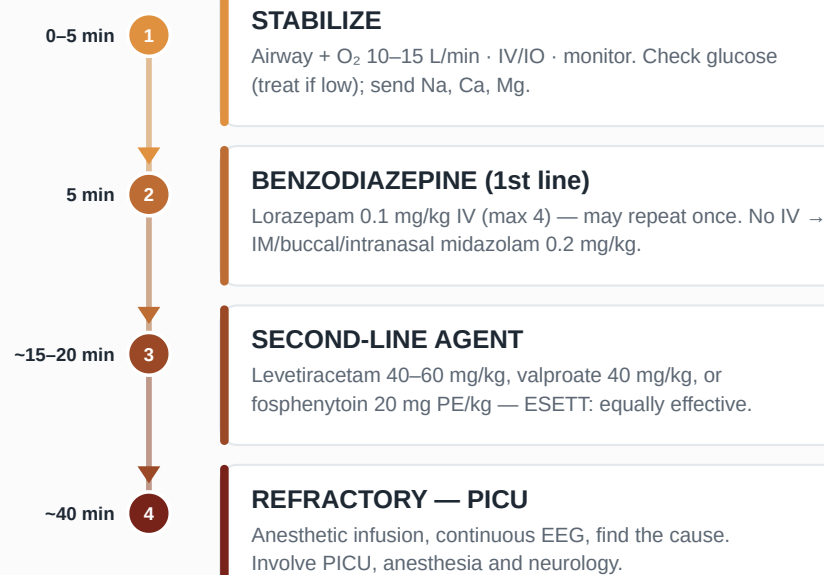
Convulsive status epilepticus – treat by the clock

Stabilize → benzodiazepine at 5 min → second-line at ~20 min → refractory (PICU) at ~40 min.



SEIZURE ≥ 5 MIN = STATUS EPILEPTICUS

Two benzodiazepine doses maximum, then move to second-line — don't keep repeating.



Febrile Seizure

HOURS

6 MO–5 YR

Seizure with fever, no CNS infection or prior afebrile seizure, and no pre-existing neurologic abnormality.

▀ SIMPLE VS COMPLEX

- **Simple:** generalized, under 15 minutes, once in 24 hours — benign; reassure, treat the fever source, antipyretics for comfort; no routine EEG, imaging, or LP.³⁰⁴
- **Complex:** focal, over 15 minutes, or recurs within 24 hours — evaluate more carefully.³⁰⁴

✦ PEARL – NOT A SIMPLE FEBRILE SEIZURE

- Not a simple febrile seizure if any are present: **focal** features, duration **> 15 min** or recurrence within 24 h (complex), age **< 6 months or > 6 years**, incomplete recovery, or a child unwell between events.³⁰⁴
- A febrile seizure is, by definition, a seizure with fever in a child **without** CNS infection, metabolic disturbance, or prior afebrile seizures.³⁰⁵ When any of the features above is present, **exclude those first** — meningitis/encephalitis (see **Bacterial Meningitis & Encephalitis**), hypoglycemia, electrolyte disturbance, and an underlying (non-febrile) epilepsy — before labeling it a *complex febrile seizure*.

▲ LOWER THE THRESHOLD FOR LUMBAR PUNCTURE

- Consider meningitis with any meningism or history/exam suggesting CNS infection; in an infant 6–12 months **under-immunized against Hib or pneumococcus** (or of unknown immunization status); or in a child **pretreated with antibiotics** (may mask meningitis).³⁰⁴
- Age < 12 months alone is no longer an indication — AAP 2011 replaced the 1996 advice to “strongly consider” LP in every infant under 12 months; LP is now an *option* only for the under-immunized 6–12-month-old or the antibiotic-pretreated child.³⁰⁴
- A seizure lasting ≥ 5 minutes is status epilepticus (see [Convulsive Status Epilepticus](#)) — treat as above.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — complex features, prolonged/focal, incomplete recovery, or a source needing admission.
- **Home from the emergency department** — simple febrile seizure, well child, normal exam, reliable carers with safety-net advice.
- **Refer — now** — neurology only for complex, recurrent, or atypical seizures — not routine for simple febrile seizures.

Bacterial Meningitis & Encephalitis

MINUTES

> 2 MO

Fever plus altered consciousness, neck stiffness, or a bulging fontanelle — do the LP first, but never delay antibiotics for it.

▲ RECOGNIZE & ACT

- **Infants (non-specific):** fever, poor feeding, lethargy or decreased interaction, vomiting, irritability, $\pm$ rash; inconsolable or worsening irritability with progressive lethargy are red flags. **Nuchal rigidity is uncommon in infants.**³⁰⁶
- **Older children:** headache, neck pain/stiffness, photophobia, vomiting, impaired consciousness, seizures, **non-blanching rash.**¹¹⁴
- Take **blood cultures** (weight-based volumes), then give **empiric IV antibiotics immediately** — do not delay if LP is deferred.³⁰⁷
- Add **acyclovir** if encephalitis features (behavior change, focal neurology, seizures).
Encephalitis criteria: altered mental status ≥ 24 h plus ≥ 2 of — fever, new seizures, focal neurology, CSF pleocytosis, abnormal neuroimaging, or abnormal EEG.³⁰⁸
- Watch for **SIADH** and **raised ICP** (see [Raised ICP](#)).

◆ BACTERIAL MENINGITIS SCORE – CSF PLEOCYTOSIS IN A WELL CHILD

- **Use only if** age $\geq$ 2 months, previously healthy, CSF white cells $\geq$ 10 cells/ μ L, and no antibiotics in the 72 h before the LP.³⁰⁹
- **Do not use** if critically ill (severely altered consciousness, signs of herniation, needs respiratory or blood-pressure support), purpura, ventricular shunt or recent neurosurgery, immunosuppression, or another bacterial infection that needs inpatient antibiotics.³⁰⁹

Criterion	Points
CSF Gram stain positive	2
CSF neutrophils $\geq$ 1,000 cells/ μ L	1
CSF protein $\geq$ 80 mg/dL ($\geq$ 0.8 g/L)	1
Blood neutrophils $\geq$ 10,000 cells/ μ L ($\geq$ 10×10^9 /L)	1
Seizure before or at presentation	1 ³¹⁰

- **Score 0 $\rightarrow$ very low risk:** bacterial meningitis in 0.1% (sensitivity 98.3%, negative predictive value 99.9%; 3,295 children); pooled sensitivity 99.3% across 8 validation studies. Outpatient care may be considered.^{309,310,311}
- **Score $\geq$ 1 $\rightarrow$ not low risk:** manage as bacterial meningitis — admit and give empiric antibiotics until cultures are back.³⁰⁹
- **Not for infants < 2 months:** both bacterial cases missed in the validation study were younger than 2 months; in infants $\leq$ 60 days the score's specificity is 1.6%.^{309,312}

EMPIRIC & TARGETED THERAPY – MENINGITIC DOSES

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Ceftriaxone	50 mg/kg/dose q12h (or 100 mg/kg/dose once daily; max 4 g/day (2 g/dose if q12h))	IV (IM if IV not immediate); first-line empiric. Covers <i>S. pneumoniae</i> , <i>N. meningitidis</i> , <i>H. influenzae</i> . ³⁰⁷
Cefotaxime	50–75 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 3 g/dose)	IV; alternative to ceftriaxone — preferred in neonates . ³⁰⁶
Vancomycin	15–20 mg/kg/dose q6h target trough 15–20 mg/L for CNS infection ³⁰⁷ ; current consensus prefers AUC-guided dosing (AUC/MIC 400–600). ³¹³ (max 1 g/dose)	IV; add empirically for possible cephalosporin-resistant pneumococcus. ³⁰⁷
Ampicillin	75 mg/kg/dose q6h (or 50 mg/kg/dose q4h; max 12 g/day)	IV; add for <i>Listeria</i> in neonates / immunocompromised / at risk. ³⁰⁶
Meropenem	40 mg/kg/dose q8h (max 2 g/dose)	IV; alternative if a 3rd-gen cephalosporin is contraindicated — get ID advice.

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Dexamethasone	0.15 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 10 mg/dose)	IV; within 4 h of the first antibiotic — see steroid note. Not in neonates. ³⁰⁷
Acyclovir	≤ 4 mo: use neonatal HSV dosing (20 mg/kg/dose every 8 h). > 4 mo–< 12 y: 15–20 mg/kg/dose every 8 h (Red Book target 20; balance against nephrotoxicity). ≥ 12 y: 10 mg/kg/dose every 8 h. Duration 21 days (CNS)	IV, infuse over 1 h with adequate hydration + renal monitoring; add if HSV encephalitis suspected. Beyond the neonatal period the higher 20 mg/kg dose is not routine — increased neurotoxicity / nephrotoxicity (Lexicomp). ⁹⁸

◆ DURATION BY PATHOGEN

- N. meningitidis and H. influenzae 7 days; S. pneumoniae 10–14 days; group B Streptococcus 14–21 days; Listeria ≥ 21 days; aerobic Gram-negative bacilli 21 days (or ≥ 2 weeks after the first sterile CSF in neonates) — confirm the final duration with infectious diseases.³⁰⁷
- Confirm the pathogen and tailor to response.

◆ STEROIDS – DEXAMETHASONE

- Give 0.15 mg/kg/dose q6h just before, with, or **within 4 h** of the first antibiotic (earlier is better). **Continue 4 days if Hib or S. pneumoniae** is confirmed.
- Reduces hearing loss, especially in Hib.³⁰⁷

DURATION, TARGETED THERAPY & FOLLOW-UP

- When susceptibilities return, narrow therapy (penicillin-susceptible pneumococcus or meningococcus → penicillin G or ampicillin; GBS → penicillin/ampicillin + gentamicin). **IV duration:** *S. pneumoniae* 10–14 d
- Hib 7–10 d
- *N. meningitidis* 5–7 d
- GBS 14–21 d (longer if cerebritis/ventriculitis). **Formal audiology before discharge** for every child.³⁰⁶
- Repeat LP is not routine — reserve it for failure to improve, resistant pneumococcus, or selected neonates/complex cases after ID advice; also repeat the LP near the end of therapy for confirmed HSV CNS disease in young infants (to document a negative CSF HSV PCR).⁹⁸
- Arrange **chemoprophylaxis** for close contacts of meningococcal (and Hib per criteria) via public health.^{98,314}

⚠ DEFER THE LP (BUT NEVER THE ANTIBIOTICS) IF

- reduced or fluctuating consciousness, focal signs, signs of raised ICP, coagulopathy, or skin infection over the site (stabilize a cardiorespiratorily unstable child before any imaging) — image (contrast CT and/or MRI) first.³⁰⁷
- A purpuric / non-blanching rash with fever is meningococcal sepsis until proven otherwise¹¹⁴ (see [The Rash](#), [Septic Shock](#)).

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → hospital; reduced consciousness, shock, seizures, or raised ICP → PICU.
- **Home from the ward** — not from the acute illness; complete the course with audiology and neurodevelopmental follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — infectious diseases/neurology; PICU for complications; public health for notification and contact prophylaxis.

Brain Tumor – New Presentation

HOURS

HeadSmart / RCPCH

Persistent morning headache and vomiting with a visual, coordination, or behavioral sign — image the whole neuraxis, don't LP, and call neurosurgery.

▶ RECOGNIZE – HEADSMART RED FLAGS

- **Raised ICP:** recurrent **headache worse on waking or lying down**, **persistent vomiting (classically early-morning)**, and **papilledema** or a falling conscious level.³¹⁵
- **Visual / eye signs:** new squint or double vision, **nystagmus**, reduced acuity, an **abnormal head tilt**, or abnormal eye movements.³¹⁵
- **Motor / coordination:** **ataxia** or unsteady gait, new focal weakness or facial droop, and in a young child **regression / loss of milestones**.³¹⁵
- **Age-specific:** infants — **enlarging head, bulging fontanelle, “sunseting” eyes, developmental regression**; older children / teens — **behavior or school change, fatigue, delayed or arrested puberty, polyuria/polydipsia** (diabetes insipidus), and **precocious puberty** — associated with intracranial (pineal / suprasellar) germ-cell tumors.³¹⁵
- A new **focal seizure**, or any of the above that is **persistent or progressive**.³¹⁵

⚠ DO NOT LP

With a mass or **obstructive hydrocephalus**, an LP can precipitate **herniation** — **image first**.¹¹⁵
Don't dismiss persistent morning vomiting as gastroenteritis.³¹⁵

◆ DIAGNOSE

- **MRI** is the imaging of choice, with **contrast CT** if MRI is not immediately available or to exclude acute hydrocephalus / hemorrhage.³¹⁶ Image the **whole spine with contrast** as well to stage leptomeningeal / "drop" metastases.
- Look actively for **obstructive hydrocephalus** — it is a neurosurgical emergency.³¹⁵

▲ ACUTE MANAGEMENT

- **Position first:** head of bed up **30°**, neck midline (no venous obstruction), avoid hypotonic fluids and hyperthermia; treat seizures — the same first-line measures as for raised ICP (see [Raised ICP](#)).
- **Dexamethasone** for symptomatic peritumoral (vasogenic) edema / raised ICP — specialist-directed; commonly **0.25–0.5 mg/kg/dose**, and for severe edema or impending herniation a **1–2 mg/kg IV load then 1–1.5 mg/kg/day divided q6h** (max **16 mg/day**) — formulary dosing.⁴² Add a **PPI (e.g., omeprazole)** for gastric protection (local practice).
- **Call neurosurgery urgently**; treat hydrocephalus (EVD / CSF diversion) as directed.³¹⁵
- **Transfer to PICU** if drowsy or dropping conscious level, and manage as [Raised ICP](#) in the interim.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any suspected tumor with raised ICP, hydrocephalus, a focal deficit, or a reduced conscious level.
- **Home** — not during the acute presentation; expedite imaging and specialist review.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric **neurosurgery / neuro-oncology** at a specialist center for resection and hydrocephalus management; involve oncology.

Brain Abscess

HOURS

NEUROSURGICAL

Fever, headache, focal deficit, or new seizures — image with contrast MRI, treat by source, don't LP.

▲ RECOGNIZE

- **Subacute:** headache (most common), fever, **focal neurological deficit**, new-onset seizures, and features of **raised ICP** (vomiting, altered consciousness, papilledema). The classic triad (fever + headache + focal deficit) occurs in a **minority**.³¹⁷
- **The source predicts the organisms:** contiguous — **otitis/mastoiditis, sinusitis, dental, meningitis**; hematogenous — **cyanotic congenital heart disease** (right-to-left shunt), endocarditis, pulmonary; direct — penetrating trauma or neurosurgery; **immunocompromise** (add fungi, *Nocardia*, *Toxoplasma*).³¹⁷

◆ DIAGNOSE

- **Contrast MRI with diffusion-weighting** is the test of choice — abscess shows **restricted diffusion** (a tumor usually does not); contrast CT if MRI unavailable.³¹⁸
- Take **blood cultures**. **LP only after neurosurgical evaluation** — low yield, herniation risk with a focal mass; abscess drainage and culture is best.³¹⁸
- Contrast MRI + neurosurgery + IV antibiotics by source.
- Urgent neurosurgery + ID; empiric therapy follows source and local resistance.

DECISION – WHAT IS THE LIKELY SOURCE?

OTOGENIC / SINUS / DENTAL / HEMATOGENOUS

Ceftriaxone (or cefotaxime) + metronidazole + vancomycin. Covers the *Streptococcus anginosus* (milleri) group and anaerobes.³¹⁸

POST-TRAUMA / POST-NEUROSURGICAL

Vancomycin + an antipseudomonal beta-lactam (cefepime, ceftazidime, or meropenem) — covers *S. aureus* (incl. MRSA), Gram-negatives and *Pseudomonas*.³¹⁸

EMPIRIC AGENTS – PEDIATRIC DOSES

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Ceftriaxone	50 mg/kg/dose q12h (or 100 mg/kg/dose once daily; max 4 g/day (2 g/dose if q12h))	IV; streptococci + Gram-negatives. Cefotaxime is an alternative.
+ Metronidazole	7.5 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 500 mg)	IV; anaerobic cover for otogenic / sinus / dental sources.
+ Vancomycin	15 mg/kg/dose q6h; trough 15–20 mg/L (max 1 g/dose)	IV; add for <i>S. aureus</i> / MRSA or severe disease.
Meropenem (OR — alternative)	40 mg/kg/dose q8h (max 2 g)	IV; cephalosporin allergy, resistant Gram-negatives, or suspected <i>Nocardia</i> .
± Vancomycin	15 mg/kg/dose q6h (max 1 g/dose)	Add to meropenem where <i>S. aureus</i> / MRSA is likely.

SURGERY, DURATION & ADJUNCTS

- **Neurosurgical aspiration or excision** for diagnosis and for potential abscess drainage, or if not responding — send pus for aerobic, anaerobic, fungal and mycobacterial studies. **IV antibiotics ≈ 4–8 weeks**, guided by clinical response and serial imaging; involve **infectious diseases**.³¹⁸ **Treat the source** (mastoid, sinus, dental). **Urgent PICU consult for ICP management**; give **anticonvulsants** for seizures.
- Reserve **steroids** for significant edema / mass effect — they can reduce antibiotic penetration.³¹⁸

⚠ DON'T LP RIGHT AWAY – WATCH FOR HERNIATION

- With a focal mass, an LP can precipitate herniation and rarely changes management³¹⁷ — image first.
- Rapid deterioration, a large abscess with midline shift, or impending herniation → emergency neurosurgery & PICU consult (see [Raised ICP / The Comatose Child](#)).

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → for treatment and monitoring; potential abscess drainage.
- **Home from the ward** — after prolonged IV therapy and imaging response, with follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — neurosurgery (drainage) and infectious diseases; find the source (ENT/dental/cardiac).

Raised ICP / The Comatose Child MINUTES

Protect the brain: airway, glucose, and reverse herniation fast.

▀ RECOGNIZE HERNIATION

- Falling conscious level (GCS / AVPU), unequal or fixed pupils, abnormal posturing, and the **Cushing triad** (hypertension + bradycardia + irregular breathing) = impending herniation.
- Coma work-up — **DEFG**: "**Don't Ever Forget Glucose.**" Sort causes with **AEIOU-TIPS**: alcohol/toxins, epilepsy, insulin/glucose, opioids, uremia/metabolic, trauma, infection, psychiatric, stroke/shock.

STABILIZE

- Airway (add C-spine control if trauma; use an appropriately sized collar), oxygen, ventilation.
- Check glucose; treat seizures.
- Position the head midline and elevate the head of the bed to 30°²¹⁵.
- Keep normothermic and normoglycemic; avoid hyponatremia — keep sodium in the normal-to-high range.²¹⁵
- **Call PICU.**



LOWER ICP

Maintain oxygenation and **normocapnia** (avoid routine hyperventilation); give hyperosmolar therapy; urgent CT + neurosurgery (measures extrapolated from pediatric severe-TBI guidance).²¹⁵

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Hypertonic saline 3%	3–5 mL/kg over 10–15 min	IV; for raised ICP / herniation ²¹⁵
Mannitol	0.5–1 g/kg over 10–15 min	IV; alternative (caution if hypovolemic/hypotensive) — formulary dosing ⁴²
Dextrose 10% — hypoglycemia only	2–5 mL/kg (0.2–0.5 g/kg); recheck glucose	IV/IO only to correct documented hypoglycemia (“don’t ever forget glucose”); use the smallest effective dose.

⚠ FLUIDS — AVOID FREE WATER

In suspected raised ICP, **avoid dextrose-containing and hypotonic fluids** as a bolus or maintenance — once the glucose is metabolized the leftover free water worsens cerebral edema. Maintain with **isotonic 0.9% saline** (expert consensus — not guideline-stated). The one exception is **documented hypoglycemia**, which injures the brain and must be corrected.

⚠ DO NOT DELAY TRANSFER

Do not delay transfer to PICU/neurosurgery; repeat hyperosmolar therapy is specialist-guided.

⚠ HYPERVENTILATION

Brief hyperventilation **only** as a bridge for impending herniation; sustained hypocapnia causes cerebral ischemia.²¹⁵

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → PICU.
- **Home from the ward** — not from the acute episode.
- **Refer — now** — neurosurgery/neurology and the primary-cause specialty (tumor, infection, metabolic, trauma).

Guillain-Barré Syndrome / Acute Flaccid Paralysis MINUTES EAN/PNS 2023

Ascending weakness that can reach the diaphragm — the emergency is respiratory failure and autonomic instability.

▀ RECOGNIZE

- Progressive, fairly **symmetric ascending weakness** with **reduced/absent reflexes**, often after a GI or respiratory infection; a refusal to walk in a young child.³¹⁹
- CSF (if done) shows **high protein with normal cell count** (albuminocytologic dissociation) — may be normal in the first week; MRI may show nerve-root enhancement.³¹⁹

⚠ THE TWO THINGS THAT KILL

- **Respiratory failure** — track vital capacity/effort; rising CO₂ and a falling forced vital capacity (roughly < 15–20 mL/kg) mean elective intubation, not a trial of NIV. **Autonomic instability** — labile blood pressure, arrhythmia, ileus; put the child on a cardiac monitor.³¹⁹
- Rapid progression or bulbar weakness (choking, weak cough) = ICU.³¹⁹

✦ DON'T BE REASSURED BY A NORMAL EARLY TAP

- Weakness can outrun the CSF and the reflexes early on.
- If the picture fits, admit and monitor breathing serially rather than discharging on a single normal test.
- Always exclude a compressive cord lesion (a sensory level, back pain or sphincter loss points to the cord, not GBS).³¹⁹

📌 WORKUP

- **Lumbar puncture** — albuminocytologic dissociation (high protein, normal cells); **may be normal in the first week**.³¹⁹
- **Nerve conduction studies / EMG** (subtype; may be normal early — repeat).
- **Serial bedside spirometry** — FVC (and NIF/MIP) **every 4–6 h** in the progressive phase, plus bulbar assessment;³¹⁹ act on the **"20/30/40" thresholds** (FVC < 20 mL/kg, MIP < 30, MEP < 40 cmH₂O) or a **> 30% fall** from baseline — these predict the need for ventilation (adult-derived thresholds from a mainly adult ICU cohort).³²⁰
- **Spirometry is unreliable under ~5–6 years** or with facial/bulbar weakness (poor mouth seal) — there, rely on **serial clinical assessment**: single-breath count, cough strength, paradoxical breathing, ability to lie flat, and the blood-gas/CO₂ trend (expert practice — not guideline-stated).
- **Continuous ECG/BP** for dysautonomia.³¹⁹
- **Spinal MRI with contrast** (nerve-root enhancement; excludes a compressive cord lesion).
- Anti-ganglioside antibodies (GQ1b for Miller-Fisher).³¹⁹ **Stool for poliovirus/enterovirus** in acute flaccid paralysis — two specimens ≥ 24 h apart within 14 days of onset.³²¹

Treatment	Dose	Notes
IV immunoglobulin	2 g/kg total, over 2–5 days	First-line; equivalent to plasma exchange — a second course is not recommended in non-responders (SID-GBS) ³¹⁹
Plasma exchange	Per center protocol	Alternative — not combined with IVIG ³¹⁹
Corticosteroids	Not recommended	No benefit in GBS ³¹⁹

📌 ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** all suspected cases for respiratory and cardiac monitoring.

- **Call** neurology; critical care early if bulbar/respiratory involvement or rapid progression. Acute flaccid paralysis is **notifiable** (polio surveillance) — send stool.

The Child with Neuromuscular Disease

MINUTES

DMD Care 2018 • CHEST 2023

A known neuromuscular disease rewrites every emergency — the weak cough, the anesthetic that can kill, the heart, and the steroids.

► RESPIRATORY – THE USUAL KILLER

- It is the **weak cough, not the lungs**: a “simple” chest infection tips into **hypercapnic respiratory failure**. Support ventilation with **NIV (bilevel)** and clear secretions with **mechanical insufflation–exsufflation (cough assist)** — not oxygen alone.^{322,323}
- The **oxygen saturation lies** — it can be normal while CO₂ climbs. Track **capnography / blood-gas pCO₂**, not SpO₂.

⚠ ANESTHETIC / RSI HAZARD – FLAG BEFORE ANY SEDATION

- **Succinylcholine is contraindicated** in dystrophinopathies and many myopathies (hyperkalemic cardiac arrest), and **volatile agents** (sevoflurane, isoflurane, desflurane) risk **anesthesia-induced rhabdomyolysis / hyperkalemia** (see [Rhabdomyolysis](#)). **Safe approach**: total IV anesthesia (propofol, opioid, benzodiazepine) + a **non-depolarizing** blocker (rocuronium) reversible with sugammadex.³²⁴
- Obtain a baseline CK and an ECG before any procedure, and recheck K⁺ and CK if perioperative rhabdomyolysis is suspected.³²⁴

⚠ DO NOT GIVE UNCONTROLLED OXYGEN

- High-flow O₂ masks a rising CO₂ and can abolish respiratory drive³²² → **CO₂ narcosis and arrest**.
- Titrate O₂ only **with** ventilatory support and CO₂ monitoring — correct the hypoventilation, not the number.³²²

► CARDIAC

- **Duchenne / Becker** → dilated cardiomyopathy and arrhythmia (may be silent — reduced mobility hides symptoms). **Emery-Dreifuss / LGMD1B** → progressive **AV / conduction block** and sudden death (may need pacing).^{322,325}
- Any acute deterioration: **12-lead ECG + echocardiogram**; troponin and BNP/NT-proBNP if acute myocardial injury or heart failure is suspected.³²²

► ADRENAL – STRESS-DOSE STEROIDS

- A child on **chronic daily steroids** (prednisone/deflazacort for Duchenne) **cannot mount a stress response**. Acute illness, vomiting, trauma, surgery or shock needs **stress-dose**

steroids to prevent adrenal crisis — **never stop steroids abruptly**³²⁶ (see [Adrenal Crisis](#)).

► MYASTHENIC CRISIS

- Worsening bulbar/respiratory weakness → treat with **IVIG or plasma exchange** and support the airway.³²⁷ Follow **FVC and NIF**, not SpO₂.
- **Avoid drugs that worsen myasthenia:** aminoglycosides, macrolides, fluoroquinolones, **IV magnesium**, beta-blockers, and procainamide.³²⁸

✦ TWO NUMBERS THAT MISLEAD, ONE THAT DOESN'T

- In neuromuscular weakness a normal **SpO₂** and a normal **respiratory rate** are falsely reassuring — the child fails from **CO₂ retention and a failing cough**.
- The honest bedside numbers are **pCO₂ (capnography/gas)** and **FVC / NIF**.
- A metabolic/mitochondrial myopathy adds a fourth: start **IV dextrose (D10) early** — fasting and catabolic stress precipitate metabolic decompensation (limit or avoid dextrose in pyruvate-metabolism disorders or on a ketogenic diet).³²⁹

► WORKUP

- **VBG/ABG with pCO₂ + continuous capnography** — the key respiratory measure; **FVC and NIF** where the child can cooperate.
- Electrolytes incl. **potassium, magnesium, calcium; creatine kinase**; renal function; **glucose**; lactate.
- **12-lead ECG**; troponin + BNP/NT-proBNP; echocardiogram if cardiac concern.
- Chest X-ray ± sputum culture if infective; swallow/bulbar assessment.³²²

Situation	Dose	Route & notes
Stress steroids — tolerating oral	≈ triple the maintenance steroid dose during the illness	PO; for the child on chronic steroids (Duchenne)
Stress steroids — unwell / vomiting / shock	Hydrocortisone ≈ 2 mg/kg (or 50 mg/m²) IV, then continued	IV/IM; treat as adrenal crisis — do not wait. DMD care considerations: emergency IM hydrocortisone 50 mg (< 2 yr) or 100 mg (≥ 2 yr); stress dosing 50–100 mg/m ² /day in severe illness, major trauma or surgery. ³²⁶
Myasthenic crisis	IVIG 2 g/kg over 2–5 days or plasma exchange	Plus airway support; treat the trigger/infection
Metabolic myopathy — catabolic stress	IV dextrose (D10) early	Prevents fasting-driven decompensation / rhabdomyolysis

◆ LOCAL & ANTICIPATORY

- Ask for the child's **EMERGENCY / ANESTHESIA ALERT CARD** and neuromuscular care plan on arrival, and involve the **NEUROMUSCULAR TEAM** early.
- Keep succinylcholine and volatile agents off the plan for dystrophinopathies, and flag the diagnosis to anesthesia/critical care before any transfer, sedation or intubation.³²²

▶ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — any respiratory decompensation, myasthenic/adrenal crisis, new cardiac signs, or a child who needs assisted airway clearance.
- **Refer — now** — call neuromuscular/neurology, cardiology and critical care/anesthesia; new acute flaccid weakness without a known diagnosis → see [Guillain-Barré / Acute Flaccid Paralysis](#).

12

Orthopedic & Musculoskeletal

The limping child · fractures & NAI · SCFE · compartment syndrome · bone & joint infection

Orthopedic Emergencies – Call Now MINUTES

Immediate orthopedic (± vascular/spinal) consultation — do not wait for imaging.

⚠ IMMEDIATE ORTHOPEDIC CONSULTATION

- Septic arthritis
- Compartment syndrome
- Open fracture
- SCFE
- Joint dislocation
- Fracture with pulseless limb
- Unstable pelvic injury
- Spine injury with neurological deficit

Osteoarticular Infections HOURS RECOGNIZE

Acute hematogenous osteomyelitis (AHO) and septic arthritis (SA) — consider in any limp, refusal to use a limb, or pseudoparalysis.

▶ CLINICAL PRESENTATION

- **Pseudoparalysis / limp / refusal to weight-bear**, or focal limb pain — often the only symptom. Fever supports diagnosis but may be absent.⁹²

- **Osteomyelitis:** point tenderness over the **metaphysis** of a long bone ± localized swelling/erythema; fluctuance suggests a periosteal abscess.⁹²
- **Septic arthritis:** joint effusion, swelling, and pain on any movement of the isolated joint; the limb is held in a position of comfort.³³⁰
- *S. aureus* → acute, rapidly progressive, higher CRP (MRSA more severe). *Kingella kingae* (young children) → milder, indolent, lower markers.⁹²
- **Chronic recurrent multifocal osteomyelitis (CRMO/CNO)** — consider with recurrent bone pain, multifocal lesions, sterile cultures, and poor response to antibiotics.⁹²

▲ MOST COMMON SITES & PATHOGENS

- **Bone:** metaphysis of long bones — **femur, tibia, humerus**. Pelvic bones are easily missed (vague pain, mimics abdomen).⁹²
- **Joint: hip and knee** most common, then ankle, elbow, shoulder. SA + adjacent osteomyelitis is common (≈ 32% of SA), especially with *S. aureus* and longer symptom duration.³³⁰
- **Pathogens:** *S. aureus* overall most common; *K. kingae* dominates under ~4 yr (inoculate fluid into blood-culture bottles). Add *Salmonella* in sickle cell disease; *H. influenzae* type b if under-immunized.⁹²

◆ KOCHER CRITERIA – HIP SA VS TRANSIENT SYNOVITIS

- Four predictors, one point each: **NON-WEIGHT-BEARING; FEVER > 38.5 °C; ESR > 40 MM/H; WHITE-CELL COUNT > 12,000/ML.**
- Many add **CRP > 20 MG/L** as a strong independent predictor.³³¹
- A risk-stratification aid for the hip, not a rule-out.³³²
- More positive criteria substantially raise septic-arthritis probability, but always interpret alongside CRP, ultrasound, and clinical judgment.³³²

KOCHER – PROBABILITY OF SEPTIC ARTHRITIS

Predictors present	Approx. probability of SA
0 of 4	< 0.2 %
1 of 4	~ 3 %
2 of 4	~ 40 %
3 of 4	~ 93 %
4 of 4	~ 99 %

⚠ WORK-UP

- Blood cultures **before** antibiotics. **CRP** at baseline (sensitive, falls fast — best for monitoring; ESR less useful).⁹²
- Plain films to exclude mimics; **ultrasound** for hip/shoulder effusion; **MRI is the imaging modality of choice** (add contrast if abscess or soft-tissue extension is suspected); **MRI with gadolinium** is the most sensitive/specific test, defining abscess, adjacent osteomyelitis, and soft-tissue extent.⁹²

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all suspected septic arthritis/osteomyelitis → IV antibiotics after cultures/aspiration. **Delay antibiotics until a joint aspirate is obtained whenever clinically feasible.**
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; step down to oral with monitoring and orthopedic follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics (aspiration/washout) and infectious diseases.

Osteoarticular Infections – Management

HOURS

CULTURES FIRST

Cultures first, then empiric IV cefazolin; involve orthopedics early for any septic joint or bony abscess.

DECISION

Osteomyelitis or septic arthritis?

OSTEOMYELITIS (AHO)

Most respond to **antibiotics alone**. Surgery (drainage/debridement) for a **subperiosteal/intraosseous abscess**, or if not improving in the first few days — repeat imaging and reconsider debridement.⁹²

SEPTIC ARTHRITIS

Orthopedic emergency — urgent **aspiration ± arthroscopic/open drainage & irrigation**; send synovial fluid for cell count/differential, Gram stain and culture, with molecular (PCR) testing if no pathogen is identified, especially in preschool children (*K. kingae*).³³⁰ Hip and shoulder are especially time-critical (avascular-necrosis risk; expert consensus).

Empiric therapy after cultures: IV cefazolin — covers MSSA and *K. kingae*.⁹²

ANTIBIOTIC THERAPY

Scenario	Drug & dose	Notes
Empiric — first-line IV	Cefazolin 37.5–50 mg/kg/dose IV q6–8h (max 2 g/dose)	Covers MSSA and <i>K. kingae</i> — the two commonest pathogens. Start after blood cultures. ⁹²
Under 4 yr / unimmunized	Cefuroxime 50 mg/kg/dose IV q8h (max 1.5 g/dose)	Broadens to cover <i>H. influenzae</i> in unimmunized young children. ⁹²
MSSA — confirmed	Continue cefazolin, or cloxacillin 37.5–50 mg/kg/dose IV q6h (cloxacillin max 2 g/dose)	Cloxacillin narrows further but irritates veins. ⁹²
MRSA — suspected/confirmed	Add/use vancomycin 15 mg/kg/dose IV q6h (max 1 g/dose; level-guided)	Where MRSA prevalent or known carrier. Note: <i>K. kingae</i> is resistant to vancomycin, clindamycin & cloxacillin. ⁹²
Oral step-down — MSSA / culture-neg	Cephalexin 40–50 mg/kg/dose PO TID (max 6 g/day)	First-line oral. Cloxacillin 25 mg/kg/dose QID is an alternative (poor taste). Formulary dosing. ⁴²
Oral step-down — MRSA	Clindamycin, TMP-SMX, or linezolid	Per susceptibilities, with infectious-diseases input; MRSA usually needs longer before switching (expert practice).

◆ IV → ORAL SWITCH & DURATION

- Switch to oral when **CLINICALLY IMPROVED** (afebrile, using the limb) and **CRP FALLING**, with an active, well-tolerated oral option and assured adherence.^{330,333} **DURATION (CRP-GUIDED): AHO 3–4 WEEKS**
- uncomplicated SA as short as **10–14 DAYS** total (IV + oral) when improving rapidly with a progressively falling CRP by the end of week 1
- SA with adjacent osteomyelitis, a slow response, or the hip/shoulder: longer, individualized course with infectious-diseases input.³³⁰
- Randomized data (Peltola) support short courses once response is good and CRP normalizes early.³³⁴

⚠ FOLLOW-UP

- Confirm clinical resolution and a **normal/normalizing CRP** before stopping.
- End-of-therapy radiographs mainly if the **growth plate** was involved or a large lytic lesion present — these and any physeal involvement need **orthopedic follow-up**.
- Routine follow-up MRI/CT is not needed — reserve for complications or non-improvement.⁹²

◆ **DIFFICULT IV ACCESS?** Reassess for an early IV→oral switch at every line failure rather than re-sticking — see [IV → Oral Switch & the DIVA Patient](#) (Quick Reference).

The Limping Child

ASSESS

APPROACH

A limp is a symptom — use age and red flags to separate the benign from septic joint, SCFE, malignancy, and abuse.

DEFINE

- A **limp** is any deviation from normal age-appropriate gait; pain present in ~80%. Broad differential — separate benign causes from the **can't-miss** ones: septic joint, osteomyelitis, SCFE, malignancy, and inflicted injury.³³⁵

APPROACH – AGE NARROWS THE DIFFERENTIAL

- **Toddler (1–3 y):** toddler's fracture, transient synovitis, developmental dysplasia of the hip, inflicted injury.
- **Child (4–10 y):** transient synovitis, Legg-Calvé-Perthes, septic arthritis, reactive/juvenile idiopathic arthritis.
- **Adolescent (> 10 y):** SCFE, apophysitis/overuse, sports injury.³³⁵
- **Spinal:** consider discitis, vertebral osteomyelitis, or a spinal tumor in a child refusing to walk with a **normal hip exam** — especially with back pain or spinal tenderness.³³⁵
- **Malignancy:** persistent night pain, pain out of proportion to the exam, constitutional symptoms, or failure to improve³³⁵ → **urgent investigation**.
- History: pain, trauma, fever, systemic or night symptoms. Examine gait (antalgic vs Trendelenburg), hip, knee, spine, neurology — **knee pain often means hip disease**.³³⁵
- **Any age — look beyond the hip:** consider a **first presentation of juvenile idiopathic arthritis (JIA)**, which occurs across **all age groups**, and **examine every joint** — not only the painful one (a commonly missed step that reveals oligo- or polyarticular disease).³³⁵

WORK-UP

Plain radiographs of the involved site — **both hips (add a frog-leg view for SCFE)** if the exam does not localize. **FBC, CRP/ESR, blood culture** if febrile or systemically unwell; ultrasound for a hip effusion; MRI if osteomyelitis or malignancy is suspected.³³⁵

RED FLAGS

- **Fever + refusal to weight-bear + raised inflammatory markers** → septic joint/osteomyelitis. Normal early CRP/ESR/white count do **not** exclude osteoarticular infection — reassess if symptoms persist or worsen.³³⁵
- **Night pain, weight loss, pallor, bruising, or hepatosplenomegaly**³³⁵ → malignancy/leukemia.
- **Multiple or unexplained fractures, or a fracture in a non-ambulatory infant**³³⁶ → inflicted injury.
- **Adolescent hip or knee pain with a limp**¹³² → SCFE until excluded.

✦ PEARL – POINT TO THE HIP

Isolated knee or thigh pain in a child is hip pathology until proven otherwise — SCFE and Perthes both refer pain to the knee.³³⁵

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — septic arthritis, osteomyelitis, fracture, or systemic illness; unable to weight-bear with red flags.
- **Home from the emergency department** — transient synovitis in a well child with safety-net advice and review.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics for red flags.
- **Refer — clinic** — oncology/rheumatology as indicated.

Transient Synovitis vs Septic Arthritis HOURS KOCHER

The commonest atraumatic limp — but rule out the septic joint first; fever + non-weight-bearing + high CRP means aspirate.

▀ DEFINE

- **Transient synovitis** — a benign, self-limited, often post-viral hip inflammation and the commonest cause of an atraumatic limp.³³⁷ Typically 3–8 years; symptoms usually resolve within **7–10 days** (expert consensus). Must be separated from **septic arthritis**, a surgical emergency.³³²

▀ APPROACH – READ THE CHILD

- **Transient synovitis:** a well child, low-grade or no fever, **weight-bears with discomfort**, mildly raised markers, often a recent upper-respiratory infection.
- **Septic arthritis:** an unwell/febrile child who **refuses to move the joint**, severe pain on any movement, the limb held in flexion/abduction/external rotation.³³²

◆ KOCHER CRITERIA – HIP: SEPTIC ARTHRITIS VS TRANSIENT SYNOVITIS

- One point each: **NON-WEIGHT-BEARING; FEVER > 38.5 °C; ESR > 40 MM/H; WBC > 12,000/ML.**
- Many add **CRP > 20 MG/L** as a strong independent predictor.
- Probability of septic arthritis: 0/4 < 0.2%
- 1/4 ≈ 3%
- 2/4 ≈ 40%
- 3/4 ≈ 93%
- 4/4 ≈ 99%.
- A risk aid, not a rule-out.³³²

⚠ WORK-UP

- FBC, **CRP**, ESR, blood culture; hip **ultrasound** (an effusion is seen in both and does not distinguish).³³²
- If septic arthritis is suspected → **urgent ultrasound-guided aspiration** (cell count, Gram stain, culture into a blood-culture bottle).³³⁵

▴ MANAGEMENT

- **Septic arthritis** — orthopedic emergency: urgent joint drainage plus IV antibiotics after cultures (see [Osteoarticular Infections](#)).
- **Transient synovitis** — rest, NSAIDs, review in 24–48 h; settles over days. Re-evaluate promptly if it does not improve or markers rise (expert consensus — not guideline-stated).

✦ PEARL – WHEN IN DOUBT, ASPIRATE

Fever + refusal to weight-bear + a raised CRP is a septic joint until an aspirate proves otherwise — do not label it transient synovitis by default.³³²

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — any suspicion of septic arthritis (Kocher criteria, raised markers) → aspiration.
- **Home from the emergency department** — transient synovitis, afebrile, mobilizing, with review.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics for aspiration/washout if septic.

Nursemaid's Elbow

ASSESS

1–4 YR

A pulled, pronated arm the child will not use — reduce by hyperpronation; no film needed if the story is classic.

▴ DEFINE

- **Nursemaid's elbow (radial head subluxation, 'pulled elbow')** — the annular ligament slips over the radial head after axial traction on an extended, pronated arm.³³⁸ Commonest elbow injury in children aged 1–4 years.

▴ APPROACH & WORK-UP

- Typical story: sudden **pull or lift** on the arm. Child holds the arm slightly flexed and **pronated**, refuses to use it, with **no swelling, bruising, or deformity** and minimal tenderness.³³⁸
- **No imaging needed** with a classic history and a normal-looking arm. Image if the story is atypical, or there is swelling, focal bony tenderness, or deformity.³³⁸

⚠️ RED FLAGS

- Swelling, bruising, point bony tenderness, or deformity → suspect a fracture and radiograph.
- An inconsistent or implausible history should prompt consideration of inflicted injury.

▀ MANAGEMENT – REDUCE IT

- **Hyperpronation** (support the elbow, firmly pronate the forearm) — a meta-analysis shows it is **more effective and less painful** than supination-flexion — do it first.³³⁸
- Alternative: **supination-flexion** (supinate the forearm, then fully flex the elbow). A palpable click often signals success.³³⁸
- Child usually resumes normal use within 5–30 minutes. If reduction fails, try the other maneuver; if still unsuccessful, immobilize, image, reassess.³³⁸

✦ PEARL – NO FILM NEEDED IF IT WORKS

- With a classic pull mechanism and no swelling, reduce without imaging — if the child uses the arm normally afterwards, diagnosis is confirmed and no radiograph is required.³³⁸
- Do not attempt repeated reductions if there is swelling, bruising, focal tenderness, or an atypical history — image and consider safeguarding.³³⁸

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — not required.
- **Home from the emergency department** — after successful reduction and return of normal arm use.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics only if reduction fails, or for swelling/deformity suggesting fracture (image first).

Slipped Capital Femoral Epiphysis (SCFE) HOURS CAN'T MISS

Peri-pubertal limp with hip or knee pain — stop weight-bearing and get frog-leg views of both hips.

▀ DEFINE

- **Slipped capital femoral epiphysis (SCFE)** — the proximal femoral epiphysis slips through the physis. Peri-pubertal; **obesity is the strongest risk factor**; up to ⅓ bilateral. Consider endocrinopathy if the child is young (< 10 years), underweight, or atypical.¹³²

▀ APPROACH & WORK-UP

- Limp with **hip, groin, thigh, or knee pain**; the leg lies **externally rotated** with limited internal rotation and **obligate external rotation on hip flexion** (Drehmann sign).³³⁹

- **Stable** (able to weight-bear, with or without walking aids) vs **unstable** (cannot bear weight — high avascular-necrosis risk).³⁴⁰
- **AP + frog-leg lateral radiographs of BOTH hips.**³³⁹ For an **unstable** slip avoid forced frog-leg positioning and use AP + **cross-table lateral** to prevent further displacement; Klein's line may fail to intersect the epiphysis on the affected side but is insensitive on the AP view alone (expert practice).

⚠ RED FLAGS

- An **unstable slip** (non-weight-bearing) carries high avascular-necrosis risk.
- Missed or delayed diagnosis → progression and permanent deformity.³³⁹
- Assess both hips.

▢ MANAGEMENT

- **Make the child non-weight-bearing immediately** and refer urgently to orthopedics for **in-situ screw fixation.**³³⁹
- **Do not attempt reduction** — forceful manipulation increases avascular-necrosis risk (expert consensus — not guideline-stated).
- Consider prophylactic contralateral fixation in high-risk patients (young age, obesity, endocrinopathy) — a specialist decision (expert consensus).

✦ PEARL — FROG-LEG BOTH HIPs

Any obese adolescent with a limp or knee pain gets frog-leg views of both hips and is kept off the leg until SCFE is excluded — knee pain is the classic decoy.^{132,339}

▢ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → non-weight-bearing, urgent surgery.
- **Home from the ward** — post-operative.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics urgently (surgical fixation).
- **Refer — clinic** — endocrinology if bilateral or atypical.

Fractures — Patterns & Non-Accidental Red Flags

ASSESS

SAFEGUARDING

Know the common breaks — and the fractures that mandate a child-protection assessment.

▢ DEFINE

- Common pediatric fracture patterns and — critically — the fractures that trigger a **child-protection** assessment. Children's growing bone breaks differently from adults'.³³⁶

▲ APPROACH – COMMON ACCIDENTAL PATTERNS

- **Buckle/torus** (distal radius, stable) and **greenstick** fractures³⁴¹, and the **toddler's fracture** (spiral distal tibia in an ambulant toddler).
- **Physeal (Salter-Harris)** fractures cross the growth plate and risk growth arrest — always classify and follow up.³⁴¹
- Radiograph the **joint above and below**; obtain comparison views when needed (standard radiographic practice).
- **Supracondylar humeral fractures** need careful neurovascular assessment — document radial pulse, capillary refill, and **median (including anterior interosseous), radial, and ulnar** nerve function before and after splinting/reduction. A pulseless or poorly perfused hand needs **immediate orthopedic consultation**.³⁴²

▲ RED FLAGS – INFLICTED INJURY

- Escalate to safeguarding when the **injury is inconsistent** with the stated mechanism or the child's development — especially a **long-bone (femur/tibia) fracture in a non-ambulatory infant**, delayed presentation, multiple fractures of different ages, or **rib, metaphyseal 'corner', scapular, or spinous-process** fractures.³³⁶
- In children < 2 years with a suspicious fracture, obtain a **skeletal survey**.³³⁶
- Associated **bruising, patterned burns, retinal hemorrhage**, or other unexplained injuries further raise suspicion of abuse.³³⁶

▲ MANAGEMENT

- Immobilize, provide analgesia, and refer to orthopedics for displaced, physeal, or unstable fractures.
- Where abuse is suspected, follow the mandatory **child-protection pathway** — evaluation and reporting are not optional.³³⁶

◆ KUWAIT – REPORTING IS MANDATORY

- Under the **CHILD RIGHTS LAW NO. 21 OF 2015**, children are protected from all forms of violence, abuse, exploitation, and neglect, and **PHYSICIANS ARE LEGALLY OBLIGED TO REPORT** suspected child maltreatment.²
- Refer through the **KUWAIT NATIONAL CHILD PROTECTION PROGRAM (KNCPP), MINISTRY OF HEALTH**, via the national **CHILD PROTECTION HOTLINE 147**.
- Ensure the child's immediate safety, document findings objectively, and involve the hospital child-protection team.

✦ PEARL – IF THEY CAN'T WALK, BE SUSPICIOUS

A fracture in a child who is not yet walking is highly suspicious for abuse until proven otherwise — do the skeletal survey and involve safeguarding.³³⁶

✦ PEARL – DOCUMENT THE NEUROVASCULAR EXAM

Every **supracondylar fracture** needs documented radial pulse, capillary refill, and median (including anterior interosseous), radial, and ulnar nerve function **before and after** splinting or reduction. **A pulseless hand is an orthopedic emergency, even if it remains pink.** ³⁴²

Compartment Syndrome

MINUTES

LIMB-THREATENING

Rising compartment pressure starves muscle and nerve — in children the 3 A's beat the 5 P's; fasciotomy is the fix.

▀ DEFINE

- **Acute compartment syndrome** — rising pressure in a fascial compartment cuts perfusion → muscle/nerve ischemia. Limb-threatening; **clinical** diagnosis. Most follow fractures (tibia, forearm), tight casts, crush, or reperfusion. ³⁴³

⚠ RED FLAGS – THE 3 A'S IN CHILDREN

- The adult '5 Ps' (pain out of proportion, pain on passive stretch, paresthesia, pallor, pulselessness) are **unreliable in children.** ³⁴³
- Suspect from the **3 A's — rising Analgesia requirement, Anxiety, and Agitation** — appearing on average ~7 hours before any neurovascular change. ³⁴³
- Tensely swollen compartment = most consistent sign. **Pulselessness and paralysis are late.** ³⁴³

⚠ WORK-UP

- Clinical diagnosis.
- Reserve compartment-pressure measurement for the obtunded or equivocal patient ($\Delta P < 30$ mmHg from diastolic is concerning). **Do not delay fasciotomy to obtain pressures.** ³⁴³

▀ MANAGEMENT

- **Remove or split all constricting casts and dressings down to skin;** keep the limb at heart level (do not elevate). ³⁴³
- Analgesia, oxygen, correct hypotension. Dense regional/nerve blocks can mask ischemic pain — in high-risk limb injuries prefer low-concentration blocks and stay vigilant (breakthrough or escalating pain, rising analgesic needs). ³⁴³
- **Emergency surgical fasciotomy without delay** — the definitive treatment. ³⁴³

✦ PEARL – ESCALATING PAIN = CALL SURGERY

A child with a limb injury whose analgesia needs keep climbing has compartment syndrome until proven otherwise — split the cast and call surgery. ³⁴³

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all suspected → emergency.
- **Home from the ward** — post-operative.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedic (lower limb) / plastic surgery (upper limb) **IMMEDIATELY** (fasciotomy); do not delay for pressure measurement in a clear case.

Open Fracture

HOURS

ANTIBIOTICS EARLY

Skin breach over bone — early IV antibiotics, tetanus cover, saline dressing, and urgent orthopedics.

▲ DEFINE

- **Open (compound) fracture** — fracture with an overlying skin breach communicating with bone; high infection risk. Graded Gustilo-Anderson I–III by wound size, contamination, and soft-tissue injury.³⁴⁴

▲ APPROACH & WORK-UP

- Visible wound/bleeding over the fracture, exposed bone, or gross deformity. **Assess neurovascular status distal to the injury.**³⁴⁴
- Remove gross contamination, photograph the wound once, then **cover with a saline-soaked sterile dressing**; radiograph; check **tetanus** status.³⁴⁴

▲ RED FLAGS

- A **pulseless, pale, cold limb** needs urgent reduction/vascular assessment.
- Gross contamination, type-III wounds, and evolving **compartment syndrome** raise the stakes.³⁴⁴

MANAGEMENT

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Antibiotics — timing	First IV dose as soon as possible (ideally < 1 h, at latest < 3 h)	The clock starts at injury, not arrival. ³⁴⁴
Type I–II	Cefazolin 30 mg/kg/dose IV (max 2 g) every 8 h	First-generation cephalosporin — gram-positive cover (regimen adult-derived; pediatric weight-based dose per formulary). ^{42,344}
Type III	Add gentamicin 5–7 mg/kg/dose IV once daily add benzylpenicillin for farm/soil contamination (anti-clostridial cover)	Add gram-negative cover for high-grade/contaminated wounds (adult-derived; pediatric dose per formulary). ^{42,344}

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Farm / soil contamination	Add penicillin	Anti-clostridial cover.

▀ THEN

- **Tetanus prophylaxis** per immunization status; analgesia; realign and splint the limb.³⁴⁴
- **Urgent orthopedic referral** for formal debridement, irrigation, and stabilization in the operating room.³⁴⁴

✦ PEARL – ANTIBIOTICS ON THE CLOCK

Give the first cephalosporin within an hour of injury, update tetanus, cover with a saline dressing, call orthopedics — early antibiotics drive the infection rate down.³⁴⁴

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all open fractures and significant limb injuries.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; post-operative/reduction.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics (early antibiotics, tetanus, debridement); vascular surgery if perfusion is threatened.

Fracture with Pulseless Limb MINUTES LIMB-THREATENING

An absent pulse needs urgent assessment; a pale, cool, poorly perfused limb needs emergent restoration of circulation.

▀ DEFINE

- A fracture with an absent distal pulse may indicate arterial compression, entrapment, or injury.^{342,345}

▀ APPROACH

- Obtain urgent radiographs.
- Record injury time, pulses, capillary refill, skin temperature and color, and individual peripheral-nerve function; compare with the opposite limb.
- Reassess and document after realignment, splinting, reduction, and surgery.
- Persistent suspected arterial injury requires consultant-directed vascular imaging, usually **CT angiography**, coordinated so that emergency revascularization is not delayed.³⁴⁵

⚠ RED FLAGS

- Pallor, coolness, delayed refill, worsening pain, progressive sensory or motor deficit, or deteriorating perfusion → **immediate orthopedic and vascular escalation**.
- Increasing pain or swelling also warrants reassessment for [compartment syndrome](#).

▀ MANAGEMENT

- Splint in the position of deformity in the emergency room.
- Emergent reduction and pinning in the operating room.
- Reassess circulation immediately post-reduction; vascular exploration if the limb remains cold and pulseless.³⁴²
- **Supracondylar fracture with a pink, warm hand** — arrange urgent reduction and fixation. If the hand remains well perfused afterwards, an absent radial pulse alone does not mandate brachial-artery exploration; the orthopedic consultant documents the decision and arranges close inpatient neurovascular observation.³⁴²

✦ PEARL – THE PINK HAND IS STILL AN EMERGENCY

A pink pulseless hand remains an orthopedic emergency; its perfusion after reduction determines the need for immediate vascular exploration.³⁴²

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all fractures presenting with a pulseless limb.
- **Home from the ward** — only after definitive management and consultant confirmation that perfusion is restored.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics immediately; vascular surgery immediately for ischemia or suspected persistent arterial injury.

Joint Dislocation MINUTES LIMB-THREATENING

Reduce traumatic dislocations promptly; compromised perfusion or threatened skin needs immediate intervention.

▀ DEFINE

- Traumatic loss of joint alignment, with or without an associated fracture.

▀ APPROACH

- Assess the mechanism, associated injuries, deformity, skin condition, and distal neurovascular function; document findings before and after reduction.
- Obtain joint radiographs to identify associated fractures — unless imaging would delay treatment of vascular compromise or threatened skin.
- Obtain post-reduction imaging and repeat the neurovascular examination.

⚠️ RED FLAGS

- Absent or diminished pulses, impaired perfusion, neurological deficit, an open injury, or threatened skin → **immediate orthopedic assessment**.

▀ MANAGEMENT

- Analgesia, then prompt reduction by an orthopedic surgeon under appropriate sedation or anesthesia with monitoring — emergency room or operating room depending on hospital capability.
- Immobilize after reduction and obtain post-reduction radiographs.
- Definitive management depends on the joint, injury pattern, and any associated fracture.

✦ PEARL — THE HIP CLOCK

A delay in reduction > 6 hours greatly increases the risk of avascular necrosis in traumatic hip dislocation.³⁴⁶

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — hip or true knee (not patellar) dislocations; open, irreducible, unstable, or neurovascularly compromised injuries; associated fractures needing inpatient treatment.
- **Home from the emergency department** — selected uncomplicated injuries after stable reduction, satisfactory imaging, normal neurovascular findings, and arranged follow-up; advise return for increasing pain, swelling, or numbness.
- **Refer — now** — orthopedics immediately; vascular surgery immediately for ischemia or suspected persistent arterial injury.

Unstable Pelvic Injury

MINUTES

LIFE-THREATENING

Treat a suspected unstable pelvic injury as major trauma — stabilization and hemorrhage control begin before radiological confirmation.

▀ DEFINE

- A pelvic-ring injury with mechanical instability, usually anterior and posterior ring disruption. Mechanical and hemodynamic instability are distinct: a child may initially maintain circulation despite an unstable fracture.³⁴⁷

▀ APPROACH

- Pediatric trauma primary survey (see [Major Trauma — Primary Survey](#)).
- Look for pelvic pain, deformity, limb-length asymmetry, and shock.
- Avoid pelvic springing and repeated stability testing; minimize unnecessary movement.
- Apply a pelvic binder as soon as possible; arrange targeted CT once sufficiently stable, with the trauma team — imaging must not delay stabilization or hemorrhage control.

⚠ RED FLAGS

- Persistent tachycardia, poor perfusion, hypotension, altered consciousness, or deterioration despite resuscitation → major hemorrhage.
- Open injury, blood at the urethral meatus, or lower-limb neurological abnormality → immediate specialist assessment.

▀ MANAGEMENT

- Activate the pediatric trauma and major-hemorrhage pathways; resuscitate while arranging urgent orthopedic, pediatric-surgical, anesthetic, and intensive-care support.
- A sheet applied over the greater trochanters serves as a pelvic binder when an unstable pelvic fracture is suspected — do not delay application for imaging.
- Ongoing hemodynamic instability despite resuscitation and binding needs immediate hemorrhage control — operative intervention or angioembolization; orthopedics determines temporary and definitive pelvic stabilization.
- Seek urological or pediatric-surgical advice before urethral catheterization if urethral injury is suspected.
- Open injuries require antibiotics and tetanus assessment.

✦ PEARLS

- An apparently reduced pelvis on imaging obtained with a binder on does not establish fracture stability.
- A negative FAST (Focused Assessment with Sonography for Trauma) examination does not exclude pelvic bleeding.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all suspected or confirmed unstable pelvic injuries; may need intensive care.
- **Home from the ward** — only after definitive stabilization, mobility, and a follow-up plan.
- **Refer — now** — triage to a pediatric-capable major trauma service; coordinate transfer and hemorrhage control with orthopedics and pediatric surgery.

Spine Fracture with Neurological Deficit MINUTES

Protect spinal alignment, support oxygenation and circulation, and obtain immediate spinal-surgical advice.

▀ DEFINE

- Traumatic cervical, thoracic, or lumbar fracture or dislocation with new motor, sensory, or sphincter dysfunction suggesting spinal cord, conus medullaris, or cauda equina injury. The same emergency pathway applies when neurological findings occur without a visible fracture (SCIWORA — spinal cord injury without radiographic abnormality).

▲ APPROACH

- Pediatric trauma primary survey with strict cervical-spine immobilization and log-roll precautions (see [Major Trauma — Primary Survey](#)).
- Document the time and evolution of weakness, sensory loss, and bladder or bowel symptoms; repeat the neurological assessment after transfers and any deterioration.
- Urgent radiographs and/or CT for injury characterization; urgent MRI for suspected cord or ligamentous injury.
- Do not delay referral to pediatric orthopedic spine or neurosurgery in order to complete imaging.

▲ RED FLAGS

- Progressive weakness, a sensory level, saddle sensory loss, new urinary retention or incontinence, or respiratory compromise → immediate escalation.
- Hypotension with bradycardia may be neurogenic shock — but hemorrhage must also be excluded.

▲ MANAGEMENT

- Maintain age-appropriate spine immobilization and minimize unnecessary movement.
- Analgesia and monitored resuscitation; correct hypoxemia and hypotension promptly.
- Involve intensive care early for mean arterial pressure support — in older children a lower limit of **75–80 mmHg** and upper limit of **90–95 mmHg**, maintained for **3–7 days** according to injury severity and neurological recovery; there is no established MAP target for young children.³⁴⁸
- The spine surgeon urgently determines the role of surgical decompression and stabilization, aiming for intervention **within 24 hours** of injury when clinically feasible to optimize neurological recovery (adult-derived: STASCIS enrolled ages 16–80).³⁴⁹
- Do not give high-dose methylprednisolone routinely for traumatic spinal cord injury; adult AOSpine guidance offers a 24-h infusion only as an option when started within 8 h of injury (not after 8 h, and never a 48-h infusion) — a specialist decision.³⁵⁰

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all; PICU for cord injury, neurogenic shock, or respiratory compromise.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric orthopedic spine or neurosurgery immediately; pediatric-capable major trauma service.

Trauma Team & Roles MINUTES

Know who leads before the patient arrives — role confusion costs the golden hour.

WHO LEADS — SET LOCALLY

- **Trauma team leader (TTL)** — identified by each hospital's own trauma pathway; the designation differs between hospitals and this guide does not prescribe it. Whoever leads runs the primary survey and resuscitation and keeps the overview; the airway is managed by the most skilled airway operator present.³⁵¹
- **Pediatric surgery** (where available; otherwise general surgery) — the surgical survey, hemorrhage source control, and performance of any operation. **The decision to operate, to image first, or to transfer is a team decision**, based on shared situational awareness of the child's physiology and trajectory — not a single-specialty call.^{15,351}
- **No trauma team on site (private hospital, peripheral facility):** stabilize with the primary survey (cABCDE), control hemorrhage, secure oxygenation and access, keep the child warm, and **transfer to the nearest trauma-capable center while resuscitating** — call the receiving team early. Do not delay transfer for imaging or specialist review that cannot change management locally.^{16,351}

△ AGREE THE PATHWAY IN ADVANCE

Confirm the trauma call, role allocation, and transfer route locally before the patient arrives — front-door role confusion costs time in the golden hour.

Major Trauma — Primary Survey & Resuscitation MINUTES

Stop the bleeding, protect the brain, keep them warm — and read the physiology, because children compensate then crash.

▲ HOW CHILDREN DIFFER — ANTICIPATE IT

- **Large head, thin scalp:** head injury is common; scalp-wound blood loss can be significant in a small child.¹⁶
- **Compliant chest wall:** serious lung injury (pulmonary contusion) occurs **without** rib fractures — a normal-looking chest wall does not exclude it.¹⁶
- **Less-protected solid organs:** liver and spleen injure easily in blunt abdominal trauma.¹⁶
- **Great reserve, then sudden collapse:** children hold blood pressure by tachycardia and vasoconstriction, so **hypotension is a late, pre-terminal sign** — act on tachycardia, cool peripheries, and prolonged capillary refill long before the BP falls.¹⁵
- **High surface-area-to-mass:** they cool fast — hypothermia drives coagulopathy. Hypoxia is the commonest cause of traumatic arrest.¹⁶

<C> CATASTROPHIC HEMORRHAGE

Control visible bleeding first: direct pressure, wound packing, a **limb tourniquet (record the exact time applied)** for uncontrolled extremity bleeding, and a **pelvic binder** for a suspected pelvic fracture.³⁵²

A – AIRWAY + C-SPINE

- Manual in-line stabilization; open (using a **jaw-thrust maneuver**) and clear the airway.
- Anticipate a difficult airway (large occiput flexes the neck; large tongue). In younger children — especially **< 2 yr** — a **shoulder roll** helps: maintain C-spine precautions and avoid over-extension or flexion.
- Secure the airway if GCS ≤ 8 or it is not protected.¹⁶

B – BREATHING

- Oxygen 10–15 L/min via non-rebreather mask. **Tension pneumothorax is a clinical diagnosis — treat before imaging.** Needle decompression at the **4th–5th intercostal space anterior to the mid-axillary line** at all ages; the 2nd space mid-clavicular line only when a pneumothorax there is confirmed (in infants and small children the heart and thymus lie against the chest wall at that site). Then finger thoracostomy/chest drain — see **Pneumothorax**.^{16,353}
- Seal an open pneumothorax; suspect massive hemothorax and pulmonary contusion.¹⁶

C – CIRCULATION

- Two large-bore IV lines; go early to **intraosseous** if access fails.
- Find the bleeding — **chest, abdomen, pelvis, long bones, and the floor**. Resuscitate with **blood, not repeated crystalloid**; consider tranexamic acid within 3 h.³⁵⁴ **Activate the massive transfusion protocol when required.**¹⁵

D – DISABILITY

GCS or AVPU (alert / voice / pain / unresponsive), pupils, and a **glucose** (do not miss hypoglycemia). Manage raised ICP with **urgent neurosurgery consult** — see the Traumatic Brain Injury card.²¹⁵

E – EXPOSURE / ENVIRONMENT

Fully undress to examine and log-roll, then **cover and actively warm** — every degree of cooling worsens clotting.³⁵²

RESUSCITATION – BLOOD, NOT CRYSTALLOID

Drug / product	Dose	Notes
Packed red cells	10 mL/kg boluses, reassess after each ^{16,355}	First-line for hemorrhagic shock; balanced 1:1:1 (RBC:plasma:platelets) in massive hemorrhage; activate the hospital massive transfusion protocol (pre-agreed with the blood bank) ¹⁵ ; 1:1:1 ratio evidence is adult-derived (PROPPR). ³⁵⁶
Crystalloid (warmed)	$\leq$ one 20 mL/kg bolus, only if blood not yet available	Each further crystalloid bolus $\rightarrow$ more coagulopathy, ventilator and ICU days ¹⁵

Drug / product	Dose	Notes
Tranexamic acid (TXA)	15 mg/kg (max 1 g) IV over 10 min then 2 mg/kg/h > 40 kg → 1 g then 1 g over 8 h	Within 3 h of injury; weight-based pediatric regimen per BSH 2016 ³⁵⁵ ; > 40 kg adult regimen from CRASH-2 (adult trial) ³⁵⁴ ; pediatric evidence is observational (PED-TRAX) ³⁵⁷

◆ RESUSCITATION REASONING

- Estimated blood volume ~70–80 mL/kg in a child (up to ~90 mL/kg in a term infant), so small losses matter.³⁵⁵
- Move early to blood products and minimize crystalloid. **DURING ACTIVE HEMORRHAGE, TRANSFUSE ACCORDING TO HEMORRHAGIC-SHOCK AND HEMOSTATIC-RESUSCITATION NEEDS – NOT TO A FIXED HEMOGLOBIN TARGET.** Once bleeding is controlled and the child is hemodynamically stable, use a restrictive red-cell strategy, generally around **HB 7 G/DL**.^{15,218} **TARGET A SYSTOLIC BP NO LESS THAN 70 + 2 × AGE (YR) MMHG** (1–10 yr band; use the age-specific systolic thresholds in the Shock card for other ages).^{16,24} **ADDRESS ONGOING LOSSES. AVOID HYPOTENSION.**^{15,215}

⚠ THE LETHAL TRIAD – AND REASSESS

- Hypothermia, acidosis, and coagulopathy feed each other: keep the child warm, give blood early, correct coagulopathy.³⁵²
- If the patient deteriorates at any point, **go back to A** and work through again.¹⁵

Major Trauma – Secondary Survey & Decisions MINUTES

Once the primary survey is controlled — find the injuries and make the calls.

▲ SECONDARY SURVEY – HEAD-TO-TOE + AMPLE HISTORY (ALLERGIES, MEDICATIONS, PAST HISTORY, LAST MEAL, EVENTS)

- Start **only after <C>ABCDE is controlled** and resuscitation underway. Examine front and back (log-roll): scalp and face, neck, chest, abdomen, pelvis and perineum, back, limbs, and a focused neurological exam.¹⁶
- **AMPLE** history: **A**llergies, **M**edications, **P**ast history, **L**ast meal, **E**vents/mechanism. Mechanism predicts the injuries — ask for it explicitly.¹⁶

DECISION

Abdomen — does this child need a CT?

PECARN (Pediatric Emergency Care Applied Research Network) intra-abdominal injury rule

— 7 features:

abdominal wall trauma / seatbelt sign

GCS ≤ 14

abdominal tenderness

chest-wall trauma

abdominal pain

decreased breath sounds

vomiting.³⁵⁸

NONE present

Very low risk for injury needing intervention
— CT can usually be safely avoided;
observe with serial examination.³⁵⁸

ANY present / unstable

Not low-risk — image (CT if stable) and
involve surgery.³⁵⁸ A **negative FAST does
not exclude** intra-abdominal injury in
children (FAST = Focused Assessment with
Sonography for Trauma — bedside
ultrasound for free fluid in the abdomen
and pericardium).³⁵⁹

CHEST

CXR for hemo/pneumothorax and pulmonary contusion; place a **chest drain** for a hemothorax or significant pneumothorax. (*Tension pneumothorax is already decompressed in the primary survey.*)¹⁶

PELVIS

Confirm the binder is correctly positioned and **image** (pelvic X-ray $\pm$ CT); do **not** repeatedly spring the pelvis.¹⁶ (*The binder is applied in the primary survey.*)

C-SPINE

- Clear with the **PECARN** 3-tier rule (clinical clearance / radiograph / CT).³⁶⁰
- **SCIWORA** (spinal cord injury without radiographic abnormality) is commoner in children — a normal X-ray does not exclude cord injury; keep the spine immobilized and call neurosurgery/spine urgently if there is any neurological deficit (weakness, sensory change, or bladder/bowel dysfunction), even with normal imaging.³⁶¹

LIMBS & ANALGESIA

Splint long-bone fractures and check distal pulses. Give **timely analgesia** (intranasal or IV opioid) — pain is routinely undertreated in injured children.^{16,351}

⚠ ALWAYS CONSIDER INFLICTED INJURY

- Be alert when the history is inconsistent with the injury or the child's development, presentation is delayed, or the pattern is suspicious (bruising or fracture in a non-mobile infant, torn frenulum, multiple injuries of different ages).
- Document carefully and escalate through local safeguarding.³³⁶

◦ ESCALATE & TRANSFER EARLY

- With no in-house pediatric surgery, involve the trauma team, anesthesia, intensive care and the receiving **trauma center early** — do not wait for the patient to deteriorate.¹⁵
- Package for transfer: airway secured, hemorrhage controlled, the child warm, and blood en route.
- Do **not** delay transfer for a CT that will not change what you do before the child leaves.¹⁵

Traumatic Brain Injury MINUTES

Decide who needs a CT; in severe injury, stop the second insult.

IMAGING DECISION – PECARN

- Use the **PECARN** rule to select children for CT after blunt head trauma and safely avoid imaging in the very-low-risk group. It is **age-stratified** — use the correct **age column** below. PECARN was not derived or validated for suspected **abusive (inflicted)** head trauma — keep a low threshold to image regardless of the rule when abuse is suspected.³⁶²

PECARN HEAD-CT – BY AGE GROUP

Risk tier	< 2 years	≥ 2 years
CT recommended (high risk)	Any of: GCS ≤ 14 , altered mental status / agitation / slow response, or a palpable skull fracture . ³⁶²	Any of: GCS ≤ 14 , altered mental status, or signs of a basilar skull fracture . ³⁶²
CT vs observe (intermediate)	Any of: occipital / parietal / temporal scalp hematoma , LOC (loss of consciousness) ≥ 5 s , severe mechanism , or not acting normally per the parent ³⁶² — shared decision-making + observation .	Any of: LOC , vomiting , severe mechanism , or severe headache — ³⁶² shared decision-making + observation .
No CT (low risk)	None of the above.	None of the above.

◆ DECISION TOOLS

- PECARN pediatric head-CT rule — mdcalc.com
- Severe-TBI management — Brain Trauma Foundation pediatric guideline, 3rd ed — doi.org



SEVERE TBI (GCS ≤ 8)

- Secure the airway.
- Keep **SpO₂ ≥ 94%** and normocapnia (PaCO₂ 35–40 mmHg).
- Avoid hypotension²¹⁵ — **target SBP no less than 70 + 2 × age mmHg (1–10 yr band; age-specific thresholds otherwise; PALS/ATLS hypotension definition).**^{24,363} Higher blood-pressure targets may be beneficial in isolated severe TBI, but the threshold, and whether to target SBP or MAP, are not established — set targets with neurosurgery and the receiving intensive care unit (PICU or ICU, per hospital policy).³⁶³
- Head midline, **elevate the head of the bed 30°**; treat pain, agitation, glucose, and temperature.²¹⁵



IMPENDING HERNIATION – BRIDGE TO DEFINITIVE CARE

- **Recognize:** new pupil asymmetry or a fixed dilated pupil, Cushing response (bradycardia + hypertension + irregular breathing), extensor posturing, or a falling GCS.
- **Bridge:** head up 30° and midline; secure oxygenation and normocapnia; avoid hypotension; give **one hyperosmolar bolus** (3% saline 2–5 mL/kg, or mannitol 0.5–1 g/kg if not hypovolemic); brief hyperventilation **only** for signs of herniation, as a temporizing measure.²¹⁵
- **Hand over** for urgent CT and neurosurgical review; ongoing intracranial-pressure and perfusion management is intensive-care therapy (PICU or ICU, per hospital policy) and is beyond the scope of this guide.

Agent	Dose	Notes
Hypertonic saline 3%	2–5 mL/kg bolus (impending herniation)	First-line hyperosmolar bridge; infusion regimens are intensive-care therapy ²¹⁵
Mannitol	0.5–1 g/kg over 15–20 min	Alternative; caution if hypovolemic or hypotensive ²¹⁵
Levetiracetam	20–55 mg/kg IV (max 4.5 g), then 10 mg/kg BID (local formulary dosing – not guideline-stated)	Prophylaxis to reduce early post-traumatic seizures in severe TBI — a short course (~7 days); phenytoin / fosphenytoin an alternative ²¹⁵

⚠ PREVENT THE SECOND INSULT

- Hypoxia and hypotension each independently worsen outcome — avoid both.
- Do **not** routinely hyperventilate (vasoconstriction lowers cerebral blood flow).
- Avoid hyperthermia and treat seizures promptly.²¹⁵

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all moderate/severe TBI and any abnormal CT to intensive care (PICU or ICU, according to each hospital's internal policy) with neurosurgical review. Until the child leaves the department, care is led by the consultant responsible at the patient's location — in the emergency department, the trauma team leader.

- **Home from the emergency department** — minor head injury meeting a validated low-risk rule, observed, with head-injury advice.
- **Refer — now** — neurosurgery for surgical lesions or deterioration; safeguarding if abuse is suspected.

Child Protection & Safeguarding

ASSESS

AAP • ACR 2025

The injury that doesn't fit the history — recognizing it once may prevent a fatal second event.

RECOGNIZE (RED-FLAG PATTERNS)

- **Any bruise in a not-yet-mobile infant** is a sentinel injury until proven otherwise. Use **TEN-4-FACESp**: bruising of **T**orso, **E**ars, **N**eck in a child ≤ 4 years, **any** bruising < 4 months, or of the **F**renulum, **A**ngle of jaw, **C**heek, **E**yelid, **S**clera, or **p**atterned marks.³⁶⁴
- History that is **absent, inconsistent, or doesn't match the developmental stage or the injury**; delayed presentation; injuries of different ages.³³⁶

ABUSIVE HEAD TRAUMA

- An infant with unexplained irritability, vomiting, apnea, seizures or reduced consciousness may have **abusive head trauma** — the triad of subdural hemorrhage, **retinal hemorrhages** and encephalopathy.^{365,366}
- Image the brain and arrange a dilated fundoscopy; it is easily mistaken for sepsis or a feeding problem.^{199,365}

EXAMINE, DOCUMENT, ESCALATE

- Fully undress and examine; document injuries factually with sizes and a body map (photograph per policy).
- In children < 2 years with suspected physical abuse, arrange a **skeletal survey** and consider coagulation studies to exclude mimics.³³⁶
- Care for the child first; you do not need to be certain to refer.³³⁶

◆ **LOCAL & LEGAL** Follow Kuwait MOH child-protection procedures — involve the hospital child-protection team/social work and make the mandatory report; ensure the child is in a safe place and that siblings are considered.³⁶⁷

WORKUP

- **Skeletal survey** — all children < 24 months; **2–5 years selectively** (radiographs of areas of concern; full survey if multiple or occult injuries are suspected); not useful > 5 years. **Repeat limited survey at ~2 weeks** when the first is negative or equivocal — it reveals healing rib and metaphyseal fractures.^{336,368}

- **Neuroimaging — immediate non-contrast head CT** for any neurological symptom or sign, scalp swelling, or a low hemoglobin (the strongest predictors of an abnormal CT: head swelling OR 46.7, neurological impairment OR 20.6, low hemoglobin OR 11.8).³⁶⁹
Neurologically normal: CT head is still usually appropriate < 24 months — occult intracranial injury is found in up to 37% of high-risk infants (rib or multiple fractures, facial injury, age < 6 months).^{368,370,371} Where rapid non-sedated MRI is available and expertly reported, **MRI may replace CT as first-line** in a stable infant whose injuries are unrelated to the head.³⁶⁹ **MRI brain ± whole spine at day 2–5** whenever CT shows hemorrhage, parenchymal injury or skull fracture, or neurology persists.^{368,370}
- **Dilated indirect ophthalmoscopy by ophthalmology — within 24 h, no later than 72 h** (hemorrhages fade): for intracranial hemorrhage or injury on imaging, unexplained coma, seizures or altered consciousness in a child < 5 years, visible eye injury, or coagulopathy. **Not a screening test** in the neurologically normal infant — image the brain first.¹⁹⁹
- **Bleeding-disorder evaluation** when bruising or intracranial hemorrhage is what raises the concern: **PT, aPTT, CBC with platelets, von Willebrand antigen and activity, factor VIII and IX activity**. Unnecessary when injuries are patterned (hand marks; ear, neck or genital bruising) or clearly non-hemorrhagic (fractures, burns). After transfusion, delay testing until transfused products have cleared; viscoelastic tests (TEG/ROTEM) are not acceptable for this purpose.³⁷²
- **Occult abdominal injury — screen every child < 5 years: AST, ALT, lipase, urinalysis. Contrast-enhanced abdominal CT if AST or ALT > 80 IU/L** or abdominal bruising, tenderness or distension — a quarter of injuries with raised transaminases have no abdominal signs.^{368,373}

▴ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — for safety and investigation whenever abuse is a realistic concern.
- **Refer — now** — child-protection team, social work, and safeguarding lead; police per local law.

Massive Transfusion & Blood Products

MINUTES

Eur. trauma guideline 2023

Balanced-ratio resuscitation with the per-kg doses — and the two silent killers, ionized hypocalcemia and the cold, acidotic child.

▴ ACTIVATE EARLY — ANY OF

- **> 40 mL/kg** of blood products in 24 h · **~1 blood volume** ($\approx 70\text{--}80\text{ mL/kg}$) in 24 h · or **> 20 mL/kg red cells in 2 h** with ongoing bleeding.¹⁵
- Uncontrolled hemorrhage with instability, a high **pediatric age-adjusted shock index (SIPA)**, or clinical judgment — **activate the protocol early, not late**.¹⁵

Component (aim 1:1:1)	Dose	Notes
Packed red cells	10–20 mL/kg	Emergency: uncrossmatched O-negative until type-specific is ready ^{16,355}
Fresh frozen plasma	10–20 mL/kg	Give in a 1:1:1 ratio with red cells & platelets (pediatric consensus; adult RCT evidence) ^{15,356} ; dose: ATLS 10–20 mL/kg ¹⁶ , BSH 15–20 mL/kg ³⁵⁵
Platelets	10–20 mL/kg (often 10)	Dose: ATLS 10–20 mL/kg ¹⁶ ; BSH 15–20 mL/kg aliquots in major hemorrhage ³⁵⁵
Cryoprecipitate	5–10 mL/kg	For fibrinogen < 1.5 g/L (or give fibrinogen concentrate) ^{352,355}

⚠ THE TWO SILENT KILLERS

Ionized hypocalcemia — citrate in stored products chelates calcium, worsening coagulopathy and cardiac contractility; keep **ionized Ca** $\geq$ **~1.1 mmol/L** and recheck it with every blood gas during transfusion.^{352,355} **The lethal triad** — hypothermia + acidosis + coagulopathy: **warm every product and the child**, correct acidosis, and treat coagulopathy early.³⁵²

Adjunct	Dose	Notes
Tranexamic acid (TXA)	15 mg/kg IV (max 1 g) over 10 min, then 2 mg/kg/h for at least 8 h or until bleeding stops	Give within 3 h of injury ^{354,355} ; consider in TBI with GCS $\leq$ 12 or intracranial bleeding on CT (adult trial, CRASH-3). ³⁷⁴
Calcium gluconate	50–100 mg/kg IV (max 2–3 g) – local practice US label initial bolus: 29–60 mg/kg (> 1 mo to < 17 yr); 100–200 mg/kg (neonate); 1–2 g ($\geq$ 17 yr) ³⁷⁵	Slow IV via a secure IV line; extravasation can cause calcinosis cutis and tissue necrosis ³⁷⁵

▴ TARGETS

- **Fibrinogen** > 1.5 g/L^{15,352,355} • **platelets** > 50 $\times 10^9$ /L with ongoing bleeding (> 100 with TBI)³⁵² • **PT ratio** < 1.5.^{352,355}

✦ DON'T DROP THE PRESSURE

- In children, and especially with TBI or threatened perfusion, maintain age-appropriate blood pressure throughout resuscitation — **target SBP no less than 70 + 2 $\times$ age (yr) mmHg**^{16,24}, address ongoing losses, avoid hypotension.^{15,215}
- Use **viscoelastic testing (TEG — thromboelastography / ROTEM — rotational thromboelastometry; bedside whole-blood clotting tests)** to guide which component to give, where available^{15,352}, and watch for **hyperkalemia** with large-volume or irradiated red cells.³⁵⁵

▶ WORKUP – SEND AT ACTIVATION, REPEAT EVERY 30-60 MIN

- CBC (hemoglobin, platelets), **fibrinogen**, PT/INR ± aPTT, **ionized calcium**, blood gas with lactate / base deficit, type & crossmatch; **point-of-care viscoelastic coagulation testing** (thromboelastography, TEG/ROTEM) if available; monitor temperature and potassium.³⁵²

◆ LOCAL & EVIDENCE

- Activate your hospital massive-hemorrhage protocol and follow its ratios and dosing.^{15,352,355}
- Pediatric ratios and thresholds are largely **EXTRAPOLATED FROM ADULT RCTS** (PROPPR, CRASH-2/CRASH-3); the pediatric TXA signal (PED-TRAX) is observational.^{354,356,357,374}
- Verify every dose against local protocol.³⁵⁵

14

Renal & Urology

AKI · HUS · hypertensive emergency · acute scrotum · foreskin emergencies · priapism · hematuria

Acute Kidney Injury HOURS

Abrupt fall in kidney function — rising creatinine and/or falling urine output.

▶ RECOGNIZE & DEFINE

- Suspect in any child with oliguria/anuria, rising creatinine, edema or fluid overload, or unexplained electrolyte disturbance.³⁷⁶
- **KDIGO (Kidney Disease: Improving Global Outcomes) stages AKI 1-3** — Stage 1 is the threshold that diagnoses AKI (see the table below).³⁷⁶

KDIGO STAGING – GRADE BY THE WORSE OF CREATININE OR URINE OUTPUT³⁷⁶

Stage	Serum creatinine	Urine output
1	1.5–1.9× baseline, or a rise ≥ 26.5 μmol/L (≥ 0.3 mg/dL)	< 0.5 mL/kg/h for 6–12 h
2	2.0–2.9× baseline	< 0.5 mL/kg/h for ≥ 12 h
3	≥ 3.0× baseline, or ≥ 353.6 μmol/L (≥ 4.0 mg/dL), or dialysis started, or – if age < 18 y – eGFR < 35 mL/min/1.73 m ²	< 0.3 mL/kg/h for ≥ 24 h, or anuria ≥ 12 h

FIND THE CATEGORY – IT DRIVES TREATMENT

PRE-RENAL • impaired perfusion (commonest)

Hypovolemia, shock, sepsis — poor perfusion.
→ **Restore perfusion:** if volume loss, give fluid; if another cause, treat that cause. Reversible if treated early.³⁷⁶

RENAL • intrinsic

HUS (see [Hemolytic Uremic Syndrome](#)), glomerulonephritis, acute tubular necrosis, nephrotoxins. → **Supportive care; treat the cause.**³⁷⁶

POST-RENAL • obstruction

Posterior urethral valves, stones, neurogenic bladder. → **Insert a urinary catheter first**, then image. After relief, watch for **post-obstructive diuresis** (urine > 3.5–5 mL/kg/h — local practice threshold, not guideline-stated) — replace fluid/electrolytes with nephrology.

MANAGE – VOLUME STATUS DRIVES FLUID THERAPY

Assess volume status first, then treat by category:

- **Hypovolemic / intravascularly deplete** (cool peripheries, tachycardia, prolonged capillary refill, low BP, weight loss) — resuscitate with **isotonic crystalloid**.
- **Euvolemic** (well-perfused, no edema, no fluid-overload signs) — match intake to **insensible losses plus measured output**¹⁸²; do **not** apply routine 4-2-1 (Holliday–Segar) maintenance during established AKI (expert consensus — not guideline-stated).
- **Hypervolemic / overloaded** (edema, hypertension, raised JVP, pulmonary crackles or a gallop, weight gain) — **restrict fluids**; diuretics do not aid recovery but may be used for established hypervolemia.³⁷⁶

Stop nephrotoxins (NSAIDs, aminoglycosides, contrast) and adjust drug doses. Watch potassium, sodium, acid–base; **avoid potassium in maintenance fluids unless treating hypokalemia.**³⁷⁶ Involve nephrology for KDIGO stage 2–3 or worsening AKI; arrange structured follow-up (stage 2–3, AKI ≥ 7 days, incomplete recovery, pre-existing CKD, or recurrent AKI).³⁷⁶

WHEN TO CALL NEPHROLOGY / PICU FOR DIALYSIS – THE "AEIOU" TRIGGERS

Refer urgently for dialysis / CRRT when any of these will **not** correct with medical treatment:

- **A — Acidosis:** severe metabolic acidosis (pH < 7.1) despite bicarbonate / ventilation.³⁷⁶
- **E — Electrolytes:** hyperkalemia that keeps rising or recurs despite full medical therapy.
- **I — Intoxication:** a dialyzable poison / drug (salicylate, methanol, ethylene glycol, lithium, theophylline).³⁷⁷
- **O — Overload:** fluid overload / pulmonary edema — **or severe hypertension driven by volume overload** — not responding to fluid restriction + diuretics (especially if it limits feeding or ventilation).
- **U — Uremia:** symptomatic — encephalopathy, pericarditis, or bleeding.³⁷⁶

The clinical picture — not the creatinine or urea number — decides. Recognize early and call; the specialist chooses the modality (hemodialysis, CRRT, or peritoneal dialysis).³⁷⁶

CROSS-REFERENCE

Treat life-threatening hyperkalemia immediately — see [Acute Electrolyte Emergencies](#) (Endocrine & Metabolic).

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all but mild pre-renal AKI; oliguria, hyperkalemia, fluid overload, or acidosis → high-dependency.
- **Home** — resolving pre-renal AKI with normalizing function and follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — nephrology for KDIGO stage 2–3, no clear cause, or need for dialysis.

Hemolytic Uremic Syndrome HOURS

Triad: microangiopathic hemolytic anemia + thrombocytopenia + acute kidney injury.

▲ RECOGNIZE

- **Typical (STEC):** preceded by bloody diarrhea; pallor, reduced urine, edema, petechiae, irritability.³⁷⁸
- **Blood film:** fragmented red cells (schistocytes), low platelets, negative direct antiglobulin test, high lactate dehydrogenase.³⁷⁸
- **Atypical (non-diarrheal) HUS:** STEC-negative; any age. **Primary** — inherited or antibody-mediated complement dysregulation (low C3, family history, relapsing course). **Secondary** — invasive *S. pneumoniae* (pneumonia/empyema, meningitis, bacteremia; **direct antiglobulin test positive; avoid plasma-containing products** — use washed red cells and platelets; treat the infection), HIV, drugs (chemotherapy, calcineurin inhibitors, ionizing radiation), systemic disease (lupus, antiphospholipid syndrome, scleroderma), and cobalamin C defect (methylmalonic aciduria with homocystinuria — check homocysteine and methylmalonic acid in infants). The underlying condition is usually already known; this guide details the complement-mediated form.³⁷⁸

▲ WORKUP

- CBC + film, U&E/creatinine, LDH, haptoglobin, direct Coombs (negative).
- **Send C3, C4, CH50 and ADAMTS13** (ADAMTS13 = the von Willebrand factor–cleaving enzyme; **severely low confirms TTP (thrombotic thrombocytopenic purpura), normal points to HUS**)³⁷⁸ **before** any plasma therapy or eculizumab. **If available, also send anti-factor-H antibodies and complement-gene screening** (*CFH*, *CD46/MCP*, *CFI*, *C3*, *CFB*, *THBD* and *DGKE*) to confirm complement dysregulation, guide prognosis and estimate recurrence risk, including after transplantation — results take weeks and must not delay treatment. Not currently available in Kuwait: store samples and send out.^{378,379}
- Stool culture for *E. coli* O157 and Shiga-toxin PCR/antigen when diarrhea is present.³⁷⁸

SUPPORTIVE CARE IS THE MAINSTAY

- Careful fluid and electrolyte management — in suspected STEC-HUS, early isotonic volume expansion before oligo-anuria may reduce kidney injury; once oliguric or fluid-overloaded, restrict fluids and involve nephrology.³⁷⁸
- Manage the acute kidney injury (see [Acute Kidney Injury](#)); transfuse packed red cells for symptomatic anemia or Hb < 6–7 g/dL (platelets only for active bleeding or a procedure); dialysis as needed — dialysis does not change STEC-HUS prognosis.³⁷⁸
- Monitor closely through the **5–14-day peak period**: daily CBC, creatinine, electrolytes and LDH, plus urine output, blood pressure and weight.³⁷⁸



DECISION

Typical (STEC) or atypical (complement-mediated)?

TYPICAL • STEC

Supportive care only. Benefit of eculizumab in STEC-HUS is unproven — not routine. The only placebo-controlled RCT (100 children) showed no improvement in the acute course, dialysis or extrarenal disease; use, if any, is a nephrology decision in severe neurological involvement.^{378,380}

ATYPICAL • aHUS

Complement inhibition (eculizumab/ravulizumab) — nephrology directed. **Meningococcal risk is > 1,000-fold and vaccination alone does not prevent it:** give **MenACWY + MenB ≥ 2 weeks before the first dose**; if treatment cannot wait, vaccinate and start **antibiotic prophylaxis (e.g., penicillin V) for the duration of therapy**. Boosters: MenACWY every 5 years (every 3 years if < 7 years at the last dose); MenB 1 year after the series, then every 2–3 years while on treatment. **Any fever = emergency blood cultures and IV ceftriaxone** — 14 of 16 US cases occurred in vaccinated patients, most from non-groupable strains.^{381,382}

⚠ AVOID

- Antibiotics in STEC (may increase toxin release — generally avoided), antimotility agents (loperamide), and NSAIDs.³⁷⁸
- Do not transfuse platelets unless active bleeding or a procedure is planned.³⁷⁸

▀ ADMIT • DISCHARGE • REFER

- **Admit** — all → monitoring and supportive care; anuria/severe → high-dependency. **PICU** for neurologic symptoms or hemodynamic instability; involve **nephrology** early for atypical HUS.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; after hematologic and renal recovery.

- **Refer — now — nephrology** (dialysis); atypical HUS → a **nephrology specialist** for complement inhibition / eculizumab.

Hypertensive Emergency MINUTES

Severe hypertension **with** new or progressing end-organ damage (encephalopathy, seizures, facial palsy, severe headache; heart failure or chest pain; acute kidney injury; retinopathy or blurred vision).

ASSESS FOR END-ORGAN DAMAGE

- **Brain:** headache, vomiting, altered mental status, seizures, visual symptoms, focal deficits.
- **Heart:** tachycardia, gallop, pulmonary edema, heart failure, chest pain (older children).
- **Kidney:** AKI, oliguria, hematuria, proteinuria.
- **Eyes:** blurred vision, retinal hemorrhages, papilledema.³⁸³

WORKUP

- CBC, electrolytes, urea, creatinine.
- Urinalysis ± urine protein.
- ECG.
- Chest radiograph if heart failure suspected.
- Echocardiography if LV dysfunction suspected.
- Fundoscopy if available.
- Renal ultrasound ± Doppler when a renal cause is suspected.
- CT/MRI brain only if neurological symptoms or concern for intracranial pathology.³⁸³

PEARL

In children, severe hypertension is **secondary until proven otherwise** — renal disease is the commonest cause.³⁸³

LOWER GRADUALLY — CONTROLLED DESCENT

- A true hypertensive emergency needs PICU/high-dependency monitoring with a titratable IV infusion under specialist guidance.
- Reduce blood pressure by no more than ~25% in the first 8 hours, then normalize over 24–48 hours.
- Abrupt drops risk cerebral, renal, and retinal ischemia.³⁸³



TREAT COMPLICATIONS

Seizures → benzodiazepine. Fluid overload (e.g., acute glomerulonephritis) → furosemide. Monitor in PICU.³⁸³

MEDICATIONS – TITRATABLE IV AGENTS PREFERRED

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Labetalol	bolus 0.2–1 mg/kg (max 40 mg); infusion 0.25–3 mg/kg/h	IV; preferred first-line (best option) in Kuwait ; avoid in asthma, heart failure ³⁸³
Hydralazine	0.1–0.5 mg/kg/dose (max 20 mg)	IV/IM every 4 h; second-line ; may cause reflex tachycardia
Sodium nitroprusside	0.3–8 mcg/kg/min	IV; reserve — cyanide risk with prolonged use/renal impairment ³⁸³
Esmolol	50–300 mcg/kg/min (after load)	IV; short-acting; may cause bradycardia/bronchospasm
Furosemide	1–2 mg/kg (max 40–80 mg)	IV; if fluid overloaded (e.g., post-streptococcal glomerulonephritis)

◆ **NOTE** Oral or sublingual nifedipine can cause a precipitous, uncontrolled fall and is **NOT** recommended for a true hypertensive emergency.³⁸³

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all true emergencies → PICU with a titratable infusion.
- **Home from the ward** — not from the emergency; controlled blood pressure with a plan.
- **Refer — now** — nephrology/cardiology for cause.
- **Refer — clinic** — nephrology/cardiology for long-term control.

Nephrotic Syndrome HOURS IPNA 2023

Heavy proteinuria, low albumin, and edema — usually steroid-responsive, but watch the complications. Doses follow the International Pediatric Nephrology Association (IPNA) 2023 guideline.

▴ RECOGNIZE

- **The triad:** nephrotic-range proteinuria (urine protein/creatinine > 200 mg/mmol, or ≥ 3+ on dipstick), **hypoalbuminemia < 30 g/L (< 3.0 g/dL)**, and edema (periorbital → generalized, ascites, scrotal/labial); usually with hyperlipidemia.³⁸⁴
- In a child **1–10 years** without the atypical features below, it is almost always steroid-responsive minimal-change disease — treat without a biopsy.³⁸⁴

CONFIRM & ASSESS

- Confirm proteinuria (first-morning-void protein/creatinine ratio preferred over a 24-hour collection); send albumin, renal function and electrolytes, lipids; weigh, record blood pressure, assess volume status.
- Assess clinically for active infection before commencing high-dose corticosteroids; investigate according to symptoms and risk factors rather than performing routine infection screening in an otherwise well child.³⁸⁴



FIRST PRESENTATION

- Oral **prednisolone 60 mg/m²/dose (≈ 2 mg/kg/dose, max 60 mg)** once daily for 4–6 weeks, then 40 mg/m² (max 40 mg) on alternate days for a further 4–6 weeks (total 8–12 weeks)
- Add a no-added-salt diet (no fluid or protein restriction) and ensure pneumococcal vaccination; routine antibiotic prophylaxis is not recommended — instead treat suspected infection promptly, including spontaneous bacterial peritonitis.³⁸⁴

⚠️ COMPLICATIONS TO PRE-EMPT

- **Hypovolemia** can hide behind gross edema — abdominal pain, cool peripheries, tachycardia, oliguria; needs urgent senior/nephrology input; treat with **fluid resuscitation if needed and 20% albumin plus a diuretic** (avoid diuretic monotherapy). **Hypervolemia** presents differently — edema with **strong peripheral pulses and warm peripheries**; treat with diuretics and close reassessment.³⁸⁴
- Watch for **spontaneous bacterial peritonitis** (pneumococcal) and other sepsis, **venous or arterial thromboembolism** (these children are hypercoagulable), and **acute kidney injury (AKI)**.³⁸⁴

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — first presentation, hypovolemia, peritonitis or sepsis, thromboembolism, severe edema with respiratory compromise, AKI, or a relapse not responding to oral steroid.
- **Home** — steroid responsiveness is not required before discharge, provided close OPD follow-up is arranged: a well child with no complications, able to tolerate oral steroids, with the family able to monitor first-morning urine and act on a written plan.
- **Refer — now** — Nephrology for any atypical feature (age < 1 or > 12 years, persistent hypertension, gross hematuria, low complement (C3), renal impairment) — these may need a biopsy or second-line therapy.³⁸⁴
- **Refer — clinic** — Nephrology for steroid resistance or frequent relapse — these may need a biopsy or second-line therapy.³⁸⁴

Near-universal in Kuwait — screen first, always give analgesia, and know the complications.

▀ BEFORE YOU CIRCUMCISE – CHECKLIST

- **Examine the genitalia first. Do NOT circumcise** if hypospadias, epispadias, chordee, ambiguous genitalia / suspected DSD, micropenis, or buried / webbed penis — the foreskin may be needed for repair → refer to pediatric surgery / urology.³⁸⁵
- Contraindicated in an **unstable or sick infant** — confirm normal feeding, elimination and thermoregulation; ensure vitamin K given.³⁸⁵
- Family history of a bleeding disorder → coagulation studies / defer.³⁸⁵
- Informed parental consent. In Kuwait usually performed by **pediatric (or general) surgery from ~1 week of age** (and later in infancy / childhood).

◆ ANALGESIA – NEVER OMIT

- **Dorsal penile nerve block** or subcutaneous **ring block** (lidocaine 1% without epinephrine; volume ≤1 mL and ceiling 3–4 mg/kg per local practice) — the most effective analgesia studied for newborn circumcision; minor bleeding, swelling or hematoma can occur.^{385,386}
- Add topical EMLA, oral sucrose, non-nutritive sucking and acetaminophen.
- Sucrose or EMLA **alone are not enough**; combination analgesia is best.³⁸⁷

METHODS

Gomco clamp, Mogen clamp, or Plastibell (ring) device — each with its own technique and complication profile.³⁸⁵

WOUND CARE

- Clean gently with warm water at each diaper change; avoid soap and wipes (they sting).
- **Gomco / Mogen:** apply petroleum jelly (or antibiotic ointment) to the glans and on the diaper for ~5–7 days to stop the wound sticking. A moist **yellow coating** (granulation) on the glans is **normal healing**, not infection.³⁸⁵
- **Plastibell:** the ring falls off by itself in ~5–10 days — **do not pull it**; sponge-bathe until it separates³⁸⁵; seek review if it slips onto the shaft or has not fallen by 10–14 days.
- Heals in ~7–10 days. After healing, gently retract the skin at the groove to prevent adhesions / skin bridges.³⁸⁸

⚠️ COMPLICATIONS – WHEN TO SEEK URGENT REVIEW

- **Bleeding** more than a few drops (commonest — direct pressure and a compressive dressing around the penis, then pediatric surgery review + coagulation workup)
- spreading redness up the shaft, pus or fever = **wound infection**
- no urine for ~8 h = **retention**³⁸⁸
- Plastibell ring migrated with a **dusky glans** = constriction (emergency)
- trapped / concealed penis, adhesions, skin bridges, or late **meatal stenosis** (deflected stream)³⁸⁸ → pediatric surgery / urology.

Acute Scrotum

MINUTES

6-HOUR WINDOW

Sudden scrotal pain is testicular torsion until proven otherwise — a clinical diagnosis; do not wait for imaging.

▴ DEFINE

- **Acute scrotum** = sudden scrotal pain/swelling. **Testicular torsion until proven otherwise** — a time-critical surgical emergency. Bimodal peaks: the neonate and the peri-pubertal boy.³⁸⁹
- Differential: **torsion of the appendix testis** (blue-dot sign, gradual, milder), **epididymo-orchitis** (dysuria, gradual, older/sexually active), trauma, idiopathic scrotal edema, incarcerated inguinal hernia.³⁹⁰

▴ APPROACH – FAVORS TORSION

- **Sudden severe pain** ± nausea/vomiting, **high-riding testis, horizontal lie, absent cremasteric reflex**, diffuse tenderness.³⁸⁹
- The **TWIST score** (hard testis, swelling, nausea/vomiting, absent cremasteric reflex, high-riding testis) risk-stratifies but does not replace surgical judgment.³⁸⁹

⚠️ WORK-UP

- **Torsion is a clinical diagnosis — do not delay surgical exploration for imaging.** Color Doppler ultrasound (absent intratesticular flow) is useful only when the diagnosis is equivocal **and** will not delay surgery.³⁸⁹
- Urinalysis: pyuria or bacteriuria supports bacterial epididymitis — but a **normal urinalysis does not exclude epididymitis, and an abnormal one does not exclude torsion**; send a culture.³⁹⁰

⚠ RED FLAGS – THE CLOCK

- Testicular salvage is **time-dependent**: near-universal ($\approx 97\%$) if detorsion occurs within ~ 6 hours of onset, falling progressively thereafter ($\approx 79\%$ at 7–12 h, $\approx 42\%$ at 19–24 h).³⁹¹
- Neonatal torsion and any delayed presentation need urgent senior/urology input.

▀ MANAGEMENT

- **Immediate urology/surgical referral** for scrotal exploration, detorsion, and **bilateral orchidopexy**.³⁹⁰
- If surgery is delayed, a trained clinician may attempt **manual detorsion** (usually 'opening a book' — medial-to-lateral) **only if experienced** as a temporizing measure while immediate exploration is arranged, guided by pain relief; success does not remove the need for surgery and orchidopexy.³⁹⁰
- **Consult surgery/urology at once and confirm the diagnosis.** Torsion → surgery. Once torsion is excluded: **appendix-testis torsion** → NSAID analgesia and rest; **epididymo-orchitis** → NSAIDs, rest and scrotal support, with **antibiotics only if urinalysis or urine culture shows bacterial infection** (send the culture before treating — prepubertal epididymitis is usually non-bacterial).³⁹⁰

✦ PEARL – ABDOMINAL PAIN CAN BE A TORSION

Examine the testes in every boy with acute lower-abdominal or groin pain — torsion frequently refers pain to the abdomen and is missed when the scrotum is not examined.³⁹²

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — torsion (confirmed or not excluded) → emergency exploration; incarcerated hernia; epididymo-orchitis only if systemically unwell, an infant, or unable to take oral analgesia.³⁹⁰
- **Home from the emergency department** — once the surgical/urology team has excluded torsion: appendix-testis torsion and epididymo-orchitis go home on NSAIDs $\pm$ antibiotics per urine results, review in 48–72 h.³⁹⁰
- **Refer — now** — surgery/urology IMMEDIATELY to confirm the diagnosis (torsion → exploration within 6 h).³⁸⁹
- **Refer — clinic** — prepubertal epididymitis warrants outpatient renal-tract ultrasound (underlying urogenital anomaly in $\sim 25\text{--}30\%$).³⁹⁰

◆ **SEE ALSO** [Testicular Torsion](#) — the time-critical diagnosis to exclude first.

Testicular Torsion

MINUTES

ADOLESCENT & NEONATE

Salvage window ~6 hours. A boy's abdominal pain → examine the scrotum.

RECOGNIZE

- Sudden severe scrotal/lower-abdominal pain, nausea/vomiting, swelling. High-riding/horizontal testis, **absent cremasteric reflex**, negative Prehn sign.³⁸⁹

Clinical suspicion = urgent exploration. Don't delay for imaging.



ACT

- **Immediate urology / pediatric surgery** → exploration, detorsion + bilateral orchidopexy.³⁹⁰
- Color Doppler ultrasound **only if it will not delay** surgery.
- Manual detorsion may temporize **only in experienced hands** — do not attempt if untrained (can worsen the torsion), and never let it delay surgical exploration.³⁹⁰

ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → emergency exploration.
- **Home from the ward** — post-operative.
- **Refer** — **now** — pediatric surgery/urology IMMEDIATELY (explore within 6 h); do not delay for imaging.

◆ SEE ALSO [Acute Scrotum](#) for the full differential.

Paraphimosis

HOURS

REDUCE PROMPTLY

A retracted foreskin trapped behind the glans — edema then ischemia; reduce promptly.

DEFINE

- **Paraphimosis** — a retracted foreskin trapped behind the glans, cannot be reduced. The constricting band causes progressive glans and distal-foreskin edema, then venous → arterial compromise. A urological emergency.³⁸⁸
- Commonly **iatrogenic** — the foreskin is left retracted after catheterization, cleaning, or examination.³⁸⁸

APPROACH & WORK-UP

- Painful, swollen glans with an edematous 'collar' of foreskin proximal to it. Diagnosis is clinical.
- Distinguish from balanoposthitis (foreskin/glans inflammation without a trapped retracted ring).

⚠️ RED FLAGS

Increasing edema, dusky glans, or pain out of proportion signal arterial compromise and impending necrosis — **reduce promptly; escalate to urology if reduction fails.** ³⁸⁸

MANAGEMENT

▀ REDUCE IT

- **Analgesia first** — penile block or procedural analgesia.
- **Reduce edema** — sustained manual compression of the glans (± a wrap such as saline-soaked gauze, ice, or an osmotic agent such as granulated sugar) for several minutes. ³⁸⁸
- **Reduce the foreskin** — push the glans back with the thumbs while drawing the foreskin forward over it with the fingers.
- **If manual reduction fails** — urology for a dorsal-slit or emergency reduction. ³⁸⁸

✦ PEARL — PREVENTION IS THE CURE

Always return the foreskin to its natural forward position after any catheterization, cleaning, or examination, and teach carers never to force-retract a child's foreskin. ³⁸⁸

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — if reduction fails or there is tissue compromise.
- **Home from the emergency department** — after successful reduction with follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — urology for failed reduction.
- **Refer — clinic** — urology for recurrent episodes.

Balanitis / Balanoposthitis & Phimosis ASSESS COMMON

Glans/foreskin inflammation and non-retractile foreskin; physiologic phimosis is normal, needs no treatment.

▀ DEFINE

- **Balanitis** = inflammation of the glans; **balanoposthitis** = glans + foreskin. **Phimosis** = non-retractile foreskin — **physiologic** (normal in young boys) or **pathologic** (scarred).
- **Physiologic phimosis is normal**: non-retractile in most infants, becomes retractile with age (≈ 99% by 17 years). Needs no treatment. ³⁸⁸

▀ APPROACH & WORK-UP

- Balanitis: red, swollen, tender glans/foreskin ± discharge, dysuria. Usually hygiene-related or candidal; consider sexually transmitted causes in adolescents.
- Distinguish physiologic phimosis (soft, healthy, pink opening) from **pathologic** (scarred white fibrotic ring — balanitis xerotica obliterans/lichen sclerosus). ³⁸⁸

- Clinical diagnosis; swab if recurrent/purulent; urinalysis if voiding symptoms.

⚠ RED FLAGS

Pathologic phimosis (white scarred ring / BXO), recurrent balanoposthitis, **ballooning or difficulty voiding**³⁸⁸, or **urinary retention** — refer to urology.

MANAGEMENT

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Balanitis — general	Hygiene, warm saline soaks	Retract gently only as far as comfortable; avoid irritants.
Balanitis — bacterial/candidal	Topical/oral antibiotic or topical antifungal	Guided by likely organism; treat/screen for STI in adolescents.
Physiologic phimosis	No treatment; do not force-retract	Reassure; resolves with age.
Symptomatic / early pathologic phimosis	Topical betamethasone 0.05% applied twice daily for 4–6 weeks	≈ 80% success; avoids or defers circumcision. ³⁸⁸
Pathologic phimosis / BXO / recurrent	Refer for circumcision	Definitive for scarred foreskin or lichen sclerosis. ³⁸⁸

✦ PEARL — HANDS OFF THE YOUNG FORESKIN

Never forcibly retract a young boy's foreskin — it tears, bleeds, and scars, converting harmless physiologic phimosis into pathologic phimosis.³⁸⁸

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — rarely — severe infection or urinary retention.
- **Home from the emergency department** — most, with hygiene and topical treatment.
- **Refer — clinic** — urology for pathological phimosis, recurrent balanitis, or balanitis xerotica obliterans.

Priapism MINUTES > 4 H = EMERGENCY

Painful rigid erection > 4 hours; ischemic priapism is a penile compartment syndrome — relieve fast.

▀ DEFINE

- **Priapism** — persistent erection > 4 hours unrelated to stimulation. **Ischemic** (low-flow, painful, rigid corpora — penile compartment syndrome, a true emergency) versus **non-ischemic** (high-flow, usually post-traumatic, not urgent).³⁹³

- Most pediatric priapism is **ischemic and associated with sickle cell disease** (the cause in about two-thirds of childhood cases); short self-limiting 'stuttering' episodes are common in SCD and can progress to a prolonged ischemic event.³⁹⁴

▲ APPROACH & WORK-UP

- Rigid, painful corpora cavernosa with a **soft glans and corpus spongiosum** → ischemic. Ask about sickle cell disease and drugs.
- **Cavernosal blood gas** distinguishes: ischemic = dark, hypoxic, acidotic blood. **Color Doppler ultrasound** also separates the two (ischemic = absent/low cavernosal flow; non-ischemic = normal/high flow). **Do not delay treatment for imaging.**³⁹³

⚠ RED FLAGS – THE CLOCK

- Smooth-muscle edema and atrophy begin as early as ~6 hours; risk of permanent erectile dysfunction rises with duration.³⁹³
- Ischemic priapism > 4 hours is a time-sensitive emergency needing immediate urology (and hematology in sickle cell disease) — do not delay urologic intervention for sickle-cell measures.³⁹³

MANAGEMENT

▲ RELIEVE THE ERECTION FIRST

- **In sickle cell disease, do not delay penile intervention for exchange transfusion** — urologic relief comes first; sickle measures (hydration, oxygen, analgesia) run concurrently.³⁹⁵
- **Corporal aspiration ± saline irrigation plus intracavernosal phenylephrine** (urology-directed), repeated as needed, with blood-pressure and heart-rate monitoring.³⁹³
- Surgical shunting only after aspiration + sympathomimetic have failed.³⁹³

Drug	Dose	Notes
Phenylephrine (intracavernosal)	100–200 mcg/dose every 3–5 min (dilute to 100–500 mcg/mL); max ~1 mg	Monitor BP and HR; doses shown are adult guidance — lower doses are recommended in children. ^{393,394}

✦ PEARL – CALL UROLOGY NOW

Acute ischemic priapism is an emergency; in sickle cell disease relieve the erection first and give sickle-specific care alongside — not instead.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — ischemic priapism → urgent intervention.
- **Home** — after detumescence with follow-up.

- **Refer — now** — urology (aspiration/irrigation) and hematology in sickle cell disease; do not delay urology.

Gross Hematuria

ASSESS

APPROACH

Confirm true hematuria, then sort glomerular from non-glomerular — that split directs the entire work-up.

DEFINE

- **Gross hematuria** — visibly bloody or tea/cola-colored urine. Confirm **true hematuria** (dipstick positive **and** ≥ 5 RBC/high-power field on microscopy) — exclude mimics: foods (beetroot), drugs (rifampin), myoglobin, urate, menstrual contamination.³⁹⁶

APPROACH — GLOMERULAR VS NON-GLOMERULAR

- **Glomerular** — brown/cola-colored, dysmorphic RBCs or RBC casts, proteinuria, hypertension, edema → glomerulonephritis (post-infectious, IgA nephropathy, Alport). **Recurrent painless gross hematuria** with a fever, viral illness or exercise → most likely **IgA nephropathy**; hematuria with **hearing impairment** (or a family history of kidney failure) → **Alport syndrome** — send genetics first.³⁹⁶
- **Non-glomerular** — bright red $\pm$ clots → urologic: UTI, hypercalciuria/stones, trauma, benign urethrorrhagia, rarely tumor. **Timing helps**: blood at the **start** of the stream → urethra; at the **end** → bladder. **Benign urethrorrhagia** — prepubertal boys, spots of blood at the end of or between voids, resolves spontaneously.³⁹⁷
- Commonest causes overall: UTI and hypercalciuria; gross hematuria without glomerular features is **usually benign**.³⁹⁷

WORK-UP

- Urinalysis with **microscopy** (casts, dysmorphic RBCs), urine culture, **blood pressure**; urine protein:creatinine and calcium:creatinine ratios; serum creatinine/electrolytes; **C3/C4 and anti-DNase B** if glomerulonephritis is suspected; **renal-bladder ultrasound** — stones, polycystic kidney disease, trauma.³⁹⁶
- Image for trauma or obstructing clot as indicated.

RED FLAGS

- Hypertension, edema, oliguria, or rising creatinine → glomerulonephritis with acute kidney injury.³⁹⁶
- Flank pain with clots (stones), significant trauma, a palpable mass, or systemic symptoms.

MANAGEMENT

- Treat the underlying cause. **Nephrology referral** for glomerular features (hypertension, proteinuria, casts, reduced GFR); **urology** for structural/urologic causes.³⁹⁶

- Isolated gross hematuria with normal blood pressure, no proteinuria, and normal ultrasound can usually be observed.³⁹⁷

✦ PEARL – DIPSTICK + MICROSCOPY + BLOOD PRESSURE

Those three bedside steps triage most children — color and RBC morphology sort glomerular from non-glomerular and direct the whole work-up.³⁹⁶

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — clot retention, significant bleeding, hypertension, or acute nephritis with impairment.
- **Home from the emergency department** — well child with a benign cause and outpatient workup.
- **Refer — clinic** — nephrology (glomerular) or urology (structural, stones, or mass).

Acute Post-infectious Glomerulonephritis (PIGN) ASSESS 2–12 YR

The commonest acute nephritis in children — cola urine, puffy eyes and a high blood pressure 1–6 weeks after an infection, classically streptococcal.

▀ RECOGNIZE

- **Acute nephritic syndrome** — cola/tea-colored urine, periorbital/leg edema, **hypertension**, oliguria; onset **1–3 weeks after pharyngitis** or **3–6 weeks after impetigo** (skin infection is the commoner trigger in hot climates). Group A streptococcus is the classic cause, but other bacteria, viruses, fungi and parasites cause the same immune-mediated nephritis — hence **post-infectious** (infection-related) GN.^{398,399}
- Ask about recent sore throat, skin sores or scabies; examine the skin, blood pressure and volume status.

▀ WORK-UP

- Urinalysis and microscopy — dysmorphic RBCs, **RBC casts**, proteinuria (usually sub-nephrotic); urine protein:creatinine ratio.
- Creatinine, urea, electrolytes (potassium), albumin, CBC.
- **Low C3 with normal C4** supports the diagnosis; **anti-DNase B** confirms recent streptococcal infection (positive in nearly all; ASO titer adds little); throat or skin swab if there is a current infection.^{398,399}
- Chest X-ray if breathless or overloaded; renal ultrasound only if the picture is atypical.

MANAGE — SUPPORTIVE CARE

- **Manage fluid balance** (strict input/output, daily weight, fluid restriction if oliguric or overloaded) and a **no-added-salt diet**.
- **Treat hypertension** — furosemide 1–2 mg/kg IV/oral⁴² for edema, overload or hypertension is usually enough⁴⁰⁰; add a calcium-channel blocker if still hypertensive³⁹⁹. Severe hypertension with headache, seizures or visual change → [Hypertensive Emergency](#).
- **Antibiotics only for a current infection** (e.g., active pharyngitis or impetigo) — they do not alter the nephritis and are not given for the nephritis itself.³⁹⁸
- **No corticosteroids or immunosuppression** for uncomplicated disease.³⁹⁸

⚠ RED FLAGS

- **Hypertensive encephalopathy** (headache, vomiting, seizures, altered consciousness) — about 1 in 10 admissions.³⁹⁹
- **Pulmonary edema**, hyperkalemia, or a **rapidly rising creatinine** → possible crescentic glomerulonephritis — nephrology the same day (see [Acute Kidney Injury](#)).^{398,399}

✦ EXPECTED COURSE

Diuresis and normal blood pressure within 1–2 weeks; C3 normalizes by 8 weeks; microscopic hematuria may persist up to a year; recurrence is rare (course timelines: expert consensus — not guideline-stated). Long-term prognosis is good.⁴⁰⁰

▢ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — hypertension, oliguria, edema/overload, raised creatinine or hyperkalemia.
- **Home** — normal blood pressure and urine output; check blood pressure and urinalysis at 1–2 weeks, C3 at 6–8 weeks.³⁹⁹
- **Refer — now** — nephrology if creatinine keeps rising or nephrotic-range proteinuria — these may need a biopsy.³⁹⁸
- **Refer — clinic** — nephrology if C3 still low at **12 weeks** (consider C3 glomerulopathy), or hematuria/proteinuria beyond 1 year — these may need a biopsy.³⁹⁸

Rhabdomyolysis

MINUTES

DASAIM/DSIT 2019 · Mannix 2006

Muscle breakdown → tea-colored urine, a very high CK, and the twin threats of hyperkalemia and AKI.

▢ RECOGNIZE

- Myalgia, weakness and **dark (tea-/cola-colored) urine** that is **dipstick-positive for blood but shows few red cells** (myoglobin), with **creatinine kinase > 5× the upper limit**. Triggers: viral myositis (influenza), trauma/crush, extreme exertion or heat, seizures, toxins/drugs, and metabolic myopathies.⁴⁰¹

⚠ TWO IMMEDIATE DANGERS

- **Hyperkalemia** — get an ECG and treat at once (see [Acute Electrolyte Emergencies](#)).
- **Acute kidney injury** — start **early, generous IV fluids** to maintain a good urine output.⁴⁰¹
- Also watch calcium/phosphate and for **compartment syndrome** in a swollen, painful limb.⁴⁰¹ **Routine urinary alkalinization and mannitol are not recommended** (adult guidance).⁴⁰²

✦ CHASE THE CAUSE

Recurrent or exertion-out-of-proportion rhabdomyolysis, or a family history, suggests an **underlying metabolic myopathy** — refer for metabolic work-up once the acute episode is controlled.⁴⁰¹

▴ WORKUP

- **Creatine kinase** (diagnostic > 5× the upper limit of normal (ULN); **serial** to track the trend)⁴⁰¹; AKI risk climbs > 5000 U/L (adult trauma data).⁴⁰³
- **Potassium + ECG**, calcium, phosphate.
- Renal function, venous blood gas/bicarbonate; urinalysis (**heme-positive with few RBCs** = myoglobinuria) + urine myoglobin.⁴⁰¹
- Uric acid, LDH, AST; metabolic/genetic screen if recurrent or exertion-disproportionate.⁴⁰¹

▴ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — significant CK elevation, any renal impairment or hyperkalemia.
- **Refer — now** — nephrology if AKI; surgery for compartment syndrome.

15

Respiratory, Allergy & Immunology

Airway, breathing, anaphylaxis, allergy & immunology

Anaphylaxis MINUTES

Acute multisystem allergic reaction — epinephrine first, always.

▴ RECOGNIZE & DIAGNOSE

- **Diagnose anaphylaxis (GA²LEN 2024 criteria) when any one applies:**
 - 1 • **No known allergen** — acute skin/mucosal signs **plus** respiratory **or** cardiovascular involvement.
 - 2 • **Likely or known allergen exposure** — any **two** of: skin/mucosa · respiratory · cardiovascular · severe GI symptoms (severe crampy pain, repeated vomiting).
 - 3 • **Known allergen exposure** — respiratory involvement **alone** (non-inhaled allergen) **or** cardiovascular involvement **alone** (hypotension, poor perfusion, collapse) — skin signs may be absent.⁴⁰⁴

- **If in doubt, give epinephrine.** Epinephrine is given immediately for suspected anaphylaxis and may be given on clinical judgment before the criteria are fully met — the risk of a missed dose exceeds the risk of an unnecessary one.^{404,405}
- Skin: urticaria, flushing, angioedema, pruritus (absent in up to 20%).⁴⁰⁵
- Breathing: stridor, wheeze, hoarseness, falling SpO₂, cyanosis, increased work of breathing, signs of respiratory distress, persistent cough.
- Circulation: poor perfusion, hypotension, collapse — **reduced BP = low systolic for age or > 30% drop from baseline.** Infants: floppiness, drooling, pallor, sudden behavior change.⁴⁰⁵
- GI: severe crampy abdominal pain or repeated vomiting — counts toward the diagnosis, especially after a likely allergen.⁴⁰⁵
- **Not anaphylaxis:** repeated vomiting 1–4 h after a food **without** skin, respiratory or cardiovascular signs → think food protein-induced enterocolitis syndrome (FPIES) — fluids and ondansetron, not epinephrine (see [Acute FPIES](#)). **If the infant is lethargic or hypotensive, treat shock immediately** (20 mL/kg bolus) **and give epinephrine if anaphylaxis cannot be excluded.**⁴⁰⁶

1ST LINE Intramuscular epinephrine immediately — there is no contraindication⁴⁰⁵



THEN

- **Remove the allergen if possible** — stop the infusion or drug, remove the stinger.⁴⁰⁵
- Lay supine, legs up (sit if breathing is hard; never stand suddenly).
- Oxygen 10–15 L/min via non-rebreather mask.
- Stridor, voice change or tongue/lip swelling = impending airway obstruction → call anesthesia/ENT now for early, controlled intubation (see [Difficult Airway](#)).
- Fluid bolus for hypotension.
- Repeat epinephrine every 5–15 min if needed.⁴⁰⁵

refractory after ≥2 IM doses



2ND–3RD LINE Refractory after repeated IM epinephrine → urgent PICU/anesthesia support; IV epinephrine infusion only by an experienced team with monitoring · IV fluids · glucagon if on a beta-blocker.⁴⁰⁵

MEDICATIONS – EACH GIVEN SEPARATELY

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Epinephrine (adrenaline) — 1st line	0.01 mg/kg (max 0.5 mg)	IM, 1 mg/mL (1:1000), anterolateral thigh; repeat every 5–15 min ⁴⁰⁵
Epinephrine autoinjector (limited availability)	0.1 / 0.15 / 0.3 mg	Some emergency departments dispense on senior-staff authorization; otherwise via the allergy clinic. 0.1 (7.5–14 kg) · 0.15 (15–25 kg) · 0.3 (>25 kg). If the 0.1 mg device is unavailable, the 0.15 mg device may be used down to 7.5 kg.

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Epinephrine infusion (refractory)	0.1–1 mcg/kg/min (max 10 mcg/min – local practice)	IV infusion via an infusion pump; titrate to effect under PICU supervision with continuous cardiac monitoring ⁴⁰⁷ ; dose range = PALS epinephrine-infusion range ²⁴
Balanced crystalloid	20 mL/kg	IV bolus for hypotension, repeat
Salbutamol (for wheeze)	2.5–5 mg nebulized	Adjunct only — does not replace epinephrine
Diphenhydramine (for skin symptoms)	1 mg/kg/dose (max 50 mg/dose)	IV/IM; adjunct only, not first-line. May use cetirizine (age-appropriate dose) as a non-sedating alternative ⁴⁰⁵
Glucagon	20–30 mcg/kg (max 1 mg)	IV over 5 min, only if on a beta-blocker and refractory

⚠ OBSERVE EVERY CHILD BEFORE ANY DISCHARGE DECISION – NO EARLY DISCHARGE FROM THE EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT

- **Admit** — usually, for the 12-h tier: minimum 12 h if more than two doses were needed, **history of severe asthma**, anaphylaxis with **severe respiratory compromise**, possible continuing allergen absorption, presentation at night/out of hours, or the family cannot recognize and respond to deterioration.⁴⁰⁸
- **Home from the emergency department** — 2-h tier: minimum 2 h after full resolution, only when every criterion is met — good response to a single IM dose within 5–10 min, symptoms completely resolved, the child leaves with **two in-date autoinjectors** dispensed and demonstrated, and a trained adult supervising.^{405,408}
- **Home from the emergency department** — longer tiers: observe 4–6 h whenever possible, and always when any criterion is unmet or the department cannot dispense autoinjectors; minimum 6 h if two IM doses were needed or there is a history of a biphasic reaction.^{405,408}
- Treatment note (not a disposition line; unchanged) — Routine corticosteroids are no longer recommended (consider glucocorticoids for persistent bronchospasm, or severe symptoms requiring more than 2 doses of IM epinephrine or IV epinephrine).

▀ ADMIT · OBSERVE · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — more than two epinephrine doses or an epinephrine infusion; ongoing or biphasic symptoms; **moderate–severe respiratory distress** or hypotension at any point; airway involvement; history of severe asthma; any child in the 12-h observation tier.^{405,408}
- **Home from the emergency department** — after observation (emergency department / short stay): resolution after one or two IM doses, the observation tier above completed, no respiratory distress at review.
- **Home from the emergency department** — checklist (Kuwait pathway) — **Home epinephrine**: where the emergency department stocks autoinjectors, a senior physician dispenses **two devices with hands-on training** before the child leaves the department; where it does not, refer to the allergy clinic with the supply pathway (imported device)

documented and teach the family the warning signs and to call emergency services at the first sign. Written action plan; allergen-avoidance advice; non-sedating antihistamine for residual urticaria only; no routine steroid.⁴⁰⁵

- **Refer — now — PICU** for refractory anaphylactic shock despite repeated IM epinephrine requiring an epinephrine infusion, or airway compromise requiring definitive airway management.
- **Refer — clinic** — Allergy/Immunology for every case.

Anaphylaxis — epinephrine first

Recognize (GA²LEN criteria) → IM epinephrine immediately → fluids & repeat → refractory (PICU).



IM EPINEPHRINE FIRST, ALWAYS

There is no contraindication — give it before antihistamine or steroid.

recognize

1

RECOGNIZE — GA²LEN CRITERIA

- 1 No known allergen: skin/mucosa + respiratory or cardiovascular
- 2 Likely allergen: any 2 of skin/mucosa · respiratory · cardiovascular · severe GI
- 3 Known allergen: respiratory alone or cardiovascular alone

If in doubt, give epinephrine.

now

2

IM EPINEPHRINE

0.01 mg/kg (max 0.5 mg) of 1:1000 in the anterolateral thigh. Lay supine, legs up; O₂ 10–15 L/min.

5–15 min

3

FLUIDS · REPEAT

Fluid bolus for hypotension. Repeat IM epinephrine every 5–15 min as needed.

≥ 2 doses

4

REFRACTORY — PICU

Urgent PICU/anesthesia. IV epinephrine infusion by experts only; glucagon if on a beta-blocker.

Acute Asthma

MINUTES

GINA 2026

Grade severity continuously: speech, work of breathing, SpO₂, silent chest. Doses follow the Global Initiative for Asthma (GINA) 2026 strategy; PICU-level therapies are beyond GINA's scope and follow critical-care practice.

GRADE SEVERITY FIRST

- Use a validated score — the **PRAM (Pediatric Respiratory Assessment Measure)**

(validated 2–17 yr) or **PASS (Pediatric Asthma Severity Score)** — with SpO₂ on room air, work of breathing, and ability to speak or feed; reassess and re-score after each step.^{409,410}



✦ PEARL – WHEN IT ISN'T ASTHMA

- Doubt the diagnosis and look for a mimicker when wheeze is present from the **first weeks of life**, is **monophonic or focal**, fails to respond to adequate bronchodilator and steroid, or comes with faltering growth, clubbing, or chronic wet cough.
- Think: inhaled **foreign body**, tracheo-/bronchomalacia or a **vascular ring**, **cystic fibrosis** or primary ciliary dyskinesia, bronchiolitis in the infant, a **cardiac** cause (heart failure), aspiration/gastroesophageal reflux disease (GERD), and — in adolescents — inducible laryngeal obstruction (vocal cord dysfunction).⁴¹¹

1ST LINE

- **Oxygen** — start it when SpO₂ is **below 92%**. Then titrate: children **6 years and older** — keep SpO₂ **92 to 95%**; children **5 years and younger** — keep SpO₂ **at or above 92%**. Do not push saturations higher (avoid over-oxygenation).⁴¹¹
- **Inhaled salbutamol** by spacer every 20 min × 3 in the first hour, reassessing before each repeat, then titrate to response (dose by age in the table).⁴¹¹
- **Systemic corticosteroid** for a **moderate–severe** exacerbation or inadequate response to salbutamol (oral — prednisolone or dexamethasone — as effective as IV). **Not routine for mild**; avoid routine oral steroids for mild viral wheeze in preschoolers.⁴¹¹



2ND LINE MODERATE–SEVERE

- Add **ipratropium × 3**.
- Severe or poor response → **IV magnesium sulfate**.
- **Call PICU**.

life-threatening / not responding



3RD LINE • PICU Not responding / life-threatening → call PICU urgently. Continuous nebulized salbutamol, IV salbutamol, non-invasive ventilation and intubation are PICU-directed (see “Beyond GINA” below).⁴¹¹

BRONCHODILATORS

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Salbutamol (inhaler + spacer)	≤ 5 yr: mild 2–4 · moderate 4 · severe 6 puffs ≥ 6 yr: mild 4 · moderate 4–6 · severe 6–10 puffs	100 mcg/puff; shake before each puff , one puff at a time (4–5 breaths each); every 20 min × 3 in the first hour, then titrate to response (hourly → every 1–4 h). GINA sets no fixed cap ⁴¹¹
Salbutamol (nebulized)	≤ 5 yr: 2.5 mg (any severity) ≥ 6 yr: mild 2.5 mg · moderate 2.5–5 mg · severe 5 mg	Every 20 min × 3, then titrate to response; spacer is preferred when the child can use it ⁴¹¹

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Ipratropium bromide	≤ 5 yr: 80 mcg by spacer (4 puffs of 20 mcg) or 250 mcg nebulized ≥ 6 yr: 4–8 puffs (80–160 mcg) or 250–500 mcg nebulized	Moderate–severe: give with each salbutamol dose, every 20 min × 3 in the first hour only ⁴¹¹
Magnesium sulfate	40–50 mg/kg (max 2 g)	IV over 20 min, age ≥ 2 yr

BEYOND GINA – CRITICAL-CARE THERAPIES (PICU-DIRECTED)

Therapy	Dose	Notes
Salbutamol — continuous nebulization	0.5 mg/kg/h, maximum 20 mg/h (many units use 10–15 mg/h)	NAEPP dose. ⁴¹² GINA accepts continuous nebulized salbutamol for severe exacerbations in the emergency department; the mg/kg/h regimen and the high-output nebulizer are critical-care practice. Cardiac + K ⁺ monitoring. ⁴¹¹
Salbutamol IV	bolus then infusion	Not routine (no GINA recommendation); PICU only, cardiac monitoring; watch for hypokalemia and lactic acidosis ⁴¹¹
Aminophylline	5 mg/kg load, then infusion	Not recommended (GINA 2026) — poor efficacy, narrow safety margin, potentially fatal toxicity (especially with prior oral theophylline); no reduction in symptoms or length of stay in children. PICU rescue only , after IV salbutamol and magnesium; monitor levels ^{411,413}
Heliox (helium–oxygen ≥ 70:30)	driving / breathing gas	No proven benefit in routine exacerbations (Cochrane); may be considered in severe exacerbations in an ICU setting. Needs ≥ 70% helium, so unsuitable when a high FiO ₂ is required ^{414,415,416}

CORTICOSTEROIDS – CHOOSE ONE; ORAL BEFORE IV

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Prednisolone	< 2 yr: 1–2 mg/kg (max 20 mg) 2–5 yr: 1–2 mg/kg (max 30 mg) 6–11 yr: 1–2 mg/kg (max 40 mg) ≥ 12 yr: 1–2 mg/kg (max 50 mg) once daily	PO, 3–5 days; age-specific maxima per GINA ⁴¹¹
Dexamethasone	0.3–0.6 mg/kg once daily (max 12–16 mg)	PO/IV, 1–2 days; equal to prednisolone — no difference in relapse, better adherence, substantially less vomiting ^{411,417}

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Methylprednisolone	1–2 mg/kg/day IV in divided doses (max 60 mg/day)	IV agent when oral is not tolerated (NAEPP dose; confirm with clinical pharmacy) ⁴¹²
Hydrocortisone	4 mg/kg every 6 h (max 100 mg/dose)	IV alternative when oral is not tolerated (equivalent to methylprednisolone)

◆ STEROID CHOICE & AVAILABILITY

- Oral prednisolone and oral dexamethasone are equally effective⁴¹⁷, and oral steroid is as effective as IV.⁴¹⁸; reserve IV steroid for the child who cannot take oral.
- When IV is needed, methylprednisolone and hydrocortisone are both acceptable — evidence does not clearly favor one.
- Note that hydrocortisone's mineralocorticoid effect can add to the hypokalemia caused by high-dose salbutamol, and all systemic steroids can raise blood pressure and glucose.
- All four are widely stocked.⁴¹¹

⚠ CLINICAL PEARLS & RED FLAGS

A **silent chest**, a falling respiratory rate with rising drowsiness, or a normal/rising PaCO₂ in a tiring child is **pre-arrest** — not improvement. **Call PICU urgently**: decisions on sedation (e.g., ketamine), non-invasive ventilation, imaging, and intubation are made by the critical-care team, aiming to maximize urgent treatment before any intubation decision.⁴¹¹

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — ongoing oxygen requirement, incomplete response after first-hour therapy, salbutamol needed more often than every 3–4 h, or prior PICU admission/intubation.
- **Home** — SpO₂ ≥ 92% on room air, salbutamol stretched to ≥ every 4 h, feeding and talking, inhaler and spacer technique confirmed; discharge prescription = salbutamol via spacer (2–6 puffs every 4 h, weaning over days), the oral steroid course, and **an inhaled corticosteroid controller started or stepped up** (GINA: an exacerbation is a failure of controller treatment — no child ≥ 6 years leaves on salbutamol alone; preschool wheeze by phenotype); written action plan; review within 1–2 weeks.⁴¹¹
- **Refer — now** — PICU for impending respiratory failure.
- **Refer — clinic** — Pulmonology for any PICU-level escalation, ≥ 2 admissions per year, or diagnostic doubt; Allergy/Immunology for difficult-to-control atopic disease.

✦ **BEFORE DISCHARGE – SCREEN FOR WHAT KEEPS ASTHMA UNCONTROLLED (GINA 2026)**

An exacerbation is the moment to look for the drivers. Ask and act on: **allergic rhinitis / rhinosinusitis** (intranasal corticosteroid — improves asthma control); **obesity** (harder to control; weight management in the plan — even 5–10% loss helps); **obstructive sleep apnea** (habitual snoring, witnessed apnea → sleep referral; see [OSA](#)); **gastro-esophageal reflux** (treat only if symptomatic — anti-reflux therapy does not improve asthma without reflux symptoms); **food allergy** (confirmed food allergy is a risk factor for asthma death → allergy testing and an epinephrine plan); **anxiety or depression** in adolescents; **inducible laryngeal obstruction** when cough or “wheeze” does not respond to bronchodilator; and **exposures** — tobacco, vaping or shisha smoke at home or in the car (parents must never smoke or vape in rooms or cars the child uses), pets, mold, school triggers. Check **adherence and inhaler technique** last — they explain more exacerbations than any comorbidity. Refer to pulmonology/allergy when asthma stays uncontrolled despite treating these.⁴¹¹

Croup

HOURS

MINUTES if severe / impending failure

6 MO–6 YR

Barking cough, hoarse voice, inspiratory stridor; worse at night. Grade severity with the **Westley score** (0–17: ≤ 2 mild · 3–5 moderate · 6–11 severe · ≥ 12 impending respiratory failure), summing level of consciousness, cyanosis, stridor, air entry, and retractions.⁴¹⁹

KEEP CALM

Agitation worsens obstruction — examine on a parent's lap, minimal handling.



DECISION

Stridor at rest / respiratory distress?

MILD

Single steroid dose; discharge with clear return-precaution advice (safety-netting).^{420,421}

MODERATE–SEVERE

Steroid + nebulized L-epinephrine; observe ≥ 2–4 hours for rebound; oxygen if hypoxic.⁴²²

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Dexamethasone	Mild: 0.15 mg/kg Moderate–severe: 0.6 mg/kg (max 16 mg)	PO/IM/IV, single dose. 0.15 mg/kg may be as effective as 0.6 mg/kg in mild–moderate croup (Cochrane 2023; 0.6 scored better at 24 h). Dexamethasone halves return visits compared with prednisolone ⁴²¹
Budesonide (nebulized)	2 mg	If oral steroid not tolerated (nebulized budesonide 2 mg performed similarly to oral dexamethasone) ^{421,423}
Epinephrine (nebulized)	L-epinephrine (adrenaline) 1:1000 (1 mg/mL) 0.5 mL/kg nebulized (max 5 mL)	Moderate–severe; observe for rebound ⁴²²

◆ CONCENTRATION CHECK

Do not confuse 1:1000 (1 mg/mL) with 1:10 000 (0.1 mg/mL) epinephrine — different concentrations.⁴²²

◆ HELIOX IN SEVERE CROUP

- In **SEVERE** croup with significant distress **NOT SETTLING** after dexamethasone and nebulized L-epinephrine, **HELIOX** (helium–oxygen) may temporize while the steroid takes effect or transfer/airway support is arranged — in small trials its effect was comparable to oxygen plus epinephrine.
- It is a **BRIDGE, NOT A SUBSTITUTE**, and the evidence is very limited (low certainty).
- Needs ≥ 70% helium, so it is unsuitable when a high oxygen requirement is present. **INVOLVE ICU/ANESTHESIA EARLY.**⁴²⁴

▲ DIFFERENTIALS

- Drooling + toxic + no cough → epiglottitis (do not examine the throat).
- Sudden choking → inhaled foreign body.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — stridor at rest persisting after a steroid ± nebulized L-epinephrine, any oxygen requirement, or a repeat epinephrine dose needed.
- **Home from the emergency department** — mild croup (no stridor at rest, no distress) after a single steroid dose, feeding well, with reliable carers and safety-netting; if epinephrine was given, observe ≥ 2–4 h after the dose for rebound before the child goes home.
- **Refer — now — early ICU / anesthesia consult** for impending obstruction or failure to respond; ENT if an alternative airway diagnosis is suspected. If intubation is considered, do it in a controlled setting (PICU or operating room) with anesthesia and ENT present and difficult-airway equipment ready — see [Difficult Airway](#).

◆ **SEE ALSO** [Pediatric ENT Emergencies](#) (epiglottitis, bacterial tracheitis) in Section 07.

Retropharyngeal Abscess HOURS 1–5 YR

Deep neck-space infection after recent upper-respiratory illness — fever, neck pain, refusal to move the neck, drooling; guard the airway.

▀ RECOGNIZE

- Peak age 1–5 yr (median ~3 yr), usually after upper-respiratory infection.
- Symptoms: fever, sore throat, odynophagia/dysphagia, neck pain and swelling, muffled (“hot-potato”) voice, trismus, and drooling.

- Signs: neck tenderness, limited neck extension or torticollis, and cervical lymphadenopathy. **Neck pain and refusal to move or extend the neck** are the most useful clues.²¹²

⚠️ GUARD THE AIRWAY

- Stridor, respiratory distress, tripod posture, or pooling of secretions signal an airway threat (it mimics epiglottitis).
- Keep the child calm and sitting upright, give oxygen, do **not** examine the throat or lie the child flat, and involve ENT + anesthesia for a controlled airway before any manipulation.²¹²

◆ IMAGING

- Lateral neck radiograph is a screening test when the diagnosis is equivocal and there is no airway obstruction (widened prevertebral soft tissue — > 7 mm at C2 or > 14 mm at C6). **Contrast-enhanced CT of the neck is the preferred, confirmatory test** — it separates a drainable abscess (rim-enhancing hypodensity) from retropharyngeal cellulitis/phlegmon and maps the extent.²¹²
- No specific laboratory test is usually required.

DECISION

Airway compromise, or a large / loculated abscess? (large = CT cross-sectional area > 2 cm² or diameter > 2.5 cm; rim enhancement is the strongest predictor of pus at surgery)^{425,426}

YES

Secure the airway with ENT / anesthesia, then **surgical incision & drainage**; send pus for culture.⁴²⁵

NO – cellulitis / small abscess

A **48-hour trial of IV antibiotics first** — many children resolve without surgery. Re-image and drain if not improving.⁴²⁵

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Ceftriaxone + clindamycin — first line	Ceftriaxone 50 mg/kg once daily (max 2 g) clindamycin 10 mg/kg/dose every 8 h (max 900 mg/dose)	IV; together cover group A streptococcus, oral anaerobes, Gram-negatives and MRSA (methicillin-resistant <i>Staphylococcus aureus</i>) — Kuwait Pediatric Council antibiotic policy. ^{26, 212}
Amoxicillin-clavulanate — second line	30 mg/kg/dose (amoxicillin component) every 8 h IV (max 1.2 g/dose)	IV alternative when the first line is unsuitable. No oral amoxicillin-clavulanate step-down at standard dose — it does not cover <i>S. pneumoniae</i> adequately; choose the oral step-down agent with infectious diseases/ENT per the Council policy. ²⁶

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all suspected retropharyngeal abscess for IV antibiotics and observation; a monitored bed if there is any airway concern.

- **Home from the ward** — not from the acute phase; step to an oral agent chosen with infectious diseases/ENT (per the Council policy) once afebrile, improving and swallowing, with ENT follow-up.
- **Refer — now** — ENT for drainage and **anesthesia** for airway control; a screening lateral neck film only if it will not delay a needed CT or airway management.

Difficult Airway MINUTES

Oxygenate first, then work the three zones — optimize (yellow) → intubate (green) → front-of-neck (red); change one thing with every attempt.

▲ ANTICIPATE & PREPARE

- **Predictors:** craniofacial anomaly / syndrome (Pierre Robin, Treacher Collins, Goldenhar, Down), limited mouth opening or neck movement, deep-neck infection or airway swelling (retropharyngeal abscess, epiglottitis, angioedema, burns), stridor, a large tongue, or a previously documented difficult airway.⁴²⁷
- **Anticipated** — manage in a **controlled setting (PICU / OR)** with **ENT + anesthesia back-up available**. **Unanticipated** (ineffective bag-mask ventilation, or a failed first direct / video laryngoscopy (DL / VL) attempt) — **call for help now**.^{427,428}
- **Muscle relaxants** at the discretion of anesthesia / PICU. **Keep spontaneous breathing** (minimal sedation or inhalational anesthesia) where muscle tone is holding the airway open — anterior mediastinal mass, epiglottitis, large tongue, deep-neck abscess, or known impossible mask ventilation.^{429,430}
- **Prepare:** assign the team (1st + 2nd airway managers, assistant, respiratory therapist, drug nurse, circulating nurse); a **time-out** to agree **Plan A + B + C** (1st / 2nd intubator and technique, and the surgical-airway option, with personnel and equipment ready); check equipment and drugs; full monitoring; assess the airway (history + exam).⁴³⁰

⚠ OXYGENATION IS THE GOAL – NOT THE TUBE

- Pre-oxygenate fully and keep **apneic oxygenation** (nasal cannula / high-flow nasal cannula (HFNC)) running through every attempt.
- Change **one variable** with each attempt — operator, device, blade, position, or adjunct — rather than repeating the same one. **If in doubt, take it out** and oxygenate.^{428,429}

THE THREE-ZONES APPROACH (KUWAIT ALGORITHM)⁴³¹

✦ FOR THE GENERAL PEDIATRICIAN

Recognize the predictors, keep the child oxygenated (yellow zone) and **call anesthesia/ENT early**. The green and red zones below are the airway team's work — shown so you can anticipate and assist, not to lead.

● **YELLOW ZONE · OPTIMIZE** — make bag-mask ventilation effective: **position** (head tilt / chin lift, jaw thrust; **shoulder roll if < 2 yr**), suction, **100% FiO₂**, change mask size / adjust the seal, **two-person bag-mask ventilation (BMV)**, insert a nasogastric tube (NGT). Add an **oropharyngeal / nasopharyngeal airway (OPA / NPA)**. Add a **supraglottic airway (laryngeal mask airway, LMA)** if ventilation is still ineffective.^{428,429}

saturated & stable

● **GREEN ZONE · INTUBATE** — intubate when **this is the best saturation you can get and the child is as stable as possible**. **Videolaryngoscopy** with an **age-adapted standard blade** is the first choice (use a stylet with a hyperangulated blade);^{429,432} **max 4 attempts total (DL + VL)**. Between attempts change **operator** or **blade** (straight / curved / hyperangulated), add a **bougie** or a **flexible intubation scope (FIS)** — through a supraglottic airway, via the nasal route, or by a hybrid technique (FIS guided by the videolaryngoscope view) — or try a **smaller endotracheal tube (ETT)**. Keep **apneic O₂** (NC / HFNC) running and **treat laryngospasm**. If **oxygenation falls or the patient deteriorates → go back to the yellow zone** and re-optimize.^{428,430}

can't intubate, can't ventilate

● **RED ZONE · CAN'T INTUBATE, CAN'T VENTILATE (CICV)** — declare it early. **ENT available**: rigid bronchoscopy ventilation or tracheostomy. **ENT not available**: **needle cricothyrotomy / cricotracheal puncture (any age)**; percutaneous or “slash” surgical cricothyrotomy in the older child by trained hands. **Call for help if it has not arrived**.^{428,430}

✦ **CONFIRM PLACEMENT**

On successful intubation, confirm the tube **primarily with continuous waveform capnography (EtCO₂)**; support with equal chest rise, rising SpO₂, bilateral air entry on auscultation, misting of the tube, and a chest X-ray with the tip in the mid-trachea (about 1–2 cm above the carina in infants, 2–3 cm in older children).³

▀ **HAVE READY (DIFFICULT-AIRWAY CART)**

Videolaryngoscope (standard + hyperangulated blades), a range of tubes, bougie and stylets, supraglottic airways (LMA) in graded sizes, a **flexible intubation scope (FIS)**, and a **front-of-neck-access / cricothyrotomy kit** — checked and immediately available before induction.⁴³⁰

Bronchiolitis HOURS < 2 YR

Viral (e.g., RSV): coryza → cough, fast breathing, wheeze/crackles, feeding difficulty.

▀ **SUPPORTIVE CARE IS THE TREATMENT**

- Superficial nasal suction when secretions impair breathing or feeding (avoid routine deep suction); small frequent feeds; NG or IV fluids if intake under 50–75% or dehydrated.⁴³³

- Give oxygen for persistent SpO₂ < 90% (consider < 92% in young infants, prematurity, cardiac/lung disease, or severe work of breathing). **Mild** — no oxygen unless SpO₂ < 90%.^{433,434} **Moderate** — low-flow oxygen by nasal cannula first; **high-flow nasal cannula only if failing low-flow** (ward or PICU per local pathway)⁴³³ — in the PARIS trials early high-flow cut escalation in hypoxemic infants with bronchiolitis but did not shorten oxygen or hospital stay, and in 1–4-year-olds with hypoxemic respiratory failure it lengthened stay and doubled ICU admission.^{435,436} **Severe / impending failure** — high-flow or CPAP in PICU.⁴³³

✦ PEARL – FIRST WHEEZE VS THE MIMICKERS

A **first** episode of wheeze with coryza in a child under 12 months in the bronchiolitis season is bronchiolitis. **Recurrent or episodic** wheeze, a strong atopic or family history, or wheeze that responds well to a bronchodilator points instead to viral-induced wheeze or pre-school asthma; **persistent focal signs** raise a retained foreign body or a structural airway lesion; and an infant who is failing to feed with hepatomegaly or a murmur may have **heart failure**, not bronchiolitis.⁴³⁴

✗ NOT ROUTINELY RECOMMENDED

Bronchodilators (salbutamol, epinephrine), corticosteroids, nebulized hypertonic saline, antibiotics, chest physiotherapy, routine chest X-ray or viral testing.^{433,434} **Red flags:** apnea, grunting, severe recession, SpO₂ < 90%, dehydration, age < 6–12 weeks, comorbidity.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — SpO₂ persistently < 90% (< 92% in high-risk infants), apnea, intake under 50–75% or dehydration, marked work of breathing — especially if high-risk (age < 8–12 wk, prematurity, or cardiopulmonary disease).
- **Home** — (NICE NG9, 2021) clinically stable; taking adequate oral fluids; SpO₂ in room air maintained **for 4 hours including a period of sleep: > 90% if ≥ 6 weeks old, > 92% if < 6 weeks or any underlying health condition**; work of breathing settling; carers confident, with written safety-netting (worsening work of breathing, intake 50–75% of normal or no wet diaper for 12 h, apnea or cyanosis, exhaustion) and a clear route back.^{433,437,438}
- **Refer — now** — PICU (for escalation to high-flow nasal cannula or continuous positive airway pressure (CPAP)) for rising work of breathing, recurrent apnea, or hypoxia despite oxygen.

◆ SEE ALSO [Community-Acquired Pneumonia](#), [Complicated Pneumonia / Empyema](#), [Pertussis](#) and [BRUE](#) in Section 04.

Community-Acquired Pneumonia

HOURS

CPS 2024

The healthy, immunized child with fever, cough, and tachypnea — treat *S. pneumoniae*, mostly orally, and keep it short.

RECOGNIZE & ASSESS SEVERITY

- Acute fever + cough + **tachypnea** (the most useful sign) ± increased work of breathing, chest or abdominal pain, poor feeding. Wheeze + hypoxia points to bronchiolitis or asthma, not bacterial CAP.⁴³⁹
- **Tachypnea cut-offs (breaths/min):**
 - < 2 mo > 60
 - 2–12 mo > 50
 - 1–5 yr > 40
 - > 5 yr > 30.⁴⁴⁰
- Check SpO₂ in everyone — hypoxemia may not be clinically obvious; **give oxygen for SpO₂ < 92%.**
- **Likely cause by age:** infants/preschool — mostly **viral** (RSV, influenza, human metapneumovirus); *Streptococcus pneumoniae* is the leading bacterial cause at all ages; school-age — add atypicals (⁴³⁹*Mycoplasma*, *Chlamydia*).

KEEP INVESTIGATIONS TARGETED

- A chest radiograph is not essential for a non-severe outpatient with a typical picture; obtain posteroanterior + lateral when the diagnosis is uncertain or the child is admitted (extent, effusion, abscess).⁴⁴¹
- Do not image typical bronchiolitis or asthma.
- In hospitalized children: complete blood count (CBC)/C-reactive protein (CRP) + blood culture before antibiotics; consider respiratory viral testing in influenza season.

DECISION

Outpatient or admit?

OUTPATIENT • NON-SEVERE

Well-hydrated, tolerating oral intake, no respiratory compromise. **Oral amoxicillin** is the mainstay — high-dose covers *S. pneumoniae*. Most do not need a chest radiograph.

ADMIT

Inadequate oral intake or intolerance, **hypoxemia / grunting / nasal flaring / apnea**, severe or complicated pneumonia, or **age < 6 months**. Start **IV ampicillin**.

Amoxicillin (oral) or ampicillin (IV) is first-line — cover *S. pneumoniae*.

EMPIRIC THERAPY

Setting / drug	Dose	Notes
Amoxicillin — outpatient, first-line	25–30 mg/kg/dose PO q8h (max 4 g/day)	Drug of choice for non-severe CAP. TID dosing (not BID). 5 days is enough if responding. ⁴⁴⁰
Ampicillin — admitted, first-line	50 mg/kg/dose IV q6h (max 12 g/day)	IV first-line for hospitalized, non-life-threatening CAP. Step down to oral amoxicillin on improvement. ⁴⁴⁰
Ceftriaxone — severe / respiratory failure	50 mg/kg/dose IV q12–24h (max 2 g/dose)	For respiratory failure or septic shock (or cefotaxime 50 mg/kg/dose q6–8h). Broader cover incl. β -lactamase <i>H. influenzae</i> .
+ Vancomycin — if MRSA suspected	15 mg/kg/dose IV q6h	Add for rapidly progressing multilobar disease or pneumatocoeles until cultures return; send nasal MRSA screen first; stop if MRSA excluded.
Azithromycin — atypical (<i>Mycoplasma</i>)	10 mg/kg day 1, then 5 mg/kg $\times$ 4 d (max 500 mg)	School-age with atypical features. Macrolide resistance rising; doxycycline (any age, short courses). ⁴⁴¹

⚠ DURATION, COURSE & FOLLOW-UP

- **5 days** for non-severe CAP (ambulatory, or admitted and responding within 24–36 h); **7–10 days** for more significant disease.⁴⁴¹
- Expect improvement (appetite, fever, tachypnea, O₂ need) within **48 h**.⁴⁴⁰
- If **not improving by 48–72 h** → re-image (radiograph/ultrasound) for empyema or abscess and reconsider the diagnosis (foreign body, tuberculosis, atypical).⁴⁴⁰
- Routine end-of-therapy radiograph is not needed — radiographic clearance lags⁴³⁹ 4–6 weeks.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — hypoxia (SpO₂ < 90%; < 92% in high-risk infants), respiratory distress, dehydration or feeding failure, an effusion/empyema, or failure of outpatient therapy.
- **Home** — well child maintaining saturations in air, feeding, on oral antibiotics with follow-up arranged.
- **Refer — now** — PICU for respiratory failure or sepsis; surgical or respiratory review for empyema or non-resolving disease.

◆ **DIFFICULT IV ACCESS?** Reassess for an early IV→oral switch at every line failure rather than re-sticking — see [IV → Oral Switch & the DIVA Patient](#) (Quick Reference).

Complicated Pneumonia – Empyema

HOURS

IDSA/PIDS 2026 • CPS 2024

Pneumonia + pus or a moderate-to-large pleural effusion — antibiotics plus, when needed, drainage with a fibrinolytic.

◆ DEFINITION & STAGES

- Empyema = intrapleural pus, or a moderate-to-large exudative parapneumonic effusion.
- It evolves: **STAGE 1** exudative (free-flowing) → **STAGE 2** fibrinopurulent (loculated) → **STAGE 3** organized (thick fibrinous peel)⁴⁴².
- Small parapneumonic effusions are common in uncomplicated pneumonia and do **NOT** need drainage.⁴⁴²
- Lung abscess and necrotizing pneumonia are separate complications.

▴ RECOGNIZE & DIAGNOSE

- Suspect it when an initially uncomplicated pneumonia is **poorly responsive** — persistent fever after 48–72 h, worsening distress or hypoxia, or new effusion signs (decreased breath sounds, dullness, reduced expansion).
- **Imaging:** chest radiograph first, then **chest ultrasound** (confirms effusion, estimates size, distinguishes free-flowing from loculated). Computed tomography (CT) is not routine — reserve for a suspected alternative diagnosis (e.g., malignancy).⁴⁴²
- **Pathogens:** *S. pneumoniae* (most common), *S. aureus* (incl. MRSA), *S. pyogenes* (group A streptococcus). Send drained fluid for **culture and Gram stain** (± pneumococcal PCR where available); blood cultures positive in only ~10%⁴⁴². Labs often show high white-cell count/ESR/CRP, thrombocytosis, hypoalbuminemia — these normalize with recovery.

DECISION

How big is the effusion, and how sick is the child?

SMALL / MILD – ANTIBIOTICS ALONE

Small effusion, mild distress, no mediastinal shift → a trial of **antibiotics alone** is reasonable with close monitoring.

MODERATE-LARGE / COMPROMISE – DRAIN

Moderate-to-large effusion, significant respiratory distress, or mediastinal shift → **drainage plus antibiotics**, early. Consult thoracic surgery / interventional radiology promptly.

▴ DRAIN WHEN

Moderate-to-large effusion or empyema causing respiratory compromise, or occupying much of the hemithorax ± **mediastinal shift**; **loculated (stage 2) or organized** collection on ultrasound, or frank **pus** on aspiration; or **failure of antibiotics alone** (not improving, or progressing, after an adequate trial).

◆ FIBRINOLYTIC (ALTEPLASE / TPA)

- First-line, most cost-effective drainage = **SMALL-BORE (≤ 12 FR) PERCUTANEOUS CHEST TUBE + INTRAPLEURAL FIBRINOLYTIC**, preferred over surgical debridement (VATS) in most cases — reserve VATS for refractory disease or extensive loculation. **ALTEPLASE 0.1 MG/KG (MAX 4 MG)** in normal saline instilled via the chest tube, **CLAMP/DWELL 1 HOUR, THEN DRAIN – ONCE DAILY FOR UP TO 3 DAYS** (a fixed 4 mg dose daily $\times 3$ is an accepted alternative). **TPA ALONE IS NOW PREFERRED OVER TPA + DNASE** (no added benefit, higher cost).⁴⁴²
- Prescribe and label as **ALTEPLASE**.

ANTIBIOTICS FOR EMPYEMA

Agent	Dose	Notes
Cefotaxime / ceftriaxone — first-line	Cefotaxime 50 mg/kg/dose q6–8h; ceftriaxone 50 mg/kg/dose q12–24h	Empiric IV cover for the usual pathogens; choose per local antibiogram. ⁴⁴¹
+ Vancomycin — MRSA	15 mg/kg/dose IV q6h	Reserve for culture-proven or strongly suspected MRSA / severe disease.
Oral step-down — culture-negative	Amoxicillin (high-dose) or amoxicillin-clavulanate	Switch once drainage complete, improving, and off oxygen.

⚠ DURATION, COURSE & FOLLOW-UP

- Total **3–4 weeks** is reasonable with adequate drainage and no further complication; transition to **oral** at or just before discharge once drained, improving, and off oxygen. **Persistent fever > 72 h is common** and — if the child is otherwise improving — usually **not** treatment failure; serial CRP can confirm improvement.⁴⁴²
- Outcome is excellent: lung function and radiograph normalize over weeks–months (a repeat film at 2–3 months is reasonable).
- Watch necrotizing pneumonia for **bronchopleural fistula** → involve surgery / respiratory / infectious diseases.⁴⁴²

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — clinically significant empyema or a moderate-to-large effusion, for IV antibiotics $\pm$ drainage.
- **Home from the emergency department** — a **small parapneumonic effusion in a well child** can be managed as community-acquired pneumonia with close follow-up rather than admitted.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; complete therapy with follow-up imaging.
- **Refer — now** — respiratory/surgery for drainage (chest drain $\pm$ fibrinolytics or VATS).

Choking (Foreign-Body Obstruction) MINUTES

Sudden cough/stridor/one-sided wheeze with a choking history.

DECISION

Mild or severe obstruction?

MILD – effective cough

Coughing effectively, can speak/cry, adequate air movement → **encourage coughing, stay, monitor closely**; no back blows or thrusts.³

SEVERE – responsive

Weak or silent cough, cannot speak or cry, cyanosis or color change, altered consciousness, apnea → start maneuvers now. **Infant < 1 yr:** 5 back blows → 5 chest thrusts, repeat (no abdominal thrusts). **Child ≥ 1 yr:** 5 back blows → 5 abdominal thrusts, repeat (AHA/AAP 2025 and ERC sequence).^{5,443}

becomes unconscious

Start CPR. Check the mouth before breaths; remove the object only if visible. No blind finger sweeps.³

⚠ REMOVE NOW

- Foreign body in the larynx or trachea (central airway), stridor at rest, severe distress or cyanosis, or complete obstruction.
- **Your job as the first doctor:** call anesthesia/ENT/PICU at once, oxygenate, continue the maneuvers above, and bring the front-of-neck-access kit to the bedside.³

⚠️ AIRWAY TEAM – COMPLETE OBSTRUCTION NOT RELIEVED BY MANEUVERS

- **Recognize:** cannot speak, cry or cough; clutching the neck; silent chest; paradoxical chest/abdominal movement; loss of consciousness. Act after two cycles of maneuvers fail or as soon as the child becomes unresponsive.^{3,5}
- **1 · Laryngoscopy** — remove a visible object with Magill forceps (experienced clinician).^{5,444}
- **2 · Not removable and rigid bronchoscopy available** → operating room now: removal by ENT/thoracic surgery with anesthesia.⁴⁴⁴
- **3 · Unstable, no immediate rigid bronchoscopy — act by level. At or above the cords:** never pass a tube blindly past the object; intubate only under direct or video view around/beyond it; if that fails or obstruction becomes complete → **front-of-neck access below the larynx as the last resort — follow the red zone of the [Difficult Airway](#) card** (ENT: tracheostomy). **Below the cords:** intubate and **advance the object into the right main bronchus**, withdraw the tube above the carina, right side down, ventilate the left lung; if intubation is impossible, positive-pressure ventilation to push the object into one bronchus is the last resort.^{3,444}
- **Anesthetic principle:** prefer spontaneous breathing and avoid positive pressure while the obstruction is **partial** (it can complete it); once obstruction is complete, distal displacement is the rescue. Spontaneous and controlled techniques have similar outcomes in the hands of the airway team.^{429,445}

▀ STABLE CHILD – SUSPECTED INHALED FOREIGN BODY

- **A convincing choking history mandates bronchoscopy even when the chest X-ray is normal** — only about 11% of inhaled objects are radio-opaque and the film is normal in about 17% of children.⁴⁴⁵
- **Chest X-ray:** standard film ± inspiratory and expiratory views (cooperative child) or lateral decubitus views (young child). Look for a radio-opaque object, unilateral hyperinflation/air trapping, segmental or lobar collapse, mediastinal shift, consolidation or pneumothorax; abscess or bronchiectasis suggest a chronic retained object. **A normal examination or X-ray does not exclude an inhaled foreign body;** CT is not a substitute for bronchoscopy.⁴⁴⁴
- **Removal is by rigid bronchoscopy, by ENT or thoracic surgery** with an experienced anesthesia team under optimal conditions, ideally **within 24 hours** (delay increases complications). **Flexible bronchoscopy is for diagnosis only** — the flexible scopes in our hospitals are not retrieval instruments.^{444,445}

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — after removal, observe for airway injury/aspiration; any hypoxia, stridor, or incomplete relief → ED/PICU.
- **Home** — only when a **retained foreign body has been excluded** (by bronchoscopy, or by ENT/respiratory review with follow-up arranged); a child can be fully recovered with an effective cough, normal examination and normal SpO₂ and still have a retained object.⁴⁴⁴
- **Refer — now** — ENT/anesthesia for suspected retained foreign body → rigid bronchoscopy.

Obstructive Sleep Apnea

ASSESS

AAP • ERS

Flagged here for its acute peri-operative airway risk (post-adenotonsillectomy compromise, opioid/sedation sensitivity). Habitual snoring and witnessed apnea; in children it looks like hyperactivity, not sleepiness.

RECOGNIZE

- **Obstructive sleep apnea (OSA)** — habitual snoring (> 3 nights/week), witnessed apnea or gasping, restless sleep, mouth breathing, enuresis; by day **hyperactivity, inattention and poor concentration rather than sleepiness**. Peak 2–8 years (adenotonsillar hypertrophy).⁴⁴⁶
- **High-risk groups:** obesity, Down syndrome, craniofacial anomalies, neuromuscular disease, Prader-Willi, achondroplasia, mucopolysaccharidoses, sickle cell disease.^{446,447}
- **Work-up is elective:** polysomnography (PSG; the apnea-hypopnea index, AHI, grades severity) remains the reference standard, or sleep-clinic referral⁴⁴⁸. Where PSG is not available, BTS accepts overnight pulse oximetry or a cardiorespiratory sleep study as a first-line test — a normal oximetry does not exclude mild–moderate OSA⁴⁴⁹; the Canadian guideline limits home testing to otherwise healthy children over 5 years and advises against diagnosing OSA on oximetry or questionnaires alone.⁴⁴⁸ ECG/echocardiography if cor pulmonale or pulmonary hypertension is suspected. Chronic treatment (adenotonsillectomy, CPAP, intranasal steroid, weight management) is decided in clinic, not in the emergency setting; the ERS statement supports treatment when AHI > 5/h, or 1–5/h with morbidity or a complex condition.^{446,447}

RED FLAGS

- **Severe OSA** — AHI ≥ 10 obstructive events/h and/or nadir SpO₂ < 80% (the AAO-HNS definition used for peri-operative risk)⁴⁵⁰; nocturnal desaturations or hypoventilation.
- **Cor pulmonale / pulmonary hypertension**, failure to thrive — complex, high-risk: refer to a specialist.
- **Cardiorespiratory failure cannot await elective evaluation** — treat urgently.⁴⁴⁶

▲ PERI-OPERATIVE & ACUTE CARE – THE BEDSIDE PRIORITY

- **Any post-adenotonsillectomy respiratory compromise** → anesthesia review at once; an ongoing oxygen requirement, obstruction or apnea after recovery → monitored bed or PICU.
- **Overnight inpatient monitoring** after tonsillectomy for children **< 3 years** or with **severe OSA** (AAO-HNS); AAP adds obesity, craniofacial/neuromuscular disease, Down syndrome, cor pulmonale, recent upper-respiratory infection and failure to thrive as reasons for a monitored bed.^{446,450} **Opioids: no codeine after tonsillectomy under 12 years** (AAO-HNS; FDA — CYP2D6 ultra-rapid metabolizer deaths) and avoid tramadol; ibuprofen and/or acetaminophen are the first-line analgesics.^{133,450}
- In moderate-to-severe OSA, minimize opioids and monitor closely — children with recurrent nocturnal hypoxemia (nadir SpO₂ < 85%) needed **about half the usual morphine dose** for the same analgesia in a randomized study, so start low and titrate with monitoring.^{446,451}
- Position ramped, keep airway adjuncts and CPAP ready.

✦ PEARL – IT LOOKS LIKE ADHD

A snoring child who is hyperactive and inattentive may have OSA, not just a behavior problem — ask about snoring and witnessed apnea at every visit.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — from the emergency department: cardiorespiratory compromise, cor pulmonale or severe hypoventilation. After adenotonsillectomy: overnight monitored bed if < 3 years, severe OSA (AHI ≥ 10 and/or nadir < 80%) or a high-risk comorbidity.^{446,450}
- **Home from the emergency department** — all others, with an urgent outpatient sleep study and ENT referral (severe OSA alone is an urgent outpatient, not an admission).⁴⁴⁶
- **Home from the ward** — after adenotonsillectomy, when no overnight monitored bed is indicated: discharge per anesthesia/ENT.^{446,450}
- **Refer — clinic** — ENT (adenotonsillectomy) and sleep medicine; cardiology if pulmonary hypertension. OSA persists after adenotonsillectomy in up to 40% — re-refer to sleep medicine/ENT if snoring or symptoms continue (options include CPAP, weight management, sleep endoscopy-guided surgery and rapid maxillary expansion).⁴⁵²

Cow's Milk Protein Allergy

ASSESS

INFANT · ESPGHAN 2024 · WAO DRACMA 2023–24 · CPS 2024

The commonest infant food allergy — IgE-mediated (fast) or non-IgE (delayed, cell-mediated). Over-diagnosis is common: confirmed CMPA affects < 1% of infants.

◆ SEE ALSO [Acute FPIES](#) (vomiting 1–4 h after a food — criteria and emergency treatment).

▀ RECOGNIZE THE TWO PATTERNS

- **IgE-mediated (minutes–2 h):** urticaria, angioedema, vomiting, wheeze, anaphylaxis.⁴⁵³
Testing: skin-prick test or specific IgE to cow's milk when the history suggests an immediate reaction — a positive result shows sensitization only; a **supervised oral food**

challenge confirms the diagnosis, except after anaphylaxis with a high specific IgE.⁴⁵⁴

- **Non-IgE (hours–days):** blood or mucus in the stool, eczema flare, faltering growth, chronic diarrhea. **Reflux, colic, loose stools and constipation are common in healthy infants and on their own do not indicate CMPA** — consider it only when they fail usual treatment or occur with other features (another organ system, faltering growth, blood in the stool).⁴⁵⁴ Distinct from lactose intolerance (an enzymatic, non-immune condition).⁴⁵⁵
- **Confirming non-IgE disease: a 2–4-week diagnostic elimination** (maternal cow's-milk-free diet if breastfed; extensively hydrolyzed formula if formula-fed) **followed by planned reintroduction** — improvement alone is not enough, because up to 20% of breastfed infants with blood in the stool settle with no change at all.⁴⁵⁴ FPIES is the exception: a typical history with resolution on withdrawal is sufficient; a supervised challenge only if the history is unclear.⁴⁵⁴

⚠ WHEN TO START AN ELIMINATION – OBSERVE FIRST

- A **well, thriving, exclusively breastfed** infant with small streaks of blood in the stool and no other atopic features: **observe for up to a month** without changing the mother's diet — most settle spontaneously.⁴⁵⁴
- **Start a 2–4-week diagnostic elimination** only for: severe or persistent bleeding; faltering growth; moderate–severe eczema not responding to treatment; or a strong overall picture of CMPA.⁴⁵⁴
- Unneeded maternal elimination shortens breastfeeding, and therapeutic formulas taste different and may shape later food preferences — both are reasons to hold the threshold.⁴⁵⁴

▀ NON-IGE SUBTYPES – RECOGNIZE THE PATTERN

- **Food protein-induced allergic proctocolitis (FPIAP)** — a well-appearing infant with blood/mucus streaks in the stool, onset **2–8 weeks**; the most common subtype, up to 50% in exclusively breastfed infants; mostly benign and self-limiting.^{454,455}
- **Food protein-induced enteropathy (FPE)** — chronic diarrhea **with** faltering growth and malabsorption (steatorrhea, hypoalbuminemia, anemia); emesis and distension may accompany. A thriving infant with loose stools alone does not have FPE. Uncommon. If the picture fits and CMPA is likely, start the elimination and expect improvement within 1–4 weeks; refer to pediatric GI — endoscopy with biopsy (villous atrophy, crypt hyperplasia) confirms the diagnosis and is prioritized when response is poor, features are severe or another cause is suspected. Exclude infection with stool studies and cystic fibrosis with a sweat test, not biopsy; celiac testing applies only once gluten is in the diet.^{455,456,457}
- **Food protein-induced enterocolitis syndrome (FPIES)** — profuse **repetitive vomiting 1–4 h after the food**, pallor, lethargy ± diarrhea; ~15% develop hypovolemic shock. Rare; mimics sepsis. Criteria and acute treatment: [Acute FPIES](#).⁴⁰⁶

MANAGEMENT – BY FEEDING & SUBTYPE (EVERY ELIMINATION IS A 2–4-WEEK DIAGNOSTIC TRIAL, THEN REINTRODUCE TO CONFIRM)

Situation	First choice	Notes
IgE-mediated — anaphylaxis	Amino acid formula (AAF)	AAF from the start after an anaphylactic reaction to cow's milk protein. ⁴⁵⁸
IgE-mediated — milder immediate reaction	Extensively hydrolyzed formula (EHF)	Step up to AAF only per the rule in the Avoid box below. ⁴⁵⁴
IgE-mediated, breastfed	Continue breastfeeding	If the infant is symptom-free on breast milk, no maternal elimination ; eliminate maternal cow's milk only if the infant reacts while exclusively breastfed. ⁴⁵⁹
Mixed-fed (breast + formula)	Change the formula; keep breastfeeding	If symptoms occur only with formula and the infant is well on breast milk, use EHF (or AAF per the rows above) and do not restrict the mother's diet — IgE-CMPA and FPIES. ^{406,459} For FPIAP/FPE the same approach is reasonable; add maternal elimination only if symptoms persist on breast milk alone.
FPIAP, breastfed — threshold met	Maternal cow's-milk-free diet, 2–4 wks, then reintroduce	Cow's milk (and other mammalian milks) first; add soy only if no response after 2–4 weeks (CPS eliminates both from the start; ESPGHAN cow's milk only). ^{454,455} Continue breastfeeding; dietitian for calcium and vitamin D.
FPIAP, formula-fed — threshold met	Extensively hydrolyzed formula (EHF), 2–4 wks, then reintroduce	Whether to eliminate at all in formula-fed FPIAP is debated (a cohort linked it to later IgE-CMPA); if started, reintroduce afterwards. ⁴⁵⁴ Soy formula is an option > 6 months if tolerated. ⁴⁵⁵
FPE, breastfed	Maternal cow's-milk-free diet, 2–4 wks	Add soy if no response; monitor growth and nutrition — resolution takes weeks. No improvement → AAF and pediatric GI. ^{455,456}
FPE, formula-fed	Amino acid formula (AAF)	First-line (not EHF) given the malabsorption; pediatric GI. ⁴⁵⁵
FPIES, breastfed	Continue breastfeeding	Rare in this group. If reacting to breast milk or faltering: maternal elimination of the trigger with allergy input; if unresolved, consider stopping breastfeeding → EHF/AAF. ⁴⁰⁶
FPIES, formula-fed	EHF first; AAF if no improvement in 2 wks	10–20% need AAF from the start; AAF preferred if faltering. Strictly avoid all forms (incl. heated/baked) of the trigger. ⁴⁰⁶

⚠ AVOID & WHO DECIDES

- **Goat's / sheep's milk** (high cross-reactivity) and partially hydrolyzed / "comfort" or "HA" formulas.⁴⁵⁴
- **Step up EHF → AAF** only after 2–4 weeks without response **and** after checking the diet for hidden milk and reconsidering the diagnosis; AAF is first-line only for anaphylaxis, FPIES with faltering growth, or FPE.^{454,455}
- **Who decides:** the treating pediatrician may start EHF or a maternal trial; the step to AAF and any prolonged maternal elimination are confirmed with allergy/GI, with a dietitian protecting calcium and growth.

✦ RE-CHALLENGE

After a confirmed diagnosis the first therapeutic elimination lasts **6 months or until 12 months of age, whichever comes first**, then an oral food challenge — supervised for IgE-mediated disease, at home via a milk ladder for most non-IgE disease; the setting is decided by the specialist.^{453,454}

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — from the emergency department: IgE-mediated reaction with anaphylaxis (manage, observe and admit per [Anaphylaxis](#)); acute FPIES with lethargy, dehydration or shock (see [Acute FPIES](#)).
- **Home from the emergency department** — after assessment: the well infant with blood-streaked stool, mild immediate symptoms that have resolved, or chronic symptoms — with the observe-first advice above, written warning signs, and clinic follow-up within 2–4 weeks; start a diagnostic elimination only if the threshold is met.
- **Home from the ward** — once feeding and growing, with the dietary plan, dietitian review and the reintroduction date written down.
- **Refer — now** — allergy for anaphylaxis (urgent).
- **Refer — clinic** — allergy: IgE-mediated disease for testing and challenge, FPIES, multiple food allergies; pediatric GI: FPE, faltering growth, no response to EHF, diagnostic doubt; dietitian for every infant on an elimination diet.

◆ **BASIS** ESPGHAN 2024 position paper⁴⁵⁴; WAO DRACMA VII (2023, elimination and reintroduction)⁴⁵³, X (2023, breastfeeding)⁴⁵⁹ and XVI (2024, nutritional management)⁴⁵⁸; Canadian Paediatric Society 2024 (non-IgE subtypes)⁴⁵⁵; international FPIES consensus 2017.⁴⁰⁶ Where CPS and ESPGHAN differ (maternal soy; observation before elimination) the card follows ESPGHAN and says so.

Acute FPIES (Food Protein-Induced Enterocolitis Syndrome) HOURS

INFANT • FPIES CONSENSUS 2017

Repetitive vomiting 1–4 h after a food, with pallor and lethargy — a non-IgE reaction that mimics sepsis; fluids and ondansetron, not epinephrine.

RECOGNIZE – 2017 INTERNATIONAL CRITERIA

- **Major criterion (required):** vomiting 1–4 h after ingestion of the suspect food **and** no classic IgE-mediated skin or respiratory symptoms.⁴⁰⁶
- **Plus ≥ 3 minor criteria:** a second episode after the same food · repetitive vomiting 1–4 h after a different food · extreme lethargy · marked pallor · emergency-department visit · need for IV fluids · diarrhea within 24 h (usually 5–10 h) · hypotension · hypothermia.⁴⁰⁶
- **Triggers:** cow's milk and soy in infants; rice and oat are the commonest solids; also egg, fish, poultry, vegetables. Onset is usually with the first exposures to formula or solids, typically at **2–7 months**.^{406,460}
- **Looks like:** sepsis, surgical abdomen, gastroenteritis, metabolic crisis. Clues: the timing after a new food, a well child an hour earlier, rapid recovery with fluids. Blood tests may show neutrophilia, thrombocytosis, acidosis and methemoglobinemia.^{406,460}

ACUTE MANAGEMENT BY SEVERITY (FPIES CONSENSUS 2017)

Severity	Features	Treatment
Mild	1–2 vomits, no lethargy	Oral rehydration — breastfeeding or clear fluids; if ≥ 6 months, ondansetron IM 0.15 mg/kg (max 16 mg) may be considered. Can resolve at home. ⁴⁰⁶
Moderate	≥ 3 vomits, mild lethargy	Ondansetron IM/IV 0.15 mg/kg (max 16 mg); consider IV access and 0.9% saline 20 mL/kg , repeated as needed; observe until tolerating fluids. ⁴⁰⁶
Severe	≥ 3 vomits with severe lethargy, hypotonia, ashen or cyanotic appearance, hypotension	IV access; 0.9% saline 20 mL/kg rapidly, repeat as needed ; ondansetron IV 0.15 mg/kg (max 16 mg); consider methylprednisolone IV 1 mg/kg (max 60–80 mg); blood gas, electrolytes, glucose, CBC; correct acid–base and electrolyte abnormalities and methemoglobinemia; manage as shock (see Shock). ⁴⁰⁶

▲ PITFALLS

- **Epinephrine does not treat FPIES** (not IgE-mediated); give it only if anaphylaxis cannot be excluded — see [Anaphylaxis](#).
- Do not label a sepsis-like infant as FPIES until the timing fits and infection has been considered; when in doubt treat for both.
- Ondansetron ≥ 6 months only; monitor the QT interval if repeated (QTc).

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — severe reaction, hypotension, ongoing vomiting or lethargy, or dehydration.
- **Home from the emergency department** — mild reaction: tolerating oral fluids, well after observation. Moderate reaction: observe in the emergency department until drinking and lethargy has resolved, then home. Both with a written plan to avoid the trigger in **all forms** and to return for repetitive vomiting after any new food.
- **Refer — clinic** — allergy for every new diagnosis (trigger confirmation, written emergency plan, supervised re-challenge usually 12–18 months after the last reaction); dietitian when a staple food is removed. Chronic feeding choices: see [Cow's Milk Protein Allergy](#).^{406,460}

◆ **BASIS** International consensus guidelines for FPIES (Nowak-Węgrzyn 2017)⁴⁰⁶; ESPGHAN 2024 for the diagnostic approach.⁴⁵⁴

Antibiotic Allergy Assessment & Pretesting ASSESS

Most allergy labels are false. Take a history, don't routinely skin-test, and de-label when you can.

▲ THE LABEL IS USUALLY WRONG

- About **10% of people** carry a penicillin/beta-lactam allergy label, but **~90% are not truly allergic**: only **5–10%** of children with a "penicillin allergy label" have a true penicillin allergy.⁴⁶¹
- Most labels accumulate from **non-allergic events** — GI upset, headache, family history, or a viral rash during treatment.
- In children, a **maculopapular rash is more often viral than allergic**.⁴⁶¹
- Routine pre-dose intradermal "**test dosing**" is **not standard of care, not validated, and should be abandoned** — it delays therapy and misleads (positive predictive value of skin testing only ~50%; it misses dose-independent and enteral reactions).⁴⁶²

◆ WHY MISLABELING HARMS

A beta-lactam label drives **second-line agents** (vancomycin, clindamycin, fluoroquinolones) that are less effective, broader, and costlier — linked to more *C. difficile* (~+23%), **MRSA** (~+13%), **vancomycin-resistant enterococci (VRE)** (~+30%), longer stays, more surgical-site infections, ICU admission, aminoglycoside-related acute kidney injury, and a ~50-min delay to the first ED antibiotic dose. **No reaction history — or a beta-lactam tolerated since — give the drug. No skin test required.**⁴⁶²

◆ READING THE TIERS

- Assign the **highest** tier any feature reaches — one high-risk feature makes the patient high-risk.
- Risk rises with reaction **severity** (intolerance → hives → anaphylaxis / severe delayed), **immediacy** (delayed benign → immediate IgE), and **recency** (remote → recent). **None / Low** → give the drug or a direct oral challenge; **Medium** → skin test ± challenge, pick a non-cross-reacting beta-lactam meanwhile; **High** → avoid the culprit, refer, do not challenge.
- The pediatric category method is preferred⁴⁶¹; adult scores (e.g., the PEN-FAST penicillin-allergy score) are not robustly validated in children⁴⁶³. **The table below applies to a child with a reported penicillin allergy (cephalosporin allergy excluded).**⁴⁶¹

Risk	History (any of)	Action
History not consistent with allergy	No previous allergic reaction; side effects / intolerance only (GI upset, headache); a reaction history but tolerated the antibiotic since the index event; family history only.	De-label the record. Give penicillin if indicated.
Low	Non-IgE-mediated reaction; delayed maculopapular rash starting ≥ 3 days into the course.	De-label the record. Give penicillin if indicated.
Medium	Urticaria (hives) or other immediate, IgE-type reaction without anaphylaxis ; a "rash" where hives cannot be excluded.	Refer to an allergist. Avoid penicillin. See the side-chain chart below for prescribing cephalosporins. ⁴⁶¹
High	Anaphylaxis ; recurrent reactions or reactions to multiple beta-lactams; prior positive skin test; any severe delayed reaction — Stevens-Johnson syndrome / toxic epidermal necrolysis (SJS/TEN), drug reaction with eosinophilia and systemic symptoms (DRESS), serum sickness, hemolytic anemia, nephritis, hepatitis.	Do not test or challenge. Refer to an allergist. Avoid penicillins and cephalosporins. ⁴⁶¹

▲ WHEN TO INVOLVE AN ALLERGIST

Any **type-1 (immediate / IgE-mediated)** reaction — urticaria, angioedema, wheeze, or anaphylaxis — prompts **allergist referral**; more nuanced than the table alone, which is a triage aid, not a substitute for specialist assessment.⁴⁶²

◆ HOW TO USE THIS CHART

- **Prescribing a cephalosporin for a penicillin-allergic child:** choose one that does **not** share a similar side-chain structure with penicillins (a "✓" against the penicillin columns below).
- Cross-reactivity follows **side-chain similarity** — not the shared beta-lactam ring.
Cefazolin has a unique side chain and is safe even after penicillin anaphylaxis.⁴⁶² Use only for **immediate / IgE** histories — **never** for SJS/TEN/DRESS, where all beta-lactams are avoided.⁴⁶²

Beta-lactam cross-reactivity by side-chain structure

Beta-lactams	Amoxicillin	Ampicillin	Cloxacillin	Penicillin	Piperacillin	Cefadroxil	Cefazolin	Cephalexin	Cefoxitin	Cefprozil	Cefuroxime	Cefixime	Cefotaxime	Ceftazidime	Ceftriaxone	Cefepime	Ertapenem	Imipenem	Meropenem
Amoxicillin		X ¹	X ⁵	X ⁴	X ³	X ¹	✓	X ¹	✓	X ²	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Ampicillin	X ¹		X ⁵	X ⁴	X ³	X ²	✓	X ²	✓	X ²	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cloxacillin	X ⁵	X ⁵		X ⁵	X ⁵	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Penicillin	X ⁴	X ⁴	X ⁵		X ⁵	✓	✓	✓	X ³	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Piperacillin	X ³	X ³	X ⁵	X ⁵		X ³	✓	X ³	✓	X ³	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cefadroxil	X ¹	X ²	✓	✓	X ³		✓	X ¹	✓	X ²	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cefazolin	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cephalexin	X ¹	X ²	✓	✓	X ³	X ¹	✓		✓	X ²	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cefoxitin	✓	✓	✓	X ³	✓	✓	✓	✓		✓	X ²	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cefprozil	X ²	X ²	✓	✓	X ³	X ²	✓	X ²	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cefuroxime	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ²	✓		X ³	X ¹	X ³	X ¹	X ²	✓	✓	✓
Cefixime	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ³		X ³	X ³	X ³	X ³	✓	✓	✓
Cefotaxime	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ¹	X ³		X ³	X ¹	X ¹	✓	✓	✓
Ceftazidime	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ³	X ³	X ³		X ³	X ³	✓	✓	✓
Ceftriaxone	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ¹	X ³	X ¹	X ³		X ¹	✓	✓	✓
Cefepime	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ²	X ³	X ¹	X ³	X ¹		✓	✓	✓
Ertapenem	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		X ⁵	X ⁵
Imipenem	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ⁵		X ⁵
Meropenem	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	X ⁵	X ⁵	

Penicillin

1st-gen cephalosporin

2nd-gen cephalosporin

3rd-gen cephalosporin

4th-gen cephalosporin

Carbapenem

✓ Different structure — considered safe

X² Same side chain — theoretical risk of cross-reaction

X⁴ Beta-lactam ring — clinical evidence of reaction

X¹ Same side chain — clinical evidence of reaction

X³ Similar side chain — potential risk of cross-reaction

X⁵ Beta-lactam ring — theoretical risk of reaction

Read row drug against column drug. ✓ = considered safe; X¹–X⁵ grade the cross-reactivity risk (see key). Diagonal (same drug) shown solid.

CHILDREN WITH A CEPHALOSPORIN ALLERGY

- **Immediate hypersensitivity** (urticaria, angioedema, anaphylaxis) — **avoid all cephalosporins and penicillins**; use an alternative and refer to allergy.
- **Inpatient / ICU** — avoid all cephalosporins and penicillins and use alternatives; consult **Allergy / ID** if a penicillin or cephalosporin is the recommended first-line treatment.
- **Severe cutaneous reaction** (SJS/TEN/DRESS) — **avoid all penicillins, cephalosporins, and carbapenems**; use an alternative and consult allergy or ID.⁴⁶¹

◆ **BASIS** Kuwait Pediatric Council practice point on skin testing before antibiotic administration; risk table adapted from the Canadian Paediatric Society⁴⁶¹ and Devchand & Trubiano⁴⁶⁴; pathway aligned with the CHOP Penicillin Allergy Clinical Pathway⁴⁶⁵ and the AAAAI/ACAAI 2022 drug-allergy practice parameter.⁴⁶² Apply to the local antibiogram; verify doses before use.

⚠ **NEVER TEST THESE**

Anaphylaxis, SJS/TEN, DRESS, acute generalized exanthematous pustulosis (AGEP), serum sickness, cytopenias, interstitial nephritis, or hepatitis — no skin test, no challenge; refer to an allergist.⁴⁶²

Hereditary Angioedema – Acute Attack MINUTES

Bradykinin-mediated swelling that does **not** respond to epinephrine, antihistamine, or steroid.

RECOGNIZE

- Recurrent angioedema **without urticaria or itch**; laryngeal swelling, abdominal attacks; family history; known C1-esterase inhibitor deficiency.⁴⁶⁶
- If anaphylaxis cannot be excluded, give intramuscular epinephrine first (see [Anaphylaxis](#)) — failure to respond supports the diagnosis.⁴⁶⁶

Airway is the danger — early anesthetics/ENT for any laryngeal involvement⁴⁶⁶



SPECIFIC THERAPY

Give a hereditary angioedema (HAE)-specific agent early; earlier treatment means a milder, shorter attack. Every child with HAE should have on-demand therapy available at all times.^{466,467}

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
C1-esterase inhibitor concentrate	20 units/kg	IV; best safety evidence in children — first-line ⁴⁶⁶
Icatibant	Weight-based (max 30 mg): 10 mg (12–25 kg) 15 mg (26–40 kg) 20 mg (41–50 kg) 25 mg (51–65 kg) 30 mg (>65 kg)	SC (subcutaneous); bradykinin B2-receptor antagonist; ready-to-use prefilled syringe. Not recommended < 2 years or < 12 kg — no dose established (EMA label, licensed from 2 years; the US FDA label covers adults ≥ 18 years only) ⁴⁶⁶
Sebetralstat (oral; ≥ 12 years — availability in Kuwait to confirm)	600 mg (two 300 mg tablets) at the first sign repeat once after ≥ 3 h if inadequate max 1,200 mg/24 h	Oral plasma kallikrein inhibitor; first-line on-demand option from 12 years in the 2026 international pediatric guideline; not approved < 12 years. Severe laryngeal attacks were not studied — use a parenteral agent ⁴⁶⁷

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Fresh frozen plasma	10 mL/kg	IV; only if specific agents unavailable ⁴⁶⁶

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — laryngeal or severe attacks → a monitored bed.
- **Home** — after resolution with on-demand therapy and a written plan.
- **Refer — clinic** — immunology/allergy (diagnosis, prophylaxis).

When to Suspect Primary Immunodeficiency (IEI) ASSESS

Inborn errors of immunity — think of it before the next live vaccine or transfusion.

▀ WHEN TO SUSPECT – THE SPUR PATTERN

- **Severe, Persistent, Unusual** (opportunistic organism or unusually severe course), or **Recurrent infection**.⁴⁶⁸
- **Family history** of immunodeficiency or unexplained early infant death, **parental consanguinity, failure to thrive**, infections needing **intravenous antibiotics** or admission.⁴⁶⁸
- Classic thresholds: ≥ 2 pneumonias or ≥ 4 **new ear infections** in a year, ≥ 2 deep-seated infections (abscess, osteomyelitis), persistent oral/skin thrush after age 1, or little response to ≥ 2 months of antibiotics.^{468,469}
- **Non-infectious red flags** (increasingly recognized): autoimmune cytopenias — especially chronic, refractory, or multi-lineage — early or treatment-resistant inflammatory bowel disease (< 2 years), granulomas, lymphoproliferation, severe eczema.⁴⁷⁰

OVERVIEW – INFECTION PATTERN → LIKELY DEFECT

Infection pattern	Think	Typical clues
Recurrent sinopulmonary (encapsulated bacteria), onset mostly after 6 months	Antibody deficiency	Agammaglobulinemia, common variable immunodeficiency (CVID), IgA deficiency; low immunoglobulins
Early severe viral/fungal/opportunistic infection, chronic diarrhea, failure to thrive	Combined / T-cell	Severe combined immunodeficiency (SCID): lymphopenia, may have absent thymic shadow — a pediatric emergency (below)

Infection pattern	Think	Typical clues
Deep abscesses, unusual organisms (Serratia, Burkholderia, Aspergillus), poor wound healing	Phagocyte defect	Chronic granulomatous disease; leukocyte adhesion deficiency (delayed cord separation)
Recurrent Neisseria (meningococcal) or encapsulated-organism infection, or lupus-like disease	Complement deficiency	Early-onset, recurrent or familial meningococcal disease; lupus-like autoimmunity (early classical-pathway defects) ⁴⁷⁰

⚠ SUSPECTED SCID IS A PEDIATRIC EMERGENCY

- Infant in the first months of life with severe or persistent infection, chronic diarrhea, failure to thrive, oral thrush, or an **absolute lymphocyte count $< 2.5\text{--}3 \times 10^9/\text{L}$** (or a positive newborn T-cell receptor excision circle (TREC) screen) may have severe combined immunodeficiency.⁴⁷¹
- Diagnose **before** live vaccines, non-irradiated blood, or overwhelming infection — allows a life-saving transplant.⁴⁷¹
- Phone pediatric immunology the same day.⁴⁷¹

✦ FIRST-LINE SCREEN

- Full blood count **with differential** (absolute lymphocyte and neutrophil counts), immunoglobulins (IgG, IgA, IgM, IgE), lymphocyte subsets (T/B/NK by flow cytometry), complement (CH50/AH50 — total classical / alternative-pathway complement activity), and specific antibody responses (vaccine titers, isohemagglutinins); **HIV test** — exclude secondary immunodeficiency before labeling an inborn error.⁴⁷⁰
- Add a neutrophil oxidative-burst test (dihydrorhodamine) if a phagocyte defect is suspected. **Save a pre-treatment serum sample before giving intravenous immunoglobulin (IVIG).**⁴⁷⁰
- **To diagnose infections do not rely on serology** — antibody production is impaired and IVIG transfers donor antibody; use culture, PCR or antigen detection.

⚠ ACUTE DO / DON'T WHEN IEI IS SUSPECTED

- **Do not** give live vaccines (BCG, oral polio, rotavirus, MMR, varicella, yellow fever) — they can cause fatal vaccine-strain disease.⁴⁷¹
- **If blood products are needed, use only irradiated, CMV-negative, leukoreduced products** (prevents transfusion-associated graft-versus-host disease).⁴⁷²
- Do not delay empiric antibiotics for fever — treat any infection promptly and aggressively; avoid non-essential steroids/immunosuppression before a diagnosis.⁴⁷⁰

▲ SUSPECTED SCID – EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT, UNDER PEDIATRIC IMMUNOLOGY DIRECTION

- **A medical emergency:** immunology the same day; confirmatory testing (lymphocyte subsets ± TREC) at a center able to interpret it. ^{472,473}
- **Protective isolation** of infant and family from the moment of suspicion (single room, strict hand hygiene; laminar-flow unit where available). ^{472,473}
- **Treat any infection promptly and aggressively.** *Pneumocystis jirovecii* pneumonia (PJP) is frequent — chest X-ray ± bronchoalveolar lavage; if suspected or proven, co-trimoxazole (trimethoprim-sulfamethoxazole) 20 mg/kg/day of trimethoprim IV in divided doses. ⁴⁷³
- **Prophylaxis:** co-trimoxazole 5 mg/kg/day of trimethoprim (from 4–6 weeks of age — in a younger neonate immunology chooses the agent, because sulfonamides displace bilirubin); fluconazole 5 mg/kg/day; palivizumab in the RSV season. ^{472,473}
- **IVIG replacement** 400 mg/kg every 3 weeks. ^{472,473}
- Only **irradiated, CMV-negative, leukoreduced** blood products; **no live vaccines.** ^{472,473}
- Growth failure → parenteral nutrition. ⁴⁷³
- Plan **hematopoietic cell transplantation** (or gene therapy) immediately once the diagnosis is established. ^{472,473}

REFER

- Pediatric immunology for all suspected inborn errors of immunity — the same day for suspected SCID, any opportunistic infection, or profound lymphopenia.
- IVIG replacement and HLA-typing proceed under specialist direction. ⁴⁷⁰

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — as dictated by the presenting infection.
- **Home** — per the acute problem (from the emergency department or the ward, as that card dictates), with the workup arranged.
- **Refer — clinic** — immunology; avoid live vaccines and use irradiated blood products until cleared.

Pneumothorax – Tension, Traumatic & Spontaneous

MINUTES

ATLS · NAEMSP 2024 · BTS 2023

Tension: decompress on clinical grounds before any X-ray. All others: decide who goes home, who is observed, and who needs a drain. ⁴⁷⁴

▲ RECOGNIZE

- **Tension** — rapidly worsening distress and **hypoxia** with **hypotension, unilateral absent/reduced breath sounds**, hyper-resonance, distended neck veins and (late) tracheal deviation — after trauma, in asthma, or in a **ventilated child** who suddenly desaturates and drops their pressure. ^{16,474}

- **Simple traumatic** — blunt or penetrating chest injury, rib fractures, or after a central line or positive-pressure ventilation. **Primary spontaneous** — typically a tall, thin adolescent with sudden pleuritic pain ± breathlessness. **Secondary spontaneous** — asthma, cystic fibrosis, connective-tissue disease (Marfan, Ehlers–Danlos), congenital lung lesion, necrotizing pneumonia, or ventilation. ^{475,476,477}

⚠ **TENSION PNEUMOTHORAX – DECOMPRESS NOW**

- Tension pneumothorax is a **clinical diagnosis** — if tension pneumothorax is suspected in an unstable child, **do not wait for a chest X-ray**. ^{16,474}
- Perform immediate **needle decompression**, or **finger thoracostomy** where appropriate for the child's size and available expertise, followed by **chest-drain insertion**. ⁴⁷⁴
- **Not for newborns** — neonatal pneumothorax (transillumination, needle/butterfly aspiration) follows the NRP / neonatal unit protocol; see [Neonatal Resuscitation](#).

Step	Landmark	Notes
Needle decompression	4th/5th intercostal space, anterior axillary line – preferred at all ages. 2nd space mid-clavicular only when a pneumothorax there is confirmed: in infants and small children the heart and thymus lie against the chest wall at that site	Over the top of the rib; aspirate while advancing; ultrasound before puncture whenever time allows (confirms the pneumothorax, chest-wall depth and no heart beneath). ^{16,353,478}
Cannula size (suggestions)	Infant: 22–20 G × 25–32 mm Child (≈ 5 y): 20–18 G × 32 mm Older child (≈ 10 y): 18 G × 45 mm Adolescent: 16–14 G × 45–50 mm	These sizes are suggestions. Select an appropriate device for the child's body habitus. The listed length is not the insertion depth. Aspirate continuously during insertion. Once air is aspirated, stop advancing the sharp needle; advance the plastic catheter off the needle and withdraw the needle. Use ultrasound if time allows. Avoid large-bore cannulas in infants (intercostal space ≈ 4–6 mm). Chest-wall thickness is 11–19 mm in most children, so a standard 32 mm catheter reaches the pleura. ^{353,479,480}
Finger thoracostomy	4th/5th space, anterior to the mid-axillary line (the chest-drain site)	When needle decompression fails, or the child is large enough and expertise is at hand; converts to a drain. ⁴⁷⁴
Definitive	Chest drain, 4th/5th space anterior to the mid-axillary line	Follows decompression — do not delay for imaging; size by age and indication (hemothorax needs a larger tube); X-ray afterwards for position. ^{16,474}

▶ WORKUP (NON-TENSION)

- Upright chest X-ray. Lung ultrasound by a trained operator (absent lung sliding, lung point) is faster and more sensitive than a supine film (meta-analysis of mostly adult studies)⁴⁸¹ — in trauma as part of eFAST¹⁶. CT is not needed for a first spontaneous pneumothorax.⁴⁷⁶

▶ DISPOSITION – WHO GOES HOME, WHO IS OBSERVED, WHO NEEDS A DRAIN

- **Emergency drain** — tension or hemodynamic compromise, significant hypoxia, bilateral pneumothorax, hemopneumothorax, ventilated child, or a large pneumothorax with underlying lung disease (asthma, CF) — adult-derived criteria (BTS); CF per CF Foundation guidance.^{475,477}
- **Admit · observe or non-emergency drain** — any **secondary** pneumothorax (admit; low threshold for a drain; CF: large → chest tube, small and stable → close observation; withhold BiPAP while present); a symptomatic primary pneumothorax needing intervention → needle aspiration, or an ambulatory device where a follow-up pathway exists; infants and young children (adult pathways do not apply — decide with surgery/respiratory).^{475,476,477,482}
- **ED discharge** — primary spontaneous pneumothorax in an adolescent who is minimally symptomatic (no significant pain or breathlessness, no physiological compromise), stable on observation, with no high-risk feature and a reliable family: written advice to return immediately if breathless; X-ray and respiratory/surgical review in 2–4 weeks; counsel on recurrence (≈ 30 % after non-surgical management) and smoking/vaping. Adult-derived evidence (trials enrolled from age 14).^{475,476,482,483}
- **Surgical referral** — air leak persisting 24–48 h, second same-side or first opposite-side episode, tension at the first episode, bilateral; CF: pleurodesis only after recurrence, never for the first episode.^{475,476,477}

✦ FLYING AND DIVING

No flying with an unresolved pneumothorax; fly only **≥ 7 days after X-ray resolution** (2 weeks in CF). **Scuba diving is discouraged permanently** unless definitive surgery (pleurectomy) has been performed. Adult guidance applied to adolescents.^{475,477,484}

▶ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — all pneumothoraces needing drainage and all secondary pneumothoraces; PICU for tension or ventilated children.
- **Refer — now** — critical care ± pediatric surgery; the respiratory team for CF/asthma.
- **Refer — clinic** — arrange follow-up for every discharged adolescent.

Cytokine Storm – HLH / MAS (Systemic Hyperinflammation) HOURS

EULAR/ACR 2022 • EULAR/PreS 2024

One process, many names: hematology calls it HLH, rheumatology calls it MAS — the joint EULAR/ACR consensus (rheumatology, hematology, immunology, infectious diseases and intensive care) is the common ground this card follows.

RECOGNIZE – A PATTERN THAT EVOLVES, NOT A SINGLE VALUE

- **Persistent fever that looks like sepsis but does not respond**, hepatosplenomegaly, **falling counts (≥ 2 lines)**, **very high or rising ferritin**, rising triglycerides, falling fibrinogen, rising transaminases and LDH, coagulopathy/DIC, and CNS signs (irritability, seizures, altered consciousness). Individual findings are non-specific — read them together and over time⁴⁸⁵.
- **Examine perfusion first** — tachycardia with cool extremities, prolonged capillary refill or reduced urine output at a **normal blood pressure** is compensated shock; myocardial dysfunction is common in hyperinflammation, so get an **early echocardiogram**^{3,486}.
- **In sJIA / Still's disease**: a **falling ESR** with rising CRP and ferritin, a **falling platelet or white count from a high baseline**, and hypofibrinogenemia are early clues (consumption). On canakinumab or tocilizumab the fever and the ferritin rise may be blunted or delayed; the risk also rises when steroids or biologics are tapered^{487,488}.
- **Ferritin**: send it in every child with new or heightened suspicion, even if a previous value was normal, and repeat daily. > 500 ng/mL is 84% sensitive in children (the Histiocyte Society cut-off) but not specific; pediatric studies use 500–2,000; a rapidly rising or very high (> 10,000) ferritin is highly suggestive⁴⁸⁵.
- The same process complicates infection (EBV, CMV, dengue, leishmaniasis, tuberculosis, typhoid, brucellosis), malignancy (leukemia, lymphoma), rheumatic disease (sJIA, lupus, Kawasaki), MIS-C, immunotherapy, and inborn errors (familial HLH, XLP, Chédiak–Higashi, Griscelli)⁴⁸⁵.

CRITERIA – USEFUL IN THE SETTING THEY WERE BUILT FOR; NONE IS SUFFICIENT EVERYWHERE⁴⁸⁵

Tool	Built for	Rule
HLH criteria — HLH-2004, revised 2024	HLH (hematology pathway): primary/familial HLH and secondary HLH outside rheumatic disease – not for MAS in sJIA (use MAS-2016 below)	5 of 7: fever ≥ 38.5 °C · splenomegaly · cytopenias in ≥ 2 lines (Hb < 90 g/L, < 100 g/L under 4 weeks; platelets $< 100 \times 10^9/L$; neutrophils $< 1.0 \times 10^9/L$) · fibrinogen ≤ 1.5 g/L and/or triglycerides ≥ 3.0 mmol/L (265 mg/dL) · ferritin ≥ 500 µg/L · hemophagocytosis in marrow or other tissue · sCD25 $\geq 2,400$ U/mL. NK-cell activity is no longer a criterion (Histiocyte Society 2024): low perforin or defective degranulation is a separate cellular pathway that supports familial HLH, as do biallelic pathogenic variants or an affected sibling. ^{489,490}
MAS-2016	Febrile child with known or suspected sJIA	Ferritin > 684 ng/mL and any 2 of: platelets $\leq$ $181 \times 10^9/L$ · AST > 48 U/L · triglycerides $>$ 156 mg/dL · fibrinogen ≤ 360 mg/dL ⁴⁸⁸
MS score	Separating MAS from an sJIA flare	7 items (CNS dysfunction, bleeding, active arthritis, platelets, fibrinogen, LDH, ferritin); score $\geq -2.1 \rightarrow$ MAS (sensitivity 0.85, specificity 0.95) ⁴⁹¹
HScore	Adults; infection- or malignancy-associated HLH	Probability from $< 1\%$ (≤ 90) to $> 99\%$ ($\geq$ 250); online calculator ⁴⁹²

⚠ DO NOT WAIT TO SATISFY A SET OF CRITERIA BEFORE TREATING A DETERIORATING CHILD

- In a child with high-risk features or progression, start empiric immunomodulation during the initial evaluation — diagnostic work-up, treatment of the trigger and prevention of complications run in parallel^{485,487}.

📌 WORK-UP – STARTS ON SUSPICION, IN PARALLEL WITH TREATMENT

- **First tier (any hospital, same day):** CBC + film, ferritin, CRP, ESR, fibrinogen, D-dimer, PT/APTT, triglycerides, AST/ALT/GGT/bilirubin/albumin, LDH, creatinine, sodium; blood cultures; EBV and CMV PCR, HIV; other infections by exposure (dengue or malaria after travel, tuberculosis, leishmaniasis, typhoid, brucellosis) — hyperinflammation can be the presentation of an infection. Send serology **before** IVIG⁴⁸⁵.
- **Second tier (with the specialist teams): sCD25 (soluble IL-2 receptor- α)** — the most useful confirmatory test where available; **bone marrow** (also for malignancy — obtain **before** steroids when malignancy is plausible and it will not delay treatment; hemophagocytosis is neither required nor specific); IL-18 and CXCL9 where available; NK-cell function, CD107a degranulation, perforin/SAP/XIAP flow cytometry⁴⁸⁵.
- **Genetics early in every child** (multigene panel or exome), and in anyone with consanguinity, family history, recurrence, albinism or prominent CNS disease — consanguinity makes this especially relevant in Kuwait; a genetic diagnosis changes treatment, prognosis and family counseling⁴⁸⁵.

- **CNS:** assess every child < 1 year, any suspected familial disease and any neurological sign — CSF (cells, protein, glucose, cytology) and contrast MRI — **without delaying treatment**⁴⁸⁵.

TREAT – EMPIRIC IMMUNOMODULATION EARLY; TREAT THE TRIGGER AT THE SAME TIME (ANTIMICROBIALS BY EXPOSURE; AN ACTIVE INFECTION DOES NOT DELAY MAS TREATMENT)^{485,487}

Step	Drug & dose	Notes
1 • Methylprednisolone — MAS pathway and undifferentiated hyperinflammation	Methylprednisolone pulse 15–30 mg/kg/day IV (max 1 g) × 3 days then 2 mg/kg/day divided	Strongest evidence across all forms of HLH/MAS; shorter-acting agents are preferred while the diagnosis is still evolving ^{485,487}
1 • Dexamethasone — HLH pathway (hematology leads) or CNS involvement	10 mg/m ² /day IV or PO (≈ 2–4 mg/kg/day methylprednisolone) HLH-94/2004 8-week taper: Wk 1–2 • 10 mg/m ² /day Wk 3–4 • 5 mg/m ² /day Wk 5–6 • 2.5 mg/m ² /day Wk 7 • 1.25 mg/m ² /day Wk 8 • taper to zero	Preferred when HLH is the leading diagnosis because it crosses the blood–brain barrier (better CNS penetration). Long half-life — a shorter-acting steroid is preferable while the diagnosis is still evolving. ^{485,490,493}
2 • Add early — MAS / sJIA, Kawasaki or MIS-C overlap, undifferentiated hyperinflammation	Anakinra (IL-1 receptor antagonist) 2–4 mg/kg/day (above the standard 1–2 mg/kg/day) Critically ill: escalate to 10 mg/kg/day, divided q6–12 h or repeated IV doses	Immunomodulation without immunosuppression; short half-life; does not obscure a malignancy work-up ^{485,487,494}
2 • IVIG	1–2 g/kg	Endorsed for empiric use, especially with Kawasaki/MIS-C overlap; a large colloid load — caution with cardiac dysfunction ⁴⁸⁵
3 • Inadequate response at 24–72 h, or severe / rapidly worsening — with the reference team	Ciclosporin oral or IV, level-guided or tacrolimus 0.1 mg/kg/day divided q12h (EULAR/ACR alternative)	For MAS; not for primary HLH (proven ineffective). Combination therapy on a background of high-dose glucocorticoid is often needed and may be initial therapy in severe MAS ^{485,487}
3 • Emapalumab (anti-IFN-γ)	Primary HLH: 1 mg/kg IV twice weekly (with dexamethasone) Still's / sJIA-MAS: 6 mg/kg once, then 3 mg/kg every 3 days to day 16, then twice weekly Titrate to max 10 mg/kg/dose	FDA-approved for primary HLH and for HLH/MAS in Still's disease after glucocorticoid failure; screen and monitor for TB, CMV and other infection ^{487,495}

Step	Drug & dose	Notes
3 · Ruxolitinib	Specialist, off-label	JAK inhibition; promising in refractory HLH/MAS ^{485,487}
3 · Etoposide-based (HLH-94)	Hematology-directed Primary/familial HLH, severe EBV-HLH: HLH-94 induction – etoposide 150 mg/m² IV twice weekly wk 1–2, then weekly to wk 8, with the dexamethasone taper above Secondary HLH – severe, or no response to steroids ± IVIG at 72 h: start etoposide promptly – children 150 mg/m² once weekly; older teenagers 50–100 mg/m²	Life-saving in primary HLH and severe EBV-HLH; not first-line for MAS (low-dose only if refractory); not for most non-EBV infections. Cyclosporin is no longer given in the first weeks (HLH-2004 upfront cyclosporin showed no benefit). ^{485,487,493,496}
3 · Rituximab	Hematology-directed	EBV-driven HLH (B-cell depletion) ⁴⁸⁵

✦ SUPPORTIVE CARE AND MONITORING

- Sepsis-style resuscitation and broad antimicrobials pending cultures; consider *Pneumocystis* and antifungal prophylaxis early (part of HLH-94); no live vaccines; irradiated blood products if transplant is possible⁴⁸⁵.
- **Daily** ferritin, CRP, CBC, fibrinogen and ALT (± triglycerides); more often if critical. A ferritin that fails to fall predicts a poor outcome — escalate and re-examine the diagnosis (lymphoma, unrecognized infection, genetic HLH)⁴⁸⁵.

◆ KUWAIT JOINT PATHWAY – RHEUMATOLOGY · HEMATOLOGY/ONCOLOGY · PICU

- **SAME FIRST HOUR, WHICHEVER TEAM IS CALLED FIRST:** ferritin + first-tier panel, cultures, methylprednisolone pulse ± anakinra. **NO TEAM DELAYS GLUCOCORTICOIDS WAITING FOR THE OTHER.**
- **RHEUMATOLOGY LEADS** when there is a known or strongly suspected rheumatic context (sJIA/Still's, lupus, Kawasaki, MIS-C): MAS pathway — glucocorticoid + anakinra ± cyclosporin → emapalumab⁴⁸⁷.
- **HEMATOLOGY/ONCOLOGY LEADS** when: age < 2 years, consanguinity or family history, EBV-driven disease, cytopenias or organomegaly dominant, possible malignancy, or no rheumatic context: HLH pathway — genetics and marrow first where safe; dexamethasone with the HLH-94 taper; etoposide when severe or no response at 72 h; emapalumab for primary HLH^{485,490}.
- **BOTH ARE CONSULTED WITHIN HOURS IN EVERY CASE;** PICU for organ dysfunction; infectious diseases for the trigger and prophylaxis; immunology for inborn-error evaluation. A multidisciplinary HLH/MAS team improves recognition and reduces over- and under-treatment⁴⁸⁵. Transfer of care is by agreement, not by admission ward.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → high-dependency/PICU.

- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; under the leading team with a written taper and monitoring plan.
- **Refer — now** — hematology and rheumatology within hours; PICU.⁴⁸⁵
- **Refer — clinic** — genetic counseling for every family tested.⁴⁸⁵

Kawasaki Disease HOURS

Medium-vessel vasculitis; leading cause of acquired heart disease in children.

RECOGNIZE

- Fever ≥ 5 days + ≥ 4 of: bilateral non-exudative conjunctivitis, oral mucosal changes (cracked/red lips, strawberry tongue, diffuse oropharyngeal erythema), polymorphous rash, extremity changes (swelling/peeling), cervical lymphadenopathy > 1.5 cm¹⁰⁸.
- **Incomplete Kawasaki** is common in infants < 6 months and older children — fewer features but high coronary risk; use inflammatory markers and echocardiography¹⁰⁸.

PEARL — THINK INCOMPLETE KAWASAKI

- Suspect **incomplete Kawasaki** in any infant < 6 months with ≥ 5 days of **unexplained fever** even without the full clinical criteria — this is the group most often missed and at the highest risk of coronary aneurysms¹⁰⁸.
- Check inflammatory markers and arrange echocardiography; treat on a compatible picture rather than waiting for every feature. **AHA pathway:** fever ≥ 5 days + 2–3 clinical criteria (or an infant with ≥ 7 days of unexplained fever) → check CRP/ESR; if CRP ≥ 3 mg/dL and/or ESR ≥ 40 mm/h, look for ≥ 3 supplementary lab findings (anemia, platelets $\geq 450 \times 10^9/L$ after day 7, albumin ≤ 3 g/dL, raised ALT, WBC $\geq 15 \times 10^9/L$, sterile pyuria) or a positive echocardiogram¹⁰⁸ → treat.

Treat within 10 days of fever onset to protect the coronaries¹⁰⁸



FIRST-LINE

- IVIG 2 g/kg as a single infusion + **low-dose (antiplatelet) aspirin 3–5 mg/kg/day**; baseline echocardiogram¹⁰⁸.
- Discuss adjunct corticosteroids with cardiology/rheumatology for high-risk patients (infants < 1 year, coronary changes, high inflammatory markers, or Kawasaki disease shock syndrome)¹⁰⁸ — AHA 2024 defines high risk as **age < 6 months or baseline LAD/RCA z-score ≥ 2.5** (CRP ≥ 13 mg/dL and Asian ancestry also predict aneurysms) and supports intensified initial therapy for this group.⁴⁹⁷

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
IVIG	2 g/kg single infusion over 10–12 h	IV. IVIG-resistant fever $\geq$ 36 h after the end of the infusion → second IVIG 2 g/kg, or corticosteroids, or a biologic (infliximab, now dosed 10 mg/kg IV over 2 h) ^{108,497} Echo: baseline at diagnosis (do not delay IVIG for it); if any coronary Z score $\geq$ 2.5, repeat at least twice weekly in hospital until dimensions stop progressing; repeat before discharge if IVIG-resistant or high-risk. ^{108,497}
Aspirin	3–5 mg/kg/day PO once daily from diagnosis continue 6–8 weeks or until the echocardiogram is normal	Antiplatelet dose only, from the outset. Anti-inflammatory doses (30–100 mg/kg/day) are not recommended — no coronary benefit, more adverse effects ^{498,499} . See the aspirin note below
Methylprednisolone → prednisolone (high-risk)	IV 2 mg/kg/day (max 60 mg/day) in divided doses for 5 days then oral prednisolone 2 mg/kg/day tapered over 15 days once CRP is normal (RAISE protocol)	Adjunct to IVIG in high-risk patients or Kawasaki disease shock syndrome ^{108,497}

⚠ NOTE

- Single-dose methylprednisolone with IVIG is **not** recommended as routine primary therapy¹⁰⁸.
- Avoid ibuprofen with aspirin (antagonizes antiplatelet effect¹⁰⁸).
- **Aspirin and varicella/influenza:** withhold aspirin during active varicella or influenza (Reye syndrome) and use an alternative antiplatelet agent (clopidogrel) meanwhile; give the annual influenza vaccine to every child on aspirin¹⁰⁸.

◆ WHY THE ANTIPLATELET DOSE

- Anti-inflammatory dosing has never been shown to reduce coronary aneurysms¹⁰⁸: a randomized trial found IVIG alone non-inferior to IVIG + high-dose aspirin⁴⁹⁸; a network meta-analysis of 1,944 patients found no difference in coronary lesions, IVIG resistance or hospital stay between no aspirin, 3–5, 30–50 and 80–100 mg/kg/day⁴⁹⁹; meta-analyses and cohorts show equal coronary outcomes with low-dose from the outset and fewer adverse effects (GI bleeding, transaminase rise, Reye syndrome)^{500,501,502,503}.
- One Japanese database study found more coronary abnormalities at 5 than at 30 mg/kg/day (OR 1.40) — observational and contradicted by the randomized data; a 1,346-patient trial of 30–50 vs 3–5 mg/kg/day is under way⁵⁰⁴.
- **AHA 2024** still describes moderate- (30–50 mg/kg/day) or high-dose (80–100 mg/kg/day) aspirin until afebrile 48–72 h as traditional practice, but now states that medium- or high-dose aspirin in the acute phase "is likely not associated with improved CA outcomes" and gives no dose recommendation pending the ongoing randomized trial^{108,497}; this guide recommends the antiplatelet dose (3–5 mg/kg/day) from diagnosis on the strength of the randomized and pooled evidence above.

CORONARY ARTERY INVOLVEMENT – AHA Z-SCORE CLASSIFICATION & CARDIOLOGY-DIRECTED THROMBOPROPHYLAXIS

Category	Z score (LAD or RCA)	Echo frequency & antithrombotic plan
No involvement	< 2	Repeat echo 1–2 weeks after discharge and at 4–6 weeks; AHA 2024: if normal at diagnosis and at 1–2 weeks, further imaging only if new concerns arise. Low-dose aspirin until the follow-up echo is normal. ^{108,497}
Dilation only	2 to < 2.5	As above; the AHA also counts a fall in Z score of ≥ 1 during follow-up as dilation. ¹⁰⁸
Small aneurysm	≥ 2.5 to < 5	Echo at least twice weekly in hospital until dimensions stop progressing; echo at discharge and again within 1 week. Low-dose aspirin. ^{108,497}
Medium aneurysm	≥ 5 to < 10 and < 8 mm	As for small aneurysm; low-dose aspirin, clopidogrel may be added; anticoagulation not indicated. ¹⁰⁸
Large or giant aneurysm	≥ 10 or ≥ 8 mm	Twice-weekly echo while expanding, then at least weekly for the first 45 days. Low-dose aspirin plus anticoagulation (warfarin INR 2–3 or LMWH anti-Xa 0.5–1.0 U/mL; DOACs emerging); clopidogrel added for very extensive/distal aneurysms or prior thrombosis. Lifelong cardiology follow-up. ^{108,497}

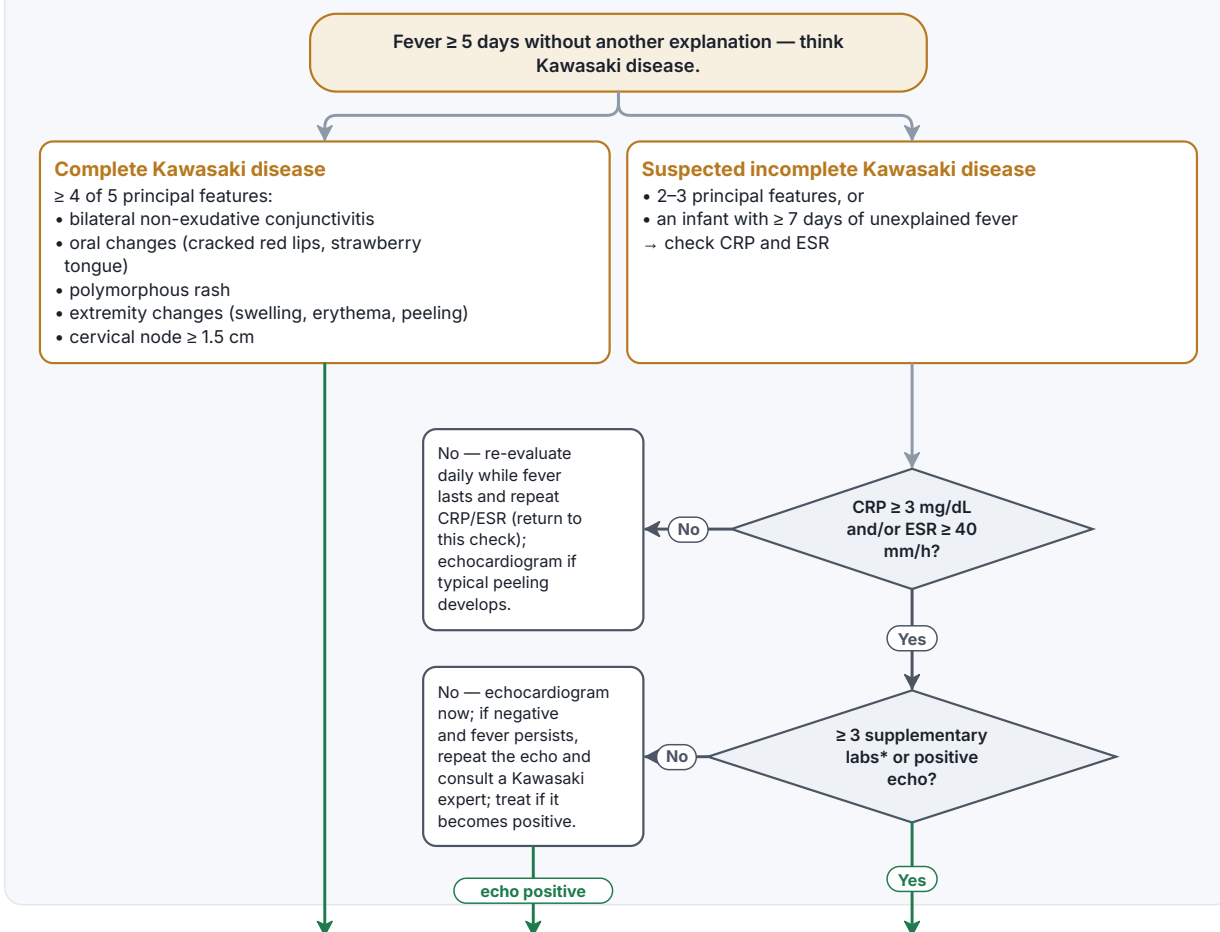
Kawasaki disease – algorithm A: diagnosis and initial treatment

Adapted from the AHA Kawasaki disease scientific statement, 2024 update^{108,497}. Aspirin 3–5 mg/kg/day from diagnosis is this guide's policy (see "Why the antiplatelet dose").

Kawasaki disease — A. Diagnosis and initial treatment

Adapted from the AHA Kawasaki disease scientific statement, 2024 update · Z = coronary artery Z score (LAD or RCA, adjusted for body surface area)

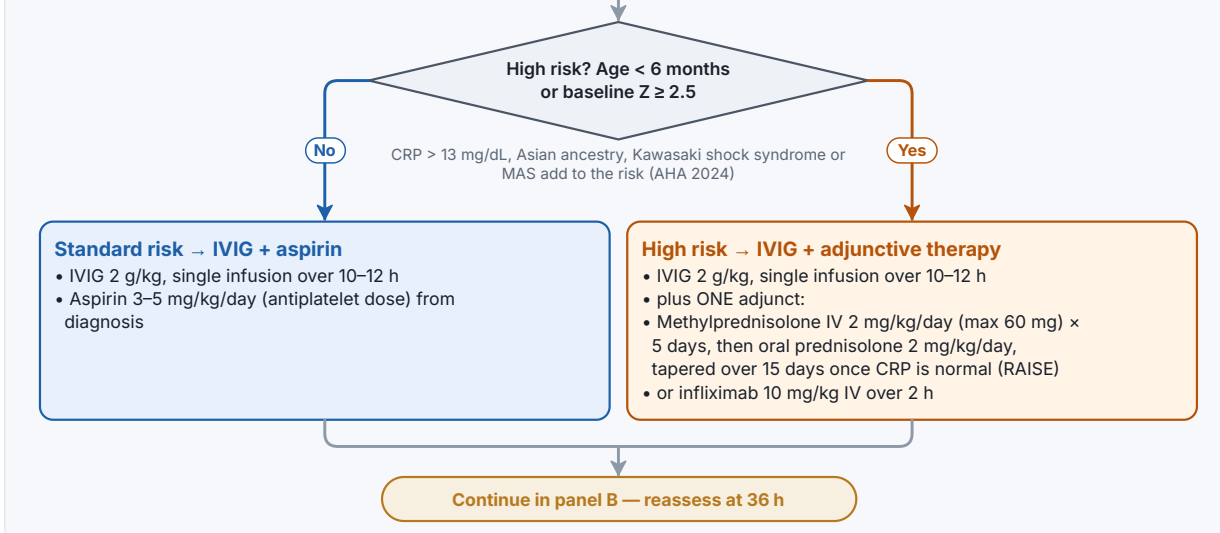
1 DIAGNOSE



TREAT

Baseline echocardiogram when the diagnosis is considered — unavailability or technical limits must not delay IVIG. Treat within 10 days of fever onset; after day 10 still treat if CRP > 3 mg/dL with persistent fever or coronary aneurysms.

2 TREAT — RISK-STRATIFY (AHA 2024)



*Supplementary laboratory findings: anemia for age · platelets ≥ 450 × 10⁹/L after the 7th day of fever · albumin ≤ 3 g/dL · raised ALT · WBC ≥ 15 × 10⁹/L · urine ≥ 10 WBC/hpf. Aspirin 3–5 mg/kg/day from diagnosis is this guide's policy (see card); AHA still lists moderate/high dose until afebrile as an option.

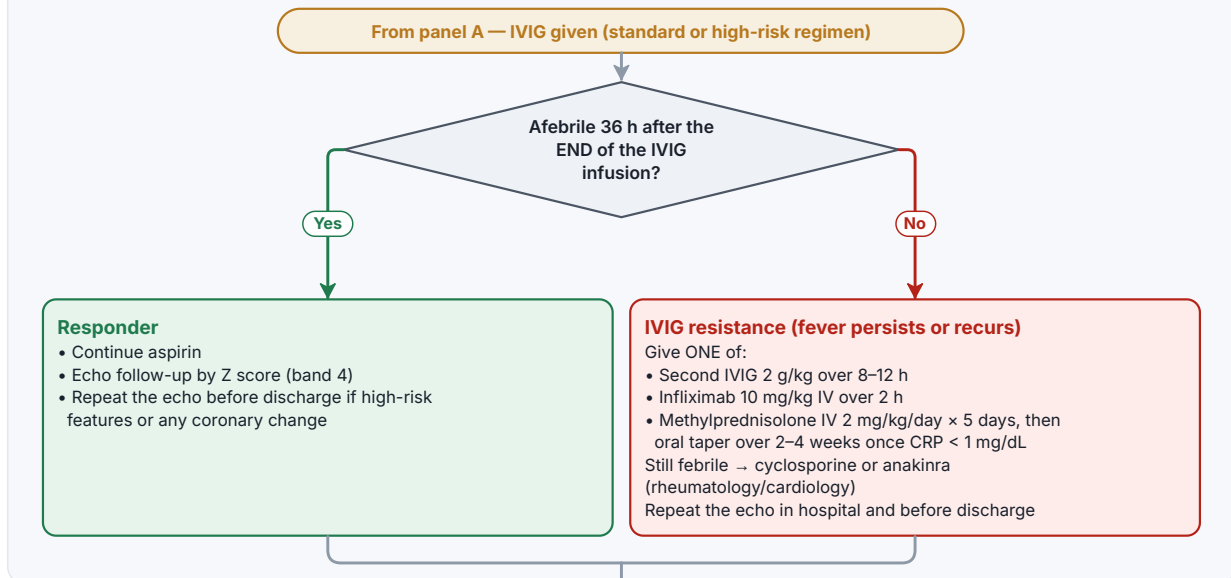
Kawasaki disease – algorithm B: reassessment at 36 h and echocardiogram follow-up by Z score

IVIG resistance = persistent or recrudescent fever ≥ 36 h after the end of the infusion⁴⁹⁷; echo at least twice weekly for $Z \geq 2.5$ and before discharge when IVIG-resistant or high-risk^{108,497}.

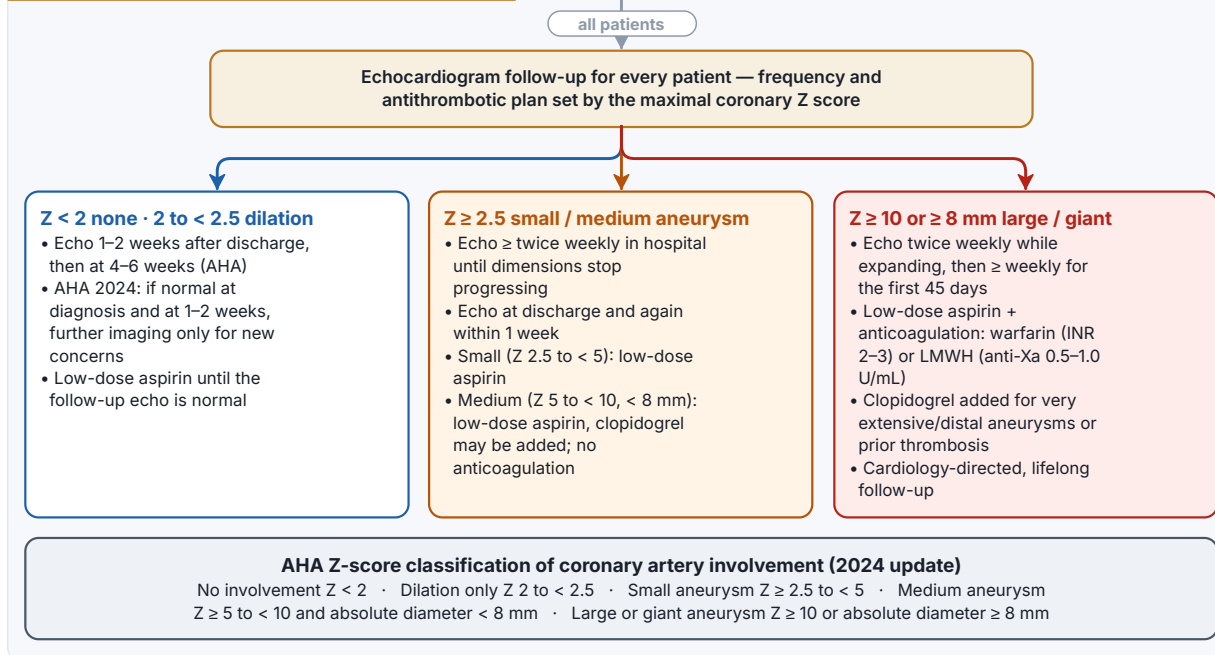
Kawasaki disease — B. Reassessment and echocardiogram follow-up

Adapted from the AHA Kawasaki disease scientific statement, 2024 update · Z = coronary artery Z score (LAD or RCA, adjusted for body surface area)

3 REASSESS AT 36 HOURS



4 ECHO FOLLOW-UP BY MAXIMAL Z SCORE



Source: Jone PN et al. Update on diagnosis and management of Kawasaki disease: a scientific statement from the AHA. Circulation 2024;150:e481–e500 (retains the diagnostic algorithm and Z-score classification of the earlier AHA statement). IVIG resistance = persistent or recrudescent fever ≥ 36 h after the end of the infusion (AHA 2024).

⚠ WATCH FOR

Macrophage activation syndrome (cytokine storm — see [HLH / MAS](#)) and **Kawasaki disease shock syndrome** (hypotension / poor perfusion) — both signal severe, high-risk disease; escalate, add adjunctive steroids, and involve rheumatology/cardiology + PICU^{108,488}.

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → for IVIG and monitoring; PICU for Kawasaki disease shock syndrome or MAS.
- **Home from the ward** — afebrile ≥ 36 h after the end of IVIG, with an **echocardiogram repeated before discharge** if fever persisted or recurred (IVIG resistance), high-risk features, or any coronary dilation/aneurysm; repeat echo **1–2 weeks after discharge** (within 1 week if $Z \geq 2.5$) and at 4–6 weeks (AHA 2024: may be omitted when the first two are normal); aspirin plan written down.^{108,497}
- **Refer — now** — cardiology (echo, Z scores) and rheumatology for every case; IVIG-resistant cases urgently.¹⁰⁸
- **Refer — clinic** — cardiology follow-up per the Z-score table; lifelong if an aneurysm ever formed.¹⁰⁸

IgA Vasculitis (Henoch–Schönlein Purpura)

ASSESS

SHARE 2019

Palpable purpura on the legs and buttocks — the commonest childhood vasculitis; the kidney is the long game.

▀ RECOGNIZE (PURPURA + ≥ 1)

- **Palpable purpura** (mandatory), lower-limb/buttock predominant, with normal platelets and coagulation, **plus** at least one of: diffuse abdominal pain · arthritis/arthralgia · biopsy showing IgA deposition · renal involvement (hematuria/proteinuria)⁵⁰⁵.

⚠ TWO THINGS THAT TURN IT INTO AN EMERGENCY

- **Intussusception** — usually **ileo-ileal** (easily missed on routine imaging — use ultrasound⁵⁰⁶) in a child with severe/colicky abdominal pain or GI bleeding.
- And **testicular pain/swelling** can mimic torsion⁵⁰⁶.
- Severe abdominal pain, GI bleeding, scrotal pain or a rapidly rising creatinine/BP all need admission⁵⁰⁶.

✦ THE KIDNEY CAN DECLARE ITSELF LATE

- Nephritis may appear **weeks to months** after the rash.⁵⁰⁶
- Check **blood pressure and urinalysis at every visit** and continue surveillance for **6 months** (schedule below) even after the rash resolves^{506,507,508}.
- Persistent proteinuria⁵⁰⁶ → nephrology.

▀ WORKUP

- **Urinalysis + urine protein:creatinine ratio** and **blood pressure** at every visit — nephritis screen (monitor for 6–12 months even if initially normal⁵⁰⁶).
- Serum **creatinine / eGFR**⁵⁰⁶.

- CBC + coagulation — platelets are **normal/high** in IgA vasculitis (excludes ITP/HUS⁵⁰⁵).
- **Renal biopsy** only for significant or persistent proteinuria or impaired function⁵⁰⁶.

Problem	Approach	Notes
Joint / mild pain	Acetaminophen; NSAIDs if no renal involvement or GI bleeding	Most cases are supportive only ⁵⁰⁶
Severe abdominal pain / orchitis	Prednisolone 1–2 mg/kg/day (max 60 mg), short course with taper	Eases pain; does not prevent nephritis ⁵⁰⁶
Nephritis (significant)	Nephrology-directed (steroids ± immunosuppression)	Do not manage severe nephritis alone ⁵⁰⁶

◆ WHERE TO MANAGE – MOST CHILDREN GO HOME

- **UNCOMPLICATED IGA VASCULITIS** (rash ± joint pain, mild abdominal pain, normal blood pressure, normal or trace urinalysis, eating and walking) is **OUTPATIENT CARE**: analgesia, counseling, and teaching the family to check the urine for protein at home over the next 3–6 months, with a written follow-up plan. No guideline recommends routine admission — most children need only supportive treatment^{506,507,508}.
- **RETURN AT ONCE IF**: severe or worsening abdominal pain, vomiting, blood in the stool, swollen or painful testicle, blood in the urine or foamy urine, swelling of the face/legs, headache or reduced urine output.
- **ADMIT ONLY FOR**: severe abdominal pain (needs parenteral analgesia), GI bleeding or suspected intussusception, unable to walk or drink, scrotal/testicular involvement until torsion is excluded, hypertension, acute kidney injury or a nephrotic/nephritic presentation, CNS or pulmonary involvement, or an unsafe discharge^{506,507}.

✦ FOLLOW-UP PLAN FOR THE NEPHRITIS SCREEN – GIVE IT IN WRITING AT THE FIRST VISIT

- **What:** blood pressure + early-morning urine dipstick at every visit; protein $\geq 1+$ → urine protein:creatinine ratio; creatinine/eGFR at diagnosis and whenever the urine is abnormal^{506,508}.
- **When:** diagnosis · **day 7** (a normal day-7 urinalysis predicts a normal renal outcome with 97% negative predictive value⁵⁰⁹) · day 14 · day 28 · months 2, 3 and 6 — at least monthly for 6 months even if normal^{507,508}. Nephritis appears on average ~4 weeks after the rash and can appear late, so early normal results do not shorten the schedule⁵⁰⁶.
- **Discharge from surveillance** at 6 months if blood pressure and urine have stayed normal; extend to 12 months if any abnormality occurred^{506,507}; biopsy-proven nephritis is followed for years by nephrology^{507,508}.
- **Nephrology now:** urine protein:creatinine > 250 mg/mmol at any time (biopsy if it persists 4 weeks); 100–250 mg/mmol persisting (biopsy if 3 months); eGFR < 90 mL/min/1.73 m²; hypertension; nephrotic or nephritic syndrome; acute kidney injury^{506,507,508}. ACE inhibitor/ARB for proteinuria lasting > 3 months⁵⁰⁶.
- **Steroids do not prevent nephritis** — no prednisolone for the rash; reserve it for severe abdominal pain/GI bleeding once intussusception is excluded, orchitis, or other severe organ involvement^{506,507}.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — only for the indications above.
- **Home** — outpatient follow-up per the schedule, with the return precautions explained.
- **Refer — now** — surgery if intussusception; urology if the scrotum is involved.
- **Refer — clinic** — nephrology per the thresholds above.

MIS-C (Multisystem Inflammatory Syndrome) MINUTES

CDC/CSTE 2023 · ACR 2022

Post-COVID hyperinflammation that overlaps Kawasaki and toxic shock — and can crash the heart.

▴ RECOGNIZE (CRITERIA)

- **CDC/CSTE 2023 case definition** — age < 21 y with **fever ≥ 38.0 °C** (subjective or documented; no minimum duration), **illness severe enough to need admission**, **CRP ≥ 3.0 mg/dL (30 mg/L)**, and **new involvement of ≥ 2 of 5 systems:** **cardiac** (LVEF < 55 %, coronary dilation/aneurysm/ectasia, or raised troponin) · **mucocutaneous** (rash, oral mucosal inflammation, conjunctival injection, or extremity erythema/edema) · **shock** · **gastrointestinal** (abdominal pain, vomiting, diarrhea) · **hematologic** (platelets < $150 \times 10^9/L$ or lymphocytes < $1.0 \times 10^9/L$) — with **no more likely alternative diagnosis**.⁵¹⁰
- **SARS-CoV-2 link: confirmed** when PCR or antigen is positive within the 60 days before or during admission, or antibodies are detected during the illness; **probable** when there was close contact with COVID-19 in the preceding 60 days.⁵¹⁰

⚠ IT LOOKS LIKE SEVERAL KILLERS AT ONCE

- Overlaps **Kawasaki disease, toxic shock syndrome and sepsis** — treat the shock, take cultures and cover for sepsis until excluded⁴⁸⁶.
- Prominent abdominal pain can mimic appendicitis. **Cardiac:** myocardial dysfunction, arrhythmia and **coronary artery aneurysms** — get an early echocardiogram and troponin/BNP⁴⁸⁶.
- **Shock is often compensated at first.** Tachycardia, cool or mottled extremities, prolonged capillary refill, weak pulses, reduced urine output or drowsiness **with a normal blood pressure** is shock until proven otherwise — hypotension is a late sign³. Myocardial dysfunction can be insidious and children can decompensate rapidly: examine perfusion at every review, get the **echocardiogram early** (left-ventricular function, coronary z-scores), and repeat troponin/BNP⁴⁸⁶. Fluid cautiously (5–10 mL/kg, reassess) and start epinephrine early if the heart is the problem.

▢ WORKUP

- **Inflammatory:** CRP, ESR, **ferritin**, procalcitonin, CBC (lymphopenia), fibrinogen⁴⁸⁶, **D-dimer**.
- **Cardiac:** troponin, BNP/NT-proBNP, ECG and echocardiogram (coronary arteries + function)⁴⁸⁶.
- **SARS-CoV-2** PCR and serology; **blood cultures** to exclude sepsis⁴⁸⁶.
- CMP, LDH, triglycerides, coagulation.
- **Tiered approach when the child is stable:** tier 1 (any facility) CBC with differential, metabolic panel, ESR, CRP, SARS-CoV-2 testing → proceed to tier 2 (cardiac markers, ECG, echocardiogram, ferritin, D-dimer, procalcitonin, cytokine panel if available) when ESR/CRP is raised **plus one of:** lymphocytes $< 1.0 \times 10^9/L$, platelets $< 150 \times 10^9/L$, sodium < 135 mmol/L, neutrophilia or hypoalbuminemia (ACR 2022). A child with shock is treated while the work-up is completed⁴⁸⁶.
- **Admit for observation** while under investigation if any of: abnormal vital signs, respiratory distress, altered mental status, renal or hepatic injury, marked inflammatory markers, abnormal ECG, or raised troponin/BNP⁴⁸⁶. ECG at least every 48 h in hospital; telemetry if conduction is abnormal⁴⁸⁶.

TREATMENT PATHWAY – ACR 2022 (STEPWISE; DUAL THERAPY FIRST-LINE FOR MOST ADMITTED CHILDREN)

Step	Drug & dose	Notes
1 · First-line — IVIG (after the first glucocorticoid dose)	2 g/kg (ideal body weight, max 100 g)	Start IVIG after the first glucocorticoid dose has been given and once cardiac function and fluid status have been assessed; with cardiac dysfunction give 1 g/kg/day over 2 days, slow the rate and/or add a diuretic to avoid volume overload ⁴⁸⁶
1 · First-line — methylprednisolone, given first	1–2 mg/kg/day IV Give the first dose at once – before the IVIG infusion is set up	Dual therapy with IVIG for most hospitalized patients (ACR 2022); giving IV methylprednisolone before the IVIG reduces cardiac inflammation and improves cardiac function before the heart is loaded with the IVIG volume (CPS 2021); furosemide halfway through the infusion may be considered when cardiac function is impaired ⁵¹¹ ; IVIG alone only in mild disease or when steroids are contraindicated, with intensification at the first sign of worsening. Glucocorticoid monotherapy is not recommended ⁴⁸⁶
2 · Refractory (no response within 24 h: persistent fever or ongoing organ involvement) or shock on inotropes	Methylprednisolone pulse 10–30 mg/kg/day	Do not repeat IVIG (hemolysis, volume overload). Children in shock on multiple inotropes/vasopressors respond best to high-dose glucocorticoid ⁴⁸⁶
2 · Alternatives	Anakinra > 4 mg/kg/day (often 5–10 mg/kg/day) IV/subcut · or infliximab 5–10 mg/kg IV once	No infliximab if there are features of macrophage activation syndrome; anakinra also as a steroid-sparing agent ⁴⁸⁶
Aspirin	3–5 mg/kg/day PO (max 81 mg)	All patients without bleeding or bleeding risk, until platelets are normal and coronaries are normal at ≥ 4 weeks; add gastric protection with steroids ⁴⁸⁶
Anticoagulation	Enoxaparin (anti-Xa 0.5–1.0)	Coronary z-score ≥ 10 (≥ 2 weeks, then warfarin/DOAC) or documented thrombosis; consider with ejection fraction < 35%; otherwise individualized ⁴⁸⁶
Taper	2–3 weeks or longer	Guided by serial CRP/ferritin and cardiac reassessment to avoid rebound ⁴⁸⁶

◆ CARDIAC FOLLOW-UP

- Repeat echocardiogram at 7–14 days and at 4–6 weeks in every child (more often with LV dysfunction or aneurysms); consider one at 1 year if the heart was involved; cardiac MRI at 2–6 months after moderate–severe LV dysfunction⁴⁸⁶.

▲ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — all confirmed cases; PICU for shock, cardiac dysfunction or conduction abnormality.
- **Refer — now** — call pediatric rheumatology/infectious diseases and cardiology from the start (multidisciplinary team).
- **Refer — clinic** — follow up coronary imaging.

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Surgical Emergencies

Recognize early · resuscitate · refer fast

Malrotation / Midgut Volvulus MINUTES OFTEN < 1 MO

Bilious (green) vomiting in a well infant — the "drop-everything" abdomen.

RECOGNIZE

Bilious vomiting ± distension/pain; bloody stool and shock are late (ischemia)⁵¹².



RESUSCITATE & CONFIRM

- Nil by mouth, NG decompression, IV fluids, bloods.
- **Urgent upper-GI contrast** (abnormal duodeno-jejunal junction, "corkscrew") ± Doppler ultrasound⁵¹².



CONSULT FIRST

- Consult **pediatric surgery immediately** — for definitive care and **safe transport**.
- Do not image at a center that will not operate; if surgery is unavailable on-site, **transfer without delaying for contrast studies**.

Immediate surgery — Ladd procedure. Peritonitis or shock → straight to the operating room, do not delay for imaging⁵¹³.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all suspected → emergency, nil by mouth, fluids.
- **Home from the ward** — not acutely; post-operative.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery IMMEDIATELY (bilious vomiting = volvulus until excluded); urgent upper-GI contrast.⁵¹³

Intussusception

HOURS

6 MO–3 YR

Telescoping bowel; the classic triad is usually incomplete.

RECOGNIZE

- Intermittent colicky pain (drawing up the legs), vomiting, lethargy between episodes.
- Sausage-shaped mass; "redcurrant jelly" stool is **late**. Unexplained lethargy may be the only clue⁵¹⁴.

CONFIRM

Ultrasound — "target/doughnut" sign (highly sensitive and specific in experienced hands)⁵¹⁴.
Resuscitate with IV fluids first.



DECISION

Stable, no peritonitis/perforation?

YES

Non-operative air or contrast enema reduction — perform only at a center with **pediatric surgical backup** where the child will be definitively treated (perforation needs immediate surgery)⁵¹⁴.

NO / failed

Operative reduction; resect non-viable bowel⁵¹⁴.

ADMIT • DISCHARGE • REFER

- **Admit** — all → for reduction and observation.
- **Home from the ward** — after successful reduction and an observation period without recurrence.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery and interventional radiology (air/contrast enema); surgery if reduction fails or peritonitis.

Hypertrophic Pyloric Stenosis

HOURS

3–6 WK

Progressive non-bilious projectile vomiting in a hungry infant.

RECOGNIZE & CONFIRM

- "Olive" mass, visible gastric peristalsis, dehydration. Labs: **hypochloremic hypokalemic metabolic alkalosis**.⁵¹⁵ Ultrasound: muscle $\geq$ 3–4 mm, channel $\geq$ 14–16 mm⁵¹⁵.

① CORRECT FIRST

Rehydrate and normalize chloride, potassium and bicarbonate **before** surgery. NG if vomiting⁵¹⁵.



② Pyloromyotomy once biochemically stable. The electrolytes are the emergency, not the surgery⁵¹⁵.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → correct fluids/electrolytes before surgery.
- **Home from the ward** — post-operative, feeding established.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery (pyloromyotomy) after biochemical correction — it is not a surgical emergency until corrected.

Acute Appendicitis HOURS

Most common surgical abdomen; young children atypical, high perforation risk.

▴ RECOGNIZE

- Periumbilical pain migrating to the right lower quadrant, anorexia, fever, vomiting; guarding/rebound, pain on movement⁵¹⁶.
- Clinical scores (Alvarado / Pediatric Appendicitis Score) + ultrasound first-line; CT or MRI selectively⁵¹⁶.

MANAGE

Nil by mouth · IV fluids · analgesia for pain · **urgent surgical evaluation** → appendectomy.

⚠ MIMICS

Examine the testes (torsion), consider DKA (see [Diabetic Ketoacidosis](#)), lower-lobe pneumonia, UTI, ovarian torsion (clinical practice point).

⚠ DO NOT BYPASS SURGICAL EVALUATION

- **Antibiotics** — not for *suspected* appendicitis before surgical assessment; started before diagnosis is confirmed, they can partially treat and mask it (blunted WBC/neutrophils, softer signs) — expert practice point, not guideline-stated.
- Start once diagnosis is confirmed and surgical plan agreed — or immediately if the child is septic or perforated. **Analgesia** — never leave a child in pain, but stay opioid-sparing while awaiting surgical review: give non-opioid analgesia first (IV or oral acetaminophen); reserve opioids for severe pain as a single titrated dose, with no repeat opioid until the surgeon has assessed (local practice).
- Never give parenteral opioids then discharge an undifferentiated abdomen.
- Analgesia does not reduce diagnostic accuracy — never a reason to delay evaluation⁵¹⁷.

ANTIBIOTICS – ONCE DIAGNOSIS CONFIRMED AND SURGICAL PLAN AGREED (OR NOW, IF SEPTIC/PERFORATED)

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Piperacillin-tazobactam	100 mg/kg/dose (piperacillin component) IV every 8 h 2–9 months: 80 mg/kg/dose IV every 8 h > 40 kg (adult dose): 3.375 g (piperacillin 3 g + tazobactam 0.375 g) IV every 6 h	Single-agent cover including anaerobes; common first choice ^{518,519} .
Ceftriaxone + metronidazole	Ceftriaxone 50–75 mg/kg/dose IV once daily (max 2 g) + metronidazole 10 mg/kg/dose IV every 8 h (max 500 mg/dose)	Alternative combination; give the first dose promptly once diagnosed ^{27,518} .

◆ DURATION

- Uncomplicated appendicitis: perioperative prophylaxis only — a single pre-operative dose, up to 24 h⁵¹⁶.
- Complicated or perforated: continue ~4–5 days after adequate source control, or until afebrile with a normalizing white count and returning bowel function (STOP-IT — a predominantly adult trial; pediatric use is extrapolated)⁵²⁰.

▶ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → for surgery and IV antibiotics.
- **Home from the ward** — post-operative per pathway.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery; interventional radiology for an abscess (drainage) when non-operative.

Incarcerated Inguinal Hernia HOURS

Irreducible tender groin or scrotal lump — reduce it or operate.

RECOGNIZE

- Firm, tender, **irreducible swelling** in the groin extending to the scrotum or labia; irritability and vomiting (may mimic bowel obstruction⁵²¹).
- Common in infancy, especially preterm.⁵²² **Overlying skin erythema or a toxic child suggests strangulation⁵²¹.**

REDUCE

- If no signs of strangulation: analgesia or sedation, head-down (Trendelenburg) position, gentle sustained manual reduction (taxis) by experienced hands⁵²¹.
- If it does not reduce on the first attempt, stop and consult pediatric surgery — repeated attempts worsen edema and make later reduction harder⁵²¹.
- Once reduced, admit for repair on the same admission — re-incarceration risk is high^{521,522}.

DO NOT REDUCE — STRAIGHT TO SURGERY

Skin erythema, systemic toxicity, peritonitis, bloody stools, or prolonged incarceration — signal ischemic bowel or gonad → emergency exploration⁵²¹.

ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all → for reduction/observation or surgery.
- **Home from the ward** — after successful reduction, for early elective repair.
- **Refer — now** — pediatric surgery urgently; emergency if irreducible or strangulated.

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Toxicology & Environmental

Poisoning · burns · heat & drowning

Poisoning & Toxic Ingestion HOURS

Resuscitate, identify the agent, call for advice, give the antidote.

☎ Kuwait Poison Control Center (KPCC): 1804774 — 24/7. Call early for any exposure: agent-specific advice, decontamination, antidotes, and disposition.⁸

GENERAL APPROACH (ABCDE FIRST)

- Stabilize airway, breathing, circulation; give oxygen; check glucose and a 12-lead ECG (QRS width, QT interval).⁵²³
- Identify the agent, amount, time, and intent; in any deliberate ingestion send **acetaminophen and salicylate levels**.^{523,524}

- Decontamination: decide in the first hour, with KPCC — single-dose activated charcoal, whole bowel irrigation, or neither (box below).^{8,525,526}
- Call KPCC **1804774**; give the specific antidote below; observe for delayed toxicity.⁸

▀ DECONTAMINATION – DECIDE IN THE FIRST HOUR

- **Stabilize first.** Gut decontamination is **never routine**: neither activated charcoal nor whole bowel irrigation (WBI) has been shown to improve outcome — use it only after a potentially toxic ingestion, and decide with KPCC **1804774**.^{8,526,527,528}
- **Swallowed a poison that charcoal binds, and the airway is safe** (awake with intact airway reflexes, or already intubated) → **single-dose activated charcoal**, as early as possible: most benefit within 1 h; for many poisons still worthwhile up to 6 h, and later when absorption continues (modified-release products, tablet masses, very large ingestions).^{525,527}
- **Carbamazepine, cardiac glycosides, colchicine, dapsone, phenobarbital, phenytoin, thallium or theophylline** → **multiple-dose activated charcoal** to speed elimination, on toxicology advice.^{525,529}
- **Substantial iron, lithium or potassium, a sustained-release or enteric-coated drug** (especially > 2 h after ingestion), or **swallowed drug packets** (body packing) → consider **WBI**: charcoal has no role for iron or lithium, and there are few other ways to empty the gut.^{525,526,528}
- **Charcoal and the airway.** Not intubated → give charcoal **by mouth only**; do **not** pass a nasogastric tube just to give it. Already intubated for another reason (unprotected airway, respiratory failure, low conscious level, refractory seizures, shock) → a nasogastric or orogastric tube for charcoal is reasonable. Do **not** intubate just to give charcoal, unless life-threatening toxicity is expected; decide with a toxicologist.⁵²⁵
- **Not recommended: routine gastric lavage**: should not be used routinely, if ever; if ever considered, only by experienced staff with a protected airway.⁵³⁰ **Ipecac**: no benefit; delays charcoal, oral antidotes and WBI.⁵³¹

Method	Dose / rate	Use for · do not use
Activated charcoal — single dose	1 g/kg once max 50 g by mouth; by nasogastric/orogastric tube only if intubated (confirm tube position on X-ray) additional (second) dose, if advised: same dose ^{523,525}	Use for a potentially toxic amount of a poison that charcoal binds (most drugs), with a safe airway. An additional dose may be advised after carbamazepine, acetaminophen, paraquat, phenobarbital, salicylates, thallium, theophylline, valproic acid or verapamil, modified-release products, or a dose too large for one charcoal dose. No role (do not give): iron, lithium, alcohols (ethanol, methanol, ethylene glycol), lead, arsenic, copper, caesium, metformin. Do not use if airway reflexes are absent or may be lost (unless intubated), with a risk of bowel perforation, absent peristalsis, likely upper endoscopy (caustics — see Caustic (Corrosive) Ingestion), or a hydrocarbon with high aspiration risk ^{523,525,527}
Activated charcoal — multiple dose	first dose 1 g/kg (max 50 g) then 1 g/kg (max 50 g) every 4 h or 0.5 g/kg (max 25 g) every 2 h continue until the child's condition and drug levels are improving IV antiemetic often needed ^{525,529}	Use for poisoning with carbamazepine, cardiac glycosides, colchicine, dapsone, phenobarbital, phenytoin, thallium or theophylline — to speed elimination, on toxicology advice. Do not use without an intact or protected airway, or with bowel obstruction ^{525,529}
Whole bowel irrigation (WBI)	polyethylene glycol electrolyte solution (PEG-ES) by small-bore nasogastric tube (tip in mid-stomach on X-ray) 9 months–6 years: 500 mL/h 6–12 years: 1000 mL/h adolescents: 1500–2000 mL/h sitting up, or head of bed ≥ 45° continue at least until the rectal effluent is clear (many hours); longer if X-ray or ongoing passage shows toxin still in the gut vomiting: parenteral non-sedating antiemetic (metoclopramide also speeds gastric emptying); if it persists, halve the rate for 30–60 min, then resume ⁵²⁸	Consider for substantial iron, lithium or potassium ingestion; sustained-release or enteric-coated drugs, especially > 2 h after ingestion; swallowed packets of illicit drugs (body packing) — no proven outcome benefit. Do not use with bowel obstruction, perforation or ileus, clinically significant gastrointestinal bleeding, an unprotected or compromised airway, hemodynamic instability, or uncontrollable vomiting; caution in debilitated children. Charcoal given during WBI may bind less ^{526,528}

▲ **RECOGNIZE THE TOXIDROME – THE PATTERN NAMES THE POISON BEFORE THE HISTORY DOES**

↑ increased · ↓ decreased · ± can go either way · **normal** = usually unchanged · **no specific change** = sources describe no typical finding. Patterns are typical, not universal: dose, timing, age and co-ingestants change them. The combination of vital signs, pupils, gut and skin is more reliable than any single sign; a known ingestion does not exclude a second agent.⁵²³

How the colors work: the color shows the **state of the child** —

●●● red · orange · pink = **excited**

●● blue · gray = **depressed**

● green = **wet (secretions)**

● purple = **metabolic (fast, deep breathing)**

Then **skin, gut, pupils and breathing** separate patterns of the same color: excited + **sweaty** = sympathomimetic, or serotonin toxicity if there is **clonus**; excited + **dry skin, quiet gut** = anticholinergic; depressed + **pinpoint pupils and slow breathing** = opioid; depressed + **near-normal vital signs** = sedative-hypnotic (benzodiazepine alone; alcohol and barbiturates do slow breathing); wet + **pinpoint pupils** = cholinergic, though a young child may show only coma and floppiness. The line under each name (e.g. “hot, red, dry, blind, mad, full”) is the memory hook.^{523,532,533,534,535}

Toxidrome · agents	Mental status	Vital signs · breathing	Pupils · gut · skin	Clues
EXCITED — FAST, HOT, AGITATED				
Sympathomimetic amphetamines, cocaine, pseudoephedrine, caffeine, ADHD stimulants	Agitation, psychosis, hallucinations; seizures	HR ↑ · BP ↑ · T ↑ (hyperpyrexia) · RR ↑	Pupils dilated · gut: no specific change · skin sweaty	Wet skin separates it from anticholinergic; clonus points to serotonin toxicity instead; tremor, hyperreflexia, rhabdomyolysis; tachycardia may be absent on β-blockers ^{523,532,534, 536,537}
🔥 fast, hot, wet, wild				
Anticholinergic antihistamines (diphenhydramine), tricyclics, atropine/ scopolamine, antipsychotics, <i>Datura</i>	Agitated delirium, hallucinations, or drowsiness; seizures, coma	HR ↑ · BP mildly ↑ (↓ if severe) · T ↑ (usually ≤ 38.8 °C) · RR ↑	Pupils dilated, poorly reactive (may look fixed) · gut ↓ (bowel sounds ↓ or absent) · skin hot, flushed, dry ; dry mouth	Urinary retention (“full”); dry skin and a quiet gut separate it from sympathomimetic and serotonin toxicity; no clonus; wide QRS with diphenhydramine or tricyclics (get an ECG); antihistamine overdose in young children: excitation, hallucinations, seizures ^{10,523,532,534, 536,538}
🌱 hot, red, dry, blind, mad, full				

Toxidrome · agents	Mental status	Vital signs · breathing	Pupils · gut · skin	Clues
Serotonin syndrome SSRIs/SNRIs, alone or with linezolid, tramadol, dextromethorphan, ondansetron or methylene blue; MDMA ✂ clonus, sweat, hot, agitated	Agitation, hypervigilance, easy startle → agitated delirium, coma	HR ↑ · BP ↑ (severe: may collapse into shock) · T normal (mild) to ↑ (> 41 °C life-threatening) · RR ↑	Pupils dilated · gut ↑, diarrhea · skin sweaty, shivering	Clonus (inducible, spontaneous, ocular), hyperreflexia, tremor; legs > arms; rigidity in severe cases may mask clonus; about 60% present within 6 h of a new drug, dose change or overdose; Hunter criteria ^{10,523,532,539,540}
DEPRESSED — SLOW, SLEEPY				
Opioid morphine, methadone, fentanyl, codeine, tramadol, buprenorphine 😴 slow, small pupils, not breathing	Sedation → stupor → coma	HR normal or ↓ · BP normal or ↓ · T normal or ↓ · RR ↓ (apnea): the defining sign	Pupils pinpoint (may be normal or dilated with tramadol, meperidine or co-ingestants; dilated if hypoxic) · gut ↓ · skin cold, clammy	Naloxone response. Children: toxicity may be delayed, severe and prolonged; admit children ≤ 3 y for 24 h after methadone, a fentanyl patch or an extended-release opioid, and admit any toddler exposed to buprenorphine. Clonidine, or imidazoline eye-drop / nasal-spray, ingestion in young children mimics it: lethargy, bradycardia, hypotension, respiratory depression; no worsening after 4 h; pupils small or dilated; naloxone response inconsistent ^{523,533,541,542,543,544}

Toxidrome · agents	Mental status	Vital signs · breathing	Pupils · gut · skin	Clues
Sedative-hypnotic benzodiazepines, Z-drugs (zolpidem), barbiturates, alcohol  asleep, near-normal vital signs	Drowsiness → coma; dysarthria, ataxia	Benzodiazepine alone: HR, BP, RR usually normal · barbiturates, alcohol: BP ↓ · RR ↓ · T ↓ · HR ±	Pupils normal or small (dilated late in severe barbiturate poisoning) · gut and skin: no specific change	Isolated benzodiazepine overdose rarely causes life-threatening hypoventilation or hypotension; if present, look for a co-ingestant (alcohol, opioid); miosis + coma <i>without</i> marked respiratory depression points away from opioid ^{523, 533,534,537,545}
WET — SECRETIONS EVERYWHERE				
Cholinergic organophosphate and carbamate pesticides  wet everywhere: DUMBELS	Lethargy, confusion → coma; seizures in about 1 in 5 children	HR ↓ or ↑ (tachycardia in about half of children) · BP ± · T: no specific change · bronchorrhea, bronchospasm → respiratory failure	Pupils pinpoint (in about 3 of 4 children) · vomiting, diarrhea · sweating, salivation, tears	Fasciculations, weakness; pesticide/solvent smell; carbamates look the same; atropine titrated to a dry chest (antidote table). Young children: CNS depression and floppiness may dominate and muscarinic signs may be missing, so their absence does not exclude it ^{523,534, 535,546,547}
METABOLIC — FAST DEEP BREATHING				
Salicylate aspirin, oil of wintergreen, bismuth subsalicylate  fast breathing, ringing ears, acidosis	Lethargy, confusion → seizures, coma	RR ↑, deep (hyperpnea): respiratory alkalosis early, then anion-gap metabolic acidosis · T ↑ (hyperpyrexia = advanced poisoning) · HR ↑ with fever or dehydration · BP: no specific change	Pupils: no specific change · vomiting, abdominal pain, hematemesis · skin sweaty	Tinnitus, deafness, dehydration; cerebral and non-cardiogenic pulmonary edema; oil of wintergreen 1 mL ≈ aspirin 1.4 g, so more than a lick or taste in a child < 6 y needs ED assessment; a normal acid-base picture does not exclude toxicity: keep a low threshold for a salicylate level ^{523,548}

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Acetaminophen (paracetamol)	Acetylcysteine IV – total 300 mg/kg; dose weight capped at 100 kg Two-bag (20 h), preferred ≥ 41 kg: 200 mg/kg over 4 h → 100 mg/kg over 16 h Three-bag (21 h), use ≤ 40 kg: 150 mg/kg over 1 h → 50 mg/kg over 4 h → 100 mg/kg over 16 h High-risk ingestion: double the second bag to 200 mg/kg over 16 h^{524,549,550}	Treat if the level is on/above the nomogram treatment line (150 mg/L at 4 h). The high-risk line (300 mg/L at 4 h) marks a large ingestion — give a higher acetylcysteine dose and call toxicology.⁵²⁴ Both regimens prevent liver injury equally; the two-bag causes fewer anaphylactoid reactions, so it is preferred where weight allows.^{551,552} Dilute in 0.45% sodium chloride (preferred) or 5% dextrose; adjust the volume < 41 kg (≤ 20 kg loading bag 3 mL/kg) — unadjusted volumes cause hyponatremia, seizures.⁵⁵⁰ Monitor acetaminophen, ALT/AST, INR, electrolytes. Stop only when acetaminophen < 10 mg/L, INR < 2.0, ALT/AST normal or fallen 25–50% from peak, and the child is well — do not stop automatically at 20–21 h.^{524,549}
Anticholinergic	Physostigmine 0.02 mg/kg IV; may repeat every 5–10 min to effect, up to a total of 2 mg — or a benzodiazepine for agitation^{523,553,554}	Give by slow IV, ≤ 0.5 mg/min, for anticholinergic delirium/agitation; reverses central and peripheral signs and outperforms benzodiazepines, which do not reverse delirium.^{554,555} Keep atropine at the bedside.⁵⁵³ Do not give if the QRS is prolonged on the ECG; use caution after an overdose of a QRS-prolonging drug (e.g., a tricyclic) and with known coronary disease — bradysystolic arrest and seizures have been reported.⁵⁵⁶ Monitor ECG, heart rate and secretions; watch for cholinergic excess (bradycardia, bronchorrhea, vomiting).⁵⁵³

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Benzodiazepine	Supportive care (airway, ventilation) – the mainstay Flumazenil 0.01 mg/kg IV (max 0.2 mg), repeat to max total 0.05 mg/kg or 1 mg – selected cases only ^{537,557}	Isolated benzodiazepine overdose is rarely fatal — observe and support breathing. Reserve flumazenil for reversing pure benzodiazepine respiratory depression in a benzodiazepine-naïve child (e.g., iatrogenic procedural sedation). ⁵³⁷ Avoid in undifferentiated overdose: it can precipitate seizures or dysrhythmias in benzodiazepine-dependent patients or with co-ingested tricyclics, and is contraindicated when a benzodiazepine is controlling a life-threatening condition (e.g., status epilepticus, raised intracranial pressure) or with signs of serious tricyclic overdose. ^{537,557} Observe for resedation up to ~2 h after use. ⁵⁵⁷
Beta-blocker	High-dose insulin: 1 unit/kg IV bolus, then 1–10 units/kg/h Vasopressors (norepinephrine/epinephrine), titrated Glucagon 0.05–0.15 mg/kg IV bolus, then infusion 1–15 mg/h (adult range; do not exceed the adult dose) ^{537,558}	Severe toxicity (hypotension, bradycardia, conduction block): call KPCC 1804774 and PICU early. ⁸ Give vasopressors and high-dose insulin for hypotension; insulin is an inotrope, so start it early, together with a vasopressor. ^{537,558} Run dextrose to keep glucose normal (needed for ~24 h after insulin stops) and replace potassium. Monitor glucose and potassium frequently. ^{558,559} Glucagon for bradycardia or hypotension; expect vomiting. ⁵³⁷ Escalate to pacing or VA-ECMO for refractory shock. ⁵³⁷
Calcium-channel blocker	Calcium chloride 10% 0.2 mL/kg (20 mg/kg) – or calcium gluconate 10% 0.6 mL/kg (60 mg/kg) – IV, repeat every 10–20 min or infuse High-dose insulin 1 unit/kg bolus then 1–10 units/kg/h Vasopressors (norepinephrine/epinephrine) ^{537,559}	Severe toxicity (hypotension, bradycardia, conduction block): call KPCC 1804774 and PICU early. ⁸ Give calcium (central line preferred, especially in children), high-dose insulin and vasopressors as first-line for hypotension; the choice is led by the clinical picture. ^{537,559} Titrate calcium to blood pressure; do not exceed ionized calcium 1.5–2× the upper normal. Run dextrose and replace potassium with high-dose insulin — monitor glucose and potassium frequently. ^{537,559} Lipid emulsion and VA-ECMO are rescue options. These steps come from an adult expert consensus; pediatric data are limited. ⁵⁵⁹

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Carbon monoxide	Oxygen 100% by non-rebreather mask, or by endotracheal tube if intubated⁵⁶⁰ Continue until symptom-free¹⁸ Hyperbaric oxygen (HBO) – consider for every acute symptomatic CO poisoning; children can be treated safely⁵⁶⁰	Refer for HBO whatever the COHb if any loss of consciousness, neurologic signs, cardiovascular dysfunction or severe acidosis; COHb correlates poorly with severity, so use it as one factor, not a cut-off (COHb $\geq$ 25% is one more reason to discuss HBO); the shortest delay gives the best result^{560,561} Children take up CO faster than adults but also clear it faster⁵⁶⁰ Monitor — COHb by co-oximetry on venous or arterial blood; COHb $\geq$ 2% supports the diagnosis in a non-smoker¹⁸ Pulse oximetry is falsely reassuring — a standard oximeter cannot tell COHb from oxyhemoglobin; a pulse CO-oximeter (SpCO) cannot rule CO out⁵⁶⁰ Fire victim → treat cyanide too (next row); HBO is also indicated for CO with cyanide poisoning⁵⁶⁰ — see <u>Smoke Inhalation & Carbon Monoxide Poisoning</u>
Cyanide (smoke inhalation, nitroprusside)	Hydroxocobalamin 70 mg/kg IV/IO (max 5 g) over 15 min^{20, 537, 562} Second dose if needed: 70 mg/kg (max 5 g) over 15 min (very unstable) to 2 h Total max 140 mg/kg (max 10 g)^{20, 562} ± Sodium thiosulfate 250 mg/kg = 1 mL/kg of 25% (max 12.5 g = 50 mL), slow IV, in a separate line^{537, 563} Oxygen 100%⁵³⁷	Treat empirically — fire/smoke exposure with cardiac arrest, altered mental status, raised lactate, severe metabolic acidosis or hypotension⁵³⁷ Lactate > 10 mmol/L (fire victims) or $\geq$ 8 mmol/L (other cyanide poisoning) is a sensitive marker, but specificity is only moderate — do not rely on lactate alone^{564, 565} Repeat — second dose according to severity and clinical response⁵⁶² Monitor — blood pressure (transient rise); renal function (urea, creatinine) for 7 days; skin discoloration; hydroxocobalamin interferes with colorimetric laboratory tests^{537, 562} Never give thiosulfate or nitrite through the hydroxocobalamin line²⁰ Sodium nitrite only if hydroxocobalamin is unavailable — its methemoglobin may worsen oxygen delivery when CO is also present (smoke)⁵³⁷

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Digoxin	Digoxin-specific immune Fab (each vial binds ~0.5 mg) Acute, amount known: vials = $\text{mg ingested} \div 0.5$ Acute, unknown: 10–20 vials (start 10, repeat 10) Chronic, unknown level: adults/children ≥ 20 kg 6 vials; < 20 kg 1 vial By level: vials = $\text{level (ng/mL)} \times \text{weight (kg)} \div 100$^{537, 566}	Give for life-threatening cardiac-glycoside toxicity — ventricular dysrhythmia, bradycardia/high-grade block unresponsive to atropine, or potassium > 5.5 mEq/L (adults) / > 6 mEq/L (children).⁵⁶⁶ Infuse over ≥ 30 min (bolus if arrest is imminent). In small children reconstitute/dilute to avoid volume overload. Monitor potassium closely for several hours (can fall fast); serum digoxin becomes unreliable after Fab. Re-dose if toxicity persists or recurs.^{537, 566}
Iron	Deferoxamine IV, infusion rate up to 15 mg/kg/h; max 6,000 mg/24 h⁵⁶⁷	Refer any ingestion ≥ 40 mg/kg elemental iron, or with severe or persistent symptoms (persistent vomiting or diarrhea, altered consciousness, hematemesis, bloody diarrhea).⁵⁶⁸ Chelate for systemic toxicity, on toxicology (KPCC) advice.^{8, 567} Slow or stop the infusion for rate-related hypotension. Limit continuous IV infusion to ~24 h — longer durations are linked to ARDS.^{567, 569} Monitor blood pressure and urine colour (a reddish change may follow chelation); switch IV→IM once stable.⁵⁶⁷
Isoniazid	Pyridoxine IV – amount known: 1 g for each 1 g of isoniazid ingested^{570, 571} Amount unknown: 80 mg/kg (adult 5 g) Slow IV bolus over 3–5 min Repeat if seizures continue (more than 10 g is rarely needed)⁵⁷⁰ Diazepam if seizures continue after pyridoxine (doses: <u>Convulsive Status Epilepticus</u>)⁵⁷⁰	Who — every symptomatic child, and any acute ingestion > 80 mg/kg even if well⁵⁷⁰ Expect seizures, severe metabolic acidosis and coma 30 min–3 h after ingestion⁵⁷⁰ Target — seizures stop; they may not respond to anticonvulsants until pyridoxine is given, so keep IV pyridoxine readily available⁵⁷² Phenytoin only with caution (isoniazid slows its metabolism)⁵⁷⁰ — see <u>Isoniazid Poisoning</u>

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Local anesthetic systemic toxicity (LAST)	Lipid emulsion 20% Under 70 kg: bolus 1.5 mL/kg over 2–3 min, then 0.25 mL/kg/min Over 70 kg: bolus ~100 mL over 2–3 min, then ~250 mL over 15–20 min Still unstable: repeat the bolus and double the infusion (0.5 mL/kg/min) Max 12 mL/kg^{537, 573} Epinephrine – smaller than usual doses; start with < 1 mcg/kg⁵⁷³ Seizures – benzodiazepine preferred⁵⁷³	When — call for help, get the LAST rescue kit and give lipid early; LAST resuscitation is different from standard advanced life support⁵⁷³ Continue the infusion for > 15 min after the circulation is stable⁵⁷³ Avoid vasopressin, calcium-channel blockers, β-blockers and more local anesthetic⁵⁷³ Monitor — ≥ 2 h after a seizure; 4–6 h after cardiovascular instability⁵⁷³
Methanol / ethylene glycol	Fomepizole IV – loading 15 mg/kg then 10 mg/kg every 12 h $\times$ 4 doses then 15 mg/kg every 12 h Each dose as a slow infusion over 30 min During hemodialysis: every 4 h⁵⁷⁴ Methanol – add folinic (or folic) acid^{575, 576} Ethanol only if fomepizole is unavailable (harder dosing, more monitoring, more adverse effects)⁵⁷⁵	Stop when methanol or ethylene glycol is undetectable or < 20 mg/dL and the child is symptom-free with a normal pH⁵⁷⁴ Monitor — blood gas and pH, electrolytes, urea, creatinine, urinalysis, methanol/ethylene glycol levels⁵⁷⁴ Dialysis — methanol: coma, seizures, new visual loss, pH ≤ 7.15, acidosis despite antidote, anion gap > 24 mmol/L, methanol > 700 mg/L (21.8 mmol/L) on fomepizole, or impaired kidney function; stop when methanol < 200 mg/L (6.2 mmol/L) and the child is improving⁵⁷⁶ Dialysis — ethylene glycol: coma, seizures or acute kidney injury; glycolate > 12 mmol/L or anion gap > 27 mmol/L; consider if ethylene glycol > 50 mmol/L or osmolal gap > 50 on fomepizole; stop when anion gap < 18 mmol/L⁵⁷⁷ Adjust fomepizole doses during dialysis^{574, 577}

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Methemoglobinemia	Methylene blue 1 mg/kg IV (range 1–2 mg/kg) over 5–30 min^{21,537,578} Repeat 1 mg/kg after 30–60 min if MetHb stays > 30% or symptoms persist^{21,578} Max cumulative 5–7 mg/kg (toxicity from 7 mg/kg)^{21,537,578} G6PD deficiency – contraindicated (hemolysis; may not work) → ascorbic acid or exchange transfusion^{21,578}	Treat when MetHb ≥ 20% with symptoms, or ≥ 30% without; 10–30% if symptomatic with heart or lung disease, significant anemia or CO poisoning⁵⁷⁸ Stop the oxidant; give oxygen; make sure glucose is available⁵⁷⁸ Target — MetHb falls within ~1 h; no response after 2 doses → exchange transfusion or hyperbaric oxygen (PICU)^{21,578} Monitor — MetHb by co-oximetry; pulse oximetry is unreliable (sticks near 85% with high MetHb) and methylene blue lowers the reading — use a blood gas^{21,578} MetHb may rebound after dapsone or aniline — recheck^{21,578} Serotonergic drugs or opioids — risk of serotonin syndrome; avoid the combination²¹ Infants with diarrhea and acidosis and MetHb < 20% may improve with fluids and bicarbonate alone⁵⁷⁸
Opioids	Naloxone 0.1 mg/kg IV/IO/IM (max 2 mg), repeat every 2–3 min Small titrated increments if opioid-dependent Infusion: two-thirds of the effective waking dose per hour^{523,537,579}	Titrate to adequate ventilation and airway reflexes, not full arousal.⁵³⁷ In a known opioid-dependent child give gradual small increments to avoid precipitated withdrawal.^{523,533} Naloxone is shorter-acting than most opioids, so observe until consciousness and vital signs normalise and start an infusion ($\frac{2}{3}$ of the effective dose per hour) if resedation occurs — longer for methadone, sustained-release products or buprenorphine.^{533,537}

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Organophosphate / carbamate	Atropine 0.02 mg/kg IV/IO (not above the adult 1–2 mg); double the dose every 5 min until the chest is dry Then infusion 10–20% of the total loading dose per hour⁵³⁷ Pralidoxime (organophosphate) 20–50 mg/kg (max 2 g/dose) IV over 15–30 min then 10–20 mg/kg/h or repeat 20–50 mg/kg after ~1 h if weakness persists, then every 10–12 h^{537,580} Diazepam for seizures or agitation (doses: <u>Convulsive Status Epilepticus</u>)⁵⁴⁶	Target — bronchorrhea and bronchospasm reversed, bradycardia and hypotension corrected (adult targets: pulse > 80/min, systolic BP > 80 mm Hg)^{537,546} Too much atropine → anticholinergic delirium⁵⁴⁶ Pralidoxime — never as a rapid bolus (vomiting, tachycardia, laryngospasm, rigidity); max 200 mg/min; start once atropine is working^{546,580} Known carbamate: pralidoxime is not indicated (may increase carbaryl toxicity)⁵⁸⁰ Succinylcholine — prolonged paralysis; use only with caution⁵⁸⁰ Monitor ≥ 48–72 h — sudden respiratory muscle weakness (intermediate syndrome), recurrent cholinergic signs, changing atropine needs^{546,580}
Salicylate	Sodium bicarbonate – IV bolus, then infusion (≈ 150 mEq/L in 5% dextrose with potassium) to alkalinize the urine Hemodialysis for severe poisoning^{581,582,583}	Alkalinize to a urine pH 7.5–8.0, running the infusion to a urine output ~2–3 mL/kg/h; check urine pH frequently.^{581,582} Keep potassium normal/high-normal — hypokalemia prevents urinary alkalinization; replace early.^{581,582} Maintain high minute ventilation if intubated (avoid respiratory acidosis).⁵⁸¹ Hemodialysis for altered mental status, ARDS needing oxygen, failure of standard therapy, severe acidemia, or a very high level (≈ 100 mg/dL acute).^{581,583}
Serotonin syndrome	Stop all serotonergic drugs^{532,584} Benzodiazepine for agitation (doses: <u>Convulsive Status Epilepticus</u>)^{532,584} Active cooling^{532,584} Cyproheptadine – oral only; adult dose 4–12 mg for moderate toxicity; benefit unproven and dose not well defined^{532,584}	Severe — temperature > 39 °C with agitation, reduced consciousness, rigidity, or no response to cooling → early paralysis and intubation (PICU); supportive care comes before any antidote^{532,584} Monitor — temperature (rapid rise), muscle rigidity, clonus⁵⁸⁴ Expect improvement within 24 h of stopping the drug⁵³² — see <u>Drug-Induced Hyperthermia Syndromes</u>

Poison	Antidote · dose	Rate · target · monitor
Sodium-channel blocker / tricyclic	Sodium bicarbonate 1–3 mEq/kg IV bolus, repeat to narrow the QRS Lidocaine if refractory ⁵³⁷	Give for QRS > 100 ms, ventricular dysrhythmia or hypotension; repeat boluses (then an infusion) until the QRS narrows , avoiding excessive alkalemia. ^{537,585} A class Ib agent (lidocaine) is a reasonable next step for refractory wide-complex toxicity; lipid emulsion for life-threatening cases unresponsive to other therapy. ⁵³⁷ Monitor the ECG (QRS width), blood pressure, serum pH, sodium and potassium. ⁵³⁷
Sulfonylurea	Octreotide – children 1–1.5 µg/kg IV/SC, then 2–3 further doses 6 h apart (adults 50 µg) Dextrose for hypoglycemia (bolus then infusion) ^{586,587}	Treat hypoglycemia first with IV dextrose, then give octreotide to stop insulin release and prevent recurrent hypoglycemia; hypoglycemia recurred in half of the reported children, so repeat doses are often needed. ^{586,587} Taper the dextrose infusion as octreotide takes effect. ⁵⁸⁷ Check glucose frequently ; do not give prophylactic IV dextrose. ⁵⁸⁶ Observe ~12 h after the last octreotide/dextrose dose for relapse — longer for large or sustained-release ingestions. ^{586,587}
Sympathomimetic (cocaine, amphetamines)	Sedation first – IV benzodiazepine titrated to control agitation (doses: <u>Convulsive Status Epilepticus</u>) ^{537,588} Rapid external cooling for life-threatening hyperthermia – ice-water immersion or evaporative cooling (faster than cooling blankets or cold packs) ^{537,588} Sodium bicarbonate 1–3 mEq/kg IV for cocaine wide-complex tachycardia or cardiac arrest (lidocaine is an alternative for the tachycardia) ⁵³⁷ Vasodilator (nitrate, phentolamine, calcium-channel blocker) for coronary vasospasm or a hypertensive emergency that persists after sedation ^{537,588}	Target — benzodiazepines are the mainstay of initial control of agitation and blood pressure ⁵³⁷ Monitor — ECG, temperature; watch for seizures, hyperthermia, rhabdomyolysis, metabolic acidosis and myocardial infarction ⁵⁸⁸ β-blockers — safety in cocaine toxicity is controversial (both benefit and harm reported) ⁵³⁷

⚠️ AVOID

- Flumazenil is generally avoided (seizure risk) — see the benzodiazepine row.⁵²³
- Several agents have **delayed or biphasic** toxicity (acetaminophen,⁵²⁴ iron, sustained-release products,⁵²³ sulfonylureas⁵⁸⁶) — observe and recheck.

▴ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — symptomatic, a significant/unknown ingestion, or a delayed-toxicity agent (observe).
- **Home from the emergency department** — asymptomatic after the appropriate observation window with a non-toxic exposure.
- **Refer — now** — the poison center/toxicology; psychiatry for intentional ingestion; safeguarding as needed.

One Pill Can Kill — Toddler Alert

HOURS

< 6 YR · AAPCC 2005–2007

One tablet or one teaspoon of these can seriously harm or kill a 10-kg toddler — observe for the full period even if the child is well.

▴ RECOGNIZE

- One or two adult dose units can kill a 10-kg toddler. The classic list includes tricyclic antidepressants, antipsychotics, antimalarials (quinine derivatives), calcium-channel blockers, opioids, oral hypoglycemics, camphor and methyl salicylate.^{589,590}
- These few drugs caused 40% of toddler poisoning deaths reported to US poison centers in 1990–2000.⁵⁹⁰
- The list keeps growing. By 2018 it had doubled, adding newer anticoagulants, a PDE-5 inhibitor, newer antiepileptics, antidiabetic drugs, multiple-sclerosis drugs and second-generation antipsychotics.⁵⁹¹
- Toxicity can be **delayed and prolonged** (methadone, modified-release products, sulfonylureas, diphenoxylate). A child who is well on arrival is not reassuring.^{533,586,592,593}

DECIDE

- **Any possible ingestion of a listed agent by a child < 6 y = toxic**, even if the ingestion is unconfirmed or the amount unknown.^{533,590,594}
- Call KPCC **1804774**. Check glucose and a 12-lead ECG on arrival.^{8,523}
- **Observe for the full period in the table even if the child looks well. Never send home early.**⁵³³
- Do not induce emesis.^{548,585,592,595}

AGENTS, DANGER DOSE AND MINIMUM OBSERVATION

Medicine / product	Danger at one dose	Observe at least	First action
Antimalarials — chloroquine, hydroxychloroquine	1–2 chloroquine tablets have caused serious toxicity > 10 mg/kg chloroquine base or unknown amount: hospital Treat hydroxychloroquine the same ⁵⁹⁴	4–6 h ⁵⁹⁴	12-lead ECG and cardiac monitor; call KPCC ^{523,589,594}
Antipsychotics — second-generation; phenothiazines	Child < 12 y, hospital at: aripiprazole 15 mg clozapine 50 mg olanzapine 10 mg quetiapine 100 mg risperidone 1 mg ziprasidone 80 mg ⁵⁹⁵	6 h ⁵⁹⁵	Continuous cardiac monitoring (conduction disturbances) ^{589,590,595}
Buprenorphine (tablet, film)	> 2 mg, or more than a lick or taste if < 2 y Every child taking > 4 mg had some effect; most often drowsiness, vomiting, miosis; respiratory depression in 7% Onset 20 min–3 h ⁵⁹⁶	Admit Effects lasted 8–24 h in 26%, > 24 h in 4% ^{533,596}	Naloxone for respiratory depression (at least partial response in 67%); dose in the Poisoning antidote table ^{533,596}
Calcium-channel blockers — amlodipine, nifedipine, verapamil, diltiazem	Amlodipine 5 mg caused hypotension in a 2-year-old ⁵⁹⁷	Immediate-release: 6–8 h Modified-release: 24 h ^{592,597}	Cardiac monitor, blood pressure; IV fluids, then IV calcium for hypotension (antidote table) ^{590,592,597}
Camphor — camphorated oil, rubs	5 mL of 20% camphorated oil killed a 19-month-old > 30 mg/kg: hospital Toxic effects, including seizures, often within 10–20 min ^{597,598}	4–8 h (one seizure reported at 9 h) ^{597,598}	Benzodiazepine for seizures; no activated charcoal ^{589,597,598}
Clonidine; imidazoline eye drops and nasal sprays	Clonidine 0.1 mg is toxic; one 0.3-mg tablet caused coma 1–2 mL of drops or spray: coma, bradycardia, slow breathing (≤ 5 y) Onset 30–90 min; may last 1–3 days ^{544,597}	4 h after arrival (no later deterioration in a pediatric series); admit if any symptom ⁵⁴³	Monitor heart rate, blood pressure, breathing; support the airway — naloxone works inconsistently ^{542,543,544,597}

Medicine / product	Danger at one dose	Observe at least	First action
Diphenoxylate–atropine (Lomotil)	Half a tablet has caused toxicity Mainly opioid: coma, respiratory depression, cerebral edema, death ^{593,597}	24 h in a monitored bed (respiratory depression recurred at 13–24 h) ^{593,597}	IV naloxone, then a continuous infusion if needed ^{593,597}
Methadone, fentanyl patch, extended-release opioids	One methadone tablet can kill a toddler In children, toxicity is delayed, severe and prolonged ^{533,599}	Admit for 24 h (≤ 3 y), even if the ingestion is unconfirmed ⁵³³	Naloxone (children may need larger doses; repeat or infuse if breathing slows again); undress the child and look for patches ^{533,599}
Methyl salicylate (oil of wintergreen)	5 mL of 98% = 7,000 mg salicylate < 5 mL has been fatal More than a lick or taste (< 6 y): hospital ^{548,597}	Salicylate level every 2 h until improving and non-toxic ⁵⁹⁷	Salicylate level now; call KPCC ^{8,548,597}
Sulfonylureas — glibenclamide, glipizide	A single tablet can cause hypoglycemia Hypoglycemia in 30% of exposed children (96% of them within 8 h); may be delayed and persistent ^{586,597,600}	12–24 h; keep until morning rather than discharge at night ^{586,597}	Glucose checks often; feed; no prophylactic IV dextrose. Hypoglycemia: IV dextrose bolus, then octreotide (Hypoglycemia) ^{586,597,600}
Tricyclic antidepressants — amitriptyline, imipramine, nortriptyline	> 5 mg/kg: hospital (nortriptyline, desipramine > 2.5 mg/kg) One 50-mg tablet = 5 mg/kg in a 10-kg child 15–20 mg/kg potentially lethal ^{585,597}	6 h, with a normal ECG at the end ^{585,597}	ECG: QRS > 100 ms → sodium bicarbonate (antidote table); benzodiazepine for seizures; no flumazenil ^{585,597}

⚠ PITFALLS

- Naloxone wears off before methadone or diphenoxylate do, so respiratory depression returns. Re-dose or start an infusion, and keep the child in a monitored bed.^{533,593}
- In clonidine poisoning, naloxone helps inconsistently; 6 of 47 children needed intubation.⁵⁴³
- Sulfonylureas: no prophylactic IV dextrose, and no discharge at night.⁵⁸⁶
- Ask about every adult's medicines in the home — toddlers find and swallow them.⁵³³

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — methadone, fentanyl patch or extended-release opioid (≤ 3 y, 24 h); any buprenorphine; diphenoxylate–atropine (24 h, monitored); modified-release calcium-channel blocker; sulfonylurea when the 12 h would end at night; any symptomatic child.^{533,586,593,597}

- **Home from the emergency department** — well at the end of the agent's observation period, with normal vital signs, a normal ECG (tricyclics) and normal glucose (sulfonylureas), after KPCC advice. Advise storing medicines, eye drops and nasal sprays out of children's reach. ^{8,544,586,597}
- **Refer — now** — PICU for coma, apnea, hypotension, bradycardia, seizures, QRS widening or recurrent hypoglycemia. Involve child protection when supervision or malicious administration is a concern. ^{533,585,595,599}

Caustic (Corrosive) Ingestion HOURS

Acid or alkali burns — protect the airway; do no harm.

RECOGNIZE

- Drooling, dysphagia, painful swallowing, oral or lip burns, chest or abdominal pain. Stridor or respiratory distress means airway injury.
- The **absence of oral burns does not exclude esophageal injury**. Alkali (drain cleaner) causes deep liquefactive necrosis; acid causes coagulative necrosis. ⁶⁰¹

DO NOT

No induced emesis, no gastric lavage, **no activated charcoal**, no neutralizing or forced dilution — these re-expose the esophagus and worsen injury. ⁶⁰¹

DO

- Airway first — anticipate swelling and intubate early if any compromise (by anesthesia/ENT/PICU)
- Avoid blind nasogastric-tube insertion unless directed after endoscopic/surgical assessment.
- Keep nothing by mouth; give IV fluids, analgesia, antiemetics.
- Chest and abdominal X-ray for free air. **If esophageal perforation is suspected (free air, severe chest or abdominal pain, or sepsis), start IV fluids and consult pediatric surgery immediately.** Contact poison control. ⁶⁰¹

ENDOSCOPY

- **ANY SYMPTOM OR SIGN** (mouth lesion, drooling, vomiting, dysphagia, hematemesis, breathing difficulty, abdominal pain) → upper endoscopy **WITHIN 24 H**, once stabilized with a secure airway; acid and alkali alike. Three or more symptoms predict severe injury. ⁶⁰²
- **NO SYMPTOMS, NO DROOLING AND NO MOUTH LESIONS** → routine endoscopy is not needed, provided follow-up is assured. ⁶⁰²
- Later than 48 h raises perforation risk. ⁶⁰¹
- Watch for delayed strictures over the following weeks.
- A swallowed button battery is a separate emergency ²³⁶ — see **Button (Lithium) Battery Ingestion**.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- Disposition depends on agent, amount, intent, symptoms and poison-center/GI assessment, and on the ability to tolerate oral intake.
- **Admit** — all symptomatic or significant exposures → nil by mouth, plan imaging/endoscopy.
- **Home from the emergency department** — asymptomatic minor exposure after observation.
- **Refer — now** — ENT/GI/surgery (endoscopy) and PICU; do not blind-pass a nasogastric tube.

Hydrocarbon Ingestion & Pneumonitis

HOURS

YOUNG CHILDREN · Clin Toxicol 2014

The danger is the lungs, not the gut — observe 6–8 h, X-ray at the end, never make the child vomit.

▲ RECOGNIZE

- **High aspiration risk — thin, runny, volatile products:** gasoline, kerosene, spot removers, mineral spirits. Lamp oil, kerosene and lighter fluid/naphtha cause most of the serious lung injury.⁶⁰³
- **Extra danger beyond the lungs:** camphor (toxic effects, including seizures, often within 10–20 min; > 30 mg/kg needs hospital care); halogenated solvents (they sensitize the heart to epinephrine and can trigger a non-perfusing rhythm); products containing pesticides, metals or methanol.^{597,598,603}
- **Aspiration signs:** cough, vomiting, drowsiness, fever, fast breathing, tachycardia, altered mentation. Wheeze, tachypnea or altered mentation **within 2 h** predicts the need for treatment.⁶⁰³
- **Timeline:** pneumonitis follows about 15% of ingestions and evolves over the first 6–8 h. It peaks within 48 h, then improves; up to 5% progress rapidly to respiratory failure. Chest X-ray changes appear by 4–8 h and do not always match the clinical picture. Pneumatocoles can appear after 6–10 days and resolve within 6 months.^{603,604}
- Most children stay well: in a poison-center cohort of all ages, 1% developed significant complications.^{604,605}

DO

- Airway and breathing first; give oxygen for hypoxemia; watch the work of breathing.^{603,604}
- **Observe 6–8 h**, then take a **chest X-ray at the end of observation**. An early film can be falsely normal.^{603,604,606}
- Call KPCC **1804774** with the product name. Ingredients such as camphor, pesticides, halogenated solvents or methanol change management.^{8,603}

⚠ DO NOT

- No induced emesis and no gastric lavage — both cause aspiration. **No activated charcoal** — it provokes gagging and vomiting. ^{527,603}
- No prophylactic corticosteroids (no benefit). No prophylactic antibiotics: fever and infiltrates are part of chemical pneumonitis. Give antibiotics only for bacterial superinfection. ^{603,604}

TREATMENT

Treatment	Dose · route	Endpoint · monitoring
Activated charcoal	Not indicated ^{527,603}	Gagging and vomiting raise the risk of aspiration ^{527,603}
Antibiotics	Not prophylactic Only for bacterial superinfection ^{603,604}	Fever and infiltrates alone are not an indication ^{603,604}
Benzodiazepine (seizures, e.g. camphor)	Dose as in <u>Convulsive Status Epilepticus</u>	Seizure stops; watch breathing ⁵⁹⁸
Corticosteroids	Not indicated ^{603,604}	No benefit shown ^{603,604}
Oxygen	Supplemental, to correct hypoxemia Intubation and mechanical ventilation if hypoxemia does not respond or the CNS is severely involved ^{603,604}	SpO ₂ , work of breathing, mental status. ECMO, surfactant and high-frequency ventilation are reported only in case reports ^{603,604}

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — symptomatic on arrival or during the 6–8 h observation, or an abnormal chest X-ray. About 90% of admitted children have a benign course. ^{604,606}
- **Home from the emergency department** — well through at least 6 h of observation with a normal chest X-ray. Children with early symptoms who settle within the 6 h and have a normal X-ray also do well. ^{603,606}
- **Refer — now** — PICU for increased work of breathing, altered sensorium, seizures, or hypoxemia despite oxygen. Discuss camphor, pesticide or halogenated products with KPCC. ^{8,604}

Isoniazid (INH) Poisoning – Refractory Seizures

MINUTES

ISONIAZID LABEL 2025

Seizures that will not stop, with acidosis and coma, in a child with TB medicine at home — give IV pyridoxine now.

RECOGNIZE

- **Who:** a child taking INH for TB infection, or one with access to a household member's TB medicine. Ingestion may be accidental or deliberate. With known access to INH, **a seizure is INH toxicity until proved otherwise.**^{572,607}
- **Onset 30 min–3 h:** nausea, vomiting, dizziness, slurred speech, blurred vision and visual hallucinations. These progress rapidly to stupor, coma, respiratory depression and severe, intractable seizures.⁵⁷⁰
- **Triad:** seizures that do not respond to anticonvulsants · severe metabolic acidosis · coma. Ketonuria and hyperglycemia are typical.^{570,572,607}
- **Dose:** in a pediatric series, seizures followed ingestions of 14–99 mg/kg (mean 54 mg/kg). An acute ingestion of **> 80 mg/kg** needs IV pyridoxine even without symptoms.^{570,572}

DO

- Airway, breathing, oxygen. Give a benzodiazepine for the seizure **together with** pyridoxine; the two act synergistically in animal studies.^{570,607}
- **IV pyridoxine now** (dose below). **Repeat it if seizures continue.** A single gram-for-gram dose prevented recurrent seizures and shortened coma.^{570,571}
- Send blood gas, electrolytes, urea and glucose. Acidosis usually clears once seizures are controlled, so dialysis is rarely needed.^{570,571}
- Call KPCC **1804774** and ask pharmacy for the full pyridoxine dose at once.^{8,608}

MEDICATIONS

Drug	Dose	Route · rate · repeat	Endpoint · monitoring
Benzodiazepine (midazolam, lorazepam, diazepam)	Dose as in <u>Convulsive Status Epilepticus</u>	Route as in that card Give together with pyridoxine, not instead of it ⁶⁰⁷	Seizure stops Watch breathing ^{570,607}
Pyridoxine (vitamin B6)	Known amount: equal to the INH ingested (1 mg per mg) Unknown amount: 80 mg/kg (adult 5 g) Well child, > 80 mg/kg ingested: equal to the INH ingested Total > 10 g rarely needed; maximum safe dose unknown ⁵⁷⁰	IV Seizing: slow bolus over 3–5 min Not seizing: over 30–60 min Repeat the dose if seizures continue ⁵⁷⁰	Seizures stop; acidosis and coma resolve Monitor seizure activity, ventilation, blood gas, electrolytes, glucose ^{570,571}

◆ IF IV PYRIDOXINE IS NOT IN THE DEPARTMENT

- Keep treating seizures with benzodiazepines and the second-line drugs of the **Convulsive Status Epilepticus** card while KPCC and pharmacy obtain pyridoxine. Seizures may stop only once parenteral pyridoxine is given.^{8,572}
- When it was not stocked in the ED, pyridoxine was delayed by 5.8 h on average and one child had to be transferred. Pyridoxine should be **immediately available** in every ED.^{572,608}
- At 100 mg/mL in 1-mL vials, a 5-g dose is 50 vials.⁶⁰⁹

⚠ PITFALLS

- **Under-dosing:** an infant given 70 mg/kg (650 mg) after a 290 mg/kg ingestion seized again and needed 2 g more. When the amount is known, dose gram-for-gram regardless of age.⁶⁰⁷
- **Phenytoin:** use it cautiously, because INH interferes with its metabolism.⁵⁷⁰
- **Sodium bicarbonate** in a hypoventilating child can worsen hypercarbia. Monitor CO₂ and support ventilation first.⁵⁷⁰
- **Missed diagnosis:** INH was not suspected at a first seizure and the child returned with another. Ask about TB medicines in the home.⁵⁷²

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — every symptomatic child. Seizures, coma or acidosis need intensive care with repeated blood gases to protect against hypoxia, hypotension and aspiration.⁵⁷⁰
- **Home from the emergency department** — only a well child after a small accidental ingestion, once the observation period agreed with KPCC has passed. Advise locked storage of TB medicines.⁸
- **Refer — now** — PICU for recurrent seizures, coma or respiratory insufficiency. Psychiatry after a deliberate ingestion (3 of 8 episodes in a pediatric series were suicide attempts).^{570,572}

Burns HOURS

Cool it, size it, replace fluid to urine output — and protect the airway.

▀ ASSESS

- Estimate % total body surface area (TBSA) with a Lund-Browder chart (age-adjusted values are in the Lund-Browder figure on this card; the child's palm including fingers ≈ 1%); assess depth and mechanism.⁶¹⁰
- **Airway red flags** — stridor, hoarseness, respiratory distress, black sputum, singed nasal hairs, facial swelling or progressive airway edema → prepare pediatric airway equipment, involve anesthesia/airway expertise early; low threshold for early intubation. If intubated, **do not trim the endotracheal tube** (facial swelling can leave it too short) — secure it carefully and reassess.^{611,612,613}

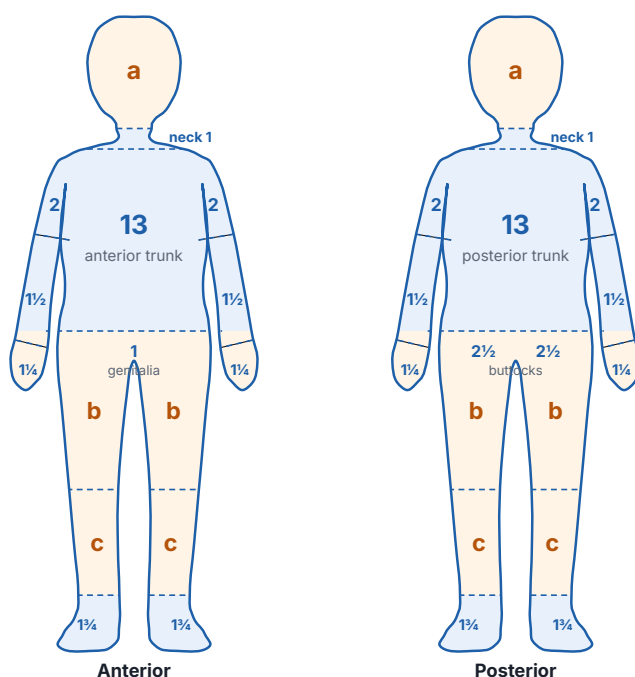
- **Enclosed-space flame/flash burn** → **100 % oxygen**; co-oximetry for carboxyhemoglobin; consider cyanide (hydroxocobalamin) — see **Smoke Inhalation & Carbon Monoxide Poisoning**.⁶¹²
- **Elevate** significantly burned limbs and the head of the bed for head/neck burns; document distal perfusion. **Circumferential limb or chest burn** → check distal perfusion / chest excursion frequently; urgent burns advice if perfusion or ventilation is compromised; escharotomy only with expert guidance.^{612,613}
- Mechanism suggesting trauma (fall, blast, vehicle) → trauma primary survey first (**\$13 Major Trauma**); spinal precautions when indicated.⁶¹²

Burns – Lund-Browder estimate of % TBSA

Age-adjusted regions a, b, c; fixed regions carry their value per side and aspect; the child's palm with fingers ≈ 1 %^{610,614}.

Burns — Lund-Browder estimate of % total body surface area (TBSA)

Values are per region for that aspect (front or back) · amber regions a, b, c change with age (table) · the child's palm with fingers ≈ 1 %



Percentage of body surface by age

	0 y	1 y	5 y	10 y	15 y	adult
a · 1/2 head	9 1/2	8 1/2	6 1/2	5 1/2	4 1/2	3 1/2
b · 1/2 one thigh	2 3/4	3 1/4	4	4 1/4	4 1/2	4 3/4
c · 1/2 one lower leg	2 1/2	2 1/2	2 3/4	3	3 1/4	3 1/2

Fixed regions (blue; per side, per aspect)

neck 1 · trunk 13 · genitalia 1 (anterior)
 buttock 2 1/2 each (posterior)
 upper arm 2 · forearm 1 1/2 · hand 1 1/4
 foot 1 1/4 · front + back add up to 100 %

How to count

Count partial- and full-thickness burn only (ignore simple erythema). For a region that is partly burned, take that fraction of its value. Formal IV resuscitation when TBSA > 10 %.

Source: Lund CC, Browder NC. The estimation of areas of burns. Surg Gynecol Obstet 1944;79:352–358; ISBI practice guidelines 2016. Age-adjusted values a, b, c from Lund & Browder. Original drawing for this guide.

FIRST AID

Stop the burning; cool with running water for **20 min** — worthwhile even if started up to **3 h** after the burn (**not** ice; no hydrogel products); then **cool the burn, warm the child**: remove wet clothing and jewelry, warm room, blankets (infants lose heat fastest); cover; analgesia.^{610,612,613,615}



FLUIDS (TBSA > 10%)

- Lactated Ringer's starting at **3 mL/kg × %TBSA** for the first 24 h (sources give 2–4): ½ in the first 8 h from the time of the burn, ½ over the next 16 h, **plus** maintenance with dextrose (4-2-1); adjust the rate hourly to urine output — the formula is only a starting estimate.^{610,616}
- **Shock at presentation** is unusual from the burn alone in the first hours — look for hemorrhage/trauma, inhalation injury or sepsis; give **10–20 mL/kg** isotonic crystalloid and reassess rather than repeated boluses (over-resuscitation harms).^{612,613}
- Titrate to urine output **1 mL/kg/h if < 30 kg; 0.5 mL/kg/h if ≥ 30 kg**.^{610,612}



REFER TO A BURNS CENTER

> 10% TBSA, full-thickness, face/hands/feet/perineum/joints, electrical or chemical, inhalation injury, or suspected inflicted injury.⁶¹⁰

⚠️ AIRWAY / CIRCULATION RED FLAGS

- Enclosed-space fire → 100 % O₂; consider carbon monoxide ± cyanide.
- Hoarseness, stridor, respiratory distress, black sputum, singed nasal hairs or progressive facial swelling → early airway/anesthesia involvement; do not trim the tube.
- Circumferential chest burn + impaired ventilation → urgent burn-specialist advice.
- Circumferential limb burn → check distal perfusion frequently.
- Elevate significantly burned limbs and head/neck burns.
- Cool the burn, but keep the child warm.⁶¹²

⚠️ AVOID OVER-RESUSCITATION ("FLUID CREEP")

- The formula is only a starting estimate — titrate to urine output, not to the number.⁶¹⁰
- Don't apply ice or home remedies.

⚠️ RAISE SUSPICION FOR INFLECTED INJURY

- A significant share of pediatric burns are inflicted — most intentional burns are scalds.⁶¹⁷
- Red flags: a **well-demarcated** burn with **uniform depth** and **no splash marks**; a symmetric immersion ("stocking/glove") pattern with a clear upper margin and skin-fold sparing; burns in normally **protected sites** (groin, perineum, buttocks, back, thighs); a **patterned contact burn** reproducing the shape of an object (iron, cigarette, lighter, heater, hair dryer)⁶¹²; delayed presentation or a history that does not fit the burn pattern or the child's developmental stage.
- Look for other injuries and old fractures; safeguard.⁶¹⁷

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — large or deep burns, airway/inhalation injury, electrical/chemical burns, or a safeguarding concern → burns center.

- **Home from the emergency department** — small superficial burns with dressing and review.
- **Refer — now** — a burns unit per criteria; ophthalmology/surgery as needed.

Heat Stroke MINUTES

A clinical diagnosis — core $\geq 40^{\circ}\text{C}$ + CNS dysfunction after heat exposure. Cool fast; antipyretics do not work.

▴ DIAGNOSE CLINICALLY

- **Core temperature $\geq 40^{\circ}\text{C}$ with CNS dysfunction** after environmental heat exposure. Criteria and cooling evidence are largely adult/exertional; children thermoregulate as effectively as adults when hydrated, so adult data are applied to children.^{618,619}
- **CNS:** confusion, delirium, irritability, hallucinations, ataxia, slurred speech, seizures, coma. **CVS:** tachycardia, hypotension, dehydration/shock. **GI:** nausea, vomiting ($\pm$ diarrhea). **Other:** hot skin, tachypnea.

INVESTIGATIONS – DO NOT DELAY COOLING

RBS (hypoglycemia) · CBC · electrolytes (Na/K/Ca) · urea & creatinine · LFTs · coagulation (DIC) · blood gas (metabolic acidosis $\pm$ early respiratory alkalosis) · creatine kinase (rhabdomyolysis) · urinalysis (myoglobinuria).⁶¹⁸

▴ MANAGEMENT

- **1 · ABCDE** — secure airway, support breathing and circulation.
- **2 · Immediate rapid cooling (do not delay). Ice-water immersion ($1\text{--}5^{\circ}\text{C}$)** when feasible — the fastest method; aim to cool by $\geq 0.15^{\circ}\text{C}/\text{min}$. Otherwise **tepid-water immersion** or **evaporative cooling** — remove clothing, spray/mist water, high-flow fans, mesh stretcher/hammock — plus **ice packs to neck, axillae, and groin**. Room-temperature 0.9% saline for dehydration/shock (avoid overload). **Continuous rectal core-temperature monitoring.**^{19,618}
- **3 · Stop active cooling at a core temperature of 38.6°C** to avoid overshoot hypothermia.¹⁹
- **4 · No antipyretics** (acetaminophen/ibuprofen) — ineffective in heat stroke and may worsen liver, renal, or GI injury.⁶¹⁸ Treat shivering cautiously with IV midazolam or lorazepam; treat seizures per the pediatric status epilepticus protocol (see **Convulsive Status Epilepticus**).

⚠ DISPOSITION

- **Admit** — children with true heat stroke (CNS dysfunction) go to a PICU or high-dependency/PICU-capable setting depending on severity and organ injury — thermal instability and organ injury (rhabdomyolysis, AKI, DIC) can evolve over days.⁶¹⁸
- High-yield in Kuwait's climate.

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — all with CNS dysfunction or organ injury → high-dependency/PICU.
- **Home from the emergency department** — mild heat exhaustion, resolved and hydrated with normal mentation.
- **Refer — now** — PICU; nephrology for rhabdomyolysis/AKI.

Drowning MINUTES

Respiratory impairment from submersion/immersion — ventilate first; rescue breaths are the key intervention.

▲ INITIAL MANAGEMENT (ABCDE)

- **Airway & breathing:** start **rescue breathing immediately** (the single most important intervention); give 100% oxygen; support ventilation as needed. **A Heimlich maneuver and postural drainage have no role in drowning** — do not perform them; they delay ventilation and risk aspiration.⁶²⁰
- **Circulation:** check pulse; if no pulse, start CPR per the **PALS cardiac-arrest algorithm** — **rescue breaths and chest compressions** (compressions only if the rescuer cannot give breaths). Start CPR before applying an AED and never delay CPR to get one; give oxygen as soon as available.¹⁹ In the ED, **check the rhythm and give electrical therapy with a manual defibrillator** if the rhythm is shockable.⁶²⁰
- **Temperature:** remove wet clothing; if core < 35°C, prevent further heat loss and begin active rewarming.⁶²⁰
- **Post-ROSC:** manage per PALS post-cardiac-arrest care.

OBSERVE ALL IN THE EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT FOR 6–8 H

- Every submersion patient, even if asymptomatic: continuous pulse oximetry with serial respiratory and neurological exams^{620,621} (delayed pulmonary edema can appear within 4–8 h)
- No routine chest X-ray or laboratory tests in an asymptomatic child.^{620,621}

ASYMPTOMATIC

No cough, normal work of breathing, SpO₂ ≥ 95% on room air, normal mental status and lung exam.
No routine chest X-ray or blood tests → well at 6–8 h → **discharge** with return precautions.^{620,621}

MILD – NO ADMISSION NEEDED

Mild cough only; normal work of breathing; SpO₂ ≥ 95% on room air; normal mental status; normal or minimally abnormal lung exam; stable circulation.
Pulse oximetry, oxygen only if needed, chest X-ray, serial exams; observe 6–8 h. Symptoms resolved, SpO₂ ≥ 95% on room air, normal exams and chest X-ray → **discharge** with return precautions.
Symptoms persist or worsen → **admit**.⁶²¹
Cough with a normal lung exam carried 0% mortality in 1,189 drowning patients.⁶²²

MODERATE – ADMIT (WARD)

Persistent cough, increased work of breathing, abnormal lung exam, SpO₂ < 95% on room air that responds to oxygen, or GCS 13–14; stable circulation.
Oxygen, cardiorespiratory monitoring, glucose, blood gas, CBC, electrolytes, renal function, chest X-ray, ECG; avoid fluid overload. CPAP/BiPAP for persistent hypoxemia if the airway is protected (HFNC if not tolerated).
PICU if the oxygen need rises, NIV is needed, or breathing or mental status worsens.⁶²¹

SEVERE – PICU

Severe distress or respiratory failure, SpO₂ < 90% despite oxygen/NIV, frothy secretions, significant altered mental status, shock, or ARDS.
Secure the airway; intubate with lung-protective ventilation and PEEP, 100% oxygen initially; rewarm; cautious fluids ± vasopressors; consider ECMO where available.⁶²¹

⚠ ADMIT

- **Admit** — moderate symptoms (ward); mild symptoms that persist or worsen after 6–8 h; severe symptoms, rising oxygen need or need for NIV/ventilation (PICU). Mild cases that recover during observation do not need admission.⁶²¹

◆ NOT RECOMMENDED

- Heimlich maneuver
- postural drainage
- routine chest X-ray or blood tests in an asymptomatic child
- glucocorticoids
- routine antibiotics
- routine cervical-spine immobilization unless trauma (e.g., a diving injury) is suspected.^{620,621}

▲ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — moderate symptoms → ward; severe → PICU; mild symptoms only if they persist or worsen after 6–8 h observation.⁶²¹
- **Home from the emergency department** — asymptomatic or mild, well after 6–8 h observation with SpO₂ ≥ 95% on room air and a normal exam (and a normal chest X-ray if mild). Return at once for increasing or persistent cough, difficulty breathing, cyanosis or chest pain, persistent vomiting, drowsiness or seizure, or fever after the first 24 h.⁶²¹
- **Refer — now** — PICU for severe or worsening respiratory compromise; child protection when the history, supervision, delay in presentation or injury pattern raises concern.⁶²¹

Smoke Inhalation & Carbon Monoxide Poisoning

MINUTES

FIRE / SMOKE

Fire injures three ways — airway, carbon monoxide, cyanide. Look for and treat all three.

▲ DEFINE

- Fire/smoke injures by three mechanisms: **(1) thermal / chemical airway injury, (2) carbon monoxide (CO), (3) hydrogen cyanide (HCN)**. Suspect all three after any **enclosed-space fire**, especially with altered mental status.⁶¹¹

▲ APPROACH — THE AIRWAY FIRST

- Signs of inhalation injury: **facial/neck burns, singed nasal hairs, soot in the mouth or sputum, carbonaceous sputum, hoarseness, stridor, oropharyngeal edema or blistering**.
- Airway injury is **progressive** — edema worsens over hours. Reassess continuously.⁶¹¹

▲ SECURE THE AIRWAY EARLY

- Deep facial/neck burns, oropharyngeal blistering or edema, hoarseness/stridor, or large cutaneous burns → **intubate early** (call PICU/anesthesia urgently — expert airway control) before edema makes the airway impassable.⁶¹¹
- Avoid over-aggressive IV fluids — they worsen airway edema.⁶¹¹

CARBON MONOXIDE

▲ RECOGNIZE & MEASURE

- CO binds hemoglobin ~**200–250× more avidly than oxygen** → tissue hypoxia plus direct cellular toxicity; **symptoms and COHb level correlate poorly**.⁵⁶¹
- **Pulse oximetry reads falsely normal** (it cannot distinguish carboxyhemoglobin) — measure **COHb by co-oximetry** (blood gas). COHb > 2% (non-smoker) or > 9% (smoker) supports the diagnosis.⁵⁶¹
- Symptoms: headache, nausea, dizziness, confusion, syncope, seizure, cardiac ischemia, coma.

◆ HYPERBARIC OXYGEN (HBO) – AVAILABLE LOCALLY

- High-flow **100% OXYGEN VIA A NON-REBREATHER** (or ventilator) is first-line and cuts COHb half-life from ~4–5 h to ~60–90 min.
- With a chamber on site, **CONSIDER HBO** for severe poisoning: **LOSS OF CONSCIOUSNESS/SYNCOPE**, seizure or altered mental status, **CARDIAC ISCHEMIA** or arrhythmia, persistent metabolic acidosis, end-organ damage, a markedly raised COHb, or **PREGNANCY** (COHb > 15%) — decide early; the Undersea and Hyperbaric Medical Society (UHMS) advises considering HBO for any acute symptomatic CO poisoning. Pediatric COHb cut-offs are not established.^{560,561}
- HBO speeds elimination and may reduce delayed neurocognitive sequelae; trial evidence is mixed, so weigh case by case.⁶²³
- In children benefit is extrapolated from adult trials (under-16s excluded from the pivotal RCT); let CO exposure duration, COHb level, neurologic signs, and lactate guide the decision.⁵⁶¹

⚠ CYANIDE – DON'T MISS IT

- Suspect HCN co-poisoning in an enclosed-space fire with soot, **altered mental status**, **hemodynamic instability**, or **severe lactic acidosis (lactate ≥ 8–10 mmol/L)**.
- Treat **empirically — do not wait for levels**.²⁰
- Use **hydroxocobalamin**; avoid nitrite-based kits in smoke victims (induced methemoglobinemia worsens hypoxia).^{20,611}

MANAGEMENT

Intervention	Dose	Notes
Oxygen	100% via non-rebreather (or intubate)	Continue until symptom-free and COHb < 5%. ^{18,561}
Hydroxocobalamin (suspected cyanide)	70 mg/kg/dose IV (max 5 g)	Empiric in smoke inhalation with shock, or lactate ≥ 8–10 mmol/L plus compatible clinical findings (do not rely on lactate alone); repeat once if needed. ²⁰
HBO (severe CO)	Per hyperbaric-unit protocol (pressure and number of sessions set by the unit)	Refer to the hyperbaric unit for the criteria above; the pivotal adult RCT gave three sessions within 24 h. ⁶²⁴

▴ ALSO

- Cardiac monitoring + ECG, serial lactate and COHb, cautious fluid resuscitation; ICU/burns referral.
- See also **Burns** and **Poisoning & Toxic Ingestion** for concurrent burn and antidote management.

✦ PEARL – THE OXIMETER LIES

- A normal SpO₂ does not exclude CO poisoning — measure carboxyhemoglobin.
- In a fire victim with shock and a high lactate, give hydroxocobalamin without waiting for confirmation.²⁰

▀ ADMIT · DISCHARGE · REFER

- **Admit** — respiratory symptoms, altered mentation, or a significant carboxyhemoglobin → oxygen and monitoring.
- **Home from the emergency department** — asymptomatic with normal levels after observation.
- **Refer — now** — hyperbaric/PICU for severe CO; burns/ENT for airway injury.

Envenomation — Scorpion Sting & Snakebite

MINUTES

WHO 2016 · regional

Two regional bites: scorpion = an autonomic storm; snake = local tissue injury and coagulopathy.

▀ SCORPION STING

- Severe local pain, then an **autonomic storm**: sweating, salivation, vomiting, hypertension and tachycardia, agitation, and in severe cases **pulmonary edema, myocardial dysfunction and cardiogenic shock** (severity depends on venom dose, time to care and the victim's age).^{625,626}
- Supportive care and analgesia; **prazosin** for autonomic/cardiovascular toxicity. Give **antivenom** for systemic envenomation per local protocol — with prazosin it hastened recovery in an Indian RCT (*Mesobuthus tamulus*), but evidence for other Old World species is weaker.^{625,626} Benzodiazepines for agitation (expert practice).

▀ SNAKEBITE

- Look for **local** swelling/necrosis and **systemic** effects — coagulopathy/bleeding, neurotoxicity (ptosis, bulbar/respiratory weakness) or rhabdomyolysis, depending on species.⁶²⁷
- First aid: reassure; **immobilize/splint the bitten limb and minimize movement**; remove constrictions; move to hospital. Give species-appropriate **antivenom** for systemic envenomation and monitor the airway and clotting.⁶²⁷

⚠ DON'T MAKE IT WORSE

- **No** tourniquets, incision, suction or ice on snakebites — they increase harm.⁶²⁷
- Watch for delayed coagulopathy and compartment syndrome; recheck clotting serially.
- Anticipate **anaphylaxis to antivenom** and have epinephrine ready.⁶²⁷

◆ **LOCAL** The national/KPCC protocol and species-specific antivenom take precedence over generic international regimens. Call KPCC **1804774** early for species identification and antivenom dosing.⁸

▲ WORKUP

- **Snakebite: 20-minute whole-blood clotting test**, CBC/platelets, PT/INR + fibrinogen, D-dimer, renal function + potassium, CK, urinalysis (myoglobin), ECG, **serial limb marking**, group & crossmatch.⁶²⁷
- **Scorpion**: continuous cardiac/BP monitoring, serial ECG, **cardiac enzymes (troponin/CK-MB) + echocardiogram** if cardiac signs (stress-type cardiomyopathy), glucose, electrolytes, blood gas (pulmonary edema).^{625,626}

▲ ADMIT · REFER

- **Admit** — admit/observe all systemic envenomation and any child with progressing local signs.
- **Refer — now** — call critical care and Poison Control; surgery for compartment syndrome/necrosis.



Quick Reference

Weight · airway · vital signs · master doses

Time-critical emergencies – quick reference

Solid bar = knowable clock / deadline · dashed bar = unknown onset / prognosis. See each condition's card for detail.

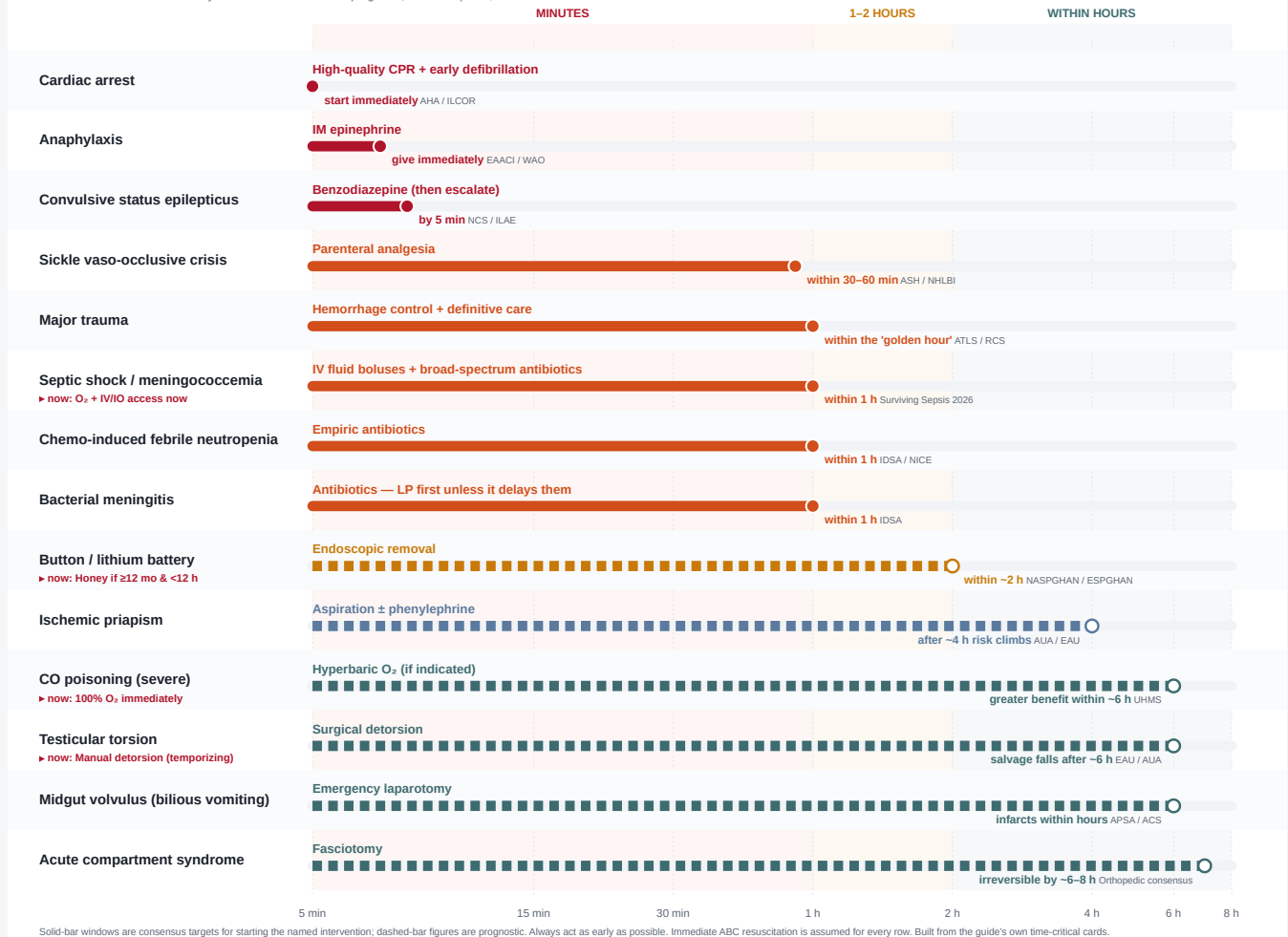
The Golden Window

What must be done — and by when — for the guide's time-critical emergencies. The intervention above each bar is what the window governs.

► Red "now" = a step that starts immediately, before any window applies (e.g. 100% O₂ in CO poisoning).

■ Solid = clock starts at a knowable moment (recognition / arrival) — a real deadline to beat.

■ Dashed = onset usually unknown — the window is prognosis; act on suspicion, do not treat it as a countdown.



Solid-bar windows are consensus targets for starting the named intervention; dashed-bar figures are prognostic. Always act as early as possible. Immediate ABC resuscitation is assumed for every row. Built from the guide's own time-critical cards.

When to Admit

General triggers first, then condition-specific thresholds.

▲ ANY ACUTELY UNWELL CHILD

Toxic or septic appearance; shock or unstable vital signs; hypoxia (SpO₂ < 92%); unable to tolerate oral fluids or medicines; moderate to severe dehydration; fever under 3 months; diagnostic uncertainty in an unwell child; or unreliable follow-up.

Condition

Admit if

Febrile young infant

Any under 28 days; 29–90 days unless low-risk on screening; ill-appearing at any age.

UTI	Under 3 months; toxic; vomiting or unable to take oral; no response by 48 h or a resistant organism; known uropathy, obstruction, chronic kidney disease, or transplant; suspected renal abscess; acute kidney injury.
Gastroenteritis / dehydration	Shock or severe dehydration; failed oral or nasogastric rehydration; persistent vomiting; significant electrolyte disturbance; under 6 months with heavy losses; possible surgical abdomen.
Bronchiolitis	Apnea; SpO ₂ persistently under 90–92%; feeding under 50–75% or dehydration; severe respiratory distress; under 3 months or comorbidity (prematurity, congenital heart disease, chronic lung disease).
Croup	Stridor at rest persisting after a corticosteroid; repeated nebulized L-epinephrine; hypoxia, exhaustion, or toxic appearance.
Asthma	Incomplete response to bronchodilators; ongoing oxygen need; needing bronchodilator more often than 1–2 hourly; silent chest, exhaustion, or altered consciousness (→ critical care).
Pneumonia	SpO ₂ under 92%; moderate to severe distress; under 3–6 months; not tolerating oral; dehydration; effusion or empyema; or failed oral antibiotics.
Nephrotic syndrome	First presentation; hypovolemia (abdominal pain, cool peripheries, hypotension, oliguria); peritonitis or sepsis; thromboembolism; severe edema with respiratory compromise; acute kidney injury; relapse not responding to oral steroids.
BRUE	Under 2 months; prematurity; more than one event; event needed CPR or vigorous stimulation; or a concerning history or examination (higher-risk).

Rabies Post-Exposure Prophylaxis HOURS WHO 2018

Dog, cat, or bat bite/scratch — wash, risk-stratify, give vaccine ± immunoglobulin same day.

▀ FIRST – WOUND CARE (MOST IMPORTANT)

- Wash/flush the wound **~15 minutes** with soap and running water, then apply a virucidal (povidone-iodine or 70% alcohol).⁶²⁸
- Avoid early suturing; if unavoidable, suture loosely **after** immunoglobulin infiltration.⁶²⁸
- Give **tetanus prophylaxis**; add antibiotics for a deep or contaminated bite (e.g., amoxicillin-clavulanate).

WHO category	Exposure	Action
I	Touching/feeding, licks on intact skin	No PEP — wash only
II	Nibbling of uncovered skin; minor scratch/abrasion without bleeding	Wound care + vaccine

WHO category	Exposure	Action
III	Transdermal bite/scratch, lick on broken skin, mucous-membrane contamination, or any bat contact ⁶²⁸	Wound care + vaccine + immunoglobulin

▀ VACCINE & IMMUNOGLOBULIN

- **Never previously vaccinated** — cell-culture vaccine IM on days **0, 3, 7, 14** (add day 28 if immunocompromised); the WHO 1-week 2-site intradermal schedule (days 0, 3, 7) is an accepted dose-sparing option.⁶²⁸
- **Previously fully vaccinated** — 2 doses only (days 0 and 3); **no immunoglobulin**.⁶²⁸
- **Rabies immunoglobulin** (category III, or category II if immunocompromised) — human RIG **20 IU/kg** (equine 40 IU/kg) as a single day-0 dose; infiltrate as much as possible into and around the wound, give any remainder IM at a site distant from the vaccine.⁶²⁸
- Repeat exposure within 3 months of a complete course → wound care only (no vaccine or RIG).⁶²⁸

⚠ DO NOT DELAY

- Start PEP the same day — rabies is almost always fatal once symptomatic.⁶²⁸
- Immunoglobulin can blunt live vaccines (separate MMR/varicella by ~4 months).⁶²⁹
- Follow the Kuwait MOH / local rabies protocol and notify public health.

IV → Oral Switch & the DIVA Patient ASSESS

In difficult access, every lost cannula is a switch decision — not an automatic re-stick.

▀ WHY IT MATTERS IN DIVA

- In **difficult intravenous access (DIVA)**, each re-cannulation means pain, delay, distress, and line risk. Reassess switch eligibility at **every line failure** rather than reflexively re-sticking — for many infections, evidence supports switching to oral earlier than previously recommended.⁶³⁰

DIVA SCORE – PREDICT DIFFICULT ACCESS

Variable (add the points)	Points
History of prematurity	3
Age: < 1 yr / 1–2 yr / ≥ 3 yr	3 / 1 / 0
Vein not palpable (after tourniquet)	2
Vein not visible (after tourniquet)	2

◆ INTERPRETATION

- Score ≥ 4 (max 10) $\rightarrow$ > 50% chance of first-attempt cannulation failure.⁶³¹
- Use it early: escalate to an ultrasound-guided / senior inserter or vein-finder — and in a child improving and able to take oral, favor an IV $\rightarrow$ **ORAL SWITCH** over repeated sticks.
- The simpler **DIVA-3** (age + vein visibility + palpability, dropping prematurity) performs as well.⁶³²

▀ SWITCH CRITERIA – ALL SHOULD BE MET (COMS)

- Clinically improving and responding to treatment.
- Oral route works — functioning gut, tolerating intake, not vomiting, no malabsorption.
- Markers settling — defervescing, hemodynamically stable, no ongoing sepsis ($\pm$ falling CRP/white count).
- Suitable oral agent — adequate spectrum and bioavailability.

DECISION

Deep-seated / high-risk infection?

SWITCH EARLY

Uncomplicated CAP, UTI/pyelonephritis, uncomplicated skin/soft-tissue infection, and acute osteomyelitis/septic arthritis (early oral non-inferior, with fewer line complications).

KEEP IV

Bacterial meningitis/brain abscess, endocarditis, *S. aureus* bacteremia, febrile neutropenia (until low-risk/recovery criteria), undrained deep abscess, septic shock until stabilized.

◆ LEAN ON HIGH ORAL-BIOAVAILABILITY AGENTS

- Near-IV exposure, ideal in DIVA: ciprofloxacin, levofloxacin, linezolid, metronidazole, fluconazole, trimethoprim-sulfamethoxazole, clindamycin, doxycycline, rifampicin.
- Beta-lactams (e.g., high-dose amoxicillin) are usable but dose adequately for their lower oral absorption.

⚠ DIVA RULE OF THUMB

- Do not place a PICC or midline solely to finish an IV course that an oral agent could complete.
- Weigh the procedural burden of central access against the switch criteria above.

Weight & Airway Sizing

Quick estimates — a length-based tape is more reliable.

Estimate

Formula

Weight (1–5 yr)	$(\text{age} + 4) \times 2 \text{ kg}$
Weight (6–12 yr)	$(\text{age} \times 3) + 7 \text{ kg}$
Endotracheal tube (uncuffed)	$(\text{age} \div 4) + 4 \text{ mm}$
Endotracheal tube (cuffed)	$(\text{age} \div 4) + 3.5 \text{ mm}$
Tube depth at lip	$\text{tube size} \times 3 \text{ cm}$
Hypotension (< 1 yr)	systolic BP < 70 mmHg
Hypotension (1–10 yr)	systolic BP < $70 + (2 \times \text{age}) \text{ mmHg}$
Hypotension (> 10 yr)	systolic BP < 90 mmHg

◆ GROWTH CHARTS

- Plot weight, length/height, and head circumference — [WHO standards \(birth–5 yr\)](#)



- [CDC charts \(2–19 yr\)](#)



Oxygen Delivery Systems & Cylinder Duration

Device → flow → approximate FiO₂ → when to escalate; and how long a cylinder will last.

OXYGEN DELIVERY SYSTEMS

Device	Flow · FiO ₂	Notes & escalation
LOW Nasal cannula (low-flow)	Infant 1–2 L/min Child up to 4 L/min Older child up to 6 L/min FiO ₂ ~24–45%	Variable — FiO ₂ rises with flow, falls with high inspiratory demand / mouth-breathing. Above ~2 L/min the dry gas irritates and dries the nasal mucosa — add humidification (and warming) at these flows.
LOW Simple face mask	5–10 L/min FiO ₂ ~40–60%	Minimum 5 L/min to flush CO ₂ (avoid rebreathing). Variable performance.
HIGH O₂ Non-rebreather (reservoir) mask	10–15 L/min keep the bag inflated FiO ₂ ~60–90%	Highest FiO ₂ without support — resuscitation / emergency .
FIXED Venturi (air-entrainment) mask	2–15 L/min per valve fixed FiO ₂ 24 / 28 / 31 / 35 / 40 / 60%	Delivers a precise FiO₂ regardless of breathing pattern — when a controlled FiO ₂ matters.

Device	Flow · FiO ₂	Notes & escalation
SUPPORT High-flow nasal cannula (HFNC)	≈ 2 L/kg/min (to device max, up to ~60 L/min) FiO ₂ 21–100% (titratable)	Warmed & humidified; adds 1–3 cmH ₂ O PEEP + deadspace washout. Can be run on the ward where a clear written escalation protocol exists (defined limits, monitoring, and criteria to step up); otherwise HDU / PICU.
SUPPORT CPAP / BiPAP (NIV)	Device-set flow set FiO ₂	Non-invasive support for rising work of breathing, recurrent apnea, or hypoxemia despite O ₂ . PICU-directed.

📖 READING THE TABLE

- **LOW** low-flow, **VARIABLE** FiO₂ · **HIGH O₂** / **FIXED** high or **CONTROLLED** FiO₂ · **SUPPORT** also provides **PRESSURE / WASHOUT** → escalation.
- **TARGET SPO₂**: give O₂ for SpO₂ < 90% (consider < 92% in young infants, prematurity, or cardiac / lung disease); titrate to target and wean.
- **INFANTS**: if prongs/mask are not tolerated use **BLOW-BY**; a **HEAD BOX / HOOD** (5–15 L/min) gives up to ~80–90% FiO₂. Neonatal resuscitation: T-piece or self-inflating bag **WITH RESERVOIR**.
- Low-flow FiO₂ figures are estimates — the faster the child breathes, the lower the true delivered FiO₂.

READING THE PULSE OXIMETER – PRACTICAL NOTES

📌 GET A RELIABLE NUMBER

- **Trust it only with a good trace.** Confirm a clean plethysmograph **waveform** and that the oximeter's **pulse rate matches** the palpated / ECG rate — a damped or absent trace means the number is unreliable.
- **Weak signal = poor perfusion.** Cold, shock, vasoconstriction or hypotension drop the signal (under-reads or fails) — warm the hand, try another site (toe, earlobe), check the perfusion index if shown.
- **Motion and bright / ambient light** cause erratic or false readings — settle the limb, shield the probe, use motion-tolerant sensors.
- **Nail polish, henna, dirt** — remove them or turn the probe sideways. In **darker skin** oximeters can **overestimate** true saturation (occult hypoxemia) — correlate with the clinical picture and a blood gas if in doubt.

⚠ WHEN THE NUMBER LIES – FALSELY REASSURING

- **Carbon monoxide poisoning:** a standard oximeter reads **carboxyhemoglobin as oxyhemoglobin**, so SpO₂ looks **normal / high despite real hypoxia**. Suspect it by history; confirm with **co-oximetry / ABG** and give **100% O₂ regardless of the SpO₂**.
- **Methemoglobinemia** pins SpO₂ around **~85%** whatever the true saturation (a “saturation gap” vs the ABG) — suspect it with cyanosis **unresponsive to O₂** (topical anesthetics, dapsone).
- **Severe anemia / blood loss:** SpO₂ measures **saturation, not oxygen content** — it can read normal while oxygen delivery is inadequate.

✦ SPO₂ IS NOT PAO₂ – AND IT LAGS

- On the dissociation curve, **SpO₂ 90% ≈ PaO₂ 60 mmHg**; **below 90%** a small SpO₂ fall means a **large PaO₂ drop** — act quickly. The curve is **flat near the top**, so “100%” hides the reserve and **cannot detect hyperoxia** (important in preterm / neonates).
- SpO₂ **lags** real change by seconds (longer if poorly perfused) — a falling number can already be a **late** sign.
- **Neonates — pre- vs post-ductal:** right hand = pre-ductal, foot = post-ductal; a difference **> 3%** (or lower post-ductal) suggests a right-to-left shunt / **critical CHD** (CCHD screening).

OXYGEN CYLINDER – CONTENT & HOW LONG IT LASTS

Step	Equation
Usable duration (quick · psi)	$(\text{gauge psi} - 200) \times \text{cylinder factor} \div \text{flow (L/min)}$
Usable content (metric)	$\text{capacity (L)} \times (\text{gauge bar} - 14) \div \text{full pressure (bar)}$
Duration (metric)	$\text{usable content (L)} \div \text{flow (L/min)}$

⊙ WHAT THE TERMS MEAN

- **PSI** = pounds per square inch, a unit of gas pressure (what the cylinder gauge reads); **1 BAR ≈ 14.5 PSI**.
- **CYLINDER FACTOR** = liters of oxygen released per 1 psi of pressure (= the cylinder's full capacity ÷ its full pressure). Multiply the **USABLE** pressure (gauge – 200 psi safe residual) by this factor to get the liters available.

⊙ SAFE RESIDUAL & CYLINDER DATA

- **SAFE RESIDUAL ≈ 200 PSI (~14 BAR)** — a cylinder is treated as **EMPTY** at this pressure; **SUBTRACT IT FROM THE GAUGE** before calculating, and do not run lower.
- **CONTENT WHEN FULL (BOC):** CD **460 L** (230 bar) · D **340 L** (137 bar) · E **680 L** (137 bar) · F **1360 L** (137 bar). US E ≈ 625–680 L at ~2000 psi. 1 bar ≈ 14.5 psi. **CHECK THE LABEL – CAPACITY/PRESSURE VARY BY SUPPLIER.**
- **CYLINDER FACTORS (L/PSI):** D 0.16 · E 0.28 · M 1.56 · G 2.41 · H/K 3.14.

✦ WORKED EXAMPLES

- **Imperial:** E cylinder, gauge **1800 psi**, flow **6 L/min** → $(1800 - 200) \times 0.28 \div 6 \approx 75 \text{ min}$.
- **Metric:** E cylinder, gauge **100 bar**, flow **4 L/min** → $680 \times ((100 - 14) \div 137) \approx 427 \text{ L} \rightarrow \div 4 \approx 107 \text{ min}$.
- **High flow drains fast:** at 30–60 L/min a full E cylinder lasts only **~10–20 min** — use wall O₂ or a large cylinder (and an air blender) for transport.

⚠ SAFETY MARGIN

Do not use a cylinder below the **safe residual (~200 psi / ~14 bar)** — treat it as empty. Change or refill at about **~500 psi / ~35 bar** to keep a working reserve, and for transport carry **≥ 2×** the calculated requirement (account for device / blender flush).

📄 BEST CLINICAL RESOURCES (OPEN-ACCESS)

- **OPEN CRITICAL CARE – OXYGEN DELIVERY DEVICES** (evidence-based, WHO-aligned):

opencriticalcare.org



- **WHO – OXYGEN THERAPY FOR CHILDREN** (2016 manual): [who.int](https://www.who.int/publications-detail/who-oxygen-therapy-for-children)



Normal Vital Signs by Age

Reference ranges (awake, at rest).

Age	Heart rate /min	Respiratory rate /min	Systolic BP mmHg
Newborn	100–180	40–60	60–90
Infant < 1 yr	100–160	30–53	72–104
1–2 yr	90–150	22–37	86–106
3–5 yr	80–140	20–28	89–112
6–11 yr	70–120	18–25	97–120
12+ yr	60–100	12–20	110–131

- ◆ **BLOOD-PRESSURE PERCENTILES** Age-, sex-, and height-based BP centiles (elevated BP ≥ 90th; hypertension ≥ 95th) — [AAP 2017 BP tables](https://www.aap.org/clinical-resources/blood-pressure-percentiles)



Scales, Equations & Synonyms

The scores, formulas, and drug names you reach for at the bedside.

Glasgow Coma Scale — child values in brackets (best 15, worst 3)

Pts	Eye	Verbal (<2 y)	Motor (infant)
6	—	—	Obeys (spontaneous movement)
5	—	Oriented (coos, babbles)	Localizes (withdraws to touch)
4	Spontaneous	Confused (irritable cry)	Withdraws to pain
3	To voice	Wrong words (cries to pain)	Abnormal flexion
2	To pain	Sounds only (moans)	Extension
1	None	None	None

APGAR — score at 1 and 5 minutes (≤3 low, 4–6 moderate, 7–10 reassuring)

Sign	0	1	2
Appearance	blue / pale	body pink, limbs blue	all pink
Pulse	absent	< 100	≥ 100
Grimace	none	grimace	cry / cough
Activity (tone)	limp	some flexion	active
Respiration	absent	slow, irregular	strong cry

Dehydration — severe means shock; give 20 mL/kg

Sign	Mild ~3–5%	Moderate ~6–9%	Severe ≥10%
General	alert, thirsty	restless, irritable	lethargic, floppy
Eyes / mucosa	normal, moist	sunken, dry	deeply sunken, parched
Skin pinch	instant	< 2 s	> 2 s
Cap refill / pulse	normal	prolonged	> 3 s, weak, cool
Urine	normal	reduced	minimal or none

Quick equations

For	Formula
Maintenance fluid	4·2·1: 4 mL/kg/h first 10 kg + 2 next 10 + 1 each kg over 20 (Holliday–Segar)
Fluid deficit (mL)	% dehydration × weight (kg) × 10

Corrected Na (high glucose)	add 2.4 mmol/L per 5.6 mmol/L (100 mg/dL) glucose above 5.6 mmol/L (Hillier; the older 1.6 factor underestimates at high glucose)
Calcium	Measure ionized calcium — albumin-corrected calcium is unreliable (misses hypocalcemia in critical illness and kidney disease)
Anion gap	$\text{Na} - (\text{Cl} + \text{HCO}_3)$; normal 8–12 mmol/L
Serum osmolality	$2 \times \text{Na} + \text{glucose} + \text{urea}$ (mmol/L). Osmolar gap = measured – calculated osmolality; > 10 suggests an unmeasured osmole (methanol, ethylene glycol, ethanol, mannitol).
Expected pCO ₂ (met. acidosis)	Winter: $1.5 \times \text{HCO}_3 + 8 \pm 2$ (mmHg) — the expected respiratory compensation for a metabolic acidosis; measured PaCO ₂ above the range = added respiratory acidosis, below = added respiratory alkalosis.
QTc (Bazett)	$\text{QT} \div \sqrt{\text{RR}}$ (s); prolonged > 0.46 s
eGFR (Schwartz)	$36.5 \times \text{height (cm)} \div \text{creatinine } (\mu\text{mol/L})$ — i.e. $0.413 \times \text{height} \div \text{creatinine (mg/dL)}$ ⁶³³
Glucose infusion rate	$\text{mg/kg/min} = \text{dextrose\%} \times \text{rate (mL/h)} \div (6 \times \text{weight kg})$

Names & synonyms

Generic (US)	Also known as
Epinephrine	adrenaline
Norepinephrine	noradrenaline
Albuterol	salbutamol
Acetaminophen	paracetamol
Furosemide	frusemide
Lidocaine	lignocaine
Acyclovir	aciclovir
Amoxicillin–clavulanate	co-amoxiclav
Valproic acid	sodium valproate
Regular insulin	soluble insulin
Normal saline (0.9% NaCl)	isotonic saline
Lactated Ringer's	Hartmann's, compound sodium lactate
Succinylcholine	suxamethonium

Procedural Sedation, RSI & Analgesia

Quick weight-based doses — prepare airway, suction, and monitoring first.

◆ NEONATAL INTUBATION – PREMEDICATE?

- **Emergency** (delivery room, life-threatening airway) → intubate now; no premedication.⁶³⁴
- **All other intubations** → premedicate every time, IV, in this order:⁶³⁴
 1. **Atropine** 20 mcg/kg — prevents severe bradycardia^{634,635}
 2. **Fentanyl**, slow IV: < 28 wk 1–2 mcg/kg · 28–32 wk 2–3 mcg/kg · > 32 wk 3–4 mcg/kg⁶³⁴
 3. **Succinylcholine** 2 mg/kg — not in hyperkalemia, malignant-hyperthermia risk or neuromuscular disease^{634,636}
- **Do not** use an opioid alone (morphine or remifentanyl) as the only premedication.⁶³⁴
- **Alternative** if blood pressure is normal: **propofol** — ≥ 28 wk 2 mg/kg (repeat 1 mg/kg if needed); < 28 wk 1 mg/kg steps, max 2 mg/kg.⁶³⁴

ANALGESIA

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Acetaminophen	15 mg/kg/dose (max 1 g/dose)	PO/PR/IV; mild–moderate pain
Ibuprofen	10 mg/kg/dose (max 400 mg/dose)	PO; mild–moderate pain (avoid in dehydration, renal impairment, GI bleeding)
Morphine	0.05–0.1 mg/kg	IV, titrate; for moderate–severe pain
Fentanyl	1–2 mcg/kg IV; 1.5 mcg/kg intranasal	Rapid onset; useful when no IV access

PROCEDURAL SEDATION

Procedural sedation and RSI by credentialed clinicians only — airway-rescue capability, full monitoring, and an institutional sedation policy.

Drug	Dose	Route & notes
Ketamine	1–2 mg/kg IV; 4–5 mg/kg IM	Dissociative; usually preserves airway reflexes/respiratory drive — but airway obstruction, laryngospasm, and apnea can still occur
Midazolam	0.05–0.1 mg/kg IV; 0.3–0.5 mg/kg buccal/intranasal	Anxiolysis; respiratory depression with opioids

RAPID SEQUENCE INTUBATION

Step	Dose	Route & notes
Induction	Ketamine 1–2 mg/kg Propofol 2–3 mg/kg Etomidate 0.3 mg/kg (avoid in septic shock) ¹² Midazolam 0.1–0.3 mg/kg ± Fentanyl 1–2 mcg/kg (pre-treatment)	Choose by hemodynamics
Paralytic	Rocuronium 1–1.2 mg/kg Succinylcholine 1–2 mg/kg	IV
Atropine (pre-treatment)	0.02 mg/kg	IV in young infants if bradycardia risk

⚠ BEFORE ANY SEDATION/RSI

- Have oxygen, suction, bag-mask, the right tube size [(age ÷ 4) + 4 uncuffed], monitoring, and a reversal plan ready.
- See Weight & Airway Sizing.

Emergency Drug Doses MINUTES PALS 2025

Resuscitation doses by rule and by weight — use measured weight or a length-based tape; cross-check weight, concentration and the local chart before every dose.

Drug · indication	Rule (per kg · max)	Notes
Epinephrine — cardiac arrest	0.01 mg/kg IV/IO = 0.1 mL/kg of 0.1 mg/mL (max 1 mg)	Repeat every 3–5 min. Endotracheal: 0.1 mg/kg (0.1 mL/kg of 1 mg/mL). ³
Epinephrine — anaphylaxis	0.01 mg/kg IM = 0.01 mL/kg of 1 mg/mL (max 0.5 mg)	Anterolateral thigh; repeat every 5–15 min. ⁴⁰⁵
Amiodarone — VF / pulseless VT	5 mg/kg IV/IO bolus (max 300 mg)	May repeat up to twice. Perfusing tachycardia: give over 20–60 min. ³
Adenosine — SVT, 1st dose	0.1 mg/kg rapid push (max 6 mg)	Immediate saline flush; use the line closest to the heart. ³
Adenosine — SVT, 2nd dose	0.2 mg/kg rapid push (max 12 mg)	If the first dose fails. ³
Atropine — bradycardia	0.02 mg/kg IV/IO (min 0.1 mg, max 0.5 mg)	May repeat once. ³
Calcium gluconate 10% — hyperkalemia, Ca-channel-blocker toxicity, hypocalcemia	50 mg/kg = 0.5 mL/kg slow IV/IO (max 2 g = 20 mL) ¹⁸⁰	Calcium chloride 10% 20 mg/kg (0.2 mL/kg) only via a central line — sclerosing, high extravasation risk. ³

Drug · indication	Rule (per kg · max)	Notes
Dextrose 10% — hypoglycemia	2 mL/kg (0.2 g/kg) slow IV	Recheck glucose in 15 min; see Hypoglycemia . ¹⁷⁹
Magnesium sulfate — torsades, severe asthma	25–50 mg/kg IV/IO (max 2 g)	Torsades: rapid. Severe asthma (≥ 2 y): 40–50 mg/kg over 20 min. ^{3,411}
Naloxone — opioid toxicity	0.1 mg/kg IV/IM/IN (max 2 mg)	Titrate to breathing; re-dose (short half-life). ^{537,579}
Sodium bicarbonate 8.4%	1 mEq/kg = 1 mL/kg IV/IO	Tricyclic toxicity (QRS > 100 ms), ⁵³⁷ severe acidosis, hyperkalemia. ¹⁸⁰
Lidocaine — VF/pVT (alternative to amiodarone)	1 mg/kg IV/IO (max 100 mg)	Then infusion 20–50 mcg/kg/min. ³
Isotonic fluid bolus — shock	10–20 mL/kg	10 mL/kg in neonates, cardiac disease, DKA or severe malnutrition; reassess after each bolus. ^{12,182}
Defibrillation — VF/pVT	2 J/kg → 4 J/kg → ≥ 4 J/kg	Max 10 J/kg or the adult dose (≈ 200 J biphasic). ³
Synchronized cardioversion — unstable SVT/VT	0.5–1 J/kg → 2 J/kg	Sedate if conscious and time permits. ³

DOSES BY WEIGHT — PICK THE COLUMN NEAREST THE WEIGHT

Drug · rule (per dose) · kg▶	5	10	20	30	50
Epinephrine (adrenaline) 0.01 mg/kg IV/IO — mg (mL of 0.1 mg/mL) ³	0.05 (0.5)	0.1 (1)	0.2 (2)	0.3 (3)	0.5 (5)
Amiodarone 5 mg/kg (arrest) — mg	25	50	100	150	250
Adenosine 0.1 mg/kg (1st, max 6) — mg	0.5	1	2	3	5
Atropine 0.02 mg/kg (0.1–0.5) — mg	0.1	0.2	0.4	0.5	0.5
Calcium gluconate 10% 0.5 mL/kg (max 20) — mL	2.5	5	10	15	20
Dextrose 10% 2 mL/kg — mL	10	20	40	60	100
Fluid bolus 20 mL/kg (10 if neonate/cardiac/DKA) — mL	100	200	400	600	1000
Defibrillation — 1st shock 2 J/kg — J	10	20	40	60	100
Defibrillation — 2nd shock 4 J/kg (max 200) — J	20	40	80	120	200

Numbers are per single dose, already capped. Pick the nearest column and adjust to the child's actual weight.

Concentrations & pitfalls

- Epinephrine 0.1 mg/mL (old 1:10 000) is for IV/IO; 1 mg/mL (old 1:1000) is for IM and endotracheal use — confirm the ampoule before every dose.⁶³⁷
- Amiodarone is 150 mg/3 mL.
- Use a length-based (Broselow) tape when weight is unknown.

⚠ ALWAYS CROSS-CHECK

- Confirm weight, ampoule concentration, and the local resuscitation chart before every dose.

Anticoagulation – VTE Prophylaxis & Treatment

ASSESS

ASH/ISTH 2024 • 2026

Who to treat, for how long, who needs prophylaxis — and enoxaparin doses with anti-Xa targets.

Regimen	Dose	Monitoring / notes
Enoxaparin — treatment, < 2 months	1.5 mg/kg/dose SC every 12 h	Anti-Xa target 0.5–1.0 IU/mL, drawn 4–6 h post-dose (after the 3rd–4th dose). Treatment anticoagulation is hematology-guided with anti-Xa monitoring; adjust for renal function, age, weight, and bleeding risk ^{42,50}
Enoxaparin — treatment, ≥ 2 months	1.0 mg/kg/dose SC every 12 h	Infants often need more: term up to 1.7, preterm up to 2 mg/kg/dose
Enoxaparin — prophylaxis, < 2 months	0.75 mg/kg/dose SC every 12 h	Anti-Xa 0.1–0.3 IU/mL if monitored
Enoxaparin — prophylaxis, ≥ 2 months	0.5 mg/kg/dose SC every 12 h	Routine anti-Xa not required

▴ TREAT – WHO

- **Anticoagulate:** symptomatic DVT or PE; cerebral sinovenous thrombosis (CSVT); neonatal renal vein thrombosis.⁶³⁸
- **Individualize:** DVT or PE found by chance on imaging — anticoagulation or none are both acceptable.⁶³⁸
- **No thrombolysis** for proximal DVT or for PE without hemodynamic compromise; thrombolysis, then anticoagulation, only for PE with hemodynamic compromise.⁶³⁸
- **Line-related clot:** remove the central line either immediately or after a few days of anticoagulation (both acceptable). No IVC filter.^{638,639}

▴ TREAT – HOW LONG

- **Provoked, risk factor resolved:** 6 weeks — continue to 3 months if the 6-week scan still shows an occlusive clot.^{638,640}
- **3 months** for PE, cancer-associated VTE, recurrent VTE, a persisting risk factor, major thrombophilia, or persistently positive antiphospholipid antibodies.⁶³⁸
- **Unprovoked:** 6–12 months, not indefinite.⁶³⁸

- **Agent:** rivaroxaban or dabigatran is suggested over LMWH or warfarin, started after ≥ 5 days of parenteral anticoagulation; not in preterm neonates, eGFR < 30 , significant liver disease or active bleeding. Hematology sets the dose. ⁶³⁸

▀ PROPHYLAXIS – WHO

- **Give:** TPN for more than 60 days (home TPN or intestinal failure; not neonates); antiphospholipid syndrome (secondary prevention). ⁶⁴¹
- **Either:** leukemia or lymphoblastic lymphoma, during asparaginase cycles only — favor prophylaxis if age ≥ 10 y, obesity, T-cell or high-risk disease, or a personal or family history of thrombosis. No antithrombin supplements. ⁶⁴¹
- **Not routinely:** general ward patients, critically ill children, trauma, noncardiac surgery, solid tumors, central lines, or positive antiphospholipid antibodies without a past clot. Consider case by case when several risk factors combine (adolescence, immobility, mechanical ventilation, a central line > 7 days, obesity, estrogen or the combined pill, thrombophilia, previous VTE, major surgery) and bleeding risk is low. ⁶⁴¹
- **Before starting:** weigh bleeding risk — do not start if it is high; reassess regularly; plan doses around lumbar puncture and spinal procedures. Continue only while the risk lasts (e.g., the asparaginase cycle, long-term TPN). ⁶⁴¹

Before starting

- Baseline complete blood count, renal function, and coagulation screen.
- Avoid with active bleeding, platelets $< 50 \times 10^9/L$, or within 24 h of major surgery or a neuraxial procedure (local practice).
- Reduce dose if creatinine clearance < 30 mL/min. ⁶⁴²

Reversal & alternatives

- Protamine partially reverses enoxaparin (1 mg per 1 mg enoxaparin given in the prior 8 h; 0.5 mg per 1 mg if > 8 h or a second dose is needed) — anti-Xa activity is only partly neutralized (maximum $\sim 60\%$). ⁶⁴²
- Use an IV unfractionated heparin infusion instead of enoxaparin when rapid reversal may be needed (high bleeding risk or an imminent procedure) or creatinine clearance is < 30 mL/min — half-life 0.5–2 h, cleared by the liver, neutralized by protamine (1 mg per 100 units; no more than 50 mg in 10 min). ^{46,642}

Maximum Local Anesthetic Doses ASSESS

Single-dose ceilings — count total mg/kg across all sites. Use lower limits in neonates/infants, liver disease, or low cardiac output; count the total across all injection sites and when agents are combined.

Agent	Max single dose	Notes
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Lidocaine 1% (plain)	4.5 mg/kg (max 300 mg) = 0.45 mL/kg of 1% (max 30 mL)	Onset fast; ~30–60 min duration. 1% = 10 mg/mL.
Lidocaine 1% + epinephrine	7 mg/kg (max 500 mg) = 0.7 mL/kg of 1% (max 50 mL)	Longer duration. Lidocaine ceilings (4.5 mg/kg, max 300 mg plain; 7 mg/kg, max 500 mg with epinephrine) are the US-label adult maximums applied per kg — adult-derived (the label sets pediatric doses by age and weight) ⁶⁴³ . Caution with epinephrine on end-arteries (digits, pinna, penis).
Neonates and young infants	Lower ceiling	Use a lower ceiling (local practice 3–4 mg/kg for a neonatal penile block — see Circumcision).

Toxicity (LAST)

- Perioral numbness, tinnitus, and agitation progress to seizures, then arrhythmia or arrest.
- Stop injection, secure airway and oxygen, treat seizures with a benzodiazepine, and give 20% lipid emulsion (see [Poisoning & Toxic Ingestion](#)).
- Dilute to the least concentrated effective solution, aspirate before injecting, and inject slowly in divided doses; reduce maximums in neonates.⁵⁷³

Vital signs – normal vs red zone by age

The escalation threshold, not just the normal range. Ranges: PALS/APLS.

Vital Signs — Normal vs Red Zone by Age

The number that should trigger escalation. Red-zone values are concern thresholds, not just “abnormal.”

Compensated pediatric shock is often normotensive — tachycardia + poor perfusion precede hypotension, which is a late, pre-arrest sign.

Age	Normal HR	HR red zone	Normal RR	RR red zone	Hypotension SBP
< 1 month	100–205	<100 or >205	30–60	>60	<60
1–12 months	100–190	<100 or >190	30–53	>60	<70
1–2 years	98–140	<90 or >140	22–37	>40	<70+(2×age)
2–5 years	80–120	<80 or >120	20–28	>34	<70+(2×age)
5–12 years	75–118	<60 or >120	18–30	>30	<70+(2×age)
> 12 years	60–100	<60 or >100	12–20	>20	<90

Hypotension (5th-centile SBP): 70 + (2 × age in years) for 1–10 y; < 90 mmHg for ≥ 10 y. Example — 4-year-old: < 78 mmHg.

Sepsis/shock red flags (any): capillary refill > 2–3 s or flash, mottled/cold or bounding pulses, altered mental status, lactate > 2 mmol/L, reduced urine output.

Ranges: PALS/AHA and APLS. Bradycardia and bradypnea in a sick child are ominous late signs — treat as pre-arrest.

Kuwait Childhood Immunization Schedule

REFERENCE

MOH Kuwait 2025

The routine schedule at a glance — and the ages a missed dose should prompt catch-up.⁶⁴⁴

Age	Vaccine	Route
Pregnant mother	Tdap – one dose in this pregnancy, and every subsequent pregnancy	IM
Within 24 h of birth	Hepatitis B (HBV) – 1st dose	IM
End of 2 months	Hexa (1st) • Pneumococcal (1st) • Rotavirus (1st)	IM • IM • Oral
End of 3 months	BCG	ID
End of 4 months	Hexa (2nd) • Pneumococcal (2nd) • Rotavirus (2nd)	IM • IM • Oral
End of 6 months	Hexa (3rd) • Pneumococcal (3rd) • Rotavirus (3rd)*	IM • IM • Oral
End of 12 months	OPV (1st) • MMR (1st) • Varicella (1st) • Meningococcal conjugate (ACWY)	Oral • SC • SC • IM
At 18 months	OPV (2nd) • Hexa booster • Pneumococcal booster	Oral • IM • IM
End of 2 years	MMRV (1st)	SC
End of 3.5 years	DTaP booster	IM
4–6 years (preschool)	Check immunization status before school admission	—
10–12 years (school)	Tdap booster	IM
16–18 years (school)	Tdap booster	IM

◆ VACCINE KEY

- **HEXA** = diphtheria, tetanus, acellular pertussis, hepatitis B, inactivated poliovirus (IPV) & Hib
- **MMRV** = measles, mumps, rubella, varicella
- **DTaP/TDaP** = diphtheria, tetanus, acellular pertussis
- **OPV** = oral polio
- * rotavirus is 2 or 3 doses according to the vaccine type used.

✦ WHAT CHANGED IN THE 2025 SCHEDULE

- **Hexa** replaces the pentavalent (adds IPV)
- **MMRV** at 2 years replaces the old separate 2nd MMR + varicella
- **DTaP** replaces DPT at 3.5 years
- **Tdap** replaces Td at 10–12 and 16–18 years and is now given in **every pregnancy**
- the old OPV booster at 3.5 years and the girls-only MMR booster at 10–12 years were dropped.

✦ USE EVERY EMERGENCY VISIT AS A CATCH-UP TRIGGER

- An unwell or injured child is a chance to check the card.
- A missed **MMR/MMRV** in an outbreak, an incomplete primary series in a young infant with a fever, or no **tetanus-containing** cover before a dirty wound all change management on the spot.

Kuwait Newborn Screening Panel

REFERENCE

Kuwait program · since Oct 2014

What the heel-prick looks for, how the result reaches you — and why a sick newborn is treated before it does.

THE NATIONAL DRIED-BLOOD-SPOT PANEL — 22 DISORDERS

Group	Disorders screened	Marker · what a positive means for you
Amino acid disorders (6)	Phenylketonuria · maple syrup urine disease · classical homocystinuria · citrullinemia (types I and II) · tyrosinemia type I · argininosuccinic aciduria	Tandem mass spectrometry amino acids; MSUD, citrullinemia and argininosuccinic aciduria can present as a neonatal encephalopathy before the result — see Metabolic Crisis ⁶⁴⁵
Organic acid disorders (8)	Propionic acidemia · methylmalonic acidemia · isovaleric acidemia · glutaric acidemia type I · 3-methylcrotonyl-CoA carboxylase deficiency · β-ketothiolase deficiency · multiple (holo)carboxylase deficiency · HMG-CoA lyase deficiency	Acylcarnitines; acidosis, hyperammonemia and lethargy in the first week — treat on suspicion ⁶⁴⁵
Fatty acid oxidation disorders (4)	MCAD deficiency · VLCAD deficiency · LCHAD deficiency · trifunctional protein deficiency	Acylcarnitines (C8; C14:1 for VLCAD). VLCAD is the commonest in Kuwait (1 in 8,290 births; 1 in 5,405 Kuwaiti newborns; founder variant c.65C>A) — hypoketotic hypoglycemia, cardiomyopathy, arrhythmia; never let these infants fast ⁶⁴⁶

Group	Disorders screened	Marker · what a positive means for you
Other metabolic (2)	Classical galactosemia · biotinidase deficiency	Galactosemia: stop lactose feeds at once if suspected (<i>E. coli</i> sepsis, jaundice, cataract) ⁶⁴⁵
Endocrine (2)	Congenital hypothyroidism · congenital adrenal hyperplasia	TSH; 17-hydroxyprogesterone. Salt-wasting CAH collapses at 1–3 weeks — see Adrenal Crisis ⁶⁴⁵

- **Not in the panel:** hemoglobinopathies, G6PD deficiency, cystic fibrosis, SCID and lysosomal disorders — do not assume a "normal screen" covers them.⁶⁴⁵

▀ HOW THE PROGRAM RUNS

- **Sample:** dried blood spot 24–72 h after birth (ideally 48–72 h, after at least 2–3 feeds), accepted up to 1 month; a sample taken before 24 h is repeated within 7 days; **preterm infants give three samples** (72 h, 2 weeks, 1 month).^{645,646}
- **Laboratory:** every sample — public and private hospitals — goes to the Newborn Screening Laboratory, Kuwait Medical Genetics Center (coverage 100 % since 2019); results are available at a median of about 4 days of age.^{645,646}
- **Positive screen:** the hospital's newborn screening office recalls the infant for a confirmatory sample (second blood spot for acylcarnitines/amino acids, urine organic acids at the Al-Sabah biochemistry laboratory); a confirmed result goes to the metabolic team. A recall that is not completed is a missed diagnosis — one VLCAD infant presented at 3 months in cardiogenic shock after a lost follow-up.⁶⁴⁶

⚠ IN THE EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT

- A pending or normal screen never excludes disease: a newborn with poor feeding, vomiting, lethargy, hypoglycemia, acidosis, hyperammonemia, seizures or cardiomyopathy is a **metabolic emergency now** — stop feeds/protein, give 10 % dextrose, send glucose, gas, ammonia, lactate and the newborn-screening sample if not yet taken, and call the metabolic team ([Metabolic Crisis](#), [Neonatal Hypoglycemia](#)).
- A phone call about a positive screen for MSUD, an organic acidemia, a fatty acid oxidation disorder, galactosemia or CAH means same-day assessment, not a clinic appointment.

Think Here — Consanguinity & Gulf-Prevalent Conditions REFERENCE

Gulf pre-test probability

The same presentation carries a different differential in Kuwait — recessive disease is not rare here.

▀ WHY THE BASELINE DIFFERS

- Consanguineous marriage is common in Kuwait — **54%** of marriages in a 1983 national sample, mostly first cousins; 23–42% (first and second cousins) by governorate in 1999.^{647,648} Homozygosity sharply raises the pre-test probability of **autosomal-recessive**

✦ **RAISE THESE ON THE DIFFERENTIAL EARLIER THAN THE TEXTBOOK WOULD**

- **Inborn errors of metabolism** in the encephalopathic / acidotic / hypoglycemic neonate or the child who decompensates with fasting or intercurrent illness — check gas, glucose, ammonia, lactate and start **IV dextrose** early.^{193,194,646} **Hemoglobinopathies** (sickle cell, β -thalassemia) and **G6PD deficiency** in the pale, jaundiced, or acutely hemolyzing child.^{651,652,653}
- A **recessive syndrome** when a sick infant has an affected sibling or known parental consanguinity.⁶⁴⁹

High-Alert Drugs & Fluid Safety EVERY SHIFT ISMP 2024 • AAP 2018

The commonest pediatric harm is not the missed diagnosis — it's the decimal point.

▲ HIGH-ALERT DRUGS – WHERE A DECIMAL KILLS

- **Insulin** (units, U-100 vs U-500) · **opioids** (mcg vs mg) · **concentrated KCl / K-phosphate** (never IV push) · **heparin / LMWH** (1,000 vs 10,000 units/mL) · **chemotherapy** (intrathecal vincristine = fatal) · **digoxin / milrinone** · **magnesium sulfate** (mg vs mmol vs mEq) · **hypertonic saline / dextrose** · **neuromuscular blockers** · **oral methotrexate** (weekly, not daily).³⁶
- **Epinephrine concentration: 1 mg/mL** (old 1:1,000, IM) vs **0.1 mg/mL** (old 1:10,000, IV)⁶⁵⁴ — the classic 10-fold pediatric error.^{637,655} State the concentration, never the ratio.^{637,656}

▲ THE THREE ERROR MODES TO DOUBLE-CHECK

- **10-fold / decimal errors**^{656,657}
- **mg vs mL vs microgram vs unit** confusion⁶⁵⁶
- **concentration mix-ups.**^{637,658}
- For any high-alert drug: independent double-check of dose, concentration and pump rate.^{36,658,659}

▲ SODIUM – CORRECT WITHIN THE SAFE RAILS

- **Hyponatremia:** raise Na ≤ 8 mmol/L per 24 h (a conservative expert limit; NICE pediatric ceiling 12 mmol/L per 24 h)^{181,182} to avoid **osmotic demyelination.**^{181,660} **Acute symptomatic (seizing):** 3% saline **2 mL/kg (max 100 mL)** IV over 10 min, repeated once or twice until symptoms improve; each bolus raises Na by about 2 mmol/L.^{181,182} Full protocol: [Acute Electrolyte Emergencies.](#)
- **Hypernatremia:** lower Na ≤ 10 –**12 mmol/L per 24 h** (≈ 0.5 mmol/L/h)^{182,183} to avoid **cerebral edema** (pediatric correction-rate evidence is evolving).⁶⁶¹

FLUIDS & POTASSIUM

- **Maintenance fluids (AAP 2018):** for children **28 days–18 years**, use **isotonic** fluid (0.9% saline or a balanced solution) with KCl and dextrose — hypotonic maintenance caused iatrogenic hyponatremia.⁶⁶² Volume still by Holliday-Segar.¹⁸²
- **IV potassium:** peripheral $\leq 40 \text{ mmol/L}$ ^{131,663} (40–60 mmol/L only where local protocol allows); ward rate $\leq 0.5 \text{ mmol/kg/h}$ ¹³¹ (max 10 mmol/h).⁶⁶³; faster rates only with **continuous ECG**⁶⁶³ — PICU rates up to **1 mmol/kg/h** are local practice (not guideline-stated). Never IV push: direct injection of the concentrate can be instantly fatal.⁶⁶³ Confirm concentration/rate ceilings against local protocol.

✦ EXTRAVASATION — STOP, ASPIRATE, AND KNOW THE TWO ANTIDOTES

- Vesicants: calcium, concentrated potassium, **vasopressors**, hypertonic dextrose/saline, TPN, chemotherapy.^{184,664,665,666}
- Immediately **stop the infusion, aspirate, elevate**.⁶⁶⁴
- Antidotes: **hyaluronidase** (most hyperosmolar/calcium/TPN infiltrations)^{664,665} and **phentolamine** (vasopressor extravasation, e.g. norepinephrine/dopamine).^{665,667,668}

Must-Avoid Drugs — Conditions & Serious Interactions EVERY SHIFT

FDA • EMA • SOCIETY GUIDELINES

The diagnosis on the chart decides what you must not prescribe — check this list before the first dose.

⚠ HOW TO READ THIS CARD

- **Not exhaustive.** This card covers the conditions, ages and drug combinations that most often cause serious harm in children, but no list can be complete — read around each patient's condition and check every new drug against its current product information and an interaction checker, especially in rare diseases or polypharmacy.
-  label contraindication or boxed warning ·  guideline or label "avoid" / "not recommended" / Class III (Harm) ·  caution or monitor.
- Rows are alphabetical; within a row drugs are listed from the most to the least frequently used in pediatric practice. Every row carries its primary source (regulator label, society guideline or GeneReviews).
- A listed drug may still be given when it is the only effective treatment — the decision belongs to the treating consultant, documented in the notes.

Three lists: A — by the child's condition · B — by the child's age · C — drug combinations

A Avoid because of the child's condition

Find the diagnosis (alphabetical) — 28 conditions

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Acute hepatic porphyria (AIP, VP, HCP) — rare in children	⚠ Metoclopramide · co-trimoxazole and other sulfonamides · phenytoin · phenobarbital and other barbiturates · valproate · rifampicin · progestins Avoid fasting — IV dextrose, including before surgery	Why: can precipitate an acute attack. Use instead: opioids, benzodiazepines, phenothiazines, levetiracetam, gabapentin, lamotrigine and vigabatrin are considered safe; check a porphyria drug database (NAPOS / APF) before any new drug. ^{669,670,671}
Acute kidney injury · dehydration/hypovolemia · CKD	⚠ NSAIDs — ibuprofen · diclofenac · ketorolac (⊖ with volume depletion or advanced renal impairment) Highest risk when also on diuretics and ACE inhibitors/ARBs	Why: NSAID-induced AKI occurs even at correct doses; children < 5 y more often need dialysis or PICU. Use instead: correct the volume deficit first. ^{376,672,673,674,675}
Adrenal insufficiency (CAH, hypopituitarism, chronic steroids)	Never omit stress-dose hydrocortisone — crisis: 50 mg/m² IV, then 50–100 mg/m²/24 h; fever > 38.5 °C, gastroenteritis, surgery, trauma = increase the dose Never stop chronic steroids abruptly ⚠ Etomidate — use with caution (see Why)	Why: adrenal crisis. A single dose of etomidate blocks cortisol production (11β-hydroxylase) for up to 48 h in critically ill patients and can trigger a crisis in a child who cannot raise cortisol. Use instead: another induction agent; if etomidate must be used, give stress-dose hydrocortisone and discuss with endocrinology. ^{176,177,676,677,678}
Asthma / history of bronchospasm	⊖ Propranolol (tablets; Hemangeol) · ⊖ timolol eye drops · ⚠ metoprolol, atenolol (β1-selective) only with caution ⊖ Ibuprofen and other NSAIDs only in a child who has reacted to an NSAID before Hemangioma propranolol: give with/after feeds; skip the dose if not eating or vomiting (hypoglycemia); interrupt for lower-respiratory infection with wheeze	Why: β-blockers cause bronchospasm and mask hypoglycemia. NSAID-induced bronchospasm is uncommon in children (about 2% of school-age children with asthma on challenge), and as-needed ibuprofen did not increase attacks in young children with mild persistent asthma. Use instead: acetaminophen at standard doses for a child who has reacted to an NSAID; if a β-blocker is essential, a β1-selective one at the lowest dose, with a bronchodilator at hand. ^{674,679,680,681,682,683,684,685,686,687}

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Burns · major trauma · denervation (spinal cord injury, spinal muscular atrophy, Guillain-Barré) · upper-motor-neuron injury	⊖ Succinylcholine after the acute phase of injury — risk rises over time, peaks day 7–10 △ Great caution in chronic abdominal infection, subarachnoid hemorrhage, neurodegenerative disease	Why: hyperkalemic cardiac arrest. Use instead: rocuronium (sugammadex available).⁶³⁶
Chickenpox (varicella)	△ Ibuprofen and other NSAIDs ⊖ Aspirin and other salicylates, including bismuth subsalicylate	Why: ibuprofen — in observational studies, children who took NSAIDs during chickenpox had more severe group A streptococcal skin and soft-tissue infection, including necrotizing fasciitis; this does not prove the NSAID caused it, but the UK product information advises avoiding ibuprofen during chickenpox. Aspirin — Reye syndrome (see Age-based rules). Use instead: acetaminophen for fever or pain.^{688,689,690,691}
Cockayne syndrome	⊖ Metronidazole — FDA contraindication	Why: acute, irreversible liver failure with very rapid onset — 8 of about 100 patients in a cohort, 3 deaths, 6–11 days after the first dose. Use instead: an antibiotic from another class — the contraindication also covers tinidazole and other nitroimidazoles, including topical and vaginal forms.^{692,693,694}
Dravet syndrome (SCN1A)	Maintenance: △ carbamazepine · ⊖ lamotrigine (contraindicated) · △ oxcarbazepine · △ phenytoin · △ vigabatrin, rufinamide (review level)	Why: sodium-channel blockers typically make seizures worse. Use instead: in status epilepticus, a benzodiazepine → IV valproate or levetiracetam → IV phenytoin/fosphenytoin may be considered (not contraindicated — strong consensus).^{695,696}
Duchenne/Becker muscular dystrophy and other myopathies	⊖ Succinylcholine — boxed warning: hyperkalemic rhabdomyolysis → ventricular dysrhythmia, cardiac arrest, death (most often undiagnosed Duchenne, boys ≤ 8 y) △ Volatile (inhalational) anesthetics	Why: in children succinylcholine is reserved for emergency intubation. Use instead: rocuronium, with sugammadex for reversal.^{322,636,697}

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Fatty acid oxidation disorders (MCAD; VLCAD, LCHAD/TFP, CPT II)	Never fast — when feeds stop give $\geq 10\%$ dextrose at $\geq 1.5 \times$ maintenance (10–12 mg/kg/min glucose) Long-chain defects: $\triangle$ propofol · $\triangle$ etomidate (lipid load) · high long-chain fat · dehydration · myocardial irritation (e.g., catheterization) MCAD: $\triangle$ aspirin · MCT-based formula/coconut oil	Why: fasting or illness → hypoglycemia, coma and death; long-chain defects also → rhabdomyolysis, cardiomyopathy and arrhythmias. Use instead: $\geq 10\%$ IV dextrose with electrolytes whenever feeds stop, and an anesthetic plan agreed in advance with the metabolic center. Note: MCT oil is <i>treatment</i> in long-chain defects but must be avoided in MCAD. Valproate: case reports only. ^{698,699,700}
G6PD deficiency	$\triangle$ Co-trimoxazole · $\triangle$ nitrofurantoin (dose-related hemolysis — avoid when an alternative exists) · $\ominus$ rasburicase (boxed warning) · $\ominus$ primaquine in severe deficiency (test G6PD first) · $\triangle$ dapsone · $\ominus$ methylene blue (also ineffective) · $\ominus$ tafenoquine Non-drug: fava beans, naphthalene (mothballs)	Why: acute hemolysis $\pm$ methemoglobinemia. Use instead: for tumor lysis, allopurinol instead of rasburicase (CPIC, strong). ^{21, 253,701,702,703,704,705,706,707}
Hemophilia and other bleeding disorders	$\triangle$ Ibuprofen, diclofenac, aspirin and other NSAIDs (selective COX-2 inhibitors excepted) $\triangle$ No intramuscular analgesia Vaccines preferably subcutaneous; if IM is unavoidable: factor dose, 25–27 G needle, ice 5 min before, firm pressure ≥ 10 min	Why: platelet inhibition; intramuscular injection → muscle hematoma. Use instead: acetaminophen or opioids for pain. Note: ITP: ASH 2019 makes no NSAID/IM statement — expert practice. ²⁵⁹
Hereditary angioedema (C1-inhibitor deficiency)	$\ominus$ ACE inhibitors — captopril, enalapril, lisinopril (label contraindication; guideline: strictly avoid) $\triangle$ Estrogen-containing contraceptives / HRT	Why: ACE inhibitors and estrogens can trigger attacks or make them more frequent (ACE normally breaks down bradykinin, which causes the swelling). Use instead: progestin-only pills for contraception; treat an attack with IV C1-inhibitor, icatibant or ecallantide. Note: attacks do not respond to antihistamines, corticosteroids or epinephrine. ^{466,708,709}

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Hereditary fructose intolerance · classical galactosemia	HFI: sucrose · fructose · sorbitol · sucralose · polysorbate — enteral <i>or</i> parenteral — can be fatal:  IV sorbitol/fructose-containing medicines (EMA: "must not receive"); check oral syrups, enemas, some immunoglobulin solutions Galactosemia: lactose and galactose	Why: hypoglycemia, lactic acidosis and liver failure (HFI). Use instead: galactosemia — soy, casein-hydrolysate or elemental formula from the time it is suspected. ^{710,711,712}
Hypertrophic cardiomyopathy — obstructive	⚠ Verapamil — Class 3: Harm with rest dyspnea, hypotension, resting gradient > 100 mmHg, or any infant < 6 weeks Stop/avoid: ACE inhibitors, ARBs, amlodipine/nifedipine (dihydropyridines), digoxin (Class 2b)	Why: these drugs worsen dynamic outflow obstruction. Use instead: for hypotension unresponsive to fluid, IV phenylephrine (vasoconstrictor without inotropy) — not inotropes (Class 1). ^{713,714}
Infant botulism	⚠ Aminoglycosides (gentamicin, amikacin) — respiratory failure, deaths ⚠ Clindamycin, magnesium, calcium, tetracycline only after careful consideration with monitoring	Why: aminoglycosides potentiate the paralysis; antibiotics do not treat the botulism itself. Use instead: BabyBIG (human botulism immune globulin), started on clinical suspicion. ^{715,716,717,718}

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Inherited arrhythmia syndromes — long QT syndrome · Brugada syndrome · catecholaminergic polymorphic ventricular tachycardia (CPVT)	Long QT syndrome (Class I): △ QT-prolonging drugs — ondansetron · azithromycin, clarithromycin, erythromycin · ciprofloxacin, levofloxacin · domperidone · fluconazole · haloperidol, droperidol · citalopram, escitalopram · methadone (CredibleMeds known-risk list); correct K⁺/Mg²⁺ losses in vomiting/diarrhea Brugada syndrome (Class I): △ propofol · tricyclic antidepressants · oxcarbazepine · lithium · flecainide, propafenone · procainamide (brugadadrugs.org); treat fever promptly with antipyretics CPVT: △ digoxin · limit/avoid competitive sports and strenuous exercise (Class I)	Why: long QT syndrome — torsades de pointes. Brugada syndrome — sodium-channel blockers and fever unmask the Brugada pattern and can trigger ventricular fibrillation. CPVT — adrenaline surges with exercise or emotion trigger polymorphic ventricular tachycardia; digoxin promotes the same arrhythmia mechanism. Use instead: a drug that is not on the CredibleMeds (long QT) or brugadadrugs.org (Brugada) list; if none is suitable, prescribe only with cardiology advice. ^{719,720,721,722,723}
Ketogenic diet (epilepsy)	△ Glucose-containing IV fluids — use 0.45–0.9 % saline or Ringer's lactate; carbohydrate only for hypoglycemia or excess ketosis Prefer tablets/sugar-free formulations; count carbohydrate in medicines △ Topiramate, zonisamide, acetazolamide (carbonic-anhydrase inhibitors): monitor bicarbonate and stones · △ propofol	Why: loss of ketosis → seizures; acidosis. Use instead: tablets rather than liquid or chewable medicines, choosing formulations without added carbohydrate. Note: check glucose and ketones often when unwell. The diet can be stopped abruptly in an emergency (preferably inpatient). ^{724,725}
Malignant hyperthermia susceptibility (RYR1/CACNA1S; central core disease, King–Denborough; family history)	⊖ Sevoflurane, isoflurane, desflurane, halothane (all volatile anesthetics) · ⊖ succinylcholine	Why: these are malignant hyperthermia triggers. Use instead: total intravenous anesthesia, with dantrolene immediately available. Note: do not combine dantrolene with calcium-channel blockers (life-threatening hyperkalemia). ^{636,726}

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Mitochondrial disease	△ Aminoglycosides (gentamicin, amikacin, tobramycin) with MT-RNR1 m.1555A>G, m.1494C>T or m.1095T>C — irreversible deafness — unless no safe alternative ➡ Valproate in POLG-related disease (boxed warning — fatal liver failure) and in children < 2 y clinically suspected of a mitochondrial disorder △ Linezolid: monitor lactate Never fast — give IV glucose	Why: aminoglycosides → permanent deafness in carriers of the listed MT-RNR1 variants; valproate → fatal liver failure in POLG disease. Use instead: generally safe by international consensus (De Vries 2020): metformin, propofol (including ≤ 48 h infusion), volatile agents, ketamine, levetiracetam, NSAIDs, steroids and ceftriaxone. ^{727,728,729,730}
Myasthenia gravis (including juvenile MG)	△ Fluoroquinolones — ciprofloxacin, levofloxacin (boxed warning: exacerbation, ventilation, deaths) · △ macrolides (azithromycin, clarithromycin) · △ aminoglycosides (gentamicin, amikacin) · △ IV magnesium only if absolutely necessary · △ β-blockers · △ botulinum toxin · △ hydroxychloroquine, procainamide · △ D-penicillamine · telithromycin (withdrawn) Anesthesia: profound sensitivity to non-depolarizing blockers (reduce dose); resistance to succinylcholine. Corticosteroids may worsen weakness in the first 2 weeks	Why: myasthenic crisis / respiratory failure. Use instead: an alternative outside these drug classes when one exists; if a listed drug is essential, give it and watch closely for worsening weakness or breathing. ^{327,328,731,732,733,734}

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Pheochromocytoma / paraganglioma (suspected catecholamine crisis)	Never give β-blockers (propranolol, labetalol) before α-blockade — unopposed α-stimulation → hypertensive crisis Crisis-precipitating drugs: · metoclopramide · corticosteroids (dexamethasone, prednisolone, hydrocortisone) · pseudoephedrine, ephedrine (decongestants) · morphine, tramadol, pethidine · succinylcholine · glucagon · methylphenidate · droperidol, prochlorperazine, chlorpromazine · tricyclics · ACTH	Why: hypertensive crisis / arrhythmia. Use instead: α-blockade first (phenoxybenzamine or doxazosin), adding a β-blocker for tachycardia only after α-blockade. Note: the Hemangeol label lists pheochromocytoma as a contraindication. ^{680,735,736}
Phenylketonuria	⚠ Aspartame (E951) — a phenylalanine source: choose aspartame-free medicines and drinks (labels must state "contains phenylalanine")	Why: aspartame is broken down in the gut to phenylalanine, which builds up in PKU. Use instead: aspartame-free medicines; if none exists, give the needed medicine (e.g., an antibiotic) rather than withhold treatment. ^{711,737,738}
SCID / severe T-cell immunodeficiency (incl. complete DiGeorge) · high-dose immunosuppression (prednisone ≥ 2 mg/kg/day or ≥ 20 mg/day for ≥ 14 days, chemotherapy, HSCT)	⊖ All live vaccines — rotavirus (label contraindication in SCID) · BCG · MMR · varicella · OPV · LAIV · yellow fever · oral typhoid Irradiated cellular blood components in suspected/confirmed SCID (start while tests are pending), after intrauterine transfusion (to 6 months post-EDD), donations from relatives or HLA-selected, Hodgkin lymphoma, purine analogues, allogeneic HSCT	Why: vaccine-strain disease; transfusion-associated GvHD. Use instead: non-live vaccines, which are safe in these children, and full vaccination of household contacts. Note: irradiation is not required for HIV, solid-organ transplant, routine chemotherapy or immunocompetent DiGeorge > 2 y. ^{629,739,740,741}
Sickle cell disease — vaso-occlusive crisis	⚠ Meperidine (pethidine) — do not use unless it is the only effective opioid for that patient (normeperidine → seizures) IV fluids at no more than the maintenance rate · NSAIDs only as a short course (5–7 days) after assessing renal risk	Why: normeperidine accumulates (seizures); over-hydration → acute chest syndrome. Use instead: another parenteral opioid, started promptly and given by patient-controlled analgesia or scheduled doses rather than as needed. ^{254,256,742}

Condition	Avoid – most to least frequently used	Why · use instead
Urea cycle disorders / known hyperammonemia	⊖ Valproate · △ L-asparaginase/pegaspargase △ Also associated with hyperammonemic decompensation: furosemide · phenobarbital · phenytoin · carbamazepine · topiramate · salicylates · hydrochlorothiazide · primidone Avoid fasting, protein loads, chemotherapy and high-dose glucocorticoids	Why: these drugs, fasting and protein loads can raise ammonia → encephalopathy, coma and death. Use instead: in a crisis, stop protein and give IV glucose to prevent catabolism; ammonia scavengers/dialysis per the metabolic team.^{193,727}
Williams syndrome	△ Multivitamins containing vitamin D in early childhood · △ vitamin D supplements with caution later · calcium at the reference daily intake — do not exceed, do not restrict without supervision Sedation/anesthesia: risk of myocardial ischemia, hemodynamic collapse and sudden death — plan with pediatric anesthesia and cardiology	Why: hypercalcemia; supravalvar aortic stenosis / coronary ostial narrowing. Use instead: no substitute needed — give vitamin D only for a proven deficiency, and monitor calcium during treatment.^{743,744}
Wolff–Parkinson–White with pre-excited atrial fibrillation (irregular wide-complex tachycardia)	Class III — Harm: IV/oral β-blockers · IV digoxin · IV amiodarone · verapamil (⊖ label: AF/flutter with an accessory pathway) · diltiazem △ Adenosine: avoid when the resting ECG shows pre-excitation and the tachycardia is pre-excited (ESC 2019)	Why: AV-nodal block accelerates conduction down the accessory pathway → ventricular fibrillation. Use instead: unstable → synchronized cardioversion; stable → IV procainamide or ibutilide (Class I — adult ACC/AHA/HRS and ESC grades; pediatric use is extrapolated).^{745,746,747}

B Avoid because of the child's age

Find the drug — 12 rules

Drug	Age limit	Why · use instead
Aspirin / salicylates (incl. bismuth subsalicylate)	⊖ Children or teenagers with, or recovering from, chickenpox or flu-like illness — Reye syndrome (FDA-mandated label warning)	Why: Reye syndrome — encephalopathy with fatty liver, fatal in about a third of reported US cases. Use instead: acetaminophen for fever or pain; ibuprofen is an alternative except in chickenpox. Note: Kawasaki disease and rheumatic indications are the exception (treating team; see the IVIG/vaccine interaction).^{111,688,748,749}
Benzocaine · viscous lidocaine (teething)	⚠ OTC benzocaine gels/liquids: not < 2 years (methemoglobinemia) · ⊖ viscous lidocaine 2 %: never for teething (boxed warning — seizures, severe brain injury, deaths)	Why: benzocaine → methemoglobinemia (can be fatal); swallowed viscous lidocaine → seizures, brain injury, death. Use instead: a chilled teething ring or gum massage.^{750,751}
Codeine · tramadol	⊖ < 12 years (pain or cough) ⊖ < 18 years after tonsillectomy/adenoidectomy ⚠ 12–18 y if obese, obstructive sleep apnea or severe lung disease	Why: ultra-rapid CYP2D6 metabolism → fatal respiratory depression. Use instead: acetaminophen, ibuprofen or both for pain, including after tonsillectomy.^{133,450,752,753}
Cough-and-cold products (OTC antihistamine/decongestant/antitussive combinations)	⚠ Not < 4 years (manufacturer labels; FDA: not < 2 y; AAP: not recommended < 4 y, unproven benefit at any age) ⊖ codeine/hydrocodone cough products < 18 y	Why: serious and fatal adverse effects; no efficacy data. Use instead: saline nose drops with suction, fluids, a cool-mist humidifier, and honey for cough from 12 months.^{133,754}

Drug	Age limit	Why · use instead
Diphenhydramine · dimenhydrinate (OTC)	⚠ Diphenhydramine: do not use < 2 years; 2–5 y only if directed by a doctor; never to make a child sleepy · dimenhydrinate < 2 y only if directed by a doctor	Why: paradoxical excitation, anticholinergic toxicity; infant deaths. Use instead: a non-sedating (second-generation) antihistamine for allergy symptoms. Note: OTC labeling limits, not formal contraindications. ^{755,756}
Honey	⚠ Not for infants < 12 months (including in remedies or on pacifiers)	Why: infant botulism (<i>C. botulinum</i> spores). Use instead: for an infant's cold, saline nose drops with bulb suction and plenty of fluids — no honey before 12 months. ^{754,757}
Ibuprofen in young infants (licensing)	UK: not suitable < 3 months or < 5 kg · US OTC from 6 months ("under 6 months: ask a doctor")	Why: under 6 months, ibuprofen pharmacokinetics may differ and kidney function is still immature. Use instead: acetaminophen below these ages. Note: a licensing threshold, not a toxicity rule. ^{111,688,758}
Loperamide	🚫 < 2 years · OTC 2–5 y only on medical advice · never exceed recommended doses	Why: respiratory depression; torsades/cardiac arrest with high doses. Use instead: oral rehydration solution for acute diarrhea; antidiarrheal drugs are not recommended. ^{183,759}

Drug	Age limit	Why · use instead
Metoclopramide	⊖ < 1 year (EMA) · 1–18 y second-line only — established post-operative vomiting or prevention of delayed chemotherapy-induced vomiting — 0.1–0.15 mg/kg up to 3 ×/day, max 5 days · US label: not recommended in children at all	Why: acute dystonia / extrapyramidal reactions (more common in children); neonatal methemoglobinemia. Use instead: ondansetron — one oral dose reduces vomiting and helps oral rehydration in gastroenteritis (trial ages 6 months–10 years).^{760,761,762}
Neonates (≤ 28 days)	⊖ Ceftriaxone if calcium-containing IV fluids are needed (fatal ceftriaxone–calcium precipitates) and in hyperbilirubinemic or premature neonates (EU: up to 41 weeks postmenstrual age) · ⊖ co-trimoxazole < 2 months (kernicterus) · ⊖ benzyl-alcohol-preserved ("bacteriostatic") saline/flushes (gasping syndrome) · ⊖ nitrofurantoin < 1 month · ⚠ chloramphenicol (gray syndrome, fatalities)	Why: immature drug clearance and red-cell enzymes (gray syndrome, benzyl-alcohol toxicity, nitrofurantoin hemolysis), and bilirubin displacement by ceftriaxone and sulfonamides (kernicterus). Use instead: cefotaxime in place of ceftriaxone; preservative-free 0.9 % saline for flushes and dilution.^{27,701,702,763,764,765,766,767}
Promethazine	⊖ < 2 years (any route) — boxed warning · ≥ 2 y lowest dose, avoid with other respiratory depressants	Why: fatal respiratory depression. Use instead: ondansetron for vomiting in gastroenteritis (studied from 6 months); a non-sedating antihistamine for allergy.^{756,762,768}

Drug	Age limit	Why · use instead
Tetracyclines < 8 years	⚠ Use in children ≤ 8 y only for severe/life-threatening infection without alternative (permanent tooth staining) — but doxycycline is the drug of choice for suspected rickettsial disease at any age ; short courses have not caused staining	Why: permanent yellow-gray-brown staining of developing teeth, and enamel hypoplasia. Use instead: an antibiotic from another class when one is suitable; if a tetracycline is needed, doxycycline at the recommended dose and duration. Note: tetracycline and minocycline are not covered by the doxycycline data. ^{769,770,771}

C Avoid these drug combinations

Find either drug — 20 interactions

Drugs	Combination – most to least frequently used	Why · notes
β-Blocker therapy + anaphylaxis	β-blockers may blunt the response to epinephrine. Epinephrine-refractory anaphylaxis with hypotension/bradycardia in a β-blocked patient: IV glucagon 20–30 µg/kg (max 1 mg), repeat or infusion	Why: β-blockers may worsen the outcome of anaphylaxis and its response to epinephrine (effect not fully established). Use instead: intramuscular epinephrine first, as for any anaphylaxis; add IV glucagon only if the response is poor. Note: very limited evidence (case reports); glucagon causes vomiting — protect the airway. ^{407,772,773}
Carbamazepine	Levels ↑ (toxicity — dizziness, drowsiness, ataxia): clarithromycin · erythromycin · fluconazole · itraconazole · voriconazole · ketoconazole · grapefruit juice (CYP3A4 inhibitors) Carbamazepine lowers: hormonal contraceptives (unintended pregnancy) · itraconazole ·  voriconazole is contraindicated with carbamazepine	Why: potent CYP3A4 inducer. Use instead: with an interacting drug, monitor carbamazepine levels and adjust the dose; for contraception, an alternative or back-up method. ^{774,775}

Drugs	Combination – most to least frequently used	Why · notes
Ceftriaxone + calcium-containing IV solutions (any age)	⊖ Never mix, Y-site or give simultaneously (including parenteral nutrition) · beyond the neonatal period (> 28 days): sequential administration only after thoroughly flushing the line with 0.9 % NaCl or D5W · neonates: contraindicated (see age rules)	Why: ceftriaxone–calcium precipitates in the lungs and kidneys (fatal cases in neonates). Use instead: beyond 28 days, give them one after the other with the line flushed in between, or through separate lines at different sites; in neonates, choose another antibiotic.^{27,763}
Clonidine · dexmedetomidine + β-blockers / digoxin / calcium-channel blockers	△ Clonidine with β-blockers, digoxin, diltiazem/verapamil: monitor heart rate (bradycardia, AV block) · abrupt clonidine withdrawal → rebound hypertension — withdraw a β-blocker several days before tapering clonidine (missed doses in children on clonidine for ADHD/tics) · dexmedetomidine: bradycardia/sinus arrest with high vagal tone, bolus dosing or other negative chronotropes	Why: additive slowing of heart rate and AV conduction; stopping clonidine suddenly → rapid rise in blood pressure, worse if a β-blocker is continued. Use instead: if both are needed, monitor heart rate; to stop, withdraw the β-blocker several days first, then taper clonidine over 2–4 days. Note: the labels advise monitoring and caution; these are not contraindications.⁷⁷⁶
Colchicine (familial Mediterranean fever)	Strong CYP3A4 inhibitors — clarithromycin · itraconazole · ketoconazole · ritonavir — or the P-gp inhibitor ciclosporin: fatal toxicity — ⊖ with renal or hepatic impairment; otherwise reduce or interrupt colchicine Moderate inhibitors — erythromycin · fluconazole · verapamil · diltiazem · grapefruit juice: dose reduction · azithromycin: no adjustment	Why: fatal colchicine toxicity at therapeutic doses. Use instead: azithromycin when a macrolide is needed (no colchicine dose change); with the other listed inhibitors, reduce or interrupt colchicine.^{58,777,778}
Digoxin	Levels ↑ > 50 % — amiodarone · clarithromycin · erythromycin · verapamil · itraconazole · propafenone · quinidine: measure the level first, reduce digoxin 30–50 % · spironolactone ↑ 25 % (reduce 15–30 %) · Hypokalemia/hypomagnesemia (e.g., diuretics) predispose to toxicity · △ rapid IV calcium → serious arrhythmias in digitalized patients	Why: narrow therapeutic index. Use instead: if the combination is needed, measure the digoxin level first, cut the dose by about 30–50 % and keep monitoring.⁷¹⁴

Drugs	Combination – most to least frequently used	Why · notes
Immunoglobulin (IVIG) + live vaccines · aspirin + varicella vaccine	After IVIG defer measles- and varicella-containing vaccines: 8 months after 400 mg/kg, 10 months after 1 g/kg, 11 months after 2 g/kg (Kawasaki disease); if given earlier, revaccinate or check seroconversion after the interval ⚠ Salicylates for 6 weeks after varicella vaccine · give annual <i>inactivated</i> influenza vaccine to children on chronic aspirin	Why: antibody interference with vaccine take; Reye syndrome. Use instead: non-live vaccines, which can be given at any interval before or after IVIG.^{108, 629,779}
Isotretinoin (adolescent acne)	⚠ Doxycycline, minocycline and other tetracyclines — intracranial hypertension (pseudotumor cerebri: headache, papilledema, visual change) · ⚠ vitamin A supplements (additive toxicity)	Why: isotretinoin can cause intracranial hypertension, and some cases involved a tetracycline; vitamin A adds to its side effects. Use instead: stop the oral tetracycline before starting isotretinoin, and avoid vitamin A-containing supplements. Note: the label says "avoid", not "contraindicated".⁷⁸⁰
Linezolid · methylene blue · tramadol + serotonergic drugs (serotonin syndrome)	⚠ Linezolid and IV methylene blue are MAO inhibitors: avoid with SSRIs (fluoxetine, sertraline, escitalopram), tramadol, other opioids, SNRIs, tricyclics, triptans unless urgent (methylene blue boxed warning; linezolid  within 2 weeks of an MAOI, monitor with other serotonergic drugs) · elective use: stop the serotonergic drug ≥ 2 weeks (fluoxetine 5 weeks) before ⚠ Tramadol + SSRIs/tricyclics: seizures and serotonin syndrome	Why: serotonin syndrome (serious CNS reactions, deaths). Use instead: another antibiotic or treatment when available; if linezolid or methylene blue is urgent, stop the serotonergic drug and monitor closely for CNS toxicity.^{21,540,752,781}

Drugs	Combination – most to least frequently used	Why · notes
Methotrexate (high-dose oncology; weekly low-dose rheumatology)	⚠️ Ibuprofen, aspirin and other NSAIDs · co-trimoxazole and other sulfonamides · amoxicillin, piperacillin and other penicillins · omeprazole and other proton-pump inhibitors · probenecid — reduce methotrexate clearance ("unexpectedly severe and fatal" toxicity, mainly high-dose methotrexate + NSAIDs): reconcile and hold before HD-MTX · ⚠️ nitrous oxide anesthesia · co-trimoxazole prophylaxis in ALL: deferral during HD-MTX is protocol-dependent	Why: reduced renal tubular secretion of methotrexate. Use instead: a non-interacting alternative from the day before high-dose methotrexate until it has cleared.^{782,783}
Ondansetron + other QT-prolonging drugs	⚠️ Avoid in congenital long QT syndrome · ECG monitoring with hypokalemia/hypomagnesemia, heart failure, bradyarrhythmias or other QT-prolonging drugs — azithromycin, clarithromycin, erythromycin · ciprofloxacin, levofloxacin, moxifloxacin · domperidone · fluconazole · haloperidol, droperidol · citalopram, escitalopram · methadone (known risk; hydroxyzine and other azoles: conditional risk) · no single IV dose > 16 mg (32 mg dose withdrawn 2012)	Why: torsades de pointes. Use instead: if both are needed, give ondansetron with ECG monitoring.^{74,722}
Pimozide (Tourette)	⊖ Clarithromycin, erythromycin, azithromycin · itraconazole, ketoconazole · sertraline, citalopram, escitalopram, paroxetine, fluvoxamine · protease inhibitors · nefazodone (QT prolongation, sudden death) · clarithromycin and voriconazole are likewise contraindicated with pimozide and ergot alkaloids	Why: sudden deaths reported when clarithromycin was added to pimozide. Use instead: an antibiotic, antifungal or antidepressant that the pimozide label does not contraindicate, with an ECG at baseline and during dose adjustment.^{775,777,784}

Drugs	Combination – most to least frequently used	Why · notes
Propofol — prolonged infusion · PICU sedation · egg/soy allergy	⚠ Propofol infusion syndrome (severe metabolic acidosis, hyperkalemia, rhabdomyolysis, lipemia, Brugada-like ECG, cardiac failure) — risk with > 5 mg/kg/h for > 48 h, reported below 4 mg/kg/h · not indicated for PICU sedation (trial mortality 9 % vs 4 %) ·  after anaphylaxis to egg or soy (US label); non-anaphylactic egg/soy allergy is not a contraindication (adult data)	Why: propofol infusion syndrome, which has caused deaths, and higher mortality when used for PICU sedation. Use instead: an α_2-agonist (e.g., dexmedetomidine) as the main sedative for ventilated children; if propofol is used, keep it < 4 mg/kg/h for < 48 h. Note: EU product information carries no egg or soy contraindication; follow the locally registered label.^{785,786,787,788}
Rifampicin (enzyme inducer)	Lowerts: corticosteroids · ondansetron · fluconazole and other azoles ( voriconazole) · clarithromycin · phenytoin · doxycycline · fluoroquinolones · tacrolimus/ciclosporin/sirolimus (rejection) · hormonal contraceptives (use a non-hormonal method) · warfarin and other coumarins · methadone; several antivirals contraindicated · re-titrate doses when starting <i>and</i> stopping rifampicin	Why: potent CYP/P-gp induction. Use instead: a non-hormonal method of birth control; adjust doses of other affected drugs when rifampicin starts and again when it stops.^{775,789,790}
Sildenafil / tadalafil (pulmonary hypertension)	 Organic nitrates in any form (GTN, isosorbide; regular or intermittent) ·  riociguat	Why: profound hypotension. Use instead: a non-nitrate alternative; after tadalafil, give no nitrate within 48 hours of the last dose.⁷⁹¹

Drugs	Combination – most to least frequently used	Why · notes
Tacrolimus / ciclosporin (transplant, nephrotic syndrome, autoimmune disease)	Levels ↑ (nephro-/neurotoxicity): fluconazole · clarithromycin, erythromycin · voriconazole, posaconazole (give one-third tacrolimus dose) · itraconazole, ketoconazole · diltiazem, verapamil · grapefruit Levels ↓ (rejection): rifampicin · phenytoin · carbamazepine · phenobarbital · St John's wort △ Ciclosporin + ibuprofen/NSAIDs → renal dysfunction · △ ciclosporin + spironolactone and other potassium-sparing diuretics (should not be used) · △ ACE inhibitors/ARBs → hyperkalemia · tacrolimus prolongs QT (avoid in congenital LQTS)	Why: CYP3A4/P-gp substrates with a narrow therapeutic index. Use instead: if both are needed, adjust the dose and check tacrolimus or ciclosporin trough levels frequently.^{790,792}
Theophylline / aminophylline	△ Ciprofloxacin: serious and fatal reactions (cardiac arrest, seizures, status epilepticus, respiratory failure) — avoid; if unavoidable, monitor theophylline levels and adjust · △ clarithromycin raises theophylline — monitor with high doses	Why: CYP1A2 inhibition (ciprofloxacin-specific; levofloxacin/moxifloxacin have little effect). Use instead: another antibiotic; if ciprofloxacin cannot be avoided, monitor theophylline levels and adjust the dose.^{731,777}
Trimethoprim (co-trimoxazole) + ACE inhibitor/ARB or spironolactone (± renal impairment, potassium supplements, NSAIDs)	△ Trimethoprim blocks the distal-nephron sodium channel (amiloride-like) → hyperkalemia, especially at high dose (PJP treatment), with renal insufficiency or other potassium-raising drugs: monitor potassium or choose another antibiotic	Why: trimethoprim acts like amiloride and reduces renal potassium excretion, adding to the potassium rise from these drugs. Use instead: an alternative antibiotic when appropriate; if co-trimoxazole is needed, monitor potassium closely. Note: the sudden-death signal is from adults ≥ 66 y (BMJ 2014, CMAJ 2015); pediatric data are limited.^{701,793,794,795}
Valproate + carbapenems (meropenem, imipenem, ertapenem)	△ Valproate level falls 60–100 % within ~2 days → breakthrough seizures — not recommended; increasing the valproate dose does not compensate: use a non-carbapenem antibiotic or add another anticonvulsant	Why: inhibition of valproate-glucuronide hydrolysis. Use instead: a non-carbapenem antibiotic; if a carbapenem is essential, consider adding another anticonvulsant.^{727,796,797}

Drugs	Combination – most to least frequently used	Why · notes
Valproate + lamotrigine	Lamotrigine concentrations rise > 2-fold — lamotrigine dose with valproate is less than half the usual (label pediatric "with valproate" tablets) · boxed warning: serious rash/SJS risk is higher in children (0.3–0.8 %) and with valproate or rapid escalation	Why: inhibition of lamotrigine glucuronidation. Use instead: if both are needed, follow the label's "with valproate" schedule — less than half the usual lamotrigine dose — and never exceed its starting dose or escalation. ⁷⁹⁸

How This Guide Is Maintained

GOVERNANCE

Issued October 2026 · review October 2029

A reference is only trusted if it shows its currency, its reviewers, and a way to correct it.

▲ CURRENCY & REVIEW

- **Issued** October 2026 · **scheduled review** October 2029, or sooner if a major guideline changes. Each clinical section carries a **"reviewed / next review"** stamp so the reader can see the section's currency at a glance.
- Content is written to the **most recent high-impact guideline** for each topic; the guideline body and year appear on every card.

▲ REVIEWERS & GOVERNANCE

- Prepared for the **Kuwait Pediatric Council** and reviewed by its named faculty panel (see the Reviewers page). Section leads sign off their section before release.

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- Found a wrong dose, a broken link, or an out-of-date threshold? **Report it** — corrections are logged and issued between scheduled reviews.
- Email Ayalmajed@moh.gov.kw with the topic name and what needs correcting.

◆ HOW TO CITE

- Kuwait Pediatric Council. *Neonatal & Pediatric Common & Emergency Care Guide*. Issued October 2026. Available at: <https://kpc-guide.com>
- Decision support only — confirm against Ministry of Health protocols and specialist advice.

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Tap to view the full reference list.

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